

The Yaquis and the Empire

**Violence,
Spanish Imperial
Power, and
Native Resilience in
Colonial Mexico**

Raphael Brewster Folsom

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Power, and Native Resilience in
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This groundbreaking new study examines the history of the Yaqui people and their interactions with the Spanish Empire from first contact through Mexican independence. *The Yaquis and the Empire* focuses on three ironies: the Yaquis both resisted and came to value their ties with empire; processes of violence and negotiation were ongoing and intertwined throughout the colonial period; and the empire, though weak in manpower and distant from its bases of military and financial strength, was surprisingly effective in its drive to transform the Mexican northwest.

Using extensive, newly unearthed documentation from archives in Mexico, Spain, the United States, and Italy, Folsom shines brilliant





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THE YAQUIS AND THE EMPIRE

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THE YAQUIS AND THE EMPIRE

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Native Resilience in Colonial Mexico*

Raphael Brewster Folsom

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For Sandra

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THE YAQUIS AND THE EMPIRE

INTRODUCTION: IMPERIAL IRONIES

Above all, irony destabilizes. It rules out certain kinds of certainty. It is a mirror in which the gaze confronts something which is not quite what it seems to be. Confronting it means admitting that all interpretations, including this one, must remain up in the air.

—Jay Winter, *Remembering War*

The Yaqui people have long been known as Mexico's fiercest, most indomitable Indians. They earned this reputation in the nineteenth century as the Mexican state tried to gain control over its vast and fractured territories. Surveying the disorder of their newly independent nation, Mexican thinkers looked to political liberalism for solutions to the country's many problems. To unite the nation and develop its economy, successive regimes passed laws and made proclamations promoting democratic reform, the exultation of race mixture, the expansion of industry and scientific progress, political centralization, and the reform of land law. Such ideas rose to the height of their influence after the wars of the 1850s and 1860s had broken the power of the Roman Catholic Church. The presidency of Porfirio Díaz (c. 1876–1910) saw the expansion of a national network of railroads, the reform of education, the centralization of state power, and a steady assault on practices of collective landholding. To the liberal champions of these policies, the Yaqui people were a stumbling block in the middle of Mexico's road to modernity. The Yaquis lived on some of the best land in Mexico, but they did not exploit it to maximum advantage. As if to insult the developmental aspirations of liberal elites, the Yaquis resorted in times of need even to the practices of hunter-gatherers. Yaquis spoke a foreign language and practiced a strange and passionate religion mixing elements of Catholic belief and native ritual. They called outsiders Yoris, an ancient Yaqui term of contempt, and refused even the kindest invitations to abandon their

barbaric ways and join in the building of a better Mexico. The Díaz regime's frustration thus darkened into fury, and it soon offered the Yaquis an ultimatum: become Mexicans, the Yaquis were told, speak Spanish, attend public schools, privatize collective landholdings, and value Mexican citizenship more highly than Yaqui identity. Comply or face collective annihilation. Earlier in the nineteenth century, brilliant Yaqui generals had led successful campaigns to resist the Yori menace. But the Díaz government was much better financed and organized than any the Yaquis had faced before. In the last decade of the nineteenth century and the first decade of the twentieth, the Díaz government launched a brutally effective campaign to liquidate the Yaqui threat, killing hundreds of Yaquis and deporting thousands more to the henequen plantations in Oaxaca and to Yucatán as slaves.¹

Yet the flames of Yaqui resistance were never stamped out. When the Díaz regime crumbled and fell in 1910, the Yaquis were natural allies of the revolutionary movement. They eventually fought alongside Álvaro Obregón, the Sonoran general who prevailed in the revolutionary wars. On the strength of their service, the Yaquis later gained title to the largest communal land grant in Mexico, and the single such grant to be made on the basis of ethnic identity. This distinctive experience of trauma and triumph purchased for the Yaquis a unique place in the Mexican national consciousness. Whereas writers of the Porfirian era had depicted the Yaquis as incorrigible savages, later authors adopted the Yaquis as symbols of a new revolutionary Mexico. Mexicans came to see them as heroes in the struggle for land and liberty. The richly woven Yaqui culture and traditions that had so offended nineteenth-century liberals became part of a national patrimony in which all Mexicans could take pride. The Yaqui deer dance is the most vivid emblem of the Yaqui people's place in the Mexican national imagination. Performed in Sonora, Mexico City, and around the world by the Ballet Folklórico, depicted on grain silos, roadside *taquerías*, and the Sonoran license plate, the deer dancer has come to represent proud Yaqui traditions that no Yori has been able to destroy.²

This narrative holds many attractions for Yaquis and non-Yaquis alike. It also happens to have a great deal of evidence to support it. The genocide attempted by the Porfirian government was very real, as were Yaqui campaigns of resistance. Indeed, as early as the sixteenth century visitors to the Yaqui Valley were impressed by the fierceness of the Yaqui people. One famously wrote, "I have never seen any Indians fight so well as they." It is because this narrative of Yori aggression and Yaqui resistance is so powerful and so well documented that it has for so long obscured a much more complicated story. The history of the Yaqui people in the colonial period is utterly different from what conventional

narratives lead one to expect. This colonial history also illuminates the origins of Yaqui resistance to the modern Mexican state. To state the central claims of this book briefly, the Yaqui people were not fearsome enemies of the colonial government but were in fact its most valued allies in northwest Mexico. How this alliance came into existence, how it developed over time, how it unraveled, and why it has been so broadly forgotten are questions that cannot be answered briefly. But the search for answers can shed a great deal of light on the complexities of Spanish colonialism and of native responses to it in the vast, beguiling territory of the Spanish borderlands.³

Tracing the origins and development of Yaqui relations with the colonial regime leads into a shadowy region, one in which the stark oppositions seen in the late nineteenth century are replaced by multiple shades of gray. How, for instance, can the narrative of Yori oppression and Yaqui resistance account for the career of Juan Calixto Ayamea? Ayamea was born in the early eighteenth century, raised on the Yaqui-Jesuit mission, and in 1740 came to lead a powerful revolt that spread across the north Mexican states of Sinaloa and Sonora. He seems at first glance to personify Yaqui defiance of imperial power. But aspects of Ayamea's career were at odds with what one might expect in a Yaqui revolutionary. Urbane, well versed in Spanish diplomatic protocol, and not particularly radical, Ayamea couched his demands in courteous letters to royal officials written in fine Castilian Spanish. In one such missive, addressed to Don Juan Aldámez, the *alcalde mayor* of Río Chico, and dated May 20, 1740, Ayamea began, "My Lord, I desire that you, the lady your wife, your little children, and the rest of the gentlemen enjoy the most perfect health. We are all well," he went on, "and forever at your service." In these opening words Ayamea deployed the elaborate courtesy he knew would please his reader, while at the same time making a veiled threat: by referring to the health of the Aldámez family, he implied that they might not enjoy it much longer. He went on to make the threat explicitly: "My lord, I inform you that the time has come in which war breaks out in the name of God, and the King my lord (may God keep him many years). Now God wants all this to end." Ayamea's sophisticated use of Spanish diplomatic language, his careful balancing of sincere affection and ironic menace, and the fine distinctions he drew between good Spaniards like Aldámez and the wicked ones he planned to kill, all bespoke a history of deep engagement with empire, not just resistance to it. Simple tales of oppression and defiance cannot explain the mix of worldliness and political skill Ayamea employed in his letters. Only by attending to the many ironies of Yaqui history in the colonial period can one make sense of Ayamea's ambivalent relationship with the imperial power.⁴

Irony circulated everywhere in the empires of the Atlantic world. The violent mixing of high ideals and sordid realities and of peoples from all points of the globe produced results that no one could have foreseen. The result was often what the literary scholar Paul Fussell has called an “irony of situation.” War, he writes, is inherently ironic because it is always worse than expected: “Every war constitutes an irony of situation because its means are so melodramatically disproportionate to its presumed ends.” Fussell goes on to discuss the ways in which the poet Wilfred Owen gave voice to the ironies of the First World War. The poet contrasted the blind, maimed, “blood-shod” victims of war with what he called “the old lie”: “dulce et decorum est / Pro patria mori” (A sweet and worthy thing it is to die for the fatherland). In a few short lines, Owen traced Europe’s journey from the idealism of the nineteenth century to a twentieth-century reality so wild and awful it could scarcely have been imagined before. Henry James expressed a similar sense of wonder at war’s ironies: “The plunge of civilization in to this abyss of blood and darkness . . . is a thing that so gives away the whole long age during which we have supposed the world to be, with whatever abatement, gradually bettering, that to have to take it all now for what the treacherous years were all the while really making for and *meaning* is too tragic for any words.” In prose at once brilliant, obscure, and profound, James pinpointed the ironies many felt as they watched the high ideals of the *belle époque* lead directly to the horrors of trench warfare.⁵

Like Owen’s idealistic young soldiers, the agents of empire envision the spread of order, religion, and prosperity across the globe. But imperial dreams are almost always betrayed by ironic realities. Conquerors come to feel defrauded of their hopes, and those “liberated” by conquest learn to hate their liberators. Empires constitute ironies of situation because the violent means they employ make their envisioned ends impossible. The famous last will of Mancio Sierra, the conquistador of Peru, bore witness to the darkest ironies of empire: “I wish your Catholic Majesty to know,” wrote the old conquistador, “that what I do is because of my conscience and because of the guilt I share, for we have destroyed by our evil behavior a government that was enjoyed by these natives. . . . And when they discovered that we had thieves amongst us, and men who sought to force their wives and daughters to sin, they despised us. . . . And I now have unburdened my conscience, and I declare this to be my last will and testament.” Such bitter ironies are the wages of empire. Yet empires produce more hopeful kinds of irony as well. Imperial wars sometimes give way to reshaped worlds with unexpected possibilities for peaceful coexistence. This strange state of affairs is most often seen in fringe regions, where colonial powers could never achieve complete domination. At the imperial edges, the agents of

empire have to be more flexible in their treatment of subjected peoples than they expect or desire. The “Middle Ground” is the breeding ground of imperial ironies.⁶

There are dangers in focusing on irony. Some ironies can be seen only by a historian, gazing from the distance of centuries. If our perception of all great enterprises is infected from the outset with our knowledge of their eventual failure, we risk devaluing the courage of historical actors at the beginning of their journeys. At worst, an emphasis on irony allows us to condescend to the past. Three insights help one to avoid these dangers. The first is that irony lacks its cutting edge if we undervalue the courage required to embark on any great project. The best-laid schemes of mice and men go oft awry, as Burns’s poem says—but who will care if we fail to appreciate how much thought and work go into the laying of those schemes? A second insight is that many historical actors themselves understood the ironic outcomes of their own stories. At the end of his life, Mancio Sierra knew that the disgust he felt for himself and his fellow Spaniards was the farthest thing in the world from what he had expected as an ambitious young man. A final insight I have kept in mind is that this book is deeply, ironically different from what I expected it to be when I set out to write it. This is true of most creative projects. The economist Albert Hirschman describes the many ironies that emerge over the course of all creative enterprises in this way: “Creativity always comes as a surprise to us; therefore we can never count on it and we dare not believe in it until it has happened. In other words, we would not consciously engage upon tasks whose success clearly requires that creativity be forthcoming. Hence, the only way in which we can bring our creative resources fully into play is by misjudging the nature of the task, by presenting it to ourselves as more routine, simple, undemanding of genuine creativity than it will turn out to be.” Acknowledging the ironies of one’s own story makes it possible to avoid condescending to historical actors and to chronicle the ironies of their lives sympathetically. If handled well, a focus on irony can bring us closer to our subjects rather than distancing us from them.⁷

The history of the Yaqui people in the colonial period is rife with ironies that have yet to be explored by scholars. In many respects the story of the Yaquis is to Mexicans what that of the Plains Indians has been to students in the United States: that of a proud, doomed people whose suffering is imagined as the price of modernity and whose inclusion in the modern state symbolizes the advent of an enlightened regime. In the United States, popular perceptions of the Yaquis are similar, though with a mystical tinge laid on by the hallucinatory writings of Carlos Castaneda. Most North Americans who know anything about the Yaquis think of them as a people connected through ancient tradition to the wisdom of

their pre-Hispanic ancestors. The most obvious irony this book explores is that the reality of the Yaqui people's colonial past is unrecognizably different from what these popular narratives might lead one to expect. Tragic and inexorable decline was not a feature of the Yaqui people's colonial history. Nor was inflexible adherence to pre-Christian ways. Recognizing this allows us to perceive the complexity of Yaqui experience under colonial rule.⁸

This book focuses on three imperial ironies, unexpected circumstances that emerged from the encounter of the Yaqui people and the Spanish empire:

- The first of these is that the Yaqui people actively pursued their collective aspirations while at the same time placing high value on their reciprocal ties with empire. The Yaquis were among New Spain's best organized and most sophisticated native collaborators with the Spanish. Their relationship with the colonial power was not unique, but it was distinctive. In this sense, the Yaquis can be compared to the Tlaxcalan allies of Hernán Cortés, both in the robustness of their initial resistance to conquest and in the speed with which they pivoted from resistance to alliance with the invaders. For most of the colonial era the Yaquis pursued their ambitions within, not against, the structures of empire. The nature of the Yaquis' relationship with empire changed over time, the preponderance of power shifting between Yaqui and non-Yaqui actors. Throughout the colonial period the Yaquis pursued their interests through tough negotiation, offers of valuable aid, threats, and tactical violence. These acts were always enveloped in a shared understanding that reciprocal ties with the empire would be sustained.⁹
- The second imperial irony this book explores is that alliance with the empire did not imply an end to violence between Yaquis and invaders. Violence and negotiation were ongoing and often simultaneous processes on the Yaqui mission, and both were constitutive elements of the mission's social, cultural, and political life. Dramatic confrontations with conquering armies gave way in the seventeenth century to a panoply of smaller violent acts by Yaquis, Spaniards, and Jesuit missionaries. Scrutiny of practices such as captive exchange, threats, sabotage, and wars with unconverted Indians allows us to explore the kinds of capillary violence that persisted at the empire's extremities through the colonial period.¹⁰
- The third irony I explore is that the imperial power, though divided, isolated, weak in manpower, and dependent on the cooperation of native peoples, nevertheless came to exert considerable sway in northwest Mexico. The political theorist James C. Scott has written about the subtle arts subaltern peoples practice in resisting oppression and exploitation.

He has, more recently, explored the difficulties that empires encounter in dominating geographically isolated subjects. I argue that in remote areas such as Sinaloa and Sonora, colonial domination itself had to become a subtle art in order to persist. Jesuits, conquerors, and settlers had to learn harsh lessons in the futility of violent conquest and to grasp the necessity of negotiation in order to survive.¹¹

In arguing for the importance of these ironies, this book draws on many primary sources that have rarely, if ever, been used in the study of the Yaqui people and have certainly never before been treated in one place. The rich chronicle sources for northwest Mexico here supplement materials from multiple archives in Mexico, Spain, Italy, and the United States. These sources offer unprecedented access to the processes of violence and cultural engagement between the Yaquis and Spaniards. Moreover, they make it possible to engage several bodies of scholarly literature in new ways. The rich anthropological literature on the Yaquis themselves, recent scholarship on borders and borderlands throughout the Americas, and now-classic works on the negotiation of rule in Latin America have all informed this analysis.

A remarkable lineage of anthropologists has devoted enormous amounts of time, work, and love to the study of the Yaqui people. Edward H. Spicer and his wife, Rosamund Spicer, may be described as the patriarch and matriarch of this clan. They began their research among the Yaquis in the early 1940s and brought to light distinctive patterns in Yaqui thought, ritual, action, and politics. Critical to their vision was the idea that the Yaquis were what they called an “enduring people”—that is, a people who have maintained a sense of collective identity despite immense pressure from without. This capacity for endurance was, in Spicer’s analysis, deeply connected to the Yaquis’ sense of their history. The binding element in Yaqui identity was not an ideology of racial purity, a language, a homeland, a specific set of customs, beliefs, or practices, all of which had changed profoundly over time. Rather, Spicer wrote, “common understandings of what has been experienced in relations with other peoples” are what maintained the cohesiveness of the Yaquis. Put another way, the Yaquis’ “awareness of their experience through time—their historical understanding of themselves—is the basis for the enduring qualities.” The Spicers and their successors have shown how Yaqui ritual, myth, and literature reenact Yaqui historical understanding for each successive generation, deepening and sometimes shifting the channels through which Yaqui collective senses of self, history, and community flow.¹²

More recent anthropologists have refined and expanded on Spicer’s ideas. Kirstin Erickson has argued that the notion of endurance is not a matter of

abstract theory but a daily reality for Yaquis living today, especially Yaqui women. "Narratives of suffering and the ability to endure inform the constitution of Yaqui gendered identities—specifically concepts of femaleness," she writes. Yaquis continually use the Spanish word *aguantar*, or "to endure," to demarcate themselves in contrast to others. Tales of hardship in the wars of the nineteenth century, enslavement on Yucatecan henequen plantations, and attempted genocide are always coupled with affirmations of Yaqui endurance and identity. Yaqui rituals express the value of endurance by being more physically and emotionally exhausting than those of other peoples. So too do the ways in which the Yaquis talk about Christ's endurance on the cross and a woman's endurance of labor and childbirth. Like Erickson, David Delgado Shorter has expanded on Spicer's argument for the importance of history within Yaqui culture, arguing that history interweaves with myth, dance, and daily conversation for the Yaquis in ways that frustrate scholars' desire to write the Yaqui past "scientifically." Shorter seeks to "remap the boundary between the ethnological categories oral and literate and expand Western notions of historical expression to include non-literate representations of 'local' history through various oral and ritual practices." His work is thus a reminder of the Faulknerian precept that history (in this case Yaqui history) is not dead but alive and present.¹³

The Yaquis and the Empire seeks to remain cognizant of Yaqui ideas of the past and anthropologists' subtle explorations of them while at the same time expanding the empirical and theoretical base on which Yaqui history can be remade. Two central ideas of the Spicers and their successors inform this work: that the collective historical experience of interaction with outsiders has been critical to the development of Yaqui identities; and that Yaqui endurance and persistence in the face of hardship have been a hallmark of their journey through time. This book nevertheless diverges from earlier studies in several respects. Spicer was a visionary scholar with deep sympathy for the Yaqui people, but he did not spend much time in archives. Few other students of Yaqui culture have done so. In many circumstances the insights of anthropologists find stunning confirmation in the documents. But in countless other ways the historical record diverges from, and sometimes falsifies, anthropological assertions about Yaqui history.

Beyond the myriad small differences in empirical detail between this account and earlier ones, I argue here that there was a much deeper mutual engagement between Yaquis and Spaniards than most previous accounts have described. It is in this sense that recent historical scholarship on borders and borderlands throughout the world has proven to be enormously useful. Over the past thirty years borderlands scholars have explored a question most compellingly posed by Richard White in *The Middle Ground*: how did peoples of

profoundly diverse language, religion, culture, ideas of kinship, power, and much else coexist in regions where state power and the rule of law were absent? Violence was an almost inevitable result of such encounters. But over time violence was almost always joined by patterns of trade, intermarriage, mutual accommodation, negotiation, and convenient mutual misunderstanding. To take two examples from among the many works that have pursued these themes, James Brooks's *Captives and Cousins* and Julianna Barr's *Peace Came in the Form of a Woman* both explore the ways in which natives and invaders drew on elements of their own traditions of captive exchange to weave new diplomatic cultures in the borderlands. Studies like these place early Yaqui-Spanish contacts into perspective and help to highlight the centrality of diplomacy and captive exchange between Yaquis and outsiders. Studies in this genre, which in Brian DeLay's words "emphasize *relationships* instead of privileging either colonial or native experiences or perspectives," help us see that the secret to the Yaquis' remarkable endurance lay not in their drawing a bright line between themselves and others—Yoemem [Yaquis] and Yorim [whites], as the Yaquis say. Rather, the Yaquis profited from their exceptional skill at balancing the maintenance of a strong collective identity with the need to engage with outsiders. Such engagement sometimes took the form of welcoming outsiders among themselves and at other times that of incorporating themselves into communities far distant from their own.²⁴

Exploring the ironies of Yaqui-Spanish engagement sheds new light on borderlands processes that have often remained in the shadows. Irony is the result of historical change, and so focusing on it places emphasis on process, accident, and continuing transformation. Focusing on irony undermines certain once-fresh but now shopworn ideas governing the interpretation of the borderlands. In an understandable backlash against scholarship that denigrated native peoples, many borderlands historians have swung to the opposite extreme, attributing to Indians almost superhuman powers of foresight, compassion, worldly wisdom, and martial prowess. By concentrating on the ironies of Yaqui history one can see how much was beyond the control and understanding of the Yaqui people and grasp that their genius lay in the skill with which they adapted to the profound novelty of the colonial situation. Emphasis on irony reveals unexpected facets of the Spanish invaders as well. For a variety of reasons, from the litigiousness of Spanish society to the Spanish tradition of glorifying chivalric warfare, the Spaniards left staggeringly abundant evidence of their atrocities against America's native peoples. Historians have rightly emphasized the horrendous costs of Spanish colonialism in the Americas. But what is often missing from such accounts is the transformative effects of colonial experience

on the colonizers. For they too were often in the grip of events beyond their control, and they too had to confront deeply ironic colonial circumstances by changing their behavior and beliefs. Focusing on the ironies of Yaqui history leads us away from stark morality tales of noble Europeans and wicked savages, or of noble savages and wicked Europeans, that one still finds all too often in colonial studies. Placing irony in the foreground makes it possible to recognize the human complexity of all actors in the colonial drama.¹⁵

Much of what has been written about the colonial history of the Yaqui people overstates the enmity between Yaquis and outsiders and understates their intertwining and irony-producing involvements. This is partly because such contrasts became blindingly sharp in the nineteenth century. When Yaquis closed ranks against the onslaught of a genocidal Mexican state, differences between them and outsiders were thrown into high relief. But scholars have tended to project the hellish violence and racialized divisions of the nineteenth century back onto the very different colonial era. Evelyn Hu-DeHart's pioneering studies of Yaqui history consistently attempt to tell the story as one of intermittent Yaqui resistance and acquiescence to an overwhelming imperial power. This approach tends to diminish Yaqui power and Yaqui creativity in engaging with the Spanish, while at the same time underestimating the hardships Spaniards had to overcome in establishing a viable colony in the northwest. There was what White has called a "rough balance of power" between Spaniards and Yaquis for much of the colonial period, and this circumstance required great creativity of both parties in order for a viable colonial relationship to be established.¹⁶

More recent historical scholarship in northern Mexico has afforded scholars much guidance and context. Susan M. Deeds's *Defiance and Deference in Mexico's Colonial North* shows how five native groups in central northern Mexico confronted the imperial power and explores the ways in which two of them maintained an enduring cultural identity while three disappeared. Several insights emerge from her richly detailed narrative: those native peoples who launched apocalyptic campaigns of resistance to the Spanish were, over time, almost always crushed out of existence. Those who succumbed to Spanish acculturation too quickly soon lost their sense of who they were. Those who best weathered the storm of Spanish imperialism were those like the Tepehuanes and Tarahumaras, who balanced armed protest, selective appropriation of Spanish cultural forms, and measured, covert resistance. The Yaquis were masters of this deadly game and perhaps enjoyed even greater success at it than any of the peoples described by Deeds. Through a sophisticated mix of menace, negotiation, and exchange the Yaquis maintained their cultural and political autonomy in the face of Spanish invasion.¹⁷

Deeds's work lies at the confluence of two important streams of literature: that on the borderlands described above, which deals largely with the colonial and early independence periods of what is now the United States, and work on the engagement of ordinary or subaltern peoples with the governments they live under—a body of work that is perhaps most advanced in the study of postindependence Mexico. The latter body of work draws on an eclectic matrix of theorists, from the Subaltern Studies Group to Antonio Gramsci to Michel Foucault and James C. Scott, to show that ordinary people were not powerless in their relations with the states they lived within. They were ingenious and persistent in the ways they resisted, exploited, and collaborated with the representatives of government. As Deeds has shown, many of the intellectual tools deployed in the literature of the “negotiated state” are compatible with those of borderlands scholarship. But with notable exceptions, such as Deeds, Cynthia Radding de Murrieta, Eric Van Young, Yanna Yannakakis, and Peter Guardino, historians of the colonial period have made less use of these tools than they might have. *The Yaquis and the Empire* argues that by the eighteenth century the Yaquis had mastered the arts of smooth diplomacy and ironfisted rebellion that came into such broad use in the postindependence period.¹⁸

Throughout its history northwest Mexico has been a place of enormous biological, geological, and cultural wealth and has attracted a large, distinguished cadre of scholars. The historical literature of Sinaloa and Sonora provides crucial comparative and contextual information on the region's development. No synthesis can do justice to the richness of this literature, but three themes run through much of it and bear discussion in relation to the arguments of this book. From the earliest contacts between natives and invaders in the 1530s, the Spanish made note of the region's enormous potential for colonial exploitation. It offered fertile land, rich forests, bottomless mineral deposits, and, most important, large populations of Indians who could be dragooned for work in Spanish projects. Invaders also noted that a combination of distance from the centers of Spanish power, disunity among the region's native societies, and the ferocity of native resistance made it extremely difficult to exploit the area's abundant resources. The solution to these complicated problems of culture and political management was what Cynthia Radding de Murrieta has described as a “colonial pact,” a complex of “political ties between the Spanish Crown and Indian communities through which communities asserted certain basic claims to their means of livelihood and to a degree of local autonomy for their internal governance.” While assigning the preponderance of power to the Spanish, this colonial pact was the product of both negotiation and violence and required a large measure of active native participation.¹⁹

The themes of Sonoran wealth, Sonoran resistance to exploitation, and the emergence of a Sonoran colonial pact form the background to *The Yaquis and the Empire*. This book builds on earlier work by offering a detailed exploration of the nature of Yaqui cultural and material wealth, the peculiar ways in which the Yaquis resisted the empire, and the ingenious means by which Yaquis and Spaniards entered, negotiated, and renegotiated the colonial pact. Careful study of the Yaqui experience of Spanish imperialism reveals a story that is far more complex and interesting than a simple tale of Spanish oppressors and Yaqui rebels. Indeed it is only through the exploration of imperial ironies that one can begin to understand the aspirations of Juan Calixto Ayamea, the subtle, courteous Yaqui rebel, and Yaquis like him.

OVERVIEW

This book presents a chronological narrative of Yaqui engagement with the Spanish empire. Over the course of three hundred years all the actors in this colonial drama confronted profoundly surprising new realities. Some surprises were pleasant ones. Yaquis and Spaniards alike found aspects of one another's culture that they valued and came to adopt. Other surprises were almost unimaginably cruel. Eurasian disease decimated the Yaquis, shaking survivors to their core. Many would-be conquistadors were emotionally shattered when they came to grips with the contrast between their gilded dreams and their impoverished realities.

But more often than not, the surprises of Yaqui history took forms that mingled good and evil, misery and delight, success and failure. Chapter 1, "A Failed Conquest," explores the optimistic madness of the Spaniards who first tried to conquer northwest Mexico. Their brutality brought death and destruction to the region but also planted the seeds of future collaboration. Mestizo children, people with friends across the cultural divide, and chastened witnesses to frontier violence were the creators of a very different colony from that envisioned by the early conquistadors. Chapter 2, "A Mestizo Conquest," shows how this colony took shape. Rather than dominating the region by violence, the Spanish gained a foothold by participating in preexistent native diplomatic practices in which women and children crossed ethnic lines as collateral to peace agreements.

Jesuit priests were central to the negotiations that went on between the Spanish and the native peoples of the northwest. Chapter 3, "The Jesuit Reduction," puts Jesuit accounts of early contact with the Yaquis into perspective. Yaqui origin stories, read alongside newly discovered and rarely cited

documents, indicate that the Yaquis were deeply informed about the Spanish and were conflicted about conversion but in the end took sophisticated, decisive action when circumstances demanded it. Chapter 4, "Mission and Empire," follows the development of Yaqui-Spanish ties through the seventeenth century.

Chapter 5, "Cracks in the Foundation," analyzes two parallel developments in the history of the northwest: the transformation of imperial policy following the transition to Bourbon rule and the Yaquis' audacious attempts to take maximum advantage of the government's new laws. Yaquis understood they had much to gain from the new regime, and Jesuits quickly saw they had much to lose. In 1740 conflicts over how to respond to Bourbon policies erupted in violence. Yet even the most radical Yaquis sought not to drive out the empire but to seize control of their relations with it. Chapter 6, "'Now God Wants All This to End,'" follows the breakdown of negotiated peace among all factions in the Yaqui Valley and seeks to understand the meanings of the violence that ensued.

Chapter 7, "Reorientations," explores what is perhaps the least understood era of Yaqui history. After the rebellion of 1740 and the expulsion of the Jesuits in 1767, the Yaquis progressively appropriated the levers of power in the eight Yaqui towns. They worked extensively in the mines and enterprises of north Mexico and forged deep ties with the secular government. The final irony of this story is that the Yaquis' ties with outsiders were what made the Yaquis so dangerous to the government in the nineteenth century. It was not because the Yaquis were unconquered barbarians but because they were sophisticated operators within the colonial system that they had the means to defend themselves against a predatory Mexican state.

A NOTE ON NAMES

Studies like this one require much care in the use of proper names. Consider the term *Spain*. Many historians have pointed out that Spanish expeditions to the New World were diverse in composition and included Italians, Portuguese, Netherlands, Moroccans, and others. Indeed, each of these nationalities can be subdivided. The cultural differences between Basque, Catalan, and Andalusian Spaniards, for instance, were deep. Such subdivisions can be subdivided further still, into the parishes and families to which many so-called Spaniards were more loyal than they were to any region or empire. *Spanish* is thus a problematic term at best. For convenience, I use it to describe people from the Mediterranean region who participated in the conquest and colonization of the Americas under the auspices of the crown of Castile.²⁰

The word *Indian* is even more problematic. A by-product of European ignorance, the term nevertheless took on important meanings over time. I use this vague but useful word for two reasons: first, many people today who identify themselves as descendants of the aboriginal peoples of the Americas use it to describe themselves and take no offense when others use it to describe them; second, designation as an *Indio* had implications in Spanish-American law. *Indios*, for instance, were allowed to live on missions, while *Españoles* and *Mestizos* were not. I use the term to designate people who lived in the Americas before the arrival of Europeans, biological descendants of those first peoples, and people who were accepted by other Indians as members of native groups.

Wherever possible I try to describe people as they described themselves. But this also is hard to do. Neither the term *Yaqui* nor the political entity the term referred to existed in the same form before the arrival of the Spanish as afterward. There is little doubt that people who had a common language and who defended their territory collectively lived in what is now called the lower Yaqui Valley. For this reason and for the lack of a better alternative, I use the term *Yaqui* from the outset, though the word and its meaning were artifacts of a later period of history. In all instances my intent is to use the most common inoffensive proper names. This is at best a provisional solution to the problems of nomenclature I have encountered. Throughout the text I try to explain and justify the names I use, though inevitably my choices will differ from those others would make.²¹

A FAILED CONQUEST: THE NORTHWEST BEFORE THE JESUITS, 1500–1591

With burning woods our skies are brass,
The pillars of dust are seen;
The live-long day their cavalry pass—
No crossing the road between.
—Herman Melville, *"The Frenzy in the Wake"*

In the late summer of 1569 the settlers of San Juan de Carapoa decided they could endure no more. Five years before, they had traveled to this remote plot of land in the far northwest of New Spain in the hope of conquering fabulous kingdoms, winning immortal fame, and, in the process, getting rich. They had good reason to think they could live out their dreams. They had chosen the banks of the Río Sinaloa for their settlement, and, like all the river valleys of northwest Mexico, it was populous and fertile. Native people brought timber from pine and oak forests upriver to build palisades around their towns. One Spanish visitor described a native village of four hundred round houses of reed matting with fireplaces and vaulted roofs. A thousand men marched out from the town to greet the visitors. The warriors were spectacularly adorned with the feathers of parrots and sea birds, spears of brazil wood, bows, arrows, and obsidian-bladed swords. Cotton loincloths left their lean bodies all but naked, and their throats and ankles bore decorative conch shells and pearls. The chronicler placed equal emphasis on the exuberance, beauty, discipline, and menace of the native warriors. They greeted their visitors with great "order, joy, and harmony" and offered them gifts of wild game. This warm welcome led some to hope the conquest would be a

peaceful one. Their hopes rose when they realized the area had all the resources they needed for a successful colony: water, timber, fertile fields, wild game, and large numbers of native people to work in Spanish enterprises.¹

Indians at first seemed happy that the settlers had come, but things soon began to change. As the settlers started building their town and demanding tribute, natives resisted. They began to harass the new settlement. They shot arrows at the horses and cattle and burned outlying houses. "The Indians," wrote one settler, "did not serve or obey . . . with their customary care and interest." Soon even the simplest household chores became the occasion of terrifying native attacks. Tasks like fetching water, cutting wood, and planting corn had to be performed under an armed guard. When Indians sacked an outlying ranch, horsemen rode out and found the house in ruins. More than thirty dead bodies lay strewn across a nearby field.²

Antonio Ruíz was a teenager when he came to settle in San Juan de Carapoa with his father and was one of the very few who survived to write about his life there. He remembered the sleepless nights he passed beneath the stars as a lookout. He described the spread of hunger and fear through the settlement as supplies ran low. Finally, when life became unbearable, the community's leaders decided "to depopulate the place." They buried their heavy field guns and all their metal tools to keep them from falling into enemy hands. Then they began their journey south at dawn. Advance guards rode ahead. Rear guards protected the women and children, luggage, and livestock from any Indians who gave pursuit. "Having walked about a league," the old settler remembered, "we turned our eyes backward and saw a great cloud of smoke rising from the houses and boats the enemy was burning, and so we walked on with the greatest possible caution." Months of work were going up in flames.³

The herds—one hundred cows and five thousand sheep and goats—slowed the exodus. When the animals fell behind, some settlers were too terrified of enemy Indians to wait for them. Others feared poverty even more. When someone insisted that they wait for the livestock, voices rose in anger. A knife fight broke out. "Neither the holy fathers nor the screaming of the women could make peace among them," Ruíz recalled. The fighting stopped when an advance guard came galloping back in terror. "The whole world is against us!" he shouted, and he told of a legion of enemies coming to kill them all. "The women fell from their horses with their little children," wrote Ruíz, "and the men gathered them in the center of the group, our weapons drawn, determined to sell our lives dear." Rage and despair swept through the settler group as they prepared for a final confrontation. Antonio's father, Juan Ruíz, rode ahead to assess the enemy's strength. When he reined in his horse and squinted through

the sun and wind, something looked odd. He discerned a mounted warrior among the oncoming Indians and realized that he was looking at a Spaniard leading a party of native allies. Captain Álvaro de Tovar of Culiacán recognized Ruíz and spurred his horse forward to welcome the refugees. "He was well received by all," wrote the chronicler, "and we all embraced him, and the women in their happiness began to weep, but soon calmed down and rejoiced." The settlers had escaped with their lives. It would be years before anyone tried again to settle in San Juan de Carapoa.⁴

Chaos, terror, squalor, and, ultimately, failure marked the early years of Spanish colonialism in northwest Mexico. The failed settlement of San Juan de Carapoa was far more typical of Spanish imperial efforts in the sixteenth century than were the great victories of Hernán Cortés and Francisco Pizarro. In Sonora and throughout the Americas the grand designs of the conquistadors often ended in ashes and smoke. This chapter and the next explore the failures of Spanish colonialism in northwest Mexico and the agonizing process by which the invaders learned to survive there. These pages will also explore the wealth and power of the indigenous societies that flourished in Sinaloa and Sonora. This tale of Spanish weakness and native strength makes it possible to understand the development of the Yaqui people's relationship with the empire in later times. It was only when settlers accepted the terms of negotiation offered by native peoples that they could survive. Spaniards had to adopt native customs, offer goods that Indians wanted, and acclimate to a world that demanded both military strength and diplomatic tact. Only when these conditions were met could a colonial society be formed in northwest Mexico. Complex, violent, fraught with bitter irony and reversal, the history of the failed conquest of northwest Mexico formed the political soil in which the Yaqui mission grew.⁵

CONTACT

The region where the Yaquis and Spanish first met is made up by the present-day Mexican states of Sinaloa and Sonora. Taken together, they comprise three geographic zones: the dry coastal plains, the humid sierras, and the transitional piedmont between them. Rivers and streams meandering from northeast to southwest weave a rich geographical patchwork. In each subregion native peoples developed strategies of survival that evolved and were refined over the course of centuries. Seminomadic peoples dominated the arid plains, piedmont, and grasslands. Nomadic hunter-gatherers thrived on the coast from the mouth of the Yaqui River north to the Magdalena. Where water was more

abundant, in the humid sierras and in the river valleys, a sedentary way of life was possible (fig. 1).⁶

The coastal plains of Sinaloa and Sonora have often been described as a crossroads where the cultures of Mesoamerica met with those of what is now the U.S. Southwest. These plains were a conduit for the transmission of the Uto-Aztecan language group from the legendary northern territory of Aztlán south into the heartland of Mexico. This would later become a thoroughfare in what has been called the Aztatlán trade route connecting the Pueblo Indians of New Mexico with Casas Grandes, Sonora, Chihuahua, Durango, Nayarit, Jalisco, and ultimately with the Mesoamerican cities of Culhuacán and Cholula. In the sixteenth century this corridor became a route for the transmission of Spanish culture as well, a process that can be followed in the journeys of the region's first two European explorers. Northwest Mexico suffered the strange fate of being visited first by a regiment of Spain's most depraved, bloodthirsty lunatics and shortly thereafter by a band of Spain's most pacific, culturally sensitive, and open-minded pilgrims. The journeys of Diego de Guzmán and Álvaro Núñez Cabeza de Vaca incorporate both the human geography of northwest Mexico at the time of contact and the peculiarities of Spanish colonialism in the sixteenth century.⁷

Nuño de Guzmán and his less famous nephew Diego led expeditions that were typical of the many conquering *entradas* launched in the sixteenth century. The leaders of these crown-licensed, privately financed expeditions were almost always men with grandiose ambitions. Most often they also displayed extreme tolerance for risk, extraordinary physical stamina, and a callousness that verged on the sociopathic. Further complicating this story, these explorers were often intensely competitive among themselves. Thus conquistadors "exported" their rivals by commissioning them to explore regions as yet unseen. "The political dynamics of conquest," one historian has written, "promoted the amazingly rapid proliferation of Spanish *entradas*, expeditions by secular colonizers and by missionaries that might yet yield riches, status, or souls." Discordant passions drove them. Thirst for gold, rivalry with earlier conquerors, altruistic yearnings, desire for social precedence, and righteous hatred of the devil combined with hunger, thirst, and sexual desire as the main motives behind these expeditions. Added to this were an astonishing dearth of planning and a near total lack of sensitivity to local cultures. Taken together, these characteristics give one a fair idea of the destruction such expeditions wrought. Some conquistadors won treasure and glory beyond their wildest dreams: Pizarro held the Inca king Atahualpa for a ransom that has been estimated at eleven *tons* of gold. But much more often, *entradas* failed, brought



1. Northwest New Spain (Map by Bill Nelson)

their participants to starvation, or simply disappeared into the continent. Some explorers won nothing but infamy.⁸

Few conquistadors were more infamous than Nuño de Guzmán. His method was simple: he would search for Indians, defeat them in battle, steal their food, supplies, and anything else that seemed worth stealing, and then burn their town to the ground in order to prevent them from giving chase. In this brutal fashion, Guzmán and his party worked their way from Mexico City to the west coast of Mexico, where they turned north. When they reached what is now Sinaloa in 1531, Guzmán and his men founded the town of San Miguel de Culiacán on September 29 and remained in the region until 1533. Nuño then turned east and marched for the Caribbean coast province of Pánuco, while Diego headed north with a group of thirty horsemen into the arid lowlands by the Gulf of California. Two grim accounts of this journey survive. Laconic turns of phrase scattered through both texts suggested bloody futility: "The village was deserted . . . we captured an Indian to serve as a guide . . . we found corn in a hut . . . we burned the village and moved on . . . there was no water . . . the Indians injured ten horses and two men . . . Portillo was washed away in the river." The accounts told a tale of violent men in brutal conditions venting their fears and aspirations on a terrified local populace.⁹

Heading northward from Culiacán, Diego de Guzmán traveled through dry coastal scrubland and desert, a landscape formed by the weathering of an ancient mountain range. Still today, scattered remnants of limestone peaks jut up like islands in a sea of thorn forest. The land sloped gently to the west, with rivers smoothing alluvial plains and cutting deltas into the coastline. Rain came twice a year, heavy between July and September, lighter between November and February. Annual rainfall of twelve to sixteen inches made it possible for the land to host a remarkable variety of plant and animal life. As they rode through this arborial desert, Guzmán's party walked among varieties of grass, shrubs, trees, and cactus. Saguaro and organ pipe cactus thrived all over the region, and cardon cactus grew to sixty-five feet by the coast. Guzmán and his men could have hunted mule deer and white-tailed deer, cottontail rabbit and jackrabbit, raccoons and peccaries, pronghorn antelope and bighorn sheep. The presence of carnivores like the bobcat, cougar, coyote, gray wolf, and ocelot testified to the abundance of game to be found in northwest Mexico. Nonsedentary native peoples made the arid coastal plains their home. Cuna'ac and O'Odham peoples, later called, respectively, Seris and Pimas by the Spanish, developed cultures based on hunting, gathering, fishing, and seasonal migration according to the availability of desert and ocean products. The Jesuit chronicler Andrés Pérez de Ribas was astonished that these peoples lived most of the year without bread or any other grain, subsisting

on fresh and salted fish, eel grass, and cactus fruits. They nevertheless traded deer-skins and salt for maize with their inland neighbors.¹⁰

As Guzmán journeyed north, his party crossed four of the seven major rivers that flowed out of the Sierra Madre, across the lowlands, and into the Gulf of California. The river valleys contrasted sharply with the surrounding landscape. Whereas the plains were dominated by cacti, dry grasses, and low shrubs, the river valleys were lush with densely tangled vegetation. In the forests of the river valleys grew acacia, mesquite, willow, Brazil wood, cottonwood, ironwood, and “yellow-flowering palo verde trees.” Among these thrived smaller species like the copal and the “spindly red-flowering *ocotillo*.” Hanging vines covered many of the trees, reducing visibility in parts of these forests to a few yards. Dense patches of bamboo-like reeds stood near the water and were no easier for the Spanish to see through or pass through than the forests. The human population of these valleys was also distinct from that of the plains. Natives who spoke variants of a language the Spanish called Cáhita settled densely by the riverbanks. The prosperity of their villages was stunning to Spanish visitors. An eighteenth-century Jesuit wrote, “The fertility of Sonora is almost unbelievable. Since the land is almost astonishingly productive even with so little care, it is easy to imagine how great its fruitfulness would be were the soil tilled more diligently.” This riverine land was rich indeed, but the Jesuit was wrong to think that Indians did not cultivate it. By all accounts, Cáhita-speaking peoples pursued an unusual and highly productive kind of agriculture in the sixteenth century. Semiannual floods were so important to this way of life that one anthropologist has called them the “keystone of the Cáhita economic structure.” Near the coast, the rivers would overflow their banks twice a year, at times to a breadth of up to eight miles. During these floods the valleys turned into shallow lakes dotted with islands. As soon as the floodwaters receded, people planted crops of maize, beans, and squash on the damp levees using a traditional Mesoamerican digging stick.¹¹

To the abundant crops they harvested, Cáhita peoples added many kinds of wild game and plants. Pitahaya and prickly pear cactus fruits, ironwood seeds, mesquite pods, *guamuchil* pods, and the nut of the *jito* tree were among the wild plants enriching the Cáhita diet. Peccary, rabbit, hare, raccoon, squirrel, and, most important, deer were the main sources of wild meat. Deer acquired sacred meaning among many of the Cáhita subgroups, most notably the Yaquis. Groups of men hunted deer together, often using “fire drives” wherein fires were lit around a section of woods, and the hunters would follow the flames inward toward the center, killing whatever animals tried to escape. Many Cáhita peoples used weirs and nets to trap river fish. To the chagrin of later Jesuit

missionaries, the Cáhita peoples were quite familiar with a variety of fermented drinks, based variously on maize, the agave cactus, pitahaya fruits, and honey. Cáhita collective knowledge of their environment was thick and densely woven. According to a Jesuit dictionary of the Cáhita language, the region's native peoples had six words for waterfowl compared to the single one in Spanish, *pato*, or "duck." Cáhita had seventeen words for "bird" and nine for "tree." Among the variously named trees were one "which, when taken by mouth, is effective against pain in the molars," another whose "sap treats swelling caused by blows," another "whose sap serves to kill fleas," one "whose root serves to kill animals, such as lions or caymans," and one "whose milk serves as a poultice for women with pelvic discomfort." The peoples of the river valleys were deeply versed in the ways of the natural world they lived in and spun precise and meaningful knowledge from it.¹²

The rich rivers, forests, and soil of the river valleys supported high native populations. The lower Mayo and Yaqui River Valleys each hosted more than thirty thousand inhabitants. Daniel Reff has estimated the total population of lowland Sinaloa and Sonora at one hundred thousand. Largely because Guzmán and his party were so destructive, it is difficult to reconstruct the social, political, and material cultures of the various Cáhita-speaking peoples or the quality of relations among them. The cultural geographers Carl Sauer and Donald Brand made this point: "Our area was almost completely destroyed because it was overrun in 1530 and 1531 by about as hard a gang of killers as Spain let loose anywhere in the New World." Written and oral sources nevertheless offer some clues about the peoples Guzmán terrorized. Because floods caused the river courses to change from time to time, it was impossible for the natives who lived by them to build permanent settlements. Instead, they built *rancherías*, settlements that remained in place for a few years and then were moved as the river changed course. The key building material, still in use today, is that of the woven reed mat, or *petate*, which was often supported by wooden stakes and covered with dried mud to form walls. Dried wooden beams supported thatched roofs on some of these structures, while others used more easily disassembled lean-tos, which the Spanish called *ramadas*. Furnishings were spartan. Hanging shelves and rough pottery were used to store food, and reed and cane mats served for beds. Clothing among the Cáhita peoples was relatively simple but exhibited greater variation and ornamentation than seen in Cáhita buildings. Cáhita men wore little clothing other than a loincloth, grew their hair long, and wore necklaces and other jewels made from conchs, shells, and beads. Spaniards described men with ear and nose piercings among various Cáhita groups. Women wore skirts of

deerskin or cotton cloth and adornments of feathers, beads, shells, and pearls (figs. 2, 3).¹³

The clothing of the Cáhtas was indicative of both sophisticated craftsmanship and long-distance trade. The Yaqui ground loom consisted of four heavy wooden posts connected by two crossbeams with the warp stretched across them. Knowledge of weaving was also deployed in cane and wicker basketry and mat making. Pearls most likely came through trade with nonsedentary coastal people, and exotic feathers and turquoise through inland trade with highland Sonora, central Mesoamerica, and what is now the U.S. Southwest. The context in which such trade occurred is in equal measure important, intriguing, and difficult to pin down. Trade certainly did take place, as did intermarriage among native groups, captive exchange, and collective violence. Later Jesuit chroniclers observed that political leadership in the native towns of the northwest fell to war leaders and that war emerged from competition for land,



2. A Yaqui household ca. 1910. Several elements of this scene are attested in seventeenth-century Jesuit documents. Pérez de Ribas described houses made of mats of split cane or sticks, each with a *ramada* at its front that served as a kind of portal. Mats of the type at the right of the image were used as beds and hanging baskets for storage. (USC Digital Archive)



3. A Yaqui *ramada* ca. 1910. Jesuits measured the progress of native acculturation by the abandonment of this type of dwelling in favor of brick or adobe structures. Such ramadas were used nevertheless by all the semisedentary Cáhita peoples of Sinaloa and Sonora in the sixteenth century and remained in use into the twentieth. (USC Digital Archive)

resources, and people. The anthropologist Ralph Beals made the fascinating observation that the Cáhita word for “slave,” when in the plural, meant “riches,” an indication that captives were an indicator of wealth and status. He might also have added that the same Jesuit dictionary recorded a verb in the Cáhita language that meant “to enter a relationship of concubinage by stealing the woman” and used the following sentence to illustrate a point of Cáhita grammar: “A person fled carrying with him a stolen woman.” Warfare between neighboring towns and what scholars have called highland statelets was conducted with bows and hardwood arrows and spears, shields for defense, and a weapon called a *macuahuitl* by the Aztecs, simplified to *macana* by the Spanish, which was a hardwood club edged with shards of obsidian. A vicious poison derived from a local plant was in widespread use. The anthropologist Carroll Riley has described highland Sonora as a place of “extreme bellicosity, a region where

safety lay in alliance, military readiness, and in ever-present vigilance against all comers." There is little reason to believe the coastal lowlands were different. Warfare was a constant reality of native life in the Sinaloa and Sonora lowlands but was interwoven with ritualized patterns of trade, alliance, and captive exchange.¹⁴

Guzmán and his party had a dramatic introduction to native customs of warfare when they arrived at the Yaqui River on October 4, 1533. The explorers noted the large population that thrived by the river's shores and made the hasty judgment that it was hostile. Every study of the Yaqui people quotes the account of Jorge Robledo, one of Guzmán's henchmen, as evidence of Yaqui ferocity. There is some truth to this interpretation, and indeed there is much in Robledo's account that prefigured later developments in Yaqui history. But the account describes much more than Yaqui defiance of white intruders. The Yaqui response to the advent of the Spanish was a sophisticated mix of menace and diplomatic curiosity. Thousands of armed Indians confronted the Spanish and began to throw fistfuls of dirt into the air, drawing their bows and grimacing fiercely:

From among them there emerged an Indian distinguished from the others by a black *sambenito* like a scapulary, which was sown [*sembrado*] with meticulously crafted conchs of pearls, [representing] many little dogs, deer and many other things, and since it was the morning, and the sun shone on him, the garment glittered in the manner of silver, and he had his bow and quiver of arrows, and a well-crafted staff in his hand, and he came ruling over the people. We came together to the distance of two stone's throws; and since we were so close, this Indian who governed the others stepped out in front of all and with his bow he made a very long line in the ground, and he knelt on it and kissed the ground, and after doing this he rose up, and, standing up he and his people began to speak, telling us to stop, that we would not pass by that line he had made, and that if we did pass, they would kill us all.

Through an interpreter Guzmán tried to tell the Yaquis that he did not want a fight. The Yaquis replied that they would bring out something to eat. They went on to tell the Spanish to remain where they were and that they would come tie up the Spanish horses. They took out cords for the purpose, and they seemed "to have great arrogance among them," wrote Robledo. Guzmán himself recalled this meeting as being even more confrontational than Robledo did. He said he offered terms of peace to the Yaquis, only to receive the reply that they wanted to kill him. The Yaquis then brought out an Indian captive who had been serving the Spanish as a guide and threw him to the ground.¹⁵

Spanish perceptions aside, there is little reason to think that violence was inevitable. Many accounts of Spanish exploration in the northwest described episodes almost identical to this one, in which large groups of Yaqui and other native groups met the Spanish at a distance from their towns. This show of strength, with shouting, dancing, and arrows shot into the air, was often followed by a warm welcome. The line the Yaqui leader drew in the sand seemed to be a hostile gesture followed by threats, but it stretches credulity to think Robledo had any idea what it meant. What is clear is that the Spanish were terrified and only dimly understood what was unfolding before them. Greater calm might well have made the meeting a peaceful one.¹⁶

Guzmán was not a man disposed to calm diplomacy, and his fear soon turned into aggression. When the Indians tried to tie up the Spanish horses, “we gave the *Santiago*,” Robledo wrote, invoking the old war cry of the Spanish *reconquista*, and attacked. Guzmán claimed to have put the Indians to flight with ease, but Robledo recorded, “These Indians fought as well and with as much spirit as any Indians I have seen since I arrived in the Indies, and I have never seen any Indians fight as well as they.” The report went on to say that the Yaquis wounded twelve and killed one of the Spaniards’ seventeen horses and that they would have done more damage had it not been for the flatness of the battleground, a circumstance that favored Spanish cavalry. The Spanish camped for seventeen days near the Yaqui River, resting and recovering from the battle. During these days an old man arrived saying he wanted to meet with Guzmán. Guzmán asked him to come back in two days’ time. The Yaqui messenger complied, and when he came back he delivered a gift of three maces adorned with turquoise. He also offered some beads made of bone, then left, never to return.¹⁷

The precise meaning of these gifts is unknowable, but it is clear that the Yaquis were willing both to defend their lands and to deal diplomatically with outsiders. It is in this sense that historians have so often misconstrued the events of 1533. Most have read them as the first skirmish in an ever-escalating series of confrontations between indomitable Yaquis and greedy white men. But the incidents of 1533 were much more complicated than that. Yaqui attitudes toward Guzmán included threats, tactical retreat, and offers of food, valuables, and diplomacy, a point to keep in mind in examining the later colonial history of the Yaqui people and their neighbors. Guzmán’s exploration up and down the Yaqui River came to nothing. The Yaqui towns did not yield any gold or silver, prosperous though they may have been. Guzmán and his men were exhausted, frustrated, and hungry, and so they turned back to begin their journey south.¹⁸

Álvar Núñez Cabeza de Vaca approached the Yaqui River from the opposite direction and with the opposite attitude to that of Diego de Guzmán. He and

his men were the last survivors of a shipwrecked expedition to conquer Florida. When they meandered into Sonora in 1536, they had been walking across the continent for close to seven years. Disease, hunger, and hostile Indians had slowly decimated them. Somehow Cabeza de Vaca and his men persuaded various native groups to support them. They crossed the Mississippi on rafts before being shipwrecked once again on the gulf coast of Texas. Nothing could be farther from the experience of the murderous Guzmán party than that of Cabeza de Vaca on the shores of the Gulf of Mexico: "The Indians," he wrote, "on seeing the disaster that had befallen us and the disaster that was upon us with so much misfortune and misery, sat down among us. And with the great grief and pity they felt on seeing us in such a state, they all began to weep loudly and so sincerely that they could be heard a great distance away. And this lasted more than half an hour, and truly, to see that these men, so lacking in reason and so crude in the manner of brutes, grieved so much for us, increased in me and in others of our company even more the magnitude of our suffering and the estimation of our misfortune." What began as a quest for gold and glory thus became a penitential journey. Cabeza de Vaca told a tale in which misery brought the voyagers into communion with their fellow human beings and with God. The would-be conquistadors were stripped of their possessions and reduced to dependence on the kindness of strangers. It is hard to know how they survived, what they ate, and how they communicated with the peoples they met, but they somehow acquired an entourage of native people who regarded Cabeza de Vaca as a kind of holy man. These native followers gave him indispensable guidance and support as the party moved south across the Rio Grande into highland Sonora.¹⁹

Around 1536 Cabeza de Vaca and his party wandered into the region of the headwaters of the Yaqui River, an area then densely settled with sedentary farmers. The inland landscape of Sonora was generally cooler, wetter, and more mountainous than that of the coast, precipitation reaching forty inches annually. "On the high hills," a Jesuit later wrote, "where a cooler atmosphere prevails, there grow in abundance the finest oaks, firs, and pines, so tall they almost touch the clouds." It was "very rough, has countless steep cliffs, and is cut through in many places by very deep holes and chasms." Travel was nightmarish. Later accounts tell of nomadic Indians using the sierras as hideouts, places "from which these monsters creep forth, invade the country, and do much harm, robbing and murdering." Inland Sonora was rich in timber and materials but was guarded by rugged landscape and dangerous native peoples.²⁰

On reaching the upper Yaqui River, Cabeza de Vaca made note of prosperous towns, large buildings, and storehouses of maize, beans, and squash. Baltasar de

Obregón, a later explorer, described the highland town of Oera as “made up of good flat-roofed houses about an *estado* and a half in height and excellently grouped. Their plantations are well provided with canals used for irrigating them. They gather a great deal of corn, chick-peas, melons, calabashes, and other vegetables.” Excavation on ruins near the Sonora River has confirmed Obregón’s observations on native material culture and social organization. Archaeologists working on the Sonora River Cultures have found some two hundred settlements on mesas adjacent to a thirty-mile stretch of the river. These towns overlooked cultivated plains and ranged widely in size: some had as few as nine houses, others as many as two hundred, all on rectangular stone foundations. These buildings had walls probably made of adobe bricks and flat roofs thatched with palm fronds. Some of the settlements came together to form statelets, which both warred and traded with one another. Pottery evidence suggests that these entities thrived between 1350 and 1550 and may well have been inhabited when Cabeza de Vaca passed through.²¹

The travelers followed the Yaqui River southwest out of the sierras and stopped at a town in the foothills, probably near the convergence of two of the river’s tributaries. There, natives offered a gift of five hundred deer hearts to one of Cabeza de Vaca’s men. Cabeza de Vaca christened the town Corazones for this gift. Soon thereafter the wanderers came across an Indian wearing a necklace with a Spanish buckle and horseshoe nail. This was the first indication that, after years of walking, they might soon rejoin their countrymen. Rolena Adorno and Patrick J. Pautz argue that this meeting took place in the region of today’s Obregón Dam, about six miles northeast of the present-day site of BÁCUM, the nearest Yaqui town. Asked where he got these trophies, the man said they had been brought by bearded men from the sky who came with horses, lances, and swords and that the sky people had stabbed two of his people. This may be indicative of further slaving incursions since 1533, but it is also plausible that the man had taken the nail and buckle as spoils from the Yaquis’ battle with Guzmán.²²

Whatever the case may be, Cabeza de Vaca and his party crossed the Yaqui River and walked south, where they found desolate, burning towns, emaciated people, and abandoned fields. These victims of Spanish slavers were so miserable, they “wished to die.” They nevertheless gave the travelers beads and robes they had hidden from the Christian predators and told of the destruction of their villages and the enslavement of their people. The geography in question is impossible to pin down, but there is reason to believe that Cabeza de Vaca’s group was then led to the Yaqui people. The destitute Indians south of the Yaqui River:

showed very great pleasure with us, although we feared that when we arrived at the ones who held the frontier against the Christians and were at war with them, they would treat us cruelly and make us pay for what the Christians were doing to them. But since God our Lord was served to bring us to them, they began to fear and respect us as the previous ones had done, and even somewhat more, about which we were not a little amazed, by which it is clearly seen that all these peoples, to be drawn to become Christians and to obedience to the Imperial Majesty, must be given good treatment, and that this is the path most certain and no other. These people took us to a village that is in the cleft of a mountain. And it is necessary to climb very rugged terrain in order to reach it. And here we found many people who were gathered together, having taken refuge out of fear of the Christians. They received us very well and gave us everything they had, and they gave us more than two thousand loads of maize that we gave to those wretched and starving ones who had brought us there.

If these “ones who held the frontier against the Christians” were the same people who battled Diego de Guzmán by the Yaqui River, this passage is enormously suggestive about Yaqui attitudes toward the invaders: when visitors displayed a modicum of respect and willingness to be friends, the people of the Yaqui River were eminently willing to respond in kind.²³

An extraordinary piece of circumstantial evidence suggests that the “ones who held the frontier” were indeed the people of the Yaqui River. Throughout their modern history the Yaqui people, as noted, have called non-Yaquis *Yoris*. Edward Spicer writes that by the late nineteenth century, the word came to mean “everything evil and inhuman that could be attributed to men and women.” The violence the Yaqui suffered at the hands of Mexicans in this period had a powerful effect on the meaning of the word, sharpening the moral contrast between admirable Yaquis and perfidious outsiders. A rarely cited document from 1614 written by the Jesuit Vicente de Águila suggests the word *Yori* (plural, *Yorim*) was centuries older than Spicer knew. Describing Cabeza de Vaca’s visit to Sinaloa, Águila wrote, “And as our Lord had worked some miracles for [Cabeza de Vaca and his followers], the people saw them as something from the sky, and they followed them and never left them. And those who came with them remained to settle in this land. And from this, as some say, was born the practice of calling Spaniards *Yorim*, from the verb *yore*, which means to cure; because [Cabeza de Vaca] healed the sick; though other reasons are given for this name; because *yorim* also means brave, *item* wild beasts, like lions or tigers, and finally, demons.” Several interpretive leaps must be made in order to identify Cabeza de Vaca’s interlocutors as Yaquis. But it is certainly plausible

to surmise that the people who “held the frontier” against Guzmán and those who called the Spaniards Yorim, were one and the same and were the people of the lower Yaqui River. If so, they did not express any instinctive hostility to outsiders and were quite willing to become generous friends.²⁴

Cabeza de Vaca’s party soon moved south, where they were arrested by Spaniards and taken to Mexico City for questioning. Thereafter, Cabeza de Vaca wrote his famous *Account*, now a classic text of early colonial America. The *Account* (1542) was immediately recognized both for its charm as a story of survival and for its value as a guide to the exploration of North America. A Jesuit letter of 1593 described Cabeza de Vaca’s lasting influence on the native people of northwest Mexico and held him up as an ideal for Jesuit emulation. The Jesuit wrote that pagan Indians had been deeply impressed by Cabeza de Vaca’s exorcism of a demon and still wore crucifixes to ward off the evil spirit sixty years later. True or not, the story captured the admiration many Jesuits felt for Cabeza de Vaca. They saw him as a man able to influence native people through kindness, charity, and respect for local customs. The chronicler Pérez de Ribas contrasted the savagery of the Guzmán expedition with the humility of Cabeza de Vaca’s. Cabeza de Vaca had wandered for years among barbarian tribes, the Jesuit wrote, healing the sick through prayer, attracting Indians to the faith through Christlike gentleness. The Jesuit wrote admiringly that Cabeza de Vaca looked more like an Indian than a Spaniard by the end of his journey and that he spoke his native Spanish poorly. For the Jesuits, Cabeza de Vaca’s genius lay in the partial adoption of native customs as a means of disseminating the Christian faith. They saw this approach as both saintly and effective and made concerted efforts to imitate it.²⁵

Cabeza de Vaca’s writings had admirers outside the Jesuit order as well. Among the earliest and most avid readers of the *Account* was the famous explorer Francisco Vázquez de Coronado. Coronado and, later, Fray Marcos de Niza and Francisco de Ibarra, looked to the *Account* as a guide to north Mexico. Diego Martínez de Hurdaide, a conquistador of the late sixteenth century, drew on Cabeza de Vaca’s writings to get the lay of the land. He wrote in 1616 that the Villa de San Felipe y Santiago was near a village built by Indians whom Cabeza de Vaca had converted to Christianity. He wrote in 1622 that his own observations on Sinaloa conformed entirely to those of Cabeza de Vaca’s writings. The land, he wrote, comprised valleys, plains, and sierras full of people well disposed to become Christians. Thus Cabeza de Vaca’s pacific narrative was appropriated to a soldier’s argument for conquest. The visits of Guzmán and Cabeza de Vaca set patterns of Spanish behavior that recurred through the sixteenth century: savage attack followed by disastrous retreat on the one hand

and sensitive listening followed by incremental colonization on the other. Each method had its exponents well into the seventeenth century. Jesuit missionaries who arrived in the 1590s followed in the footsteps of Cabeza de Vaca. But before the Jesuits arrived, violent losers in the mold of Diego de Guzmán held sway.²⁶

CHILDREN OF GUZMÁN

One after another, expeditions set out from central Mexico for the far northwest, heavily armed and hell-bent on conquest, and one by one they all failed. Sonora's would-be conquistadors were ignorant of the territory and distant from their bases in central Mexico. More important, they made the mistake of modeling their expeditions on that of Cortés, whose conquest of the Aztec empire planted in their minds the idea that they too could conquer fabulous kingdoms with a handful of Spanish soldiers and the help of friendly native tribes. But the native political structures of northwest Mexico were very different from those of the central region. Most northwestern Indians did not live in hierarchical, nucleated villages and had no experience of paying tribute to an overlord. Whereas Cortés usurped the throne of a preexistent empire, seizing all the mechanisms for the extraction of tribute and co-optation of local lords, Spaniards in northwest Mexico confronted a loose network of villages that were often at war with one another. Violence, trade, and intermarriage certainly occurred among distinct native peoples in the northwest, but none of them ever established hegemony over the rest. Accordingly, the conquest could never come to a close, as it did in the Valley of Mexico, and normal colonial relations could never be established. Conquistadors could desolate a village and try to settle in it, but they were forever vulnerable to their neighbors. Their distance from reinforcements and their failure to attract new colonists compounded these problems. A single bad harvest or native raid could wipe them out.²⁷

San Miguel de Culiacán was one of the few early Spanish settlements in the northwest that survived, and it would serve as a staging ground for further expeditions to the north. In the 1530s and 1540s a handful of explorers passed through Culiacán on their way to Sinaloa and Sonora. Diego de Hurtado was felled by a mutiny among his men. Fray Marcos de Niza survived his voyage to the northwest but found nothing to keep him there. Francisco Vázquez de Coronado founded a town near the Valle de Corazones on his way north and left a lieutenant to rule it, but the camp was soon obliterated by an Indian attack. Francisco de Ibarra was the most formidable of the early explorers. He was an ambitious young man with funding from his wealthy Vizcayan father and a fortune he himself had made in the Zacatecas silver boom. But Ibarra's funds,

bravery, and wit bought him nothing but a comprehensive failure. His expedition demonstrated in great detail four basic realities in the early history of the northwest: first, Sinaloa and Sonora were heavily populated by a network of native peoples who served no single lord; second, the region offered both enormous potential resources for a colonizing people and enormous obstacles to their exploitation; third, even the most aggressive and well-equipped European invaders were totally dependent on the help of native peoples for their survival; and fourth, failures though they were, these Spanish entradas brought livestock, diseases, and extensive political disruption to the region's native peoples.²⁸

Two extraordinary chronicles recorded Ibarra's travails in the northwest. Baltasar de Obregón's *Historia de los Descubrimientos* was a skilled, highly literate narrative that deployed the conventions of chivalric romance to burnish Ibarra's reputation. The second was the rarely cited *Relación* of Antonio Ruíz, the young settler of San Juan de Carapoa. This document shared much with the writings of Bernal Díaz del Castillo, the chronicler of the conquest of the Aztecs. Like Díaz, Ruíz was intelligent but not well educated, and like *The True History of the Conquest of New Spain*, Ruíz's memoirs presented a vivid foot soldier's account of conquest. The writings of Díaz and Ruíz comprised stark moments of ugliness, shame, and dark irony that elite chroniclers tended to omit and so are indispensable to historians' understanding of their subject matter.²⁹

Francisco de Ibarra invested eight years of his life in the exploration of the northwest. He founded the Villa de Durango, which would become the capital of the province Ibarra named Nueva Vizcaya after his ancestral home. In 1564 Ibarra led one hundred Spanish soldiers and a large number of native auxiliaries west from Durango, across the Sierra de Topia, and down into Culiacán. There they met with the town governor, Juan de Tovar, who provided horses, mules, food, and gunpowder. Ibarra then rode north to Petatlán, where, a league from the town, six hundred native warriors greeted him and offered him and his army "great respect, ceremonies, and offerings." The natives treated him to "kindness and affection," offering shelter, gifts, food, and servants. In territory so totally dominated by Indians, such hospitality would be crucial to Ibarra in the months to come.³⁰

Ibarra's most important acquisition in Petatlán was a new translator. The woman the Spanish would come to know as La India Luisa would play a leading role in the history of sixteenth-century north Mexico. She knew Nahuatl and three other languages spoken in the area. Ibarra had Nahuatl speakers among his men and immediately recognized Luisa's value. Obregón's account of this woman's role in various native towns is enlightening:

This river and town of Ocoroni were governed and ruled by Luisa, the interpreter, wife of the *caudillo* and leader of this town, because of the advantages she had in policy, reason, and plans in the use and exercise of war, and which were recognized in her by the other natives, and for these causes and reasons she was held in greater esteem and respect than the native women of those provinces. She gave order and plans in many cases, and things that the natives did not guess at and were ignorant of, and for these advantages she was desired, and held, and obeyed by all the leaders and *caudillos* of these provinces and parts where she was a captive, and in all of them she was always *cacica*, captainess, and leader, and wife of them. . . . And some of the old ones affirm that she was a native of the villa of Culiacán, from which she fled to Ocoroni in order to escape service and tribute. She was skilled in the secrets and languages of two hundred leagues of those provinces from Ocoroni to the Valleys of Señora and Corazones, near the plains of the cows; and she served in the voyage from her pueblo, there and back, with great fidelity, truthfulness, care, and solicitude.

Luisa was a woman caught between worlds, traded and exploited by the many groups she came in contact with. But the unsettled world of the northwest opened avenues of power to her. She became a valued member of each community she lived in, rendering indispensable services to various Spanish expeditions. Obregón's language reflected the ambiguities of her position as at once a slave and a leader: she was intensely desired (*codiciada*) as both a captive and a captain. She was *tenida*, a term that can mean both "held" and "respected." Luisa and women like her would play increasingly vital roles in the late sixteenth century and early seventeenth, when Spaniards at last learned to value diplomatic ties with native groups.³¹

Luisa accompanied Ibarra north from the Río Petatlán to the Río Fuerte. There, on June 24, 1564, Ibarra founded the town of San Juan de Carapoa and distributed *encomiendas* to his men. The region's fertile fields and large population made Carapoa seem a propitious site, and rumors of silver mines made it irresistible. Ibarra himself headed south to explore the mines of Chiametla and would return a year later. Antonio Sotelo de Betanzos, the man Ibarra left in charge, soon realized that the settlement was surrounded by hostile Indians and developed a rough technique of controlling the environment. He tried to gain his neighbors' trust with "promises, gifts, kindnesses, and by defending them from the harm inflicted on them by their enemies." When the Indians failed to respond positively, Sotelo retaliated. He and his men first attacked the town of Tehueco and took women and children hostage as a diplomatic gambit. When men came from Tehueco to negotiate, Sotelo told them he still wanted to be

friends. He said he wanted to rule them in a spirit of justice, reason, and harmony and handed the hostages over. Sotelo went on to carry out a series of similar attacks on other native towns, his aim being to make contact with the local Indians, to impress on them the terrifying power of the Spanish empire, and then to relent, holding out the hope of a mutually advantageous friendship. The strategy was a partial success: the community survived, but it subsisted in a state of perpetual hunger and dread. Sotelo visited sentries at all hours of the night and traveled through the surrounding region, "not stopping by day or sleeping by night, nervous, suspicious, and ever prepared." The chronicler cited this as proof of Betanzos's merit. But the fact that merit was to be gained through unrelenting vigilance says something about the quality of life in San Juan de Carapoa.³²

By the time Ibarra returned in the spring of 1565, Sotelo had made tenuous alliances with some of the nearby Indians. The cavalry and infantry of Carapoa greeted Ibarra in formation with a brilliantly feathered and pearl-adorned group of "savage Indians" who staged a mock battle with the Spanish, with much shouting, dancing, music, and guns and arrows shot into the sky. Obregón and all other commentators were untroubled by the degree of cultural mixing on display. Towns such as this had to become culturally mixed in order to survive.³³

San Juan de Carapoa was to be the base camp for the conquest of Sonora. Departing for the north in the spring of 1565, Ibarra brought sixty men armed with harquebuses, a few small cannon, and iron for horseshoes along with two hundred pack and saddle horses. The soldiers were divided into groups of four or five, each accompanied by an Indian servant to prepare their meals. A Spaniard named Diego de Soberanes and Luisa of Ocoroni came as translators. Ibarra's plan was to head north, cross the Mayo River, and then follow the Yaqui River inland to Corazones and from there to discover realms of gold. A full account of Ibarra's journey cannot fit into a study of this scope, but episodes covering the steady disintegration of Ibarra's illusions, health, and sanity illustrate the horrors of this expedition.³⁴

Ruíz gave a crucial description of Ibarra's dealings with the Yaqui people that Obregón and hence all subsequent accounts of Yaqui history have omitted: "And so [Ibarra] reached the province of Yaquim where the Indians of those regions and province took up arms like the bellicose people they are, and the governor spoke through the tongue of an Indian named Luisa, native of the province of Culiacán, and this woman served as interpreter during the whole journey with much fidelity, and so all the people of this river became peaceful and gave to the said governor maize, beans, and other supplies . . . and without any further incident he moved on." The Yaquis had already gained a reputation for bellicosity by the mid-sixteenth century but were also perfectly amenable to

diplomatic relations with their neighbors. They were generously supplied with food and had both the means and desire to share. Though the confrontation with Diego de Guzmán in 1533 had been more dramatic, the Yaqui encounter with Ibarra was more typical of Yaqui attitudes toward outsiders. They were prepared for war but always ready to talk and trade.³⁵

Ibarra and his party marched up the Yaqui River and far into the interior of Sonora. There they found multitudes of Sonora River people with rich material cultures and complex systems of kinship, trade, and intercommunity violence. In one town the Indians displayed cotton blankets and mantles of "extremely white and brilliant agave thread" and flourished colorful feather crests. In another, Ibarra found slaves confined to wooden stocks and learned that they were often sold to other communities for blankets, salt, feathers, and provisions. Production, consumption, commerce, captivity, and war were all woven together in a ritual fabric. The chronicler Obregón described native towns as being both glamorous and terrifying. The Spaniards were impressed with such luxuries as the caged parrots and eagles they observed in one town and filled with dread by native poison arrows. Those injured by them died in convulsions or watched in horror as the flesh rotted and fell away from their wounds. The Spaniards were appalled by the corpses, heads, arms, legs, and ears they saw displayed in the streets of the town of Cumupa. The more they learned, the less the Spanish trusted Cabeza de Vaca's glowing praise of highland Sonora. Cabeza de Vaca had written of green fields and friendly people, but all Obregón saw was a desert of barren rocks and treacherous, naked savages.³⁶

Spanish morale reached its nadir at the ancient ruins of Paquimé. Ibarra's men had fed on hope. Their hardships seemed bearable as long as they could imagine a glorious victory somewhere over the horizon. They had been told by native informers that Paquimé, or Casas Grandes, was the capital of a wondrous kingdom. They were devastated when they found that Paquimé was a windblown ruin. Obregón wrote, "They totally lost their good hopes when they saw that it was not inhabited to the degree they had so desired and imagined, such that they regretted ever coming." The shattering of Ibarra's hopes gave way to a sober assessment of his plight: he saw that Sonora was a place of remarkable abundance but that its social structures and geography did not lend themselves to colonial exploitation. Their morale destroyed, Ibarra and his men decided to return to the lower Yaqui Valley, the one place in Sonora they thought would be worth conquering.³⁷

The journey out of the sierras was horrendous. When the explorers ran out of food, they subsisted on mushrooms and acorns. When all else failed, they slit a horse's throat, gathered its blood in bowls, and waited for the animal to collapse. Nothing went unused. "We lost the loathing and fear of eating sweet

and spongy horseflesh and we ate it without salt or chile, which we had exhausted months earlier." It got worse as the weeks dragged on. Ibarra ate a poisonous mushroom, flew into a delirium, and tried to jump into a bonfire, only to be tackled by his men. When the party tried to ford the rain-swollen Yaqui River, the remaining horses were lost in a "furious whirlpool." Ibarra broke down in tears, told his men the loss was God's punishment for their sins and that they were free to do whatever they liked. They "entertained no hope of leaving that great sierra," wrote Obregón, but they marched on. They got lucky when they captured an Indian and forced him to lead them to a town with storehouses of corn, squash, and beans. They gorged themselves on the uncooked supplies and collapsed. Days later, they found a hidden cache of salt and poured it into their parched mouths by the handful.³⁸

Only after "untold suffering, famine, and danger" did the Spaniards finally arrive at the lower Yaqui River. The pitiful state of the explorers is important to keep in mind when reading Obregón's ecstatic description of the Yaqui Valley. It is most often quoted as evidence of a conquistador's desire to exploit a vibrant native people. But it is more usefully read as evidence of the extreme weakness of the Spaniards' position. Ibarra sent messengers ahead to the Yaquis in order to avoid provoking them. The Yaquis responded with a message of welcome and said Ibarra would be greeted warmly. Five hundred "striking and handsome Indians" emerged to greet the Spaniards:

They wore their customary brilliant plumes, conchs, beads, and seashells, and were well armed with weapons, though they wore little clothing, since they harvest little cotton. The general received them with much love and many gifts. This Río de Yaquimi is the most populous of all those the general traveled to, with fifteen thousand men in the ten leagues from the sea toward the sierra. There is a forested area of great freshness a quarter of a league [wide] and a cool river with quantities of good fish, and its shores are populated by many cultivated fields of corn, beans, and squash. The people are affectionate [*amorosa*] and the women beautiful; the women go naked, their long hair hanging to their waists, and they cover their secret places with green grass. The general visited this river down to the sea, in which we found branches of coral and many pearl-bearing shells. They gave to the Christians much game, fish, and other things to eat that they have in their land, and the general, having seen the large numbers of people and supplies, looked to settle a town, as was agreed in Paquimé.

To men who had undergone the kind of punishment Ibarra had endured, the Yaqui towns were almost inexpressibly attractive. Ibarra would have loved

to conquer them, but he was in no position to do so. Like Spanish Gullivers, they found themselves washed up, half dead, on the shores of a wondrous foreign land.³⁹

The Yaquis persuaded Ibarra and his men to stay a while longer. Ibarra agreed and began making plans for a settlement among the Yaquis. He sent word to his base in the south to send soldiers, tools, ammunition, and molds for adobe bricks. But he abandoned the idea when word came back that Carapoa was on the verge of collapse. Swallowing this latest disappointment, Ibarra asked the Yaquis for a guide to lead them south, but they demurred:

It pained them for the Christians to leave their land, and they asked the general not to leave, and said they would provide food for all as long as they wanted to stay in their lands, to which [Ibarra] responded that he would soon return to stay with them. And disappointed with this, they gathered two thousand brave and handsome warriors, armed with their customary weapons, whom they ordered to go out to the road for a hunting expedition to see us off, and to celebrate with us, and also to go and devastate their enemies of Mayonbo, for which cause and hope they were so generous to us, and the general entertained them with the idea that he would help them in their wars with their enemies. And on the beaches and plains that are near a bay, the two thousand Indians fanned out across a quarter league, and when we saw them, we suspected they were going to war, such that the soldiers were unsettled and took up their arms. And since the guides knew that it was a celebration they were preparing for us, they told the Christians not to be suspicious, and that the Indians were preparing to celebrate us with a hunt, and so the hunters began to execute the hunt, in which they surrounded a marsh with great shouting, celebration, and agility, such that in a short while, they took and killed many deer, hares, rabbits, quail, all of which they presented to the general in quantities, and some of them still alive. This was the most brilliant and elegant hunt that I have ever seen.

In their dealings with Ibarra the Yaquis deployed many of the tactics they would use time and again over the course of the colonial period. They seem to have been well informed about the Spanish and knew how useful the Christians could be in their dealings with their enemies. The Yaquis were able to mobilize large numbers of people for collective projects, military and otherwise. In their diplomatic performances, they established dominance through abundant generosity, spectacular displays of force, and ostentatious collective discipline.⁴⁰

The chronicler's tone of amused surprise and his focus on the Indians' feathers and baubles disguised the fact that the Yaquis were in a position of dominance. The Yaquis expected recompense for their generosity, and they compelled Ibarra and his men to join them in an attack on the Mayos:

The general was powerless to make them return to Yaquimi, and so the next day he marched with the army through a notable growth of *chiltecpin* woven together with wild tunal cacti and spiny trees, such that it was necessary to slash and blaze a trail, and even though the Indians helped, it was hard going. The Río de Yaquimi is twenty leagues from that of Mayonbo, which those of the Yaquimi entered with great fierceness and rage, killing, robbing, and destroying the people, fields, and houses of their enemies, such that the general only stopped them with much work and many threats. The destruction stopped, and he made them friends, and as a sign of friendship, they exchanged the captives they had taken in their battles. And as a sign of truce, each gave bows and arrows to the other.

Ibarra counted three thousand Indians on the rich, fertile Mayo River and promised to protect its people from their Yaqui enemies. Much in this encounter prefigured future developments in Yaqui history: Yaqui manipulation of Spaniards for their own advantage; Yaqui-Spanish military cooperation; captive exchange as a prelude to peace; Spanish claims of freedom and success despite abundant evidence of their submission and frustration.⁴¹

After seven months of exploration, Ibarra moved south the winter of 1565–66, issuing an empty promise to return. Ibarra's travails dramatized the Spanish predicament: the colonizers were few, isolated, and ignorant, while native peoples were numerous, well adapted to the natural environment, and involved in continual exchange and violence among themselves. There was no Aztec empire to usurp, no preexistent systems of imperial control to take over, and so whatever gains the Spanish made could quickly be reversed. The disunity of the native peoples made it impossible for the Spanish to thrive in northwest Mexico. There were, however, some ways in which conflicts among native peoples could be used to Spanish advantage. Much as Ibarra inserted himself into the conflict between the Yaquis and Mayos, later conquerors would use alliances as the basis for their survival in the north. Ibarra himself never profited from this advancement in political knowledge. He went on to conquer the Xiximes of Nueva Vizcaya, to found several important towns, and to discover a string of lucrative mines throughout northern Mexico. Many of these settlements outlived Ibarra himself, who died in 1575 at the age of thirty-six.⁴²

SINALOA AFTER IBARRA

The town of Carapoa did not thrive in its founder's absence. After Ibarra left for Nueva Vizcaya, Carapoa's *encomenderos* tried in vain to build a viable community. Some Indians cooperated, some fled, and some retaliated against

the Spanish for their presumption. After the death of Pedro de Tobar, a bespectacled encomendero known as Four Eyes, whose wild beard and barbaric temper terrified the Indians, the settlement began its terminal decline. Beginning around 1569, raiders started killing cattle and setting fire to the settlers' homes at night. In the subject town of Orobato, the Tehuecos killed the Franciscan Fray Pablo de Santa Maria, his mulatto attendant Gregorio, and thirty servants, including men, women, and children. The only one to survive was a boy from the Yaqui River named Bernardino, who had been raised as a son by a Franciscan priest. Bernardino hid and escaped at night with a horse, saddle, reins, and spurs taken from the priest's effects. He would join Antonio Ruíz and his father, Juan, in their encomienda at Amabache. An armed Indian visited them there. "What are you doing here?" Ruíz recalled the visitor saying. "They have killed the priest and many others in Orobato. Get out!" Juan, Antonio, and Bernardino fled to Carapoa and raised the alarm, sending word to Culiacán that Carapoa would soon be overrun. In the meantime the Indians of Bacubirito, Chicorato, and their neighbors rose in revolt and killed a black woman servant of the encomendero Juan Martínez. Blas de Elgueta, the leader of the encomenderos, took a poison arrow to the face in a skirmish and died in agony the next day. Four soldiers went out to Orobato to confirm Fray Santa Maria's death. They buried the priest and burned the rest of the corpses to keep them from being eaten by dogs.⁴³

Another Franciscan named Juan de Herrera refused to leave his native congregation in Ocoroni, even when warned of an impending attack. Luisa had to plead with the dedicated friar to save his life. When at length the Franciscan took refuge in a settler's ranch house, all Luisa's efforts were proved to have been in vain. Enemy Indians attacked at dawn, smashed holes in the rear wall of the adobe house with axes, and lit fires to smoke the Spaniards out. When the settlers staggered into the morning light, the attackers cut them down one by one. They dismembered one of the dead Spaniards and tore up Fray Herrera's papers, "leaving the meadow strewn with pages and broken books." In response, the aged Diego de Guzmán returned to the region thirty years after his first slave raids. He traveled from Culiacán to Ocoroni with thirty-six Spanish harquebusiers and five hundred Tahue and Pacaxe allies to inspect the scene of the attack. They buried the bodies of Fray Herrera and the second victim and searched in vain for the dismembered remains of the third.⁴⁴

The exodus from Carapoa described at the beginning of this chapter took place after these killings. The settlers united with the forces of Álvaro de Tovar on the way to Culiacán and were later joined by Diego de Guzmán and his party. Guzmán ordered that they all march to Ocoroni to avenge the Franciscan's death. They camped there for fifteen days and wreaked havoc on the surrounding

towns, "with fire and blood, and many captives, men, women, and children." It was awful, said Ruíz, "to see in those lands so many killed and hanged from the trees." After the slaughter, Guzmán ordered that the settlers return to Carapoa, but they disobeyed the order and forged on to Culiacán. From there, "each went his own way."⁴⁵

Fourteen years passed during which there was little Spanish activity in the region. In late January 1583 Captain Pedro de Montoya became the next to mount a serious expedition to the north. Accompanying him were a nephew of the governor, a priest, and thirty-four cavalymen. The chronicler Antonio Ruíz set out with a second horseman on February 2 in the hope of catching up to the main party. On their way, the two men found that many Indians had burned their own homes to the ground and fled for the hills on hearing of the Spaniards' approach. Ruíz soon caught up to Montoya's party and traveled with them to the town of San Sebastián de Évora on the Mocorito River in February 1583. They were welcomed there by Christian Indians and made contact with two of Luisa's children, Don Diego and María. A native woman named Isabel, who had been raised in the household of a settler named Pedro Ochoa Garralaga, served as a translator. The explorers made another key connection when two Indians from the town of Amabache recognized Antonio Ruíz among the Spanish. He had been a boy when they last saw him. They embraced him, called him by his childhood nickname, Antonico, and asked after the health of his father. Carapoa had failed as a settlement, but there remained people with strong cultural and emotional ties to the Spanish.⁴⁶

On April 30, 1583, Montoya rechristened the town of Carapoa, calling it La Villa de San Felipe y Santiago. The next day Montoya sent out an expedition to the Mayo River, some forty miles to the north. Ruíz was named scribe of the mission and recorded the warm greeting the Mayo people gave to the visitors. The chaplain, Hernando de la Pedroza, announced that they were taking formal possession of the place in the name of the king, and the party began to count the number of houses along the river in order to assign encomiendas. The number they arrived at was twenty-four thousand. They soon returned to the Villa de San Felipe y Santiago and spent the following five months rebuilding the settlement. Things seemed to be going well. In early 1584 Ruíz and other settlers sent for their wives and extended families in Culiacán, planning to settle the place permanently. But their confidence was misplaced. When Ruíz was on his way to give Captain Montoya his support in an attack on the town of Zuaque, he received a chilling message from a Tehueco Indian. The man smiled, Ruíz wrote, and told him that Montoya and all his men were dead. Soon after, a young Spanish servant staggered into the camp. Asked why he was crying, all the boy could say was that

he had lost a silver cup of his master, Gonzalo Martínez. When Ruíz inquired after Montoya, the boy forced himself to tell the rest of the story: "Sirs," he said as he wept, "he is dead with all the Spaniards." Ruíz took the boy back to the Villa de San Felipe y Santiago and found that the women there had already heard the news. "It was the worst shame in the world to hear the screams of the widows and orphans," Ruíz recalled. Soon thereafter, on August 15, 1584, the settlers decided for the second time that the town should be abandoned.⁴⁷

Governor Hernando Bazán prevented a second exodus from Sinaloa by intercepting the fleeing settlers with an order that they return, on pain of death, to the Villa de San Felipe y Santiago. Bazán himself arrived soon after with one hundred gunmen. Ruíz was with the expedition to avenge Montoya's death, and he recorded many of its grim details. In one revealing episode Ruíz described the separation of Captain Gonzalo Martínez from his men. Martínez was ambushed and though he "cut off arms and chopped open heads," he soon fell to the ground in exhaustion and was killed along with the eighteen men under his command. The Indians "cut the flesh from [Martínez's] bones, not leaving more than the bones held together with cords and nerves, and in this state they hung him from a tree." The next day Bazán set out to vent his rage at the enemy and soon found the flayed body of Martínez. Beneath it, "a plumed Indian, his body painted entirely red with *achiote*, dancing by the bones of the said captain, singing in a high voice, and with a hollow piece of cane, he was tapping a rhythm and dancing with great pleasure, and since he was at the entrance of the *monte*, he thought he was very safe. A soldier shot him down with a harquebus, and he was taken, and before he died, the governor ordered that he be hanged." It is impossible to know the meaning of this native dance of death, but it is clear that Sinaloa and Sonora were still largely controlled by native peoples and that Spanish-Christian culture had not come close to supplanting that of the locals.⁴⁸

Bazán had set out to avenge the death of Montoya but succeeded only in committing random murders. He undid all of Ruíz's careful diplomatic work with the Mayos by enslaving some three hundred of them and chaining them in groups. When they had to cross a river on the way south, two of these groups were forced into the water and ordered to swim across. One of Bazán's men then shouldered a rifle and killed one man in each group of slaves. The cadavers, chained as they were to the living captives, dragged the others to their deaths. A Spaniard named Calvo rode into the water to save them but was himself sucked under and drowned. Bazán would go on to drive the remaining Mayo captives to Mexico City, where the viceroy, outraged at his cruelty, ordered their release. The conquistadors were failures even in perfidy.⁴⁹

Ruíz's conclusion to this awful chapter in Sinaloa's history was laced with black humor. The viceroy made the magnanimous gesture of ordering a knight of his household to escort the Mayo captives back to Sinaloa. He was to go with twelve Franciscan friars to preach the faith among the Mayos. The viceroy told the Mayos that if they wanted to stay in central Mexico, they would be given new lands for their use. He promised that the Spanish settlers would protect the Mayos after their return to Sinaloa, would keep them safe, and would build churches and preach the gospel. After an eloquent recitation of all the viceroy's generous words, Ruíz wrote, "Of all these promises, not a single one was kept." More than any other Spaniard involved in the early settlement of the northwest, Ruíz saw through to the enterprise's core of hypocrisy and cruelty. He was committed to the settlement of Sinaloa, but he was disgusted by his fellow Spaniards. He was also one of the few Europeans in the region who understood the value of friendships with native peoples and the folly of trying to conquer the region by killing and enslaving alone.⁵⁰

By 1589 the Villa de San Felipe y Santiago was occupied by five men and depended on the forbearance and protection of local Indians. The only reason it survived was that a very few settlers shared Ruíz's commitment to cultural diplomacy. Ruíz offered a poignant illustration of this when he wrote of his wife and children. He had grown up in Sinaloa and knew its ways. "All the barbarians were our friends," he wrote, "and every time we went out, the wife of the said Antonio Ruíz remained alone with her children, entrusted to an Indian cacique of the pueblo of Opochi, an *encomienda* that had been given by the governor to the said Antonio Ruíz. And the said cacique, while we were away, served her and watched over her with much care, giving her all the services she needed, and giving her much game and fish from this river." Here Ruíz made a play on words indicative of the mestizo character of the colonial culture and the kinds of reciprocity on which the Spanish depended for their survival. He wrote that he had received an *encomienda*, or crown-licensed grant of Indians from whom he was entitled to extract tribute. The word *encomienda* derived from *encomender*, "to entrust," since the Indians were literally entrusted to him. Yet Ruíz also "entrusted" (*encomendó*) his own wife and children to his *encomienda* Indians. Such relationships of reciprocal entrusting were the main reason Ruíz survived in Sinaloa while so many others perished. Such exchanges would become the foundation on which colonialism in Sinaloa and Sonora would rest in the years to come.⁵¹

Northwest Mexico, whose staggering fertility, high population, and wild beauty had once filled its Spanish visitors with visions of seigneurial paradise,

thus spiraled downward into squalor, brutality, and desperate impoverishment. By the early 1590s the Spanish had killed and enslaved hundreds of Indians, lost many of their own people to violence and starvation, founded a few tenuous, unprofitable settlements, and began disseminating the microbes and livestock that would blight the land in the years to come. But amid all this futility and waste, the failed conquest of the northwest had several lasting effects on the region's history. A small group of Spaniards developed knowledge of the region's landscape and peoples, friendships with individual Indians, and understanding of the region's potential for colonial exploitation. The settlements of northwest Mexico did not prosper, but they were landmarks for future explorers and footholds for future settlers.

Native peoples also developed knowledge of Spanish imperial behavior. They met tactful wanderers like Cabeza de Vaca, crazed murderers like Diego de Guzmán, and violent entrepreneurs like Francisco de Ibarra. The responses of native people ranged widely, from friendly curiosity to violent attack. The trend over the course of the sixteenth century seems to have been toward greater and greater violence. But the friendly precedent set by Cabeza de Vaca was an important one. It would be remembered by both native and invading peoples. A further critical development was the emergence of a small body of intermediaries who understood both native and European ways. Luisa of Ocoroni was the most notable of these, but she was not the only one. There were also Luisa's mestizo children and the young Indians adopted and educated by the clergy. A few settlers, such as Antonio Ruíz, had developed deep friendships with native peoples despite the bloody chaos that raged around them.

Most important, these expeditions introduced epidemic disease to the region. It is unclear exactly who brought the first lethal microbes to northwest Mexico. But the explorers of the sixteenth century played a role in the spread of smallpox, measles, pneumonia, typhus, typhoid, and other types of old world pestilence. What sketchy data survive indicate that these diseases went through the native population like a scythe. Mass death caused enormous changes in native demographics and social structures. Later and more detailed descriptions of native society in the region must be read in this light. The native societies of northwest Mexico had yet to become subjects of the Spanish empire, but they nevertheless were profoundly altered from their pre-Hispanic state. By the time the Jesuits began to write their ethnographic studies in the late sixteenth and early seventeenth centuries, the Indian societies of the far northwest had been transformed by their encounter with empire.⁵²

A MESTIZO CONQUEST: 1590-1610

With great evidence of their salvation, the [Aybines] asked the Fathers for the doctrine in their lands . . . and I received them under the protection and obedience of his Majesty, asking them for ten of their children as hostages.

—*Diego Martínez de Hurdaide*

In early September 1601 Diego Martínez de Hurdaide, the captain of the Villa de San Felipe y Santiago, decided to punish the Zuaque Indians. The Zuaques terrified the Spanish settlers. They sometimes seemed to want friendship with the newcomers and at other times rejected offers of alliance with contempt. They harassed the settlers and menaced the Indians allied with them. Worst of all, the Zuaques were completely unpredictable, making it impossible for the settlers to relax and attend to their fields. Captain Hurdaide wanted to make the Zuaques pay. So he traveled to the Zuaque towns on the Fuerte River with eight Spanish cavalymen and dozens of native allies. On their arrival, the captain and his men accepted Zuaque hospitality and made a show of gratitude. With his hosts thus put at ease, Hurdaide suddenly ordered an ambush and captured forty-two Zuaque men. He summoned his interpreter, the native Christian Luisa, and ordered her to tell all present that no Zuaques were ever to defy him again. With the captives chained, Hurdaide sent for priests to instruct them in the rudiments of the Christian faith. He then commanded that all the captives be executed. After watching the hanging of the forty-two men, Hurdaide declared that anyone who tried to cut down the dead would be hanged alongside them. The corpses were to remain there, swinging in the sun and wind, as a warning to all those who stood in his way (fig. 4).¹



4. Violence as speech. Taken during the Yaqui wars, probably in the 1890s or 1900s, this image testifies to a persistent lexicon of government violence against native peoples deployed since the days of Diego de Guzmán in the sixteenth century. Such atrocities declare, “We hate you and will destroy you.” But also: “We fear you and must debase you in order to vanquish our own doubts.” Inga Clendinnen describes “the therapeutic effects of a good massacre on fighting men who have lived too long with fear” (“Fierce and Unnatural Cruelty,” 74). (Library of Congress)

Violence was the *lingua franca* of early Sinaloa. Verbal communication among the region’s linguistically diverse peoples was often impossible, and so violent acts were often the clearest way to make a point. The Spanish captain’s murders declaimed to the whole region that he was a man to be taken seriously. But such violent speech acts had complicated secondary meanings. Read carefully, they yield subtle assertions about the nature of colonialism in northwest Mexico. The killing of the Zuaques signaled that Captain Hurdaide was not the only author of conquest. Translators like Luisa were key players in all Spanish dealings with the region’s native peoples. So too were native allies. The massacre further indicated that the task of protecting settlers and priests across hundreds of square miles of territory was impossible. The vastness of Sinaloa and Sonora

and their countless native inhabitants forced the captain to adopt terror as the main tool of government. He did not have the power of a well-established state behind him that would allow him to control his subjects. In that sense, the attack on the Zuaques was not a statement of imperial strength. It was an admission of imperial weakness.²

The question, then, is how the Spanish overcame their weakness and established a functioning colony in the northwest. Over the course of the sixteenth century the Spanish slowly learned that their ability to kill and enslave random Indians far exceeded their capacity to build sustainable towns. By violent trial and painful error, the Spanish in northwest Mexico began to refine their tactics and scale back their ambitions. They renounced their dreams of total conquest and began to negotiate with native leaders one by one. The success of these negotiations depended on soldiers with an unusual mix of qualities. They had to be willing to stage horrific acts of minatory violence, while at the same time being skilled in the subtle arts of native diplomacy. In Captain Hurdaide, the settlers found such a man. Throughout his career Hurdaide displayed a peculiar mix of bravery, brutality, and diplomatic tact—a set of qualities that opened avenues of success to him that were closed to earlier conquerors. A second condition for the survival of the colony was the presence of Jesuit priests. The Jesuits were vastly more sophisticated in the ways they thought about native cultures than were any of the settlers who came before them, and they would play a key role in negotiations with native peoples. By learning native languages and studying native ways the Jesuits became indispensable to the enterprise of empire in northwest Mexico. Jesuit investigations into the customs of native peoples were the third prerequisite for the survival of the colony. Jesuits learned that Indians had customs of captive exchange that were compatible with Spanish ones. The Jesuits became deeply involved in captive exchange across ethnic lines, and the practice became a central feature in northwest Mexico's emerging middle ground. The fourth and perhaps the most important condition allowing for the survival of the colony was the willingness of natives to negotiate. Violence and disease had decimated native communities, and many Indians began to see advantages in allying with the Spanish.³

The conquest of the northwest can be seen as a mestizo conquest in several senses of the term. Many people of mixed race and mixed culture participated in it. Spanish military forces were culturally mixed as well, consisting of Spanish officers, black and mulatto attendants, mestizo soldiers, and native auxiliaries from central and western New Spain. The tactics the Spanish deployed and the diplomatic customs they adhered to were of mixed Old and New World origins. And the results of the conquest were mixed as well, comprising new alliances,

continual violence, mutual dependency, and mutual hate. The Spanish never ruled the northwest, and indeed no one really did until the twentieth century. Rather, settlers, missionaries, and native peoples together wove a slowly expanding network of alliances that made Spanish settlement possible.⁴

THE JESUITS

By the early 1590s the native peoples of the northwest knew what to expect from the Spanish. Conquistadors killed and enslaved native men, assaulted native women, kidnapped native children, and tried to build towns with coerced native labor. But soon the invaders looked up from their work and realized they were alone in an alien, hostile land. The settlers' aggression poisoned the well of native friendship, and their distance from the centers of Spanish power made them vulnerable indeed. Sooner or later they were always driven out. Their main legacy was a burning trail of misery and destruction.

This was the combustible world into which the first Jesuit priests arrived in 1591. The Jesuit presence in the northwest was the product of a complex history. Founded in 1534 by Ignatius of Loyola and confirmed in 1540 as a new religious order by the pope, the Society of Jesus quickly grew in numbers and influence. By 1556 Ignatius's group of eight followers had expanded to 1,000. By 1626 there were 15,500 Jesuits, and at its zenith in 1749 the society had 22,600 members and an archipelago of colleges scattered across Europe and its colonies. This stunning expansion was partly inspired by the militant spirit of the Council of Trent. The Jesuits tried to win converts back from the ranks of the Protestants and to shed the light of the gospel across the globe. But the Jesuits were not simply the shock troops of "Catholic reaction." In subtle ways they mirrored Protestants in trying to satisfy the longings of ordinary people for a personal relationship with the divine. When Jesuit novices performed the "Spiritual Exercises," they prayed, reflected, and engaged in an intimate dialogue with God. They imagined the gospel narratives in the most vivid possible way, evoking in their minds the warm, dim intimacy of the room where Jesus Christ shared the Last Supper, the fragrance of the Garden of Gethsemane, and the blood of Christ's tormented hands and feet. Novices were instructed by their Jesuit superiors to "smell the indescribable fragrance and taste the boundless sweetness of the divinity. Touch by kissing and clinging to the places where [the three persons of the Trinity] walk or sit." After nine years of rigorous training, the Jesuits preached this sensually vivid experience of faith to their parishioners. Through brilliant color and violent drama Jesuit art made holy mysteries accessible to all. The art historian Gauvin Alexander Bailey has written that few styles of religious art "ask for such

complete emotional and sensual surrender, and yet few can be so inclusive and flexible." By appealing to sense and emotion the Jesuits sought to deepen the faith of all people and to encourage more frequent confession and prayer. This mission carried them to slave ships and slums, remote mountain hamlets, and the farthest reaches of the earth. By the late sixteenth century, Jesuits were preaching as far afield as India, China, Japan, Brazil, Paraguay, and northern New Spain.⁵

In their ventures abroad, the Jesuits brought a distinctive approach to foreign cultures. Though they shared a core set of beliefs with missionaries from other Catholic religious orders, the Jesuits were unusual in the way they separated the religious and the secular spheres of life. This separation made it possible for them to express ethnographic curiosity and admiration for foreign cultures without renouncing their hatred of idolatry. The Jesuit Matteo became famous for learning the Chinese language in the late sixteenth century, immersing himself in Chinese culture and going to near-heretical lengths to adapt Christian practice to Chinese customs (fig. 5). The Jesuit thinker José de Acosta produced a theological justification for this uniquely flexible approach to missionary work. In his treatise on missions, *De Procuranda Indiorum Salute* (1588), Acosta drew on a sixth-century exchange of letters between Pope Gregory the Great and St. Augustine of Canterbury. Augustine had written to the pope in despair of altering the barbarian customs of the British. Pope Gregory replied that the idolatrous temples of the Britons should not be destroyed and that the British practice of sacrificing bulls in honor of their gods should not be forbidden. Rather, Gregory advised that only the idols of the pagans should be eliminated, and that the bulls should be sacrificed in honor of the Christian God. By allowing new Christians such external pleasures, Gregory reasoned, Augustine would smooth the path to conversion. Gregory envisioned religious change as taking place little by little, beginning with small alterations in outward behavior and culminating in a revolution in the souls of the converted.⁶

Jesuit missionaries put Pope Gregory's theory into practice. In a little-known essay on the Sinaloa missions from the 1620s, a Jesuit wrote, "Having discussed the pagan and diabolical *fiestas* [the Yaquis] used to perform, it will be good to tell how they were exchanged for the holy and divine ones they now celebrate, transformed as they are into the Christian rites of the holy church, as the great father and pastor of the church St. Gregory ordered done with the English, who were converted to the faith by his disciple Augustine." Just as Gregory had advised, the Jesuits sought first to make small changes to existing native rituals and then, little by little, to bring about changes in belief. This method freed them to welcome native elements into the daily practice of Christianity. Native



5. The Jesuit Nicolas Trigault dressed as a Chinese Mandarin. Beyond adopting Chinese dress, some Jesuits went so far as to argue that the *Book of Changes* and other Chinese classics were inspired by the true god (Spence, *Question of Hu*, 14). (Drawing by Peter Paul Rubens, 1617; Metropolitan Museum of Art)

peoples seasoned Catholic ceremonies with the spices of native dance, native music, and native crafts. By the Jesuits' accounts, this method was effective; they claimed thousands of conversions by the late sixteenth century. But Jesuit methods had unwanted secondary effects. One of these was that native converts were often much less thoroughly Christian than the Jesuits liked to believe. Another was that many Europeans thought the Jesuit mission Indians were not really Christians at all. For this and many other reasons, the Jesuit missionary enterprise was controversial.⁷

Over the course of their history in the New World, the Jesuits clashed time and again with political and ecclesiastical enemies, conflicts that deeply influenced Jesuit writings about the northern missions. In the early seventeenth century the most important Jesuit actor in the controversies over the missions was Andrés Pérez de Ribas. Born in Córdoba, Spain, in 1575, Pérez de Ribas traveled to New Spain in 1602, completed his studies in Mexico City and Puebla, and then departed for the college of Topotzotlán in 1604. From there he continued north to the missions of Sinaloa and Sonora. He spent sixteen tumultuous years in the missions before being recalled to the college of Topotzotlán, where he became the rector and master of novices. He remained there until 1626, at which point he rose to the office of rector of the Colegio Máximo in Mexico City. In 1632 he rose yet further to become superior of the Casa Profesa, an office he held for five years before succeeding to the office of provincial, or supreme head of the Jesuit order in New Spain, in 1637. By this time the Jesuits had earned a reputation for unconventional missionary methods, deep political influence, and inordinate wealth. At the time of Pérez de Ribas's provincialate, the Jesuits of New Spain enjoyed an annual income of 119,500 pesos from rents on agricultural properties valued at over twenty-five times that sum. Beyond their conspicuous riches, the Jesuits wielded influence as the main educators of the viceroyalty's elite.⁸

In the 1630s voices rose to protest the Jesuits' power and influence. The viceroy, Marqués de Cadereyta, acceded to those complaints in August 1638, writing, "It is in my judgment time to name bishops under the *patronato real*, to collect tribute, and secularize the missions." The Jesuit missions were to be turned over to the care of secular priests, and the exemption of mission Indians from the native head tax was to end. These measures spelled the doom of the Jesuit mission system. In response, Pérez de Ribas and the Jesuits countered in 1638 in a letter to the king, claiming that the mission Indians were too poor to pay tribute. The letter issued a dire warning that the secularization of the missions would provoke an Indian uprising. And indeed, bloody revolts had recently occurred among several native groups in the north. The Jesuits' arguments won the king's favor, and the missions remained intact, despite the formal requirement that each be secularized ten years after its founding.⁹

In 1640 the Jesuits confronted their most formidable adversary yet: Juan de Palafox y Mendoza, bishop of Puebla and future viceroy of New Spain. In response to Palafox's insistence on the payment of tithes on Jesuit properties, the Jesuits sent Pérez de Ribas across the Atlantic as their special agent to the courts of Spain and the Holy See. It was while he was in Madrid pleading the Jesuit case that Pérez de Ribas published his magnum opus, *The History of*

the Triumphs of Our Holy Faith Among the Most Barbarous and Savage People of the New Orb (1645). This vast, ill-organized treasure trove of data on the northern missions has become a key point of reference for the early history of northern Mexico. But few commentators have taken into account the fact that this chronicle history made many of the same arguments that the Jesuits had set forth in 1638 in their letter to the king. *The History of the Triumphs* depicted the northern missions as impoverished moral victories for the crown. It described Jesuit methods as both ethical and effective. And it returned time and again to the threat of insurrection posed by the mission Indians. *The History of the Triumphs* remains an invaluable source for understanding Jesuit mentalities and a central text for the ethnohistory of the north. But both the text and its author were so politically involved that one is compelled to check his every claim against other evidence.¹⁰

In the end Pérez de Ribas and the Jesuit order prevailed in their defense of Jesuit methods. The missions were not secularized, and no bishopric was established in Sonora until 1779. But did Jesuit methods really work? And more important, what did native peoples think about them? Puzzlement, curiosity, and anger were common native responses to the Black Robes. The Jesuits wanted to settle in native villages, but they did not want to become full members of those communities by marrying native women. The Jesuits wanted to protect Indians from the Spanish conquerors, but they refused to take up arms in times of war. The Jesuits expressed admiration for many aspects of indigenous culture and went to extraordinary lengths to learn native languages. Yet they also went out of their way to offend native elders and tried to commandeer the sacred rites of native towns. The Jesuits risked death to care for the sick, the elderly, and the dying, yet they lashed out at Indians whose sex lives they disapproved of. It took many years for native peoples to make sense of these strange men. In the early days some native leaders concluded that the most elegant solution to the Jesuit problem would be to kill them.

EARLY CONTACTS

On July 6, 1591, Gonzalo de Tapia and Martín Pérez became the first Jesuits to arrive in Sinaloa. Born around 1561 in León, Spain, Tapia came to New Spain in 1584 and preached among the Tarascans of Michoacán and the nomadic native peoples of Guanajuato as well as Tarascan mine workers in Zacatecas. Pérez was a creole born on February 2, 1560, in the town of Villa de San Martín, where his father had made a fortune in mining. Pérez studied Latin in Mexico City and was admitted to the Jesuit order in 1577. Before traveling

to Sinaloa, he had been, like Tapia, a missionary among nomads whom the Nahuas and, later, the Spaniards gave the pejorative name of Chichimecas.¹¹

True to the methods of St. Gregory, these two Jesuits made careful studies of the native cultures near the Villa de Felipe y Santiago. They described nonreligious elements of native culture with little moral judgment, praising native skills in weaving and clothes-making. Tapia pointed out the artfulness of native hairstyles, with their complex braids and beautiful feathers plucked from birds raised for the purpose in private aviaries. Tapia shared a curiosity with other Jesuits regarding the games and entertainments of the Indians. In the summer, Tapia wrote, they played a game similar to dice from sunrise to sundown, wagering blankets and beads, and then would go home peacefully in the evenings and had no harsh words for one another. In the colder months they played a game called run the stick (*correr el palo*), in which tribes would challenge each other to kick a stick from village to village, often running a league or more. The winners would take home blankets, bows and arrows, obsidian-edged swords, feathers, and strings of beads. Whenever the Jesuits discussed cultural practices that they believed, rightly or wrongly, to be free of religious content, they were calm and observant. Their intent was to understand such practices, the better to preach the gospel on native terms.¹²

In discussing politics, sexuality, and death among the Indians, Jesuit writings alternated between expressions of fascination and moral rebuke. The Jesuits understood these areas of native life to be suffused with religious feeling and thus in need of reform or elimination. Tapia wrote that war was endemic among the Indians of Sinaloa, and later accounts noted the skill and cruelty of native fighters. They could shoot ten poisoned arrows for every shot a Spaniard could fire with a harquebus, according to one account. Native war captains were at once splendid and terrifying in war paint, feathers, and blue cotton capes decorated with glinting shells. Tapia's descriptions of native sexual customs displayed a similar mix of respect, curiosity, and repulsion. He thought native women were remarkably modest, covering their nakedness with discreet deerskin skirts and cotton blankets. Virginity was prized, he said, and adultery was punished among the Indians. But such customs as polygamy, sodomy, and transvestism remained common, and the Jesuits reviled them. Tapia described native mortuary practices in vivid detail. On the death of an Indian, all his necklaces, feather-crafts, and blankets were burned or buried along with the body, together with much food and a gourd full of water for his journey to the underworld. The passing of the dead was celebrated with a drunken ceremony in which corn wine was scattered on the burial site. All the animals of the deceased were killed and eaten, and the corpse was decorated as if for war.¹³

To the Jesuits, such native cultures, marked as they were by both refinement and savagery, were ripe for the kind of subtle transformation Augustine had wrought on the barbarian English. The Jesuits searched for analogies between their own beliefs and those of the Indians and allowed converts much freedom in the adaptation of Christian practices. Tapia noticed, for instance, that Indians loved ritual and religious festivals and set about promoting Christian feast days to attract converts. Sunday Mass, with its solemn incantations and musical accompaniment, its mystery and moral intensity, soon became a popular entertainment in Sinaloa. Indians decorated crosses with flowers and sang in procession as they approached the Jesuits' makeshift church. Tapia may have been exaggerating the enthusiasm with which Indians participated in such Christian rituals, but Jesuit letters made it clear that native peoples were free to interpret the rituals as they wished, to adapt and adorn Christian ceremonies to their liking.¹⁴

The Jesuits saw the adoption of native practices as a way of attracting converts. They brought native Christians from central Mexico to emphasize the indigenous quality of the creed they preached. In a letter of July 30, 1594, father Pedro Méndez described the usefulness of the so-called Mexican singers, who accompanied Easter Masses with organ music, presented a religious colloquy in Nahuatl, and were costumed as angels. They sang sacred songs and motets in both Nahuatl and in Otomí, which they accompanied with the music of flutes, trumpets, and woodwind instruments. The annual letter of 1594 recounted a Jesuit's visit to a rural village, during which he presided over a feast for the dead. After a prayer, the Indians came to the church and spread black shawls on the floor, lit candles over the gravesites of the departed, and prayed. The next day, an hour or two before dawn, they performed the same ritual until the celebration of the Mass, at which point they offered cotton, *tamales*, honey, and cooked beans for their dead relatives. In the town of Bacovirito a few days later, the Jesuit described his having invited Christian and pagan Indians from the surrounding countryside to hear Mass. The night before hearing it, the Indians danced naked in the chilly moonlight and so "passed the night joyfully," before cutting their hair and accepting baptism. Such ceremonies may have originated in Europe, but they had a distinctly indigenous flavor. So long as Indians seemed to accept the holy waters in good faith, the Jesuits were not troubled by the persistence of indigenous customs.¹⁵

Jesuits and native peoples shared a belief that certain individuals could influence nature and history through their contact with the supernatural. The Jesuits preached incessantly that Christian prayer could bring rain to the Indians' fields, heal the sick, and bring about general good fortune. These were precisely

the feats that native shamans claimed they could perform. In 1602 a Jesuit wrote that if it did not rain, the Indians paid *hechiceros* ("sorcerers") to summon the clouds. "I remedied this," the Jesuit wrote, and the custom "has been introduced that they make processions in the evening with the Cross, around the church, asking our Lord for water." By assuming the role of native shamans, the priest tried to ease the Indians away from their old beliefs and toward his own.¹⁶

The better to do this, the Jesuits sought out analogies between the practice of native shamans and Catholic clergymen. Pérez de Ribas noted that one of the native sorcerers' main functions was to preach on occasions when tobacco was smoked, especially at the beginning and end of wars. Such sermons ended with an exhortation to honor cherished family members and the illustrious dead: "My grandparents," the preacher would intone, "my parents, my older and younger brothers, and the children of my brothers, may you all have the same heart and feeling." These sermons, Pérez de Ribas wrote, "had great force to move the people to do what the speaker wanted." Before the Jesuits came, he went on, such rhetoric was used for evil. But "now it is used for good, and for this reason they are permitted these sermons even after they have been baptized and converted, in order that they receive the divine word and Christian customs, to persuade them that they repeat often, 'the word of God has arrived in our land, and we are no longer what we were.'" In Christian towns both native elders and Jesuit priests assumed the roles that *hechiceros* held before.¹⁷

Some of these cultural continuities made the Jesuits uneasy. They were willing to allow Indians to adapt Christianity, and they persuaded themselves that many native ritual practices were mere amusements. But they would not tolerate the persistence of overt idolatry. The Jesuits were completely unsympathetic to the defenders of the old rites and likened them to the devil incarnate. In the annual letter of 1613 Pérez de Ribas wrote that the people of Sinaloa "used to use many magic spells, and stones of singular appearance, that the Demon, appearing in human form, gave to them, as a sign of their pact, and agreement . . . to cure various diseases, or for some dishonest love, or for other ends, and they guarded these idols much as we guard religious relics." Pérez de Ribas described an *hechicero* named Taxicora as having a pact with the devil granting him magical powers. "At night he spoke with . . . souls and spirits. He mounted a horse clutching a firebrand and flew through the air in view of his people, landing when he wanted to, heaping scorn on the Spanish and saying they could never do him any harm." One of the many ironies of the early Jesuit experience in the northwest was that the Black Robes actually agreed with the native belief in the magical powers of the *hechiceros*. They differed only in

believing that the devil, rather than a native deity, was the origin of the shamans' dark power.¹⁸

The Jesuits took pride in angering native sorcerers. Provoking the Satanic enemy lured him into the open, where he could be confronted. This was a risky strategy, and the Jesuits paid for it in July 1594, when a group of native people killed Gonzalo de Tapia in a town near Ocoroni. Traveling with two native companions and a young mulatto man to the village of Tovoropa, Tapia confronted a native elder named Nacabeba and exhorted him to leave his life of sin. Pérez de Ribas recorded a speech Nacabeba gave in response. "These padres," Nacabeba declaimed, "who have come to our land are people we do not know; every day they go about baptizing more people; the baptized people and the churches multiply. . . . They introduce and teach customs we know nothing of, and which were unknown to our grandfathers. Now they do not let those they baptize have more than one wife; our entertainments and pleasures are ending. Let us put an end to this padre Tapia, who is leading the others, and we will be left in peace." Pérez de Ribas deplored every word of this speech and may have distorted much of its content, but his account of it nevertheless captured the dismay of many native elders at the death of old familiar customs and the introduction of unsettling new ones.¹⁹

On the morning of Sunday, July 11, 1594, Tapia said Mass and afterward was warned that trouble was brewing. He responded that he had done nothing wrong and that he regarded the people of the town of Tovoropa as his children. That evening two Indians approached him as he finished his prayers. One took his hand as if to kiss it, while the other positioned himself to bludgeon Tapia's head with an obsidian-edged club. When the blow stuck, Tapia screamed, rushed out of his shelter, and fell into an ambush. Three Indians severed the Jesuit's head and left arm, stripped his body, killed his dog and horse, and stole the few religious ornaments he had with him. They then paraded through the neighboring villages carrying their bloody trophies. Enemies of the Jesuits greeted the spectacle with rejoicing and killed a Christian convert in Ocoroni. Word reached the Villa de San Felipe y Santiago on the morning of July 12. Tapia's companions went out and collected what was left of his body, and the Jesuits celebrated his funeral at the Spanish fort. Nacabeba eluded the Spanish until 1599, when he fell by chance into the hands of their native allies. A group of Tehuecos captured Tapia's killer, murdered his family, and offered the rebel leader and the heads of his family members to the captain of the Spanish fort. There, Nacabeba was baptized, hanged, drawn, and quartered.²⁰

The early years of the Jesuit enterprise in northwest Mexico revealed a great deal about the Jesuits and their evolving relationships with the native peoples of

the region. The Jesuits were brave, devout, and, for their time, sophisticated in their thinking about cultural difference. They were also culturally offensive, naïve, and vulnerable. While they brought considerable cultural change among the native peoples of the northwest in the early 1590s, they underestimated the resolve of those who did not want to become Christian. In the years after Tapia's murder, the Jesuits and Spanish settlers would search hard for ways to compel Indians to act in good faith.

CAPTIVE EXCHANGE AND THE MISSION SYSTEM

In the later 1590s and 1600s the Jesuits and Spanish at last discovered a means of securing their position in the violent world of northwest Mexico. By taking and exchanging captives, they began to forge alliances with native people that made the colony sustainable. Both Spaniards and Indians were experienced in the practice. On the Spanish side, captive exchange had long been a familiar element of the military cultures of the Mediterranean world. The first Spaniards to arrive in northwest Mexico were slave raiders, and their intent seems to have been to capture Indians to use as chattel. This changed over the course of the sixteenth century, as Indian slavery was outlawed and the settlers came to realize the importance of native allies to the survival of the colony. Yet there were other, more complicated traditions of captive taking that influenced Spanish behavior. During the era of the Reconquista in Spain, captive exchange became so common that the "redemptionist" Mercedarian and Trinitarian orders emerged to ransom Christian captives from the Muslim enemy. After the fall of Granada in 1492, the large population of Moriscos, or formerly Muslim Christians, presented problems of doctrine and political management that Christian leaders tried to solve through various types of captivity. The Jesuits ran special schools for the religious education of Morisco children, the theory being that the young were more susceptible to religious change than the old and that isolating children from their families would expedite the conversion of Muslim communities. This program for the forcible reeducation of Morisco children was given a brutal twist after the Revolts of the Alpujarras in 1499 and 1568. After the battles of Gülcjar and Níjar in 1499, Christians enslaved the entire Morisco population of those towns, with the exception of children under the age of eleven, who were given to Christian families to be raised in the faith. A decree issued after the second revolt ordered that the children of the Morisco rebels were to be placed in Old Christian homes and educated in good manners and used as domestic servants until the age of twenty.²¹

This program of ethnocide through adoption and education crossed the Atlantic in the sixteenth century and the seventeenth. The 1573 Ordenanzas for new discoveries enjoined Spanish officials to protect missionary priests "by first bringing to Spanish settlements the children of caciques and chiefs, and leaving them there as hostages." The law went on to say, "In order to soften and pacify the Indians who were at war . . . it should be done with the same caution and prevention as has been stated, asking for their children in order to teach them, and in order that they be hostages in the lands of our friends." The law envisioned an ambiguous status for native children, both as students of the Christian faith and as hostages. Such a status was often realized in frontier settings. In 1608, for instance, when King Philip III granted Chilean settlers their wish for a license to enslave rebel Araucanians, he stipulated that all Araucanian boys under the age of ten and a half and all girls under the age of nine and a half were to be taken from their homelands and placed in the households of Christian families who would "instruct them in the Faith, as was done with the Moriscos of the kingdom of Granada." These were precedents for Spanish behavior in northwest Mexico.²²

Captive taking and exchange were familiar institutions among native peoples as well. Baltasar de Obregón and Antonio Ruíz both described it as prevalent in highland Sonora, and many accounts underscored its importance as a means of making peace among native communities. Much recent scholarship has explored the ambiguities in native understanding of captives. Captives were not chattel slaves and often became valued family members, even powerful leaders, among the peoples who captured them. The formidable translator and captain Luisa was perhaps the most famous case in Sinaloa and Sonora, but there were many others like her. Her story of captivity, subjection, and subsequent rise to influence was part of a deeply ingrained and widespread pattern across the native cultures of North America. In New France and what would later become the U.S. South, colonial accounts described native rites of adoption in which captives were transformed through rituals of purification into full members of their new community. Such captives often drew on their knowledge of foreign languages and customs as mediators. These were not the only roles captives played in diplomacy. Throughout North America, native groups proffered captives as gifts at the conclusion of alliances. Such gifts signified "the opposite of warfare, the giving, rather than the taking of life," while at the same time sending a powerful message of warning, underscoring the dangers of opposing the captors in war. While sharing much with the captivity and slaving practices of native groups throughout North America, elements of the captive exchange networks in Sinaloa and Sonora were distinctive. Numerous sources over

several decades reported that native groups offered their own children, rather than captives from other groups, as alliance gifts. These children would be the a decisive medium of exchange between native and Spanish parties in the 1590s and 1600s.²³

The Jesuits brought European and native traditions of captive exchange into engagement. The Spanish adopted old native traditions of making peace by exchanging children across ethnic lines, recasting the practice as *compadrazgo*, or ritual godparentage. Individual cases varied enormously over time and space. Some involved violent capture in the midst of war, while others saw the voluntary offering of captives as a gesture of friendship. But a pattern slowly emerged in which native people handed children over to the Spanish as a kind of human collateral to peace agreements. The Spanish, in turn, offered material goods, alliance in war, and, crucially, Jesuit priests. These exchanges of people and goods were prerequisites to the creation of the Jesuit mission system and the permanent settlement of the northwest.²⁴

Pérez de Ribas offered an extraordinary account of a pre-Hispanic ritual for the incorporation of orphaned children into new families. The native people of the Sinaloa River celebrated a "festival of the adopted children." The first step in the ritual was to gather all the orphans in the village. Two houses would then be built out of mats one hundred paces apart. The orphans would be placed in one of the houses for eight days and fed maize gruel. In the other house, native men made a large circle of sand, two and a half yards across. Carrying rods, they would dance in and out of the circle, their bodies painted. They used colored sand to paint images of the progenitors of mankind within the circle, deities named Viriseva and Vairubi. Around them, they painted the staves of native life: maize, beans, and squash, along with snakes, birds, and other animals. Through these images they asked their gods to protect their fields. On the eighth day the men danced in the house where the orphans were held. There they performed a ritual opening of the child's eyes, making young ones alert to arrows shot at them. They gave the children weapons, and then each man chose which orphan he would take home to raise as his own. They then took the child to the other house and erased the images of Viriseva and Vairubi by rubbing the child's body with the colored sand. The newly adopted orphans would then be given a lavish meal, and all went to the river to bathe.²⁵

Pérez de Ribas wrote that Martín Pérez and Gonzalo de Tapia had observed this native ritual and that it had since been transformed into a Christian one. Pérez recorded the transformation in the annual letter of 1593. The Jesuits invited all the region's Indians, both Christians and others, to celebrate the birth of Jesus. The Jesuits brought singers with flutes and other instruments

from Culiacán. The Cáhitas made shelters for the guests, and the Christian headman of Ocoroni addressed his people and encouraged them to prepare well for the feast. On the eve of the Nativity, Pérez preached on the mystery of Christ's birth, and during the four following days the festival was celebrated, and much food was served to the guests of the pueblo. The people of Ocoroni built a large shelter surrounded by mats, and the Indians emerged from it dancing, their bodies painted splendidly and decorated with plumes and rattles. Pérez recalled,

Padre Tapia and I, who were watching them, entered into the shelter to see what they did there. We found many people seated around a circle of sand larger than a *Mapa mundi*, in which they had arranged many figures with various colors. There were images of snakes, lions and other fierce and poisonous animals, and a figure of a man, and another of a woman, and another of a child. We asked them the meaning of this, and the headman, in the name of the group, took the hand [of father Tapia] and began to tell him, saying: "this is the image of God the Father; this of the holiest Virgin Mary; this of Jesus Christ her son, this is the field, this the river, this is the snake and this is such-and-such animal. We ask the Eternal father, and the Holiest Virgin Maria, and her son, to protect our fields, and to free us from floods, and from those fierce and poisonous animals. . . ." We praised their good intentions, and we ordered that one day of Easter they come and dance in the church, the superstitious images having been removed, and that they ask God and the Virgin (whose image was there with her son in her arms) for the same things.

This passage revealed an enormous amount about natives, Jesuits, and their interactions. Native people did not see Christianity and native beliefs as mutually antagonistic: Jesus, Mary, and the Holy Spirit shared space with pre-Hispanic deities in native art and dance. The Jesuits were willing to allow the persistence of native rituals and a degree of adaptation of Christian ones. Pérez de Ribas underscored the similarities between the festival of the adopted children and Christian rituals of godparentage, and later accounts described the convergence of native adoption rituals and Christian notions of *compadrazgo*.²⁶

Documents from the 1590s and 1600s demonstrate the centrality of ceremonial adoptions in negotiations with native people over conversion to Christianity. Méndez wrote in 1594 of a native convert offering the Jesuits a child as token of his desire to become a Christian. "This Indian has a son," he wrote, "and pointing to the child in the arms of his mother, he said, 'this child is the thing I love most, and I greatly desire that he be a Christian. In case I die in the wars,

I offer him to you from this moment, such that when he is older, you may take him away and make him Christian, even though it is against the will of his mother and my family.” The offering of a child was meant to keep the child from harm, to continue his father’s line in case he was killed, and to cement an alliance with the Spanish.²⁷

Captain Hurdaide quickly perceived the utility of such customs. By 1601 at the latest, he was taking captives as a matter of policy (fig. 6). On an expedition to the Chínipas people, Hurdaide found their towns abandoned. He found none of the precious metals he desired, but he nevertheless wanted to “take a few captives among the Chínipas, not to make them slaves, but rather to make peace with them, and to settle that nation.” Hurdaide and his men explored the



6. “A group of more than 30 women and children Yaqui Indian prisoners under guard, Guaymas, Mexico,” ca. 1910. Three hundred years after the arrival of the Jesuits among the Yaquis, women and children remained valuable tools for pacifying enemies. In the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries the Mexican government adopted the tactic of capturing and threatening Yaqui women and children. The practice had roots in the medieval Mediterranean, in ancient native practice, and in the frontier wars of the colonial period. (USC Digital Archive)

Chínipas villages and “had the good fortune to capture an Indian woman and her son, whom they treated very well.” Hurdaide took them back with them to the villa and “maintained them there for several years and baptized them, in order that if the door to that nation were opened sometime in the future, mother and child would serve as interpreters for the Jesuit Father.” A few lines later Pérez wrote, “This was the captain’s desire in all of his *entradas*.”²⁸

A letter Hurdaide wrote in 1606 confirmed that the exchange of captives was by then a central feature of his dealings with the native peoples of Sinaloa. Hurdaide wrote the viceroy that the Tehueco people of the pueblo of Macore had asked that Jesuit missionaries come and live in their village permanently. “The said natives,” Hurdaide wrote, “showed good will and desire for their salvation, and asked once again that the said Padres remain among them, and they handed over some of their children so that they might later serve as teachers, and they promised to remain faithful and permanently at peace.” Here native peoples offered their children as collateral to the peace agreement they were making with the Spanish and as an assurance that the Jesuits would not be harmed.²⁹

The Huites followed suit six years later. The annual letter of 1612 described the discovery of this highland people in the headwaters of the Sinaloa River. They lived in caves, had a simple material culture, and were the mortal enemies of their neighbors downstream. The Jesuit described them as cannibals who decorated their caves with skulls. He went on to describe a Christian Sinaloa Indian kidnapping a Huite child and taking him to the mission downstream. The Jesuit started to learn the Huite language from the boy in the hopes of converting his people to Christianity. The priest later went with some Christian Sinaloa Indians to visit the Huites and watched as the Huites and Sinaloas exchanged gifts, bows, arrows, salt, and knives. In addition, the Huites sent several of their children to live with the Jesuit on the Sinaloa mission, in order that they learn the Sinaloa language and Christian doctrine. The Huites were so happy with the exchange, the Jesuit wrote, “that one may say that they handed over pieces of their flesh, who were their children, to people they considered mortal enemies, and whose flesh they sometimes ate.” The baptism of the Huite children was celebrated with a dance much like the one in the festival of the adopted children and Spanish soldiers joined in by firing shots into the sky.³⁰

The Jesuit depicted the Huites’ behavior as almost childlike, as if a few trinkets could inspire a total reversal of sentiments. But he was really describing the integration of Jesuits and Spaniards into an established native custom in which gifts of children forged bonds of friendship. The annual letter of 1625–26

described how this custom had come to intertwine with Spanish traditions of *compadrazgo*. The Huites brought boys and girls between the ages of six and eight to Christian towns, "and they leave them in the houses of their godfathers and godmothers, to be raised in the church, and the godparents treat them better, and give them more gifts, than they would have if the children were their own." Pérez de Ribas recorded an incident in which the Huites asked a Jesuit to negotiate with the Chínipas people over Huite captives taken in an earlier war. The Jesuit negotiated with the Christian Chínipas for the return of the captives, who were then raised in the homes of Sinaloa Christians. The annual letter described the astonishing generosity of both the parents who offered the children and the godparents who raised them as the result of the Indians' conversion to Christianity. But the likelier explanation was that these exchanges were a deeply ingrained native tradition that, to use James Brooks's phrase, "knit diverse peoples in webs of painful kinship." Like Augustine among the British, the Jesuit was giving old native traditions a new Christian name.³¹

Law and custom sanctioned captive exchange on both sides of the cultural divide. Alluding to the Ordenanzas of 1573, Hurdaide wrote in 1627 of missions to the Chínipas and Guazapares that the taking of child hostages "will not be against the will and order of His Majesty, but rather very much in conformity with it, as he establishes in his Royal *cédula* and *ordenaciones*, Chapters 142 and 143, taking it as a prime method to bring their children to the towns of the Spaniards as hostages." Hurdaide noted that captive exchange was also a common practice among the region's native peoples. He wrote of the conclusion of his wars with peoples to the north of the villa: "As a sign that they were not making a deceptive deal [*trato doble*], they gave me some of their children, a custom of these nations among themselves when they make peace." Wrenching though it was, the practice of captive exchange facilitated the construction of cross-cultural alliances.³²

The Jesuits approved of the practice of captive exchange, and indeed it had precedents in St. Gregory's letters on the mission to Britain. In September 595, Pope Gregory instructed Candidus, his agent in Gaul, to purchase pagan Anglian boys for education in Frankish monasteries in order that they might return to their people as missionaries. No Jesuit document cited this text, but the similarity between Gregory's vision and the Jesuits' behavior was notably close. A Jesuit wrote in the early 1620s, "It is a great sign of their sincerity in asking for baptism when they hand over some of their young children to us, and some of greater age, so that they come to the schools and seminaries that there are in the Villa and other Christian *partidos*, where we teach them the Christian doctrine in order that they later teach it to their nation, and we also teach some of these

to read and sing with organ music and play musical instruments." The Jesuit school in the Villa de Sinaloa thus had a dual function. It was both an academy for the religious indoctrination of native children and a prison for hostages whose lives ensured the safety of Jesuits working in the field. Padre Juan Bautista Velasco's letter to the Jesuit provincial in 1610 made this dual function explicit: "The seminary for native children is moving forward well: the students are learning to read, and some of the older ones play the flute and sing the plainsong at the fiestas, and are learning the organ, and it is a great pleasure to watch and hear them." A few lines later he wrote that these young people would be of great help in the conversion of their parents and families, who, in the meantime, "have their hands tied . . . on account of the hostages we now have." Captives played a number of crucial roles in the emergent mestizo society of the northwest: translators, negotiators, and collateral to peace agreements.³³

If the Spanish took hostages, what did native people get in return? Captain Hurdaide gave a partial answer to this question in many of his letters to the viceroy and Jesuit provincial. He often complained that he had come to the far northwest in the hope of getting rich but that he had impoverished himself by giving his meager salary to the Indians. In 1604 he wrote, "All I earn I distribute to the natives in order to attract them to our side, such that at the end of the year, I am many ducats in debt." So great was the demand for metal tools that they became a form of currency by the late 1590s. The Jesuit annual letter held that one native group had welcomed another to live among them only so long as the visitors could supply "beads, knives and axes, which is the only money they use." Hurdaide wrote in 1615 that he promised the Nébome people 150 iron hoes and various articles of clothing for that people's leaders as a way of concluding an alliance with them. This practice of "peace by purchase" was a standard Spanish tactic in northern Mexico, especially during the Chichimeca Wars of which Hurdaide was a veteran.³⁴

In addition to material goods and assurances that the Spanish would not attack them, native people received Jesuit priests in exchange for their children. Jesuits often took up residence among the Indians at precisely the time children went to live in the Villa de Sinaloa. A letter Hurdaide wrote in 1627 made this exchange explicit. On making peace with the Aybines, Hurdaide wrote that they "asked for the doctrine in their lands" and that he, in turn, asked them for "ten of their children as hostages." Pérez de Ribas wrote that after the alliance of the Spanish with the Zuaques, he asked them why they had been so hostile before. A Zuaque responded that they feared the Spanish, about whom their shamans had spoken ill, but that "now that they had a Priest in their company, they were free of fear." The Jesuits protected the Zuaques against the

depredations of the Spanish, much as native hostages protected the Jesuits from the wrath of Indians.³⁵

Under certain circumstances Jesuits functioned as hostages. No Jesuit document referred to them as such, and there is no testimony from native peoples that addressed the issue. Nevertheless, there are suggestive pieces of direct and indirect evidence that native peoples saw Jesuits in this light. The Jesuits were at the mercy of the native peoples whose communities they lived in and were often threatened, injured, or killed. Their presence served as insurance against Spanish attack, and they often entered new mission fields at the same time native children were sent for reeducation in the Villa de Sinaloa. As a matter of policy the Jesuits always gravitated toward native children, since they were the first to be baptized. Indians may have associated the Jesuits with children for these reasons. Pérez de Ribas quoted a letter from Méndez on the Mayo people, in which he wrote that the children who associated with the Jesuits were called *paretabuseme*, a Mayo term meaning “the priest’s guard.” “Although the Mayo,” Méndez went on, “use this term in jest because they see that I have no other guard or escort, I take it the way that it should be taken—that through them the Lord is protecting me.” Perhaps the real source of the Mayos’ amusement lay in the fact that Méndez, a grown man, was playing a role traditionally associated with children—that of a hostage. However native people may have regarded them, Jesuits gained access to many native communities as part of a system of exchange between the Spanish and the native groups allied with them. These exchanges of people and goods were a critical element of the mestizo conquest of the northwest and would play a central role in negotiations between the Spanish and the Yaquis in 1610.³⁶

NORTHWARD EXPANSION

The Fuerte and Mayo Rivers were the testing ground for a new Spanish strategy involving negotiation through Jesuit missionaries, captive exchange, and credible threats of violence. Though this strategy never brought about Spanish dominance, it did make the Spanish important players in the region’s interethnic politics. The Río Fuerte was about thirty miles to the north of the Villa de San Felipe y Santiago, flowing southwest out of the sierras into the Gulf of California. Four Cáhita groups lived by its shores: the Sinaloas near the headwaters, the Tehuecos downstream, the Zuaques nearer to the coast, and the Ahomes by the river delta. Most of these peoples had adopted a stance of wary neutrality toward the Spanish. In the later 1590s sporadic violence along the Zuaque frontier prompted Captain Alonso Díaz to send his lieutenant

Martínez de Hurdaide to request more troops from the viceroy. The viceroy assented in 1599 and added ten more soldiers to Hurdaide's command, bringing their number to thirty-six. On his return, Hurdaide succeeded Díaz as captain, and Díaz retired to his hacienda in Durango.

In his new role Hurdaide would become a pivotal figure in the history of the northwest. Born in Zacatecas to a Vizcayan Spanish father and a Creole mother, the new captain shared a taste for violence with the military men who had come before him. But his shrewd and tactful manner in negotiations set him apart from the failed conquistadors of the sixteenth century. Pérez de Ribas described him as a warrior whose valor was matched by his Christian piety and even concocted a theological argument to justify Hurdaide's cruelest acts. The Jesuit likened Hurdaide to the heroes of the Old Testament and reveled in the many massacres Hurdaide carried out on the Jesuits' behalf.³⁷

A subtly different picture emerged from Hurdaide's correspondence. He was indeed a fierce, pious warrior, but he was much less ideological than the Jesuits made him out to be. His letters dwelled at tedious length on such mundane topics as adobe bricks, axe handles, cattle, salted fish, and, most insistently, money. He was more sensitive about his social status, his salary, and his health than Pérez de Ribas would have us believe. He also understood how limited his power was. In one pathetic missive he wrote, "In Sinaloa, I have neither haciendas nor profit of any kind, . . . but rather excessive work, great expense, and notable risk to my life." In a letter of 1602, he wrote that there were all of forty Spaniards in Sinaloa and that the Indians were ready and able to kill them all. He said the natives would slaughter the Jesuits if there were no soldiers to protect them. He went on to warn that slaving expeditions would cause a backlash and destroy all that he and the Jesuits had built. The captain tried whenever he could to appear terrifying because he knew a reputation for sadism and capricious violence would protect him. But he was often terrified himself, and that terror led him to a prudent assessment of his own weak position.³⁸

Soon after returning from Mexico City in the fall of 1601, the captain lashed out at the Zuaques, perpetrating the massacre described at the beginning of this chapter. In the wake of the killings, the Ahome people sought the captain's protection from their neighbors, the Tehuecos. Hurdaide attacked a group of Tehuecos camped in the valley of Mathahoa and took two hundred women and children captive. To those who fled into the wilderness, he sent word that they should leave the Ahomes in peace. Negotiation followed each attack, and so each of the rivers' diverse groups began to surmise what their options were in dealing with Hurdaide. They could either risk direct confrontation or acquire the Spanish and their Christian allies as friends.³⁹

Hurdaide soon traveled once again to Mexico City with four Spanish soldiers and a group of native leaders from the Sinaloa River. There they asked the viceroy for permission to continue the northward conquest. The viceroy granted it and sent two more Jesuits back to Sinaloa. Representatives of the Fuerte River peoples greeted Hurdaide on his return. Luisa spoke for the Zuaques, and a baptized leader named Lanzarote represented the Tehuecos, while unnamed representatives stood for the Ahomes. All said they wanted Jesuits to come live among them, and they offered to build churches and houses in their towns to accommodate the Jesuits. Méndez was assigned to the Tehuecos, Cristóbal de Villalta to the Sinaloas, and the future chronicler Pérez de Ribas to the Ahomes and Zuaques.⁴⁰

The Ahome mission represented the quickest and most complete success for the Jesuits. Pérez de Ribas interpreted this success in purely moral terms, claiming that the Ahomes yearned for Jesuit spiritual care. But there is ample evidence that the Ahomes also had political and material motivations for welcoming the Jesuits among them. They sent a number of their children to the Spanish fort as hostage-students. The Jesuit, in turn, served as guarantor of Hurdaide's protection. After welcoming Pérez de Ribas with a procession led by a cross decorated with flowers, the Ahomes led the Jesuit to the river. They told him of the attacks they had suffered there at the hands of the Zuaques and said, "Father . . . now that you are with us, the women can go to this river for water, whereas before, it was necessary to accompany them with bows and arrows." The Jesuit's presence guaranteed that Hurdaide would protect them against their enemies. Conversion also meant access to goods: when allies of the Ahomes came to visit, Pérez de Ribas greeted them with colored glass beads, a metal knife, an axe blade, and a needle for their fishnets. After the baptism of the Ahomes, Pérez de Ribas said Mass in the midst of native dances. So a dusting of Christianity was thrown over a vigorous native culture.⁴¹

The Zuaques were a more complicated case. They were largely responsible for the collapse of San Juan de Carapoa and had harassed and killed settlers and their native allies. They had also suffered extreme violence at the hands of the Spanish captain. There were nevertheless individuals among them who were friendly to the Spanish, most notably Luisa. She and a relative named Ventura reached out to the Spanish in 1605 to ask for a Jesuit to come baptize their people. They returned to the Zuaque towns with Pérez de Ribas and no other guards. Luisa served as godmother to many of the eight hundred children the Jesuit baptized. When Pérez de Ribas asked some Zuaques why they had been so hostile, they responded that they feared the Spanish, about whom their hechiceros had spoken ill. "But now, having a Padre in their company, they

were free of fear, undeceived, and very content." Pérez de Ribas reported one Zuaque as saying, "Ah, Padre, how right we were to have said before you came to our land: 'while our children remain un-baptized, we cannot be safe.'" The practical motivation for inviting the Jesuits could not have been plainer. Priests protected the Zuaques from the depredations of the Spanish captain. There is no evidence of the Zuaques having provided children as hostages, but there was perhaps no need to. They knew at first hand the violence they could expect if they did not treat the Jesuit well. The Zuaques nevertheless made it clear that their ferocity was undiminished and that they would change their customs only so much. The Jesuit wrote that when a shrine to the Virgin Mary had been completed, bonfires were lit in the main plaza of the town and the Zuaques danced beneath the stars. Drums that had once been beaten to convoke Zuaque war parties and to celebrate their triumphs with severed Christian heads were now beaten in praise of Jesus and the Virgin Mary. A Jesuit preached in the Zuaque language, and, in an echo of the Christian sacrifices described by Augustine of Canterbury, two cows donated by the Jesuits were slaughtered in celebration of the new shrine.⁴²

The Tehueco mission was a disaster in the early years. Like the Zuaques, the Tehuecos had blown hot and cold on the Spanish, their ambivalence expressed in divisions between those who favored the Jesuits and those who did not. Yet they had not suffered the kind of horrors the Zuaques had for their ambivalence. They had long been hostile to the Zuaques and were reluctant to ally with them by welcoming Jesuits. Hurdaide played into the hands of the anti-Spanish faction by attempting to site a new fort in Tehueco territory shortly after the arrival of Méndez. Skepticism about the Spanish and Jesuits grew among the Tehuecos when disease swept through Tehueco villages. Méndez discovered that Tehueco shamans were preaching that their idols could cure the disease. When the Jesuit destroyed as many idols as he could find, he learned that his parishioners were plotting to kill him. Hurdaide sent soldiers to protect Méndez, and the Jesuit narrowly escaped several attempts on his life. Méndez once had to take refuge in a church to escape his attackers, and Christian Tehuecos lit fires around it to warn away the Jesuit's enemies. The priest spent the night hiding in a church surrounded by a moat of flames, while his enemies circled in the reeling shadows beyond.⁴³

Hurdaide suspected that a general insurrection was at hand and in 1612 took forty heavily armed Spanish horsemen to the Tehueco mission along with four hundred head of cattle and two thousand native allies. The non-Christians in Hurdaide's party demanded that they be allowed to take scalps. Hurdaide agreed but added the provision that he would give a horse for every enemy—

“women and children in particular”—captured alive. Pérez de Ribas accompanied the mission and took a central role in the theatrics of violence. Hurdaide would whip male captives and then when he moved to whip the women and children as well, Pérez de Ribas begged the captain for mercy. This bloody stage play was meant to enhance the captain’s reputation for terrifying brutality and the Jesuits’ reputation for kindness. It may also have been a signal that hostages would be treated well, should they be offered. Hurdaide and his men found the enemy’s territory in ruins. The retreating rebels had burned their cornfields and scattered poisoned spikes in the pathways. After Hurdaide and his men chased rebels into a gorge, Pérez de Ribas was horrified to see the captain’s allies returning with bloody trophies. They had skinned the faces of the dead and carried the skins on a cord threaded through the dead men’s nostrils. “This was painful to behold, but these are the *fueros* of war,” wrote Pérez de Ribas, referring to the special privilege Hurdaide had granted his allies to take scalps. That night Hurdaide’s Indian allies lit dozens of fires and sang and danced through the night in celebration of their victory. The Indian allies were so numerous and their dances so horrifying to Pérez de Ribas that, he wrote, they looked like the very image of hell.⁴⁴

The attack on the Tehueco rebels lasted six weeks and ended with the capture of seven of the rebel leaders. Five were hanged and two garroted. All seven of the corpses were then burned. Hurdaide distributed what cattle remained to his allies and, in a fitting coda to this horrific episode, ordered the execution of a horse. He told his followers that a rebel leader responsible for the burning of a church had ridden it. The horse shared in the leader’s guilt and had to be punished. He had the animal tied to a post, and his allies shot it with arrows and then burned it. The execution of this animal for abetting a sacrilege was emblematic. It was the product of an extremely violent, multicultural world dominated by Indians but in which Christian ideas were beginning to take hold. The execution was carried out in furtherance of the Christian mission in the northwest, but it would only have made sense in a native context to hold the horse responsible for its crimes. During the conquest of the Aztec empire, Otomí warriors captured horses as worthy adversaries and ritually sacrificed them. William Taylor has described native attitudes toward a statue of St. James, arguing that the Indians had far greater regard for Santiago’s horse than for the saint who rode it. Here and elsewhere in Mexico, the conquest was thoroughly mestizo.⁴⁵

The people of the Mayo River had long been willing to negotiate with Spaniards. Located roughly thirty miles north of the Fuerte River and thirty miles south of the Yaqui, the Mayo River lay between several formidable

and often hostile groups. The enmity between the Mayos and the Yaquis had been noted as early as Ibarra's mission in the 1560s, and Ruíz described brutal Spanish attacks in the 1580s. These harsh conditions prompted the Mayos to cooperate with the Spanish. Hurdaide had employed Mayos on the construction of the fort of Montesclaros and had taken Mayo allies with him on various military expeditions, rewarding their loyalty with gifts of horses and cattle. Several Mayo families asked Pérez de Ribas when he was living among the Zuaques to come and live in the Mayo towns and baptize them. As always, Pérez de Ribas attributed spiritual motives to the Indians while providing evidence of practical ones. "At this time," he wrote, "Christians enjoyed such security among all the nations, that even if they were pagan, and even if they had had continual war with them before, all one had to do in order to be well received and have safe conduct was to say: 'I am baptized.'" This is surely an exaggeration. But Hurdaide had rewarded enough friends and punished enough enemies by this time to have convinced some Indians that baptism had its benefits. Some Mayo caciques recognized this and petitioned Hurdaide for baptism in early 1610. When Méndez arrived in 1614, he found the Mayo communities in a state of desperation. He wrote that of the three thousand people he baptized in the days after his arrival, five hundred died of disease soon thereafter. Disease made it impossible to hunt and tend to the fields. The Mayos were starving. Many had dispersed into the wilderness to escape the pestilence and scavenge for food. Hurdaide tried to allay their suffering by sending for food from the Nébomes, an unconverted people who had allied with the Spanish five years before. By inviting the Jesuits to live among them, the Mayos eliminated Hurdaide and his Christian allies as a threat and gained protection from their Yaqui enemies to the north. There is no evidence of their having offered child captives, but, like the Zuaques, they may not have had to. The alternatives to conversion—starvation, disease, and war—were motive enough for them to remain loyal to their new Spanish friends.⁴⁶

War is a savage teacher, and it beat several indelible lessons into its pupils in northwest Mexico. The Spanish learned the folly of trying to conquer the region by killing and slaving alone. The conquest had to be mestizo to succeed. Spaniards needed native help in all their endeavors, and so they had to step back and think carefully about how to obtain it. The Jesuits were indispensable to the formulation of the new strategies the Spanish deployed in the northwest. Their genius lay in their flexibility and willingness to learn. Learning native languages and observing native cultures led them to a certain partial respect for Indians. Recognizing the virtues of the Indians, in turn, allowed them to find

common ground in matters of culture, religion, and political interest. It also helped them to understand that native and invading people had mutually compatible systems of captive exchange. Settlers and Jesuits alike earned this knowledge at the cost of enormous bloodshed and suffering, but in the end it allowed them to survive where so many others had died.⁴⁷

The mestizo conquest beat savage lessons into native peoples as well. Over the course of the sixteenth century they learned that they were eminently capable of defending themselves against Spanish incursions, but that defense had terrible costs. After wave upon wave of Spanish marauders and deadly epidemic diseases had crashed over the northwest, some—though never all—the native people of the region came to see advantages to allying with the invaders. They saw that some of the Spanish were not vicious barbarians but were in fact capable of learning the languages, respecting the customs, and making friends with the people of the region. Such was the suffering and fear many Indians endured and such was the confidence some Indians began to feel in some Spaniards that natives began to welcome Europeans into their most sacred rites of friendship, kinship, and alliance. Just as the Huities handed over their children to their native enemies, so numerous native groups began to hand their children over to the violent aliens who brought slavery, disease, and Christian conversion. In many cases, native hopes for recompense were actually fulfilled. Gifts, friendships, and Jesuits came to them in exchange for their children. Indians also discovered that there were unexpected attractions to the Jesuits' novel ways of communicating with the spirits of earth and sky. There were ways of weaving native threads into the fabric of Christian religious practice. Native peoples of the northwest also learned the horrendous power of epidemic disease. Disease-stricken communities needed whatever help they could get, and the Jesuits offered care and supernatural cures that sometimes worked. The Spanish captain offered protection to native villages that were too enfeebled to protect themselves.

Both Spanish and native actors in the northwest dreamed that violence would lead to a climactic victory. Pérez de Ribas wrote that the killing of idolaters would purge native peoples of their spiritual disease. Native leaders such as Nacabeba called for the cleansing of the land in a bath of Christian blood. Neither natives nor Europeans got what they wanted. Rather than a decisive victory for either side, the mestizo conquest had the ironic result of producing a network of cultural, political, and linguistic exchange across ethnic lines. In the early years of the seventeenth century, Yaquis, Jesuits, and Spanish settlers drew on their experience in the mestizo conquest to weave an alliance that would endure through the following century.

THE JESUIT REDUCTION: THE BIRTH OF THE YAQUI MISSION TOWNS, 1610-1617

Legibility is a condition of manipulation. Any substantial state intervention in society . . . requires the invention of units that are visible. . . . Whatever the units being manipulated, they must be organized in a manner that permits them to be identified, observed, recorded, counted, aggregated, and monitored.

—James Scott, *Seeing Like a State*

How did the Yaqui mission come into existence? Yaquis tell the story of their conversion to Christianity in the Legend of the Talking Tree. There are many versions of this tale, but they all have a few elements in common. They all tell of an ancient race of little people called the Surem who lived near the mouth of the Yaqui River. One day a tree began to make dire pronouncements in a language no one could understand. Only one of the Surem, a woman called Yomomúli, or Flower Woman, could decipher the tree's speech. Yomomúli, variously described as a powerful shaman, queen, and hunter, warned that many of the Surem would be baptized and that they would die because of it. Disease would kill many others. In some versions, an angel watched all this from the heavens. Others say it was the angel who spoke through the tree. Yet others say the tree's voice was the voice of God himself. Whatever the case may be, the Surem were divided between those who wanted baptism and those who did not. "There was a great fight," runs one version of the story, "all up and down the river, the people who wanted to be baptized fighting with the people who did not want to be." Eventually those who favored baptism burned down the talking tree and were baptized by Catholic priests. The baptized Surem became the Yaquis and settled in eight sacred towns. Those who spurned baptism were transformed into invisible spirits and disappeared

into the sierras and the sea, sometimes returning to teach the Yaquis their secret arts.¹

This legend is freighted with meaning for the Yaquis. The anthropologist Kirstin C. Erickson has underscored the ways in which the legend emphasizes the Yaquis' decision making, "informed anticipation," "historical agency," and the "emergence of a new consciousness of group belonging formulated by the presence of a qualitatively different other." The legend also captures the divisions caused by the prospect of baptism. The painful losses and changes that came with the new dispensation are central to the legend, as is the mission experience as a key to the definition of the Yaquis as a distinct people. Those who accepted baptism became Yaquis. Those who did not either departed or suffered a mystical transformation.²

Jesuits told the story of Yaqui conversion very differently. Clerics such as Andrés Pérez de Ribas depicted it as a battle of Jesuit priests and virtuous Christian knights against Satan and an army of Yaqui slaves. The stakes were high, the peril great, and the eventual triumph of Christianity all the sweeter for having been so hard-won. Jesuit spiritual warfare brought the swift and complete transformation of the Yaquis from devil worshippers into devout Christians. Like the Legend of the Talking Tree, this story was deeply meaningful to the people who told it. Jesuits aspired to what they called the *reducción*, or reduction, of the native peoples of the northwest. The word's Latin root, *re-ducere*, meant "to lead back," and the Jesuits often spoke of their work as if they were leading Indians back from the wilderness and onto a path they had wandered from long before. The word was also associated with taming and domestication. Reducing the Indians meant breaking down their arrogance, as a horse trainer would do to a proud stallion. To the Jesuits, reduction was associated with order and understanding. Jesuits hoped to understand the inner workings of native cultures in order to transform them. To achieve that understanding, they aspired to suppress native customs that made it difficult to track Indians down and monitor them. Seasonal migration, hunting and gathering, living in isolated hamlets and mountain redoubts were all native practices the Jesuits wanted to destroy. They wanted Indians to live in fixed, legible settlements in river valleys, to keep to a regular work schedule, take an unchanging Christian name, and marry a single spouse of the opposite sex in a Christian ceremony.³

Too often scholars have confused Jesuit fantasies of reduction with the harsh realities of mission life. They have described the Yaqui mission as rich, populous, stable, and "the jewel of the Jesuit mission system." The arrival of the Jesuits among the Yaquis has been described as a "peaceful conquest," and the period of their residence in the Yaqui Valley as one of "remarkable creative

growth for the Yaquis." As in the rest of the Jesuit missions of northern New Spain, most claim the Jesuits wielded control of their mission Indians. Evelyn Hu-DeHart has described the Jesuits' reorganization of native societies as a "phenomenal success" that enabled the Jesuits "to extend their hegemony over northwestern society in general." The Jesuits are said to have moved immediately beyond "simple conversion to imposing profound changes on all aspects of Yaqui life and society. . . . For the most part, the Yaqui people acquiesced in this directed cultural change." Despite his many disagreements with Hu-DeHart's work, Edward Spicer expressed similar views on the question. By these lights, the Jesuits quickly achieved a more or less benign dictatorship over the Yaquis, and the Yaquis largely embraced the program of *reducción*.⁴

To be fair, there is evidence that these claims are partially right. Over time, the Jesuits did have a deep impact on Yaqui religious, cultural, and political life, and the Yaqui mission did become the centerpiece of the Jesuit enterprise in the northwest. But the documentary record tells a much more complicated story than that told by scholars to date. Archival documents reveal that Jesuit power over the Yaquis never came close to being absolute. Yaquis frustrated the Jesuits' attempts to gather information and use it to dominate them. Most often Jesuits were marginal figures, allowed to remain among the Yaquis as pawns in a loose system of alliances cultivated by the Spanish. Given their precarious foothold in Yaqui communities, the Jesuits were often reduced to accepting the pace of change the Yaquis were comfortable with. Indeed, it was often Yaquis who controlled and manipulated the Jesuits. Yaquis made Jesuits live where they could be monitored, and Yaquis used Jesuits as tools for the furtherance of their own political ambitions. Ironically, the creation of the Jesuit reduction among the Yaquis often meant the reduction of the Jesuits themselves.⁵

In this sense the Legend of the Talking Tree is closer to the truth than almost all other accounts. The archival record lacks any mention of the Surem, Yomomúli, or the fateful tree, but it does confirm many of the legend's deeper meanings. Newly discovered and rarely cited archival documents lead away from the dramatic confrontations that played so central a role in Jesuit chronicles. They point toward a complex story in which Yaquis were deeply informed about the Spanish and the Jesuits, were conflicted as to how to engage with them, and yet took sophisticated, decisive action when circumstances demanded it. The documentary record also offers vivid confirmation that native women, like the powerful Yomomúli, played fundamental roles in mediating between the Yaquis and the Spanish. And it shows that what change did occur among the Yaquis was not swift or complete but slow, piecemeal, fraught with violence and loss, and very much on Yaqui terms.

WAR

By the time the Spanish turned their attention to the Yaqui River, their behavior had coalesced into a pattern. Captain Hurdaide would intervene in existing conflicts between native peoples, rewarding those who sided with him and punishing those who did not. Alliances with the captain would often be formalized through the exchange of children for Jesuits. Jesuits would enter the towns of the Spaniards' allies, try to learn the local language, and baptize the young, the elderly, and the ill. Then they would begin administering the catechism to adults and marrying couples in Catholic ceremonies. Native children, in turn, would learn Spanish in the Jesuit college, along with basic prayers, Christian songs, and knowledge of Spanish musical instruments, all of which they would apply on their envisioned return to their home communities. Though Spaniards, Jesuits, and native peoples were killed in the process, this strategy was more effective than any previous attempt at colonization. Indians allied with the Spanish for complicated reasons, but we can discern both material incentives and spiritual attractions to doing so. Conversion meant alliance with the ferocious Spanish captain and his native Christian allies. It also meant having access to the spiritual power of the Jesuits, who promised cures for disease, rain for the fields, and material prosperity for all. The Jesuits' willingness to welcome native contributions to Christian ritual life smoothed the native path into the church. Native contributions, in turn, altered the architecture, ornaments, and meanings of the church itself.⁶

It is impossible to bring the political strategies of the Yaquis into sharp focus. We cannot know how the Yaquis defined themselves as a people or even whether a "Yaqui" people existed before the arrival of the Jesuits, questions crucial to understanding why they behaved as they did. Indeed the Legend of the Talking Tree posits that the experience of religious conversion was what effectively created the Yaquis as a people. The Jesuits agreed in some sense, claiming to have defined them as a distinct nation. By all accounts, the mission experience would make a deep impression on the Yaquis' self-definition in later times. Nevertheless, there is evidence that the inhabitants of the lower Yaqui Valley were a people distinct from their neighbors. The Yaqui River delta was larger and more fertile than any comparable zone in Sinaloa and Sonora, and it sustained the region's largest concentrated population—around thirty thousand, by several accounts. Writers from Diego de Guzmán to Pérez de Ribas suggested that the Yaquis were conscious of their distinctiveness and were willing to fight to defend themselves. Pérez de Ribas commented that the Yaquis were known as the people who spoke in shouts. He thought at first that

it was a sign of disrespect when a Yaqui spoke to him in this way, and he questioned one man who did so. “‘Do you not see that I am a Hiaqui?’ the man replied, ‘and so he said, since this name means one who speaks in shouts.’” The residents of the lower Yaqui Valley expressed a sense of belonging to a defined political entity in other ways. Captain Hurdaide noticed that the Yaquis were uniquely cohesive in battle. Where other native peoples fled en masse at the sight of their first casualties, the Yaquis stepped over the bodies of their fallen comrades, pressed the attack, and shouted, “Kill, for we are many!” Pérez de Ribas wrote in 1617 that the Yaquis were the best provided with food, water, and fertile land of all the region’s peoples and were for this reason the most politically isolated group in the northwest. He wrote that they were constantly at war with the Mayos to the south and the Nébomes to the north, a further indication of their separateness from their neighbors. All this suggests that the Yaquis were united, warlike, materially prosperous, and conscious of their distinctness from other groups.⁷

Nevertheless, a great deal of evidence shows that the Yaquis and their neighbors had deep relationships. They shared many practices with native groups on the Mayo and Fuerte Rivers to the south, including flood farming, the Cáhita language, ranchería settlements, collective hunting and fishing, ritual use of fermented drinks, and ritual dances. Álgar Núñez Cabeza de Vaca noted in the 1530s that Indians in this region traded turquoise and parrot feathers with groups as distant as the Aztecs to the south and the Pueblos of New Mexico to the north. There is also evidence that warfare between the Yaquis and their neighbors alternated with periods of peaceful exchange. Later documents show that intermarriage among the Yaquis, Mayos, Guaymas, and other native groups was not uncommon. The Yaquis were in contact with the Spanish as well, from the early contacts with Cabeza de Vaca and Ibarra through brief, tense exchanges with Hurdaide after 1600. In each circumstance the Yaquis showed a kind of aggressive curiosity toward visitors that revealed both experience in dealing with outsiders and flexibility in their responses to them. Thus by the early seventeenth century the Yaquis had demonstrated both a strong group identity and a willingness to engage with the world beyond the lower Yaqui Valley, qualities they would express time and again in their subsequent history.⁸

A document cited rarely, if ever, in the literature on the Yaquis sheds fresh light on the conditions in which the Yaquis first came into sustained contact with the Spanish. In a manuscript of 1614 now housed in the Jesuit archive in Rome, father Vicente de Águila wrote that Hurdaide traveled to Mexico City with several native leaders in 1607. There he met with the viceroy to request supplies for the missions and settlements in the northwest. His request was

granted, and he returned to Sinaloa with two Jesuits, Cristóbal de Villata and the future chronicler Pérez de Ribas, who was apparently in the capital on other business. Passing through the Sierra de Topia on the way back to the northwest, Hurdaide learned that several native communities in Sinaloa were in revolt. The Bacubritos, Ocoronis, and Zuaques had all abandoned their communities, and the Bacubritos had burned the church the Jesuits had built for them. All had fled to the Mayo River and were being harbored there by Hurdaide's sometime allies, the Mayos. Hurdaide rode to the Mayo River and took the Mayos by surprise, seizing many of the fugitives, some of whom escaped to the nearby hills of Teave. After taking his captives to the Villa de San Felipe y Santiago, Hurdaide made a second attack on the fugitives, captured some of them, and took a female Mayo leader hostage. He brought her to the Mayos and returned her to them in exchange for a promise of alliance in the future. Águila said it was at this moment that Hurdaide achieved the reputation for cunning that earned him the name wizard (*hechicero*) or dwarf (*duende*) among the native peoples of the northwest.⁹

Águila then described a crucial episode that Pérez de Ribas omitted. After Hurdaide's exchange with the Mayos, he rode north to the Yaqui River in search of the last of the fugitives. Águila wrote that Hurdaide's visit proved the adage, "Do good to all, no matter who they are" (*haz bien, y no mire a quién*). A Yaqui man whom Hurdaide had once welcomed to the villa approached the captain and his men when they got near the Yaqui River. Hurdaide had given this man gifts, protected him from his enemies, and sent him back to his home on the Yaqui River "safe and happy." The man told Hurdaide that the Yaquis were waiting for him. "And thereafter, in secret, he informed [Hurdaide] of the pits, traps, and ambushes that were being prepared for him." Hurdaide avoided these and engaged the Yaquis in battle on his own terms, killed several "barbarians," and captured the last of the baptized fugitives. Hurdaide then returned to his base, "arriv[ing] at the villa with this plunder to the great joy of all." This act of Spanish aggression was a critical antecedent to later confrontations with the Yaquis. By omitting it, Pérez de Ribas made Yaqui hostility toward the Spanish seem more unreasoning than it was. In reality the Yaquis were well informed about Hurdaide and had good reason to consider him a threat.¹⁰

Águila and Pérez de Ribas agreed that hostilities deepened with the subsequent rebellion led by a baptized Ocoroni leader named Juan Lautaro, who spoke Spanish and had spent time in the Spanish mining town of San Andrés. After burning their town's church to the ground, Lautaro and his followers took refuge among the Mayos and tried to sway them to the rebel cause. Failing this, Lautaro and forty Ocoroni families retreated north to the Yaqui River, where

the Yaquis welcomed the Ocoroni fugitives in exchange for gifts of clothing and woven mats. Pérez de Ribas reported that the rebels had to hand over their daughters to their Yaqui hosts. Lautaro shared his knowledge of Spanish ways with the Yaquis and taught the Yaquis about Spanish tactics and weaponry. Águila wrote that the Ocoroni rebels turned the Yaquis against the Spanish by telling them that Jesuits were evil magicians and that the sacraments were poison. "The many sorcerers among these nations, being the satraps and ministers of the republic that the demon has here, do nothing to help the planting and conservation of the Christian religion," wrote Águila. Águila also noted that among the Yaquis there lived many Zuaques, Mayos, and Tehuecos whose family members had died at Hurdaide's hands. These victims of Spanish aggression pleaded with the Yaquis to take vengeance on the Christians. The Yaquis may have been a group distinct from their neighbors, but they had extensive contact with them as well as access to a great deal of damning information about the Spanish.¹¹

Hurdaide rode once again to the Yaqui River in 1608 in pursuit of the Ocoroni fugitives, but he decided not to attack. He respected the advantage the Yaquis enjoyed on their home territory and the number of warriors they could put on the field of battle—eight thousand by Pérez de Ribas's count. "The Yaquis," Pérez de Ribas wrote, "though they moved nearby with arms in hand, did not attack, and neither did the Captain, who wanted to avoid war and to make peace and friendship with them, as much to dispose them toward the light of the Gospel as to end the asylum they gave to the rebels." From his camp Hurdaide sent messengers who spoke the Yaqui language to ask that they hand over Lautaro and the Christian Ocoronis. The messengers said this would bring peace to the land and would open commerce between the Yaquis and Spanish. The Yaquis responded that they would not hand Lautaro or his followers over and had no interest in forming a friendship with the Spanish. Pérez de Ribas made it look as though the Yaquis were hostile on account of stubborn prejudice and addiction to sin. But the Yaquis had in reality suffered an unprovoked attack at Hurdaide's hands, and living among them were many people whose family members had been massacred by Hurdaide and his allies. Yaqui enmity was perfectly reasonable.¹²

Faced with rejection, Hurdaide returned to his base to the south. He had only a few men with him, and wanted to try other diplomatic tools. The Jesuits agreed that diplomacy was preferable to war, given the vulnerability of the missions. Hurdaide sent messages and gifts from his base, inviting the Yaquis to deliver Lautaro. Hurdaide wrote to the viceroy that his gifts—tunics of various cloths, hats of taffeta, leggings of Brussels cloth, shoes, and swords—had bought

the loyalty of Christian converts, attracted new converts to the faith, and would have similar effects on the Yaquis. Some Yaquis seemed to welcome these messages and sent a leader named Anabailutei to the villa to speak with Hurdaide, asking to make peace with him and offering to surrender Lautaro and his followers. Hurdaide agreed and sent a party of Christian Tehuecos back to the Yaqui Valley with the Yaqui leader. As a gesture of goodwill, Hurdaide also sent back two Yaqui women he had captured on his first expedition to the valley. Yet on the arrival of Hurdaide's emissaries at the Yaqui River, the Yaquis promptly killed the Tehueco Christians, stole their horses and clothing, and reclaimed the Yaqui women Hurdaide had kidnapped.¹³

In a region where mutual trust, exchange, and alliances were critical to survival, these were shocking expressions of contempt. Why the Yaquis acted as they did is unclear. Some have argued that Anabailutei acted without the consent of the Yaqui people and so lacked the authority to negotiate with Hurdaide. Others have questioned this, arguing that the Yaquis had greater unity of purpose than this explanation would imply. But there is ample evidence of divisions among the Yaquis with respect to negotiations with the Spanish. Anabailutei may well have had political opponents among his own people who were willing to undermine his negotiations by killing allies of the Spanish. Another possibility is that Anabailutei's visit was a trick. He talked Hurdaide into giving up hostages, who were his most valuable bargaining chips, and then he treated the captain like a contemptible fool. A further possibility is that Hurdaide made some kind of error in protocol. In later negotiations the Yaquis always sent women to make initial peace offerings. The fact that Anabailutei was a man may have been a signal of hostility that Hurdaide failed to detect. The Yaquis, in turn, may have been alarmed at the captain's decision to send Tehueco men to speak for him.¹⁴

Whatever the case may be, the Tehuecos immediately demanded that Hurdaide avenge their loss. "The captain was now required to take up arms," the chronicler wrote, in order "to sustain . . . Spanish credit and reputation for valor: something of great importance among those nations." Any loss of face would have invited further disrespect. According to Pérez de Ribas, in the winter of 1608–9, Hurdaide raised an army of forty Spanish horsemen and two thousand native allies, many of them unconverted Mayos. He sent an advance guard ahead to prevent Yaqui spies from warning their people of the impending attack. After pitching camp near the Yaqui River, Hurdaide sent messengers to the Yaquis to tell them he wanted peace, but only if certain conditions were met. He received no answer until the next morning at dawn, when the Yaquis launched a massive surprise attack. Pérez de Ribas's account underscored the

captain's scrupulousness, as he carefully planned his approach and tried in vain to negotiate a peaceful agreement with his savage adversaries. Águila gave an account divulging that something close to the opposite happened. He made no mention of any preliminary diplomatic overtures from the Spanish side and said that it was Hurdaide who surprised the Yaquis rather than the other way around:

[The captain] arrived suddenly at the Yaqui River, catching them unawares, capturing by surprise several who were walking in the fields, and killing others. That great nation [the Yaquis] was much alarmed when it saw a Spaniard so suddenly in its lands, and much more so when it saw that he had already attacked its people, with the death of some and the capture of others. Word spread quickly and they swarmed like ants when they saw the poor captives, who gave them greater incentive to fight. The captain promised to hand over the captives and make peace if they handed over the Christians and evildoers. But they did not want to. Demands and responses passed from side to side before war broke out.

Pérez de Ribas depicted this as a set piece from a chivalric romance, in which a Christian paladin squared off with bloodthirsty infidels. Águila's messier and more plausible account depicted it as the first skirmish of two shrewd, ruthless, extremely experienced fighting forces. This manuscript account drew none of the stark moral polarities of later chronicles and captured the speed, violence, and chaotic unfolding of events.¹⁵

By all accounts the Yaquis thrashed the Spanish and their allies on the battlefield. The violence lasted the whole day, many Yaquis died, and many others were taken captive. The Yaquis severely wounded several Spaniards with poison arrows and killed many of the Tehueco and Mayo allies of the Spanish. According to Águila, Hurdaide himself was captured briefly and escaped only when his horse killed one of his captors by kicking him in the head. When Hurdaide realized the extent of his losses, he called a retreat. Thick brush made it difficult for the cavalry to maneuver their horses, and many of Hurdaide's Mayo allies were running away. On the way back to their home base the Spaniards found many of the Mayo people up in arms, since it was they who had sustained the most casualties. Hurdaide blamed the Mayos for their own misfortunes, saying it was their indiscipline that had gotten them killed. Here again Águila exposed ugly political realities that Pérez de Ribas glossed over. Alliances between the Spanish and Christian Indians were fraught with more distrust, rage, and frustration than the great Jesuit chronicler wished his readers to believe. Pérez de Ribas did record one critical detail, however: Hurdaide

“returned to the villa, with the captured Yaquis they had taken, and guarded and treated them well in order that they serve as hostages, and as a means of making peace in the future.” Here, as in all his previous wars, captives would play a central role in peace negotiations.¹⁶

After this defeat Hurdaide felt events spinning out of his control. In response he rode south to Culiacán for reinforcements and there raised an army of thirty-seven Spanish horsemen and four thousand native allies. They rode to the Yaqui River in the early summer of 1609 and met a force far better prepared than the one they had faced before. According to Pérez de Ribas, Hurdaide made a formal demand that Lautaro and the Ocoronis be handed over, sending a kind of sealed document he had used before to formalize peace agreements and to threaten all who violated them. One Spaniard discerned a Yaqui in the distance tying a cord to the document and dragging it through the dust, shouting and encouraging his fellow warriors all that day and into the evening. Águila made no mention of Hurdaide’s attempts at diplomacy or of the Yaquis’ disdain for it but wrote instead that early skirmishes quickly spiraled into all-out war.¹⁷

However the violence began, scores were killed and injured on both sides. The Yaquis had the advantage of proximity to the Yaqui River, which they were able to cross with ease as their offense or defense required. The rugged landscape rendered Spanish cavalry ineffective. After three days of combat Hurdaide began to see he was losing. His native allies were fleeing, and his whole army was in danger of annihilation. The captain ordered his flag-bearer, or *alférez*, to lead the retreat while he himself remained on the battlefield as a rear guard. The road south passed through a heavily wooded area, where horses would be useless. The Yaquis saw this and mounted a furious attack to separate Hurdaide from the leader of the retreat. The *alférez*, identified by Águila as Francisco Enríquez Zambrano, and the seventeen men under his command decided to strip the armor from their horses and leave the captain for dead. Tehueco Christians compounded the disaster of Zambrano’s flight by deliberately abandoning the field in order to sabotage Hurdaide. Hurdaide was left behind with only the eighteen Spaniards under his command and no native allies. Most of his men were injured, and Hurdaide himself had sustained five arrow wounds to his arms and face.¹⁸

The Yaquis had by this time seized the Spaniards’ supplies and gunpowder. Hurdaide ordered his men to retreat to the top of a treeless hill and told them to shoot only on his command in order to preserve powder and ammunition. The summer sun had dried the grass, and the Yaquis set it on fire to flush the Spaniards out. Hurdaide, cunning as ever, set the brush beneath his feet on fire with the flint and steel of a *harquebus*. The dry grass burned quickly, and

Hurdaide and his men were able to maneuver their horses onto the burned ground before the fires the Yaquis lit could envelop them. "Thus," wrote Águila, "one fire killed the other." Hurdaide's men and animals were exhausted and scorched by the heat of the sun and the expanding moat of flames surrounding them. They needed water, but the Yaquis blocked their path to the river. The Spanish earned a reprieve when a lucky shot from a *harquebus* killed one of the advancing Yaquis. The Yaquis were tired and wanted to divide the spoils of war, and so they fell back.¹⁹

At nightfall Hurdaide tried to create a distraction by letting two injured horses run free. As the Spanish hoped they would, the horses headed to the river for water, and the Yaqui guards followed them, thinking the whole Spanish party was dying of thirst. In this way Hurdaide and his men escaped, snatching defeat from the jaws of obliteration. Águila gave an elegant answer to the question of why the Yaquis let Hurdaide get away: the Yaquis actually did not do so but decided to wait for a time before pursuing them at leisure: "The next day, the barbarians gave chase, thinking they would find the fleeing Spaniards dead in the roads on account of the wounds they had received from herbed, or, to put it more accurately, poisoned arrows." After three days of fighting, the Yaquis wanted to rest, but they did so secure in the knowledge that some combination of poison, blood loss, and thirst would soon wipe their enemies out.²⁰

Remarkably, Hurdaide and his men did not die. Perhaps their Spanish armor protected them and their wounds were not as severe as the Yaquis thought. "It was certainly a marvelous thing," wrote Águila, "that they escaped such danger, since thirst alone, if not the enemy, was enough to end their lives." In any case, Hurdaide and his men were "destroyed" with fatigue when they reached the Mayo River. They were terrified that their enemies among the Mayos would kill them in their weakened state and hence did everything in their power to appear confident. To their amazement, Mayo girls greeted the captain and his men with garlands and sprinkled them with water. The girls explained to the Spanish that this was the custom of the land: when a person who was thought to be dead was found to be alive, those who had mourned him were to sprinkle him with water, a ritual reenactment of the tears they had shed before.²¹

A similarly ecstatic greeting awaited Hurdaide in the Villa de San Felipe y Santiago. Alférez Enríquez Zambrano had sown consternation when he announced that Hurdaide was dead. Jesuits wept at the imminent destruction of all they had built. Settler families despaired of surviving without Hurdaide's protection: "Very great was the weeping of the poor women in the villa, lamenting their widowhood," Águila wrote. "With the captain dead, who was the terror of all the rebel nations, Christianity was exposed to the manifest risk

of extinction,” wrote Pérez de Ribas. The Jesuit rector sent word to all of the eight missionaries in the field to convene in the villa to discuss the future of the missions. So fragile was the Spanish colonial government in Sinaloa that the death of a single soldier placed it in imminent danger of collapse. The spirits of all the Christians revived with the arrival of a loyal *pardo* (mixed race) messenger bearing news of Hurdaide’s survival. Hurdaide himself arrived shortly after, to the immense relief of all. The captain wanted to punish those who abandoned him but was afraid of the repercussions. He reasoned that if Indian allies saw Spaniards being executed for desertion, they would fear the same fate and would rebel. Hurdaide also realized he would be unable to mount such an attack without more troops and supplies and permission from the viceroy. So he turned from force to fraud in his attempts to subdue the Yaquis. A ship had recently been sighted off the coast, and Hurdaide spread rumors that it would soon attack the Yaquis and visit a terrible revenge on them. Through messengers and allies who had associations with the Yaquis, Hurdaide disseminated the lie that troops and supplies were on their way from Nueva Vizcaya.²²

The Yaquis were divided as to what to do next. Some were eager to engage Hurdaide in battle once again, while others thought the costs of their previous victories had been too high. The Jesuit annual letter of 1610 made note of a fact that few have noticed, and fewer still have attached any importance to: “Among them there were some Indians further up the same Yaqui River who did not come to make peace, and so they conspired against the people of their own nation, and they made war on them, incited as they were by the Christian Indians who had fled there; but seeing the great damage that each side was doing the other in this war, they agreed to make friends among themselves, and with the Spanish.” The decision to make peace with the Spanish was so controversial among the Yaquis that it led to something of a civil war among them, much as happened among the Surem in the Legend of the Talking Tree. Though the Yaquis were united in many ways, they were never unanimous, as many have claimed. Nor was Yaqui hostility transformed by Hurdaide’s wiles into passivity and desire for baptism. Many Yaquis still wanted him dead and were eager to go kill him. The peace process was more complicated and more difficult than has been realized, and neither the Jesuit chronicler nor modern scholars have taken note of it.²³

When the peace party at last won out, the Yaquis decided to contact Hurdaide. Why the Yaquis made the decision to end the war when they were in a position of such strength is a question that has intrigued scholars at least since Hubert Howe Bancroft’s *History of the North Mexican States and Texas*.

It is one of the key questions of Yaqui history, and there are many possible explanations for it. Águila thought fear was the motive. The Yaquis were, he thought, terrified of Hurdaide and no longer wanted to fight him. Yaqui women, he wrote, “were scared to go to the river for water, thinking Spaniards were waiting there to ambush them.” Pérez de Ribas agreed: The Yaquis, he wrote, were “very shameless and arrogant” because they had destroyed the greatest army the Spanish could muster, and they had taken rich spoils. “But in the midst of this, they were frightened, and astonished to see all the Spaniards had escaped.” This is a more plausible explanation than scholars have generally acknowledged. To say that the Yaquis were impressed by Hurdaide’s survival is not to label them as witless savages. It is to say they recognized that the captain and his allies represented a formidable enemy. Every available source agreed that native peoples called Hurdaide wizard and dwarf for his cunning in battle and his skill in negotiations over captives. The Jesuits called all native leaders wizards, or *hechiceros*, and so their translation of Hurdaide’s native moniker as wizard may indicate that native peoples described him in the same terms they used to describe their own leaders. Calling him dwarf perhaps associated him with the small but supernaturally powerful Surem. Hurdaide prided himself equally on his ferocity in battle and his generosity toward those under his protection, qualities that were also the basis of indigenous leadership. In this light, Pérez de Ribas’s explanation is plausible. The Yaquis were delighted to have beaten back the invaders, but they were weary of tangling once again with the very dangerous Captain Hurdaide and his allies. The Yaquis’ negotiating position was strong, yet so too were their incentives to make peace.²⁴

Another possible explanation is that Hurdaide himself was more willing to make concessions after the beating he had taken. None of his Jesuit admirers mentioned this possibility, and Hurdaide himself went so far as to crow that he had defeated the Yaquis. But rarely cited letters from Hurdaide shed a different light on his state of mind. In a message to the viceroy dated February 6, 1610, Hurdaide described the Yaquis as great in number, “fierce and barbaric . . . superb, valiant, and arrogant” in battle. He said he and his men had escaped from them only through “the pity of God.” He considered himself lucky to be alive and feared a worse fate if he were to fight the Yaquis again. A letter written in 1618 opens a second window into Hurdaide’s thinking. Writing to the Jesuit provincial, Hurdaide poured out his sorrows over his career in northwest Mexico. He complained about his debts and said that many people in the region wanted nothing but his “destruction and ruin.” He was proud of his work in helping the Jesuits, but he simply could not do it any more. He had only thirty-six soldiers to police the entire vast territory under his jurisdiction. “And,”

he continued, "for the Yaquimi alone, fifty would not be enough, because that people is numerous and very brave." He went on to implore the provincial to recommend him to the viceroy for a more comfortable posting in central Mexico. "Please ask him," Hurdaide wrote, "to give me a position in New Spain so that I can pay my debts, and in that way, there will be room for braver and more experienced men to pacify this province, and I will be able to live where people do not betray me." These words were written eight years after the fact, but the fear, rage, and frustration the captain expressed in this letter were probably beginning to take root in 1610. Hurdaide was proud of holding his own against the Yaquis, but he was as exhausted and terrified by them as they were by him. He was readier than ever to come to the negotiating table, and the Yaquis may well have known it.²⁵

Yet a further conceivable explanation for the Yaquis' peace overtures is that they did not consider the objective of war to be total victory or the annihilation of the enemy. The Yaquis had done much the same thing after fighting with Diego de Guzmán in the 1530s and with the Mayos in the 1560s, making offers of peace after bloody battles. Indigenous war in the region was a ritualized and normal facet of interethnic relations, and the culturally correct thing to do at this stage may have been to end the conflict through negotiation.²⁶

NEGOTIATION

A Yaqui elder named Conibomeai took the first step toward a negotiated peace in April 1610. He sent a Yaqui woman to speak with leaders of the Mayo people. He calculated that if she did not return after two days, she and the diplomatic mission with her must have come to a violent end. This nameless messenger traveled alone to the Mayo River and made contact with Mayo leaders named Osameai and Boothisume. She asked these men whether they could help broker a peace agreement with their Spanish allies. Though skeptical, the Mayo elders welcomed her overtures and promised to help her bring an end to the wars between the Yaquis and Spanish. They escorted her from Mayo territory back to the Yaqui River, where she delivered the Mayos' response to Conibomeai and several other Yaqui leaders. Encouraged, the Yaquis sent their messenger to the Mayo River once again, accompanied by a second Yaqui woman and a Mayo woman who had been captured in a previous war and was now the wife of a Yaqui leader named Otuaco. The inclusion of this Mayo woman was a gesture packed with meaning, much of which is lost to us. Pérez de Ribas commented that "these Indians sometimes prize the taking of a wife or concubine from a foreign nation." Armed conflict between the Yaquis and

their neighbors did not preclude more peaceful kinds of exchange, such as marriage and diplomacy. Indeed marriage and interethnic violence were in this case bound together in mysterious ways. Whatever the precise content of the message, the Mayos welcomed this second visit warmly and conferred with the messengers before sending their own diplomatic team to meet with Captain Hurdaide. The two Yaqui messengers and the Mayo wife of Otuaco, the Yaqui leader, remained with relatives among the Mayos.²⁷

Hurdaide welcomed the Yaquis' offer to negotiate for peace and sent a sealed letter back with the Mayos as a token of his desire that the Yaquis come to visit him. As a further signal of goodwill, Hurdaide instructed the Mayos to give food and shelter to the Yaqui emissaries. The Yaqui women staying with the Mayos then came to visit Hurdaide, accompanied by forty Mayo emissaries. The Yaqui women told Hurdaide that the Yaquis regretted their wars with the Mayos and with the Spanish and that they lived in terror of further Spanish attacks. Hurdaide asked them if they spoke for all the Yaqui people, and they admitted that there were some younger men who still wanted to fight. Nevertheless, they assured the captain that the war faction had been overruled by Conibomeai and a second leader named Hinsimeai.²⁸

Hurdaide gave horses and clothing to the Yaqui women to take back to the Yaquis, reiterating his order that the Mayos treat the ambassadors well. He told the Yaqui women he was willing to negotiate but would do so only with Yaqui men. He also demanded that the Yaquis show their good faith by congregating into towns so he could monitor them more easily. On the messengers' return to the Yaqui River, these demands met a mixed response. Some Yaquis were skeptical of the captain's intentions, while others wanted to visit Hurdaide to see for themselves if he was in earnest. On the arrival of Yaqui emissaries in the Spanish fort, Hurdaide told these men he was indeed serious about peace and asked them why they had been so hostile before. They replied that the fugitive leader Lautaro and another rebel leader named Babilonio, or Babilomo, had spread the word that Hurdaide was weak. The fugitive rebels had promised that if they all worked together they would kill Hurdaide and dance with his severed head.²⁹

The Yaqui ambassadors stayed with Hurdaide for four days and received horses, clothing, knives, and other gifts. The captain set several conditions for peace. The first was that a large number of Yaqui leaders would have to come to the Villa de San Felipe y Santiago and profess their unanimous desire to end the war. Second, the Yaquis would have to promise never to make war on the Mayos or any other group under the protection of the Spanish king. Third, the Yaquis were to promise never to give shelter to any enemies of the Spanish. Fourth, the Yaquis had to return the horses, silver plate, and weaponry they had

taken in their previous battles with the Spanish. And fifth, Hurdaide demanded that the Yaquis surrender Lautaro and Babilonio, the Ocoroni fugitives. In exchange, Hurdaide gave the Yaquis gifts and promised to come to their aid if they were ever attacked. Steep though these demands may have seemed, they amounted to little more than a return to the status quo ante. The Spanish got the fugitives they wanted, and the Yaquis received lavish gifts and promises of military help against their enemies. The modesty of Hurdaide's demands was remarkable. Hurdaide did not demand an oath of fealty to the king or tribute payment in labor or goods. He did not so much as mention the Jesuits or conversion to Christianity. Try as the Spanish might to make this look like a victory, their paltry demands revealed the weakness of their position.³⁹

The Yaqui ambassadors asked for twenty-six days to deliver the peace proposals to their people and to mobilize them behind it. On their return to the Yaqui Valley, the ambassadors presented Hurdaide's proposal to a large crowd and displayed the gifts Hurdaide had given them. The women who had visited Hurdaide wore brilliantly colored *huipiles* and *naguas* from central Mexico and dazzling feather adornments. Enough of the assembled Yaquis were convinced by this display for the agreement to move forward. The Yaqui emissaries accordingly brought news back to Hurdaide and returned much of the spoils they had taken in battle, "rich feather-work, the mules, horses, wrought silver, and other things the soldiers had lost in war." In addition, the Yaquis turned over a group of children: "In order that the sincerity of their desire for peace be known, and their desire to receive the doctrine of the gospel and to become Christians, they decided to bring with them a good number of their children, in order that they serve as peace hostages, and that they remain in the power of the padres in the seminary and school, which is in our college, for children of various other nations, where they learn Christian doctrine." There is no record of either the Jesuits or Hurdaide demanding that these children be handed over, and indeed the annual letter of 1610 specified that the Yaquis handed the children over voluntarily. It is impossible to know the thinking behind this stunning gesture of munificence and trust. But it does seem that some Yaquis were very interested in turning the Spanish into friends. Inga Clendinnen has explored similar dynamics at play in the dealings between Cortés and Moctezuma II, calling gifts given by the Aztec emperor "statements of dominance." The Yaqui gift children may have had a similar meaning, in that they expressed the abundant generosity of the Yaquis and placed the recipient under heavy obligations. In this light, it becomes possible to grasp how deeply wrong the Spanish were in their reading of the Yaquis' behavior. The Yaquis were not surrendering all they had won in battle in a final act of inexplicable cowardice. Rather, the Yaquis

were dramatizing the comprehensiveness of their victory by offering gifts only a defeated enemy could accept.³¹

The Yaquis also handed over the rebel chiefs Lautaro and Babilonio, whom Hurdaide later executed. At the urging of the Jesuits, Hurdaide spared the followers of the two chiefs. Hurdaide distributed more horses, clothing, and other gifts to the Yaqui leaders responsible for making peace, and in April 1610 recorded the official testimony of the Yaquis that they wanted Jesuit priests to come live among them. The arrival of the Jesuits in the Yaqui Valley was intended to cement a perpetual alliance between the Spanish and Yaquis.³²

These negotiations marked a watershed both in the history of the Yaqui people and in that of the region. Violence came close to ending the entire colonial endeavor in the region, much as had happened when settlers abandoned the town of San Juan de Carapoa in 1569. But because of the alliance forged between the Spanish, Mayos, and Yaquis, the colony was placed on more solid foundations than it ever had before. By choosing to negotiate with Hurdaide, the Yaquis solidified their own position in the region as well. They renounced a tradition of warfare with the Mayos, from which they had long derived material, political, and spiritual profit. Yet in making peace with the Mayos and Spanish, the Yaquis gained allies on whom they would rely in the violent years to come. Spanish aggression and Eurasian disease had sown chaos across north Mexico, provoking desperate, apocalyptic rebellions among several native groups. When the Tepehuanes demanded that the Yaquis support their insurrection in 1616, the Yaquis declined, thus avoiding the military calamity that befell the Tepehuanes at the rebellion's end. The Acaxeers and Xiximes, native peoples of highland Sinaloa, also rebelled and fared even worse than the Tepehuanes. Whereas the Tepehuanes, Acaxeers, Xiximes, and Tarahumaras launched all-out campaigns to expel the Spanish, the Yaquis first dominated the Spanish on the battlefield, then seized control of the relationship by negotiating. The Acaxeers and Xiximes were wiped out, and the Tarahumaras and Tepehuanes thoroughly subjugated. By relenting at a pivotal moment, the Yaquis were able to wrest substantial concessions from the Spanish in the negotiations that followed the violence.³³

The negotiations that ended the Yaqui-Spanish wars reveal much about the hybrid colonial culture that was coming into being in the northwest. Despite their many local peculiarities, the negotiations that went on between the Yaquis and Spanish share a great deal with similar ones in the imperial fringes. As Richard White has emphasized, the emergence of a middle ground was dependent on a rough parity of power between European and native groups. That was certainly the case with the Yaquis and Spanish. As in so many border regions,

women played central, active roles in the resolution of violent conflicts. This has been most vividly illustrated in Juliana Barr's recent study of negotiation on the Texas frontier, though many others have underscored the point. A further quality the Yaqui story shared was that violence went on before, during, and after the negotiations that were considered over by all parties. Rather than a benign Jesuit dictatorship, what was established in these years was the expansion and strengthening of a cross-cultural political network through which negotiation, violence, and exchange would be channeled in the years to come.³⁴

RELIGIOUS CHANGE AND THE FORGING OF PEACE

Seven years passed between the first exchange of vows and the consummation of the Yaqui-Spanish alliance. This murky period was critical to the evolution of relations between the colonists and the Indians. Spicer offered what is still the best analysis of these years in *The Yaquis: A Cultural History*. In the period after 1610, he wrote, "one gets the impression of a good many Yaqui women and men wandering among the missions of the Sinaloas, Ocoronis, and Guasaves on the Sinaloa River," achieving a "leisurely acquaintance under peaceful conditions" with the Jesuits. Spicer argued that this period was key to the "generally peaceful and even enthusiastic reception of the Jesuits," when at last they arrived among the Yaquis. He claimed that the Yaquis expressed a "remarkable unity of interest and acceptance" toward the Jesuits and that there was never a "deep cleavage" among them, as was the case with the Tarahumaras. Spicer went on to offer this synopsis:

To summarize the conditions within the Yaqui communities which encouraged collaborative working relations, we may list (1) a preparatory period of give-and-take discussion concerning what the missionaries had to offer and what the Yaquis wanted; (2) physical demonstration of the missions in action outside the Yaqui country which the Yaquis were able to inspect closely; (3) negotiation of mutual interests and opportunity for Yaquis to take the initiative in choosing what they wanted; (4) a minimum of innovators, only two at first and thereafter a small number in proportion to the Yaqui population; (5) no effective coercive power employed directly by the innovators until after the first hundred years; (6) constant Yaqui sponsorship, so that innovations offered were related to the context of Yaqui meanings and interpretations.³⁵

The archival record confirms much of this. The negotiations outlined here, the modesty of the Jesuit presence, the limited Spanish coercive power in the

early years, and the extent of Yaqui freedom and power were all essential features of these crucial years. Spicer's inspired guess that Yaquis wandered curiously among Christian towns finds stunning confirmation in archival documents. But several key facts eluded Spicer. The early years of the mission were anything but peaceful, and the Yaquis were never unanimous in their feelings toward the Jesuits. These facts were connected to a larger irony besetting Yaqui-Spanish negotiations. The early seventeenth century was a period of unrelenting violence in northwest Mexico, and it was in the midst of this violence that Yaquis and Jesuits learned to live and work together.

During the period from 1610 to 1617 the Yaquis were deeply divided over the question of peace with the Spanish. Pérez de Ribas later claimed that he and Tomás Basilio were the first Jesuits to preach among the Yaqui people in 1617 and that their mission had been a peaceful triumph. But the chronicler omitted two earlier attempts to convert the Yaquis, one in 1608 and another in 1610, both of which ended in violent failure. Pérez de Ribas had good reason to omit these failures from a chronicle of Jesuit "Triumphs," but they are essential to understanding the circumstances in which the Yaquis eventually did adopt Christianity. Hurdaide reported a failed mission to preach to the Yaquis in 1608 that ended with an attempt to murder the Jesuits. He reported in May 1610 that two Jesuits sent to preach to the Yaquis had enjoyed slightly greater success than the earlier padres. The Yaquis pretended to welcome the two priests but were said to have remained unshakable in their addiction to "pagan disorders," "liberty with women," and "drunken feasts" and had again tried to kill the Jesuits. Hurdaide had been forced to ride to the Yaqui Valley to rescue them. He went on to say that he captured the Yaquis responsible and executed them in the Villa de San Felipe y Santiago. Spicer was right to underscore the powerlessness of the Jesuits to impose their will on the Yaquis, but he missed the reason this was so. The Yaquis were ambivalent about conversion and would have killed the priests if they pushed their agenda too hard. Hurdaide, meantime, was swamped with other problems. The Jesuit annual letter of 1611 reported that the various rebellions near the Villa de Sinaloa had occupied the captain's energies. The Tehueco revolt took place in 1612, as did Hurdaide's savage campaign to repress it. Further revolts and murders took place among the Zuaques, Chicoratos, Bacapas, Baymoas, and others. Hurdaide's forces were stretched thin, and there were not enough Jesuits for even one to be sent to the Yaquis.³⁶

Nevertheless, there was intermittent contact between the Yaquis and Spanish between 1610 and 1617. The annual letter of 1613 described the participation of non-Christian Mayos and Yaquis in Hurdaide's campaign against the Tehuecos.

The annual letter of 1614 told of an occasion when Yaquis visited the incipient Mayo mission. The resident Jesuit, padre Pedro Méndez, wrote that he overheard conversation between Mayo and Yaqui leaders, and “the Yaquis said that they wanted to take me there to baptize them.” To Méndez’s amusement, “The Mayos responded that they would not allow it.” In January 1614 Hurdaide offered an account of negotiations between the Yaquis, Mayos, and himself over a crime committed against a Yaqui messenger. The Yaquis reported to Hurdaide that they had sent a woman to speak with him. Traveling with several other Yaquis to the Villa de San Felipe y Santiago, she had been detained by Mayos and murdered. This was in a period when the Tehuecos were in revolt, and Hurdaide suspected that the woman’s killers were conspiring to aid the rebellion. The Tehueco rebels stood to gain from any discord between the Spanish and their allies. Most of the Mayos remained loyal to the Spanish, however, and fifteen Mayo leaders testified against those accused of the crime. They said they knew nothing of the plan to kill the Yaqui messenger and did not approve of it. Hurdaide accepted this explanation, executed the murderers, and pardoned the rest of the Mayos. Though there were not yet any Jesuits living among the Yaquis, political ties between the Yaquis and Spanish were slowly developing and deepening.³⁷

These ties were tested once again in 1616. In February of that year Hurdaide described a rebel Christian’s attempt to end the alliance between the Yaquis and Spanish. Simón Muñi, of the Sinaloa people, tried to recruit the Yaquis to a rebellion against the Spanish but failed and was executed by Hurdaide before the rebellion could get fully under way. However, some Yaquis were attracted to Muñi’s insurrection and killed some of Hurdaide’s allies, which placed the captain in a bind. He wrote that it was difficult to punish the guilty while at the same time retaining the loyalty of the Yaqui people as a whole. All he could do was to demand that the Yaquis ask his pardon. He reminded them of the horrors of war and the pleasures of friendship, and, after many “digressions and expressions of rage from me, I pardoned them, and rewarded those who had remained faithful with many farm tools [*cosas de hacienda*] and especially eight horses.” Hurdaide understood that the stark calculations of cost and benefit lay behind the Yaquis’ loyalty to him and that he was in no position to force them to do his bidding. He had to pay them to remain faithful to the alliance.³⁸

Why did the Yaquis eventually allow the Jesuits to live among them? Circumstantial evidence suggests some answers to this question. All the Yaquis’ old enemies and rivals were allying with the Spanish. The Mayos welcomed padre Méndez in 1614. The Nébomes received a Jesuit in 1615. The Yaquis repeatedly beseeched Méndez to come and live among them, both out of a

sense of rivalry and a desire to end long-standing cycles of violence with these newly Christian peoples. "The competition between the natives of the Río Yaquimi [*sic*] and the Río Mayo to bring father Méndez to their lands . . ." indicated to Hurdaide "their good disposition to receive the gospel." The Jesuit annual letter of 1615 echoed these sentiments and held that the Yaquis had offered to build seventeen churches for the Jesuits when they came. Security was one of the main motives for the Yaquis' desire for priests. Hurdaide wrote in 1616 that the Yaquis were asking with courteous insistence for the honor of holy baptism: "They are devoted to us and obedient to his Majesty, and enter and leave our settlements unarmed, and pass through the territories of their old enemies, and when they are hungry or in need of other temporal things, they trade for whatever they need with great security." Many Yaquis had come to perceive that conversion had the benefit of increased safety and exchange with other Christian peoples. This became a critical consideration when the Tepehuan insurrection erupted in 1616. Refugees came flooding out of the sierras of Nueva Vizcaya and into Sinaloa, placing an added burden on the region's resources. Tepehuanes and their allies demanded help in their apocalyptic struggle against the Spanish and threatened violent retaliation if such help was denied. Faced with this threat, the Yaquis made the fateful choice to deepen their relationship with the Spanish. This decision made the need of a Jesuit guest all the greater.³⁹

The Yaquis' desire for Jesuits was at last fulfilled in 1617. Sometime in late 1616 Pérez de Ribas was appointed by his fellow Jesuits to travel to Mexico City and petition the viceroy for funding and men to begin the evangelization of the Yaquis. The party stopped in Guadiana (Durango) and consulted with the new governor there, Gaspar de Alvear. Alvear's jurisdiction reached as far as Sinaloa and Sonora, and he was displeased by Hurdaide's unauthorized forays into Yaqui country. He nevertheless let Pérez de Ribas pass on to Mexico City, where he met a more receptive audience in the viceroy, the Marqués de Guadalcázar. In letters of October 2 and December 10, 1616, Viceroy Guadalcázar approved funding to send two Jesuits each to the Yaqui and Nébome peoples and ordered Hurdaide to assist them. As a token of his approval the viceroy sent church ornaments, bells, and musical instruments with them to adorn the new mission. The two Jesuits appointed to the Yaqui mission were Pérez de Ribas and Tomás Basilio, an Italian priest recently arrived in Mexico.⁴⁰

En route to the northwest in 1616 Pérez de Ribas and his retinue were told that eight Jesuit missionaries had been killed in the Tepehuan uprising, and many feared it would spread westward over the sierras and into Sinaloa and Sonora. When they arrived in Sinaloa the Jesuits were relieved to find that this

had not occurred. The Tepehuan insurrection did, however, occupy the attention of Captain Hurdaide and his men, rendering it all but impossible for them to help the Jesuits in the Yaqui Valley. Despite the dangers they faced, the Jesuit superior in Sinaloa ordered Basilio and Pérez de Ribas to move forward as planned. The Yaqui leaders most favorable to the Spanish came to the Villa de Sinaloa to collect the two missionaries and accompany them to the Yaqui Valley. The Jesuits brought with them some of the Yaqui children who had been entrusted to them in 1610. Along the way, the Jesuits added several new members to their party: a Mayo translator to help Basilio and four Zuaque Christians who would serve as catechists and godparents to newly baptized Yaquis. On Ascension Day—April 4, 1617—the Jesuits set out from the Mayo River. All the Spanish soldiers in the region were occupied with the suppression of the Tepehuan revolt. The Jesuits had to rely on their Yaqui allies alone for protection.⁴¹

In his first letter from the Yaqui mission Pérez de Ribas wrote that the Yaquis were numerous, prosperous, extremely warlike, and for these reasons isolated from their neighbors. Pérez de Ribas had developed the theory that those Indian groups in frequent contact with outsiders developed habits of friendliness and hospitality that the Yaquis did not share. He took note of the Yaquis' material culture and social arrangements as well. They lived in clusters of seven to eight woven-mat houses rather than in large towns, each kin group settling close by its fields. The Yaqui River was the center of Yaqui life. Its annual floods watered the fields but also changed the river's course with great regularity, requiring the Yaquis to move their houses and towns as well. In 1617 the river forked before it flowed into the Gulf of California, creating a large delta island where the majority of the Yaqui population lived. The Yaqui settlements began fourteen leagues upstream from the sea in a town called Tesano.⁴²

The Jesuits began their mission there and worked their way toward the sea, baptizing children and the ill as they went. At the first of these pueblos, a group of some two hundred women and children came out to greet the padres, each one carrying a little cross made of cane. They had constructed triumphal arches out of tree branches to greet the Jesuits as well as a lean-to in which they could preach the gospel. Pérez de Ribas gave an account of himself and his mission to the people who gathered to hear him, touching on the two most important tenets of his faith: that God was the creator of the universe and that the human soul was immortal. He declared that baptism was a prerequisite of salvation and then applied the holy waters to two hundred children under the age of seven. There was some grumbling even at this early stage: Yaquis opposed to the alliance with the Spaniards were surprised and insulted by the arrival of this

unarmed band and called for the return of Captain Hurdaide, an enemy worthy of their respect.⁴³

Other Yaquis welcomed the Jesuits with gifts of maize and squash, and they included the Jesuits in a ceremony all their own: "Then began the fiestas and gatherings to smoke tobacco in the houses of the caciques," wrote Pérez de Ribas. "The *principales* are as fathers to them," he wrote, and they made sermons to their "children . . . at daybreak and sunset, and they usually last an hour or two." These Yaqui *principales* "added such a quantity of sermons, and at such volume, in the central plaza of the pueblo . . . with such shouting through the night, that even though they were in great need of rest, there was no way to get any." Those Yaquis who welcomed the Jesuits did so cordially but on their own terms and in their own way, incorporating Jesuit preaching into their preexistent rituals of conviviality and public speech.⁴⁴

Pérez de Ribas noted that a plague of *cocoliztli*—probably smallpox—had recently struck the Yaqui pueblos. The Jesuits' reaction to this fact was the same as it had been in the past: they yearned to baptize as many of the sick as they could and expressed great joy whenever the soul of a baptized Indian flitted off to heaven. It is harder to understand complexities of the Yaquis' reaction to the disease. Since the Jesuits baptized so many people on the brink of death, many Yaquis adopted the widespread view that baptism had finished them off. Pérez de Ribas tried to counter this tendency by pointing to the afflicted people who had recovered their health after being baptized. He wrote that some Yaquis accepted this argument and believed baptism to be a cure for disease. These Yaquis cast the Jesuits in the role of traditional healers and hoped that the rites of baptism and catechism would bring an end to the epidemic.⁴⁵

Whatever the Yaquis may have thought about the origins of the epidemic and the Jesuits' role in it—whether as saviors or executioners—it is clear that the Jesuits arrived in the Yaqui Valley in a time of crisis. The Tepehuanes were demanding that the Yaquis help them drive out the Spanish, and epidemic disease cast a dire shadow over Yaqui society. Desperation drove many Yaquis to accept whatever help the Jesuits could provide. With the Zuaque Christians serving as godparents, the Jesuits managed to baptize one thousand Yaqui children in the first four pueblos they visited. Yet there remained a good deal of hostility toward them. A Mayo witch who lived among the Yaquis spread the rumor that baptism killed Indian children, causing many mothers to hide their children from the Jesuits. The Yaquis made it manifest that they were watching every move the Jesuits made and often took grave offense at what the Jesuits thought were small missteps. Pérez de Ribas once asked a group of Yaquis from the lower pueblos to step away from him to let him perform some

task or other, and consequently they returned to their pueblos saying, "This Padre does not have a good heart." Many Yaquis regarded the Jesuits as interlopers and held them to exacting standards of politeness and respect for local customs.⁴⁶

After baptizing the children and the ill, the Jesuits moved on to baptize the caciques that had invited them to the Yaqui Valley. Pablo Hysimeai and Gerónimo Conibomeai were the first adult Yaquis the Jesuits baptized, and they in turn served as godfathers to other Yaquis and as protectors to the Jesuits. Hurdaide reinforced their faith when they visited him in the Spanish villa. "The captain distributed colts, and clothing among them, and they returned to their pueblos well pleased," wrote the chronicler. "They made new *pláticas* to their people, and spoke of the thousand benefits of Christianity." The good words of the baptized caciques piqued the curiosity of others from the lower Yaqui Valley. These went to visit the captain, who gave them a warm welcome and gifts. So the good reputation of the Jesuits and Spanish spread.⁴⁷

The years from 1607 to 1617 were laced with irony. Jesuits who dreamed of reducing the Yaqui people from savagery to civilization found themselves to be the passive objects of Yaqui reduction. Their utopian dreams gave way to messy, frustrating realities. They relied on a controversial Yaqui faction for their survival and knew from the first moment that there were many Yaquis who wished them dead. In the years to come, the Jesuits would have a deep influence on the course of Yaqui history. But the Jesuits' achievement was vastly more modest than they hoped and only came about through decades of tiny, often thwarted steps.

Like the Jesuits, Captain Hurdaide came to strange, unsought conclusions about himself. He shared the conquistador dreams of wealth, social advancement, and the honors due to a *gran señor*. But Hurdaide was unlike his blood-thirsty predecessors in many ways. He was much more intelligent, capable, and culturally savvy than they were, and these qualities transformed him into something he never wanted or expected to be. Through the crafty deployment of bluff, deception, and sudden terror and the construction of alliances through captive taking, gift giving, and negotiation, Hurdaide became a kind of native chieftain known to all as the wizard and the dwarf. In this role Hurdaide exerted considerable sway in the northwest. But he was hopelessly mired in debt and bound by obligations to those he had promised to help. In letter after letter to his superiors, Hurdaide expressed his agony over the strange shape his career had taken. While cultivating an image of ruthlessness, generosity, and impulsive cruelty, Hurdaide's inner life was plagued by frustration and despair.

All he could do was watch as his fortune and time were eaten away by the needy, dangerous people over whom he was nominal lord.

These were strange years for the Yaquis as well. They began the decade as the main enemies of the Spanish in the region, and they ended it as the Spaniards' most important friends. Whether they were prompted by a talking tree or by the pragmatic vision of certain Yaqui leaders, the Yaquis made farsighted decisions in these years. At the moment of their greatest strategic strength, the Yaquis allied with the Spanish and extracted from the alliance the maximum benefit they could. In a further ironic twist, they also benefited from the divisions among themselves. The diversity of Yaqui views ensured that there was always a lingering threat to the Jesuits and their friends. Under these precarious circumstances, neither Spaniards nor priests could grow complacent about the need to keep the Yaquis happy. In return for alliance the Yaquis received the Jesuits' help in the struggle against disease, Spanish military aid and protection against their enemies, and an enormous quantity of gifts. The Jesuit mission would leave a profound imprint on Yaqui culture and politics in the years to come, but the Yaquis controlled the ways in which their culture shifted and changed.

MISSION AND EMPIRE: 1617–1700

“You said they were Catholics,” Aguirre muttered.

“Oh, they are. You see, for some reason, the Yaquis allowed some Jesuits to come into these regions. There were eight Yaqui centers, towns that the Jesuits made into missions. And—perhaps God, that old trickster, was really at work after all—the Jesuits allowed the tribe to exercise its own rituals along with the new Roman high jinks. Imagine, Lauro, deer dancers in the Mass. A Native Easter!”

—*Luís Alberto Urrea, The Hummingbird’s Daughter*

In late spring of 1668 the Franciscan friar Juan Caballero Carranco found himself stranded on the coast of Sonora. He had been part of an expedition to explore the Gulf of Cortés and to supply the nascent California missions. When supplies ran low, the ship’s captain put in about twenty leagues north of the Yaqui River, hoping to find support from the Jesuits. Fray Caballero waded ashore and did a little exploring among the dunes and bushes of coastal Sonora. He was dismayed by what he found. The Guaymas Indians he met were not baptized, and there were no priests to minister to them. “They gaze on the crystalline waters of Christianity,” he wrote, “without ever being able to drink.” Two soldiers from the expedition’s crew brought word of Caballero’s landing to the Yaqui mission, where the Jesuit Juan de Montiel conferred with his fellow Jesuits and then sent back the message that the Yaqui mission would welcome the Franciscan. In the Yaqui town of Rahum, the Yaquis greeted Caballero with tolling bells, flowered arches, and the music of woodwind instruments. But soon after this cordial welcome, the Jesuits’ affections cooled. “They dislike it greatly when other ecclesiastics come to their missions to see the way they live,” Caballero wrote. “Their kindness lasts only a short time, and then they pour out their poison.”⁷¹

Caballero nevertheless remained in Sinaloa and Sonora for the next four months and came away from the experience with an intensely negative impression of the Jesuit mission system. The uncovered Indians to the north of the Yaqui River were one major problem. But the Yaquis themselves received what the Franciscan saw as perfunctory spiritual care. Padre Montiel was a melancholy man who, in addition to doing a bad job, was prone to committing the "sin of Adam," presumably fornicating with Yaqui women. "Not all of those who shine in the cities are made to preach to savages," Caballero dryly observed. He went on to comment that even a vigorous, committed priest would not be able to administer the sacraments to all the Yaquis. Each of the Jesuits in the mission was responsible for as many as four thousand Indians, and as a result many pagans lived among the converted. It seemed to Caballero that the devil had worn the Jesuits down. Rather than confronting Satan, the Black Robes had negotiated with him. They allowed native rituals to persist and even welcomed them into the Church.²

Stranger still to Franciscan eyes, the Jesuits had created elaborate political institutions on the Yaqui mission. Caballero complained there were as many political offices on the Yaqui mission as there were in a republic, and the Jesuits wasted countless hours supervising elections to fill them. The Jesuits also sold the fruits of mission fields at high prices to the few miserable Spanish settlers in the region. Jesuit control of native labor made matters worse for the settlers. Miners had to wrench native workers away from the missions, and when at last they succeeded, the Jesuits did everything in their considerable power to lure the Indians back. They spread lies about the mines and ordered the kidnapping of mineworkers' wives and children to force the workers to return home. The mines themselves were hardly better than the missions, Caballero lamented, since the Jesuits refused to preach there. In the absence of priests, the lawless mining camps became cesspools of sin. Caballero saw all this as a tragedy. Rich mineral deposits were finally being discovered in the northwest, but because of Jesuit interference it was almost impossible to work them. The result was economic stagnation and moral decline. Caballero thought the remedy to these ills was the secularization of the Jesuit mission system. He argued that more priests should be sent to the northwest and that land should be distributed to Indians individually so that they could freely sell their products to the mines. Indians should be forced to pay tribute to the king, a tax that mission Indians had avoided to date. He argued even that Sinaloa and Sonora should be split off from the government of Nueva Vizcaya and that a new provincial government should be set up to rule them.³

Fray Caballero's diatribe against the Jesuits captured many of the political complexities of northwest Mexico. The Jesuits had indeed negotiated relation-

ships with native peoples they did not want Europeans to intrude upon, and they did use their influence in the corridors of power to keep other Europeans out. But over the course of the seventeenth century this became more and more difficult. Silver strikes across the north attracted miners, and the mines attracted ranchers and merchants eager to sell their wares. Prospectors fanned out from each new mining camp to find more veins of silver. The settlers needed workers, food, and supplies, and the missions were the region's best source for all of these essentials. But the Jesuits refused to cooperate. Conflicts over land, trade, and labor broke out over the Yaqui mission in the 1660s when silver was at last discovered nearby. Silver strikes in San Miguel (1666) and Ostimuri (1668) exerted an increasingly powerful magnetism for Yaqui labor and goods in the late seventeenth century. Jesuits tried to keep Yaqui labor and products away from the new enterprises, while the Yaquis endeavored to profit from the mines however they could.⁴

Though the seventeenth century brought deep changes to life on the Yaqui mission, it is exceedingly difficult to bring these processes of change into sharp focus. The documentary record bearing on the Yaqui mission from around 1630 to 1730 is surprisingly meager, given the rich materials available for the periods before and after. This is partly attributable to the loss of documents; existing letters and reports refer to Yaqui mission account books, baptismal registers, and logs of visitors that have all disappeared. So too have many of the Jesuit annual letters from this period. A further problem is that the courts and notarial offices that produced rich records in central Mexico never fully formed in the northwest. The expulsion of the Jesuits in 1767 cut off the production of new Jesuit documents and scattered existing documents to the wind.⁵

Nevertheless, there is more documentation from this period than has been used in any study of the Yaquis to date, and it is highly suggestive. Four themes bearing on the ironies of empire in the seventeenth century stand out: resistance to colonial rule; religion and the formation of the eight Yaqui towns; Jesuit political struggles outside the mission; and Yaqui participation in the political and economic life of northern New Spain. Taken collectively, the available materials illuminate the many ironies of life on the Yaqui mission. Jesuits and settlers, though weak and few in numbers, exerted strong influence on all aspects of Yaqui life. The Yaquis, so ferocious in their early resistance to colonial rule, moved with equal ferocity to exploit their ties with the empire once they had established a relationship with it. And violence smoldered on through the years of the so-called *Pax Jesuitica*.⁶

THE DEVIL AND YAQUI RESISTANCE

The coming of the Jesuits in 1617 did not mean the end of violence between the Yaquis and Europeans. In fact, violence was a central element of the negotiations that went on between them. The Jesuits held Yaqui children hostage in their college, a circumstance that carried the threat of violence. The Jesuits themselves were under constant threat of death in the Yaqui mission. Pérez de Ribas wrote that the Jesuit on the Mayo River said he opened the door every morning expecting to hear that the padres on the Yaqui mission had all been killed. Few if any scholars have explored the tense and ambiguous state of affairs. Most have simply asserted that the Yaquis acquiesced to the cultural changes the Jesuits imposed. Understanding the peculiar shape the mission eventually took requires examination of the relations of alternating violence and negotiation that obtained in the early years.⁷

The devil was everywhere in Jesuit writings about this period, a testament to the deep antagonism between the Jesuits and most of the Yaquis and also to the vigorous persistence of non-Christian practices on the Yaqui mission. In one revealing passage, Pérez de Ribas described a Yaqui woman telling a Jesuit, "Father, look at the other side of the river; do you see how many hills, mountains, cliffs and peaks there are? In all of them, we had our superstitions; we revered all of them, and celebrated there." The Yaquis invested the landscape with supernatural meanings, and the Jesuits were too few and too vulnerable to do much about it. The earliest accounts of the Yaqui mission told of sorcerers practicing black magic among the Yaqui people and conspiring to kill Jesuit missionaries. Satan appeared regularly among the Yaquis, sometimes in the form of an old man, sometimes as a young one. One Yaqui confessed that Satan had come to him in the form of a crow and had told him to kill all the Spaniards. Pérez de Ribas was so concerned about the devil's grip on the Yaquis that he asked that a massive treatise on demonic magic written in the 1590s by the Jesuit Martín del Río be sent to him in Sinaloa from Mexico City. After perusing it, he concluded that all the evil enchantments described in del Río's book could be observed on the Yaqui mission. Indeed, Satan was so well established, and his cult had reached such heights of sophistication among the Yaquis, that it seemed the devil had established an "endowed professorship" (*cátedra*) of the dark arts on the shores of the Yaqui River.⁸

When Pérez de Ribas and Tomás Basilio made their first trip down the Yaqui River in 1617, they were confronted time and again with their powerlessness. They discovered that they were guests of a controversial minority and that those who opposed the alliance with the Spanish wanted to kill them. As Jesuits

baptized children in the town of Abasorin, they heard of a Yaqui man on the verge of death. When Basilio went with a Zuaque catechist to baptize him, Yaqui friends hastened to stop him. It was a trap, they said. If he went, he would be killed. The more populous downstream pueblos were even more hostile. Baptized Yaquis tried to dissuade the Jesuits from visiting these towns, but they could not. To show fear, the Jesuits thought, was to show weakness, and they wanted to do whatever they could to prevent a rift from opening between the Christian and non-Christian Yaquis. The Jesuits were encouraged by the warm welcome they received in Torim, the largest Yaqui town, home to one thousand families. But the baptized Yaquis had to take measures to protect the Jesuits' lives. Pérez de Ribas wrote, "From this pueblo forward, the friendly caciques brought with them . . . several of their preachers, who, in that plaza, according to their customs, and with great fervor and shouting, praised the peace, and hearing the word of God." Pérez de Ribas noted that these "preachers" were not baptized Christians but in fact great hechiceros. The Jesuits wondered at the mysteries of providence when they saw that these wicked men should be the ones to help them baptize the Yaquis. But if we peel away the layers of Jesuit moralizing, two things become clear: the majority of Yaquis did not want the Jesuits there, and those Yaquis who did welcome the Jesuits cared more about the alliance the Jesuits represented than the doctrines they preached.⁹

Several attempts to murder the Jesuits made it evident that the priests were marginal, widely detested figures. On his way to preach in Torim in 1617, Pérez de Ribas stopped to help a sick man and his son by the road. The man asked him harshly why he had come to kill Yaquis. When the Jesuit tried to comfort him, the dying man told the priest to leave. After a few more words, the man's son leapt up and ran for his bow and arrow. The Jesuit's Yaqui friends hustled him back to his mule and fled as the arrows hissed by them. None of the arrows hit their mark, but the fury behind them was unmistakable. Pérez de Ribas was painfully aware that he and Basilio were dependent on their Yaqui sponsors. "Innumerable times," he wrote, "living among them night and day, and in houses made of sticks, without doors, nor guard, nor any defense more than two or three boys from the church, who slept in the light of a candle by the door . . . it amazed us to see that they let us live, knowing that there were innumerable sorcerers who wanted to drink our blood." These are not the words of oppressors but of hostages.¹⁰

All non-Yaquis who ventured into the Yaqui Valley took their lives into their hands. Hurdaide caught wind of a potential rebellion in 1620 and immediately gathered a force of twenty Spanish soldiers and seventy-two Indian allies to

head it off. He claimed success in his mission, but he was unable to eliminate the violent hostility many Yaquis still felt toward him. When he visited once again that year, he was ambushed by a force of eight thousand archers and was able to escape only by handing over several of the Yaqui children he had earlier taken as hostages. The Jesuit Nicolás de Anaya wrote in 1621 that the Yaquis were the region's most populous nation and, as Pérez de Ribas and Hurdaide had noted earlier, its most arrogant. The thirty thousand residents of the Yaqui mission "had perpetual wars, not only with the neighboring nations, but also civil wars amongst themselves, devouring one another with regular robberies, dances, and killings." Jesuit preaching had little effect on them. "They give themselves over to all kinds of vice, innumerable superstitions, witchcraft, and idolatry, the Demon having stolen their desire to be Christian, and planted the idea that they would die on being baptized." The devil and his witch-priests showered scorn on baptism as "a vile, low, and suspicious thing, since their ancestors did not use the custom." The Yaquis got drunk before the padres' eyes, men flaunted their multiple wives, a single man sometimes marrying a mother and daughter simultaneously. The padres were too scared to try to stop them. All they could do was "cry out to heaven," "place our confidence in God," and hope that their evangelical work would some day bear fruit. Anaya's tone of horror, frustration, and pique signaled that the Yaquis were anything but acquiescent to Jesuit rule.¹¹

Later in 1621 Hurdaide reported that "a most horrendous betrayal and general uprising" was brewing among the Yaquis. Hunger and general discontent in the Yaqui mission brought to power "a devil in human form" named Yeyequi. He was preaching revolution along the lines of the Tepehuan revolt of 1616. Padre Gaspar Varela wrote that the Yaquis were desperate, scavenging for food in the wilderness. Tepehuanes threatened to attack, and some Yaquis were inclined to ally with them against the Jesuits. Varela wrote that a demon named Zeieuri was whispering rebellion to the Mayos, Yaquis, and Nébomes alike, promising good harvests and the resurrection of the dead. Anaya wrote that an evil cabal (*conciliabulo*) had convened in the town of Torim. Its members determined that the faith of the Christians was a fiction, that the Yaquis did not have to obey the priests, and that there was no heaven. They declared that the dead all lived underground in a state of joyous dissolution. For reasons Anaya did not provide, the rebellion never came to pass, and the Yaquis decided to remain on friendly terms with the captain. In Anaya's telling, the captain generously opted not to take vengeance on the Yaquis for planning the revolt, instead heaping gifts of clothing and horses on them whenever they visited him. Whatever their reasons for calling off the rebellion, the Yaquis did not simply accept Jesuit preaching

as truth and were willing to consider violent measures to preserve their way of life. Hurdaide was patently the weaker party in his dealings with the Yaquis, and he rewarded their most threatening behavior by paying them to let the Jesuits live.¹²

Even Hurdaide's threats and bribes, however, were not enough to keep the Jesuits safe. A report on the mission from 1622 said that the Jesuits had fled to the Mayo River for a time: "Andrés Pérez and Tomás Basilio are staying on the Mayo because of the terrors of the Yaquis." They had good reason to be afraid. One night in 1623, as he sat by the door of his hut, a poisoned arrow flew out of the darkness and pierced Basilio's arm. When he cried out, Yaqui friends rushed to his aid, pulled the arrow from his body, and sucked the poison from the wound. Basilio's Yaqui friends went on to capture his attacker, a one-eyed hechicero named Juan Suca, who had intended the attack as the first blow in an insurrection. Suca later committed suicide by stabbing himself with a poison arrow in order to avoid execution at Hurdaide's hands. Hurdaide recounted a similar event in 1627 in which a Yaqui shot Basilio with an arrow and was then brought to the captain for punishment. Hurdaide read this as a sign of respect for his authority, but other readings are possible. The repeated attacks on Basilio insinuated that many Yaquis hated him. The fact that the offenders were brought by other Yaquis to be punished in the Spanish base demonstrated Hurdaide's dependence on Yaqui allies for enforcement of the Yaqui-Spanish peace agreement. Hurdaide went on to write that Pérez de Ribas warned him never to come to the Yaqui mission with fewer than seventy Spanish soldiers. Throughout the 1620s and into the 1630s it seems the Yaquis were in full control of their territory.¹³

Long after the Jesuits were well established in the Yaqui pueblos and claimed the Yaquis had all been converted to Christianity, the Jesuits and others reported that non-Christian religious practices persisted there. In 1653 the Jesuit Agustín de Guzmán claimed that a Yaqui woman was living in the countryside with an incubus who had taken human form to seduce her. He went on to write that he was struggling to convince the Yaquis that Christian prayer, rather than the "diabolical cures" of Yaqui shamans, was the only remedy for disease. "The Demon," wrote Guzmán, "makes every effort to pervert them, and there is no lack of his ministers who act as children of that evil father, and [the Demon] himself appears in various forms, both to intimidate them with threats, and to silence them, such that they reveal nothing to the padre in confession." The Franciscan Carranco wrote in 1668 of large numbers of pagans living and practicing their rites among the Yaquis. Padre Diego de Marquina said the Yaquis were still "new in the faith" in 1684 and engaged in many religious

abuses. In 1740 an illiterate slave with no direct access to the Jesuit records of the early mission testified to seeing Yaqui rebels performing a rite identical to the dance of the scalps that had supposedly been eliminated in the 1620s: "They have captains and officials of war," the slave testified, "whose continual occupation is to dance and sing in their way the triumphs of their victories, with spoils from the Spaniards they have killed, such as their scalps." In 1744 a Jesuit complained that Yaquis were engaged in a menacing "Paccola" dance with masks and drums and that the acting governor of the province had ordered its suppression.¹⁴

As was the case throughout Mexico, multiple religious traditions persisted side by side on the Yaqui mission, where Yaqui-inflected Christian ceremonies shared space with shamanic practices. Far from bringing about an instant transformation in the cultural life of the Yaqui people, the early missionaries were at pains merely to survive and spread a dusting of Christianity over the preexistent Yaqui traditions. The process of Christianization was agonizingly slow and frustrating for the Jesuits. The Yaquis made their desires known by attacking, harassing, or simply ignoring the priests.¹⁵

CEREMONY AND THE MAKING OF THE EIGHT MISSION TOWNS

Given the Yaquis' oft-expressed resistance to colonial rule, how did they end up moving from eighty small *rancherías* to the famous eight towns? This is one of the focal questions of Yaqui history, and the evidence that survives cannot answer it conclusively. There are, however, a few things we can know: the making of these eight towns was a slow, haphazard affair. Hurdaide demanded that the Yaquis congregate into towns in 1610 as a condition of peace and then demanded that they do so again in 1616, a strong indication that his first demand had not been met. Pérez de Ribas wrote in 1617 that Christian Yaquis chose twelve sites for future towns, which he thought would eventually be reduced to ten. The annual letter of 1621 reported that the Yaquis were still living in eleven pueblos. The Yaqui towns of Tesano and Abasorin were described in the early seventeenth century but seem to have disappeared thereafter. Of all the traditional eight Yaqui towns, the only one mentioned by name before 1640 in any document I have found was Torim, described in 1622 as the largest town on the Yaqui River. Pérez de Ribas wrote of eight main Yaqui towns in 1645 but did not name them.¹⁶

Though the towns were certainly founded earlier, the first reference to Vicam that I have found in the documentary record was in 1645. Rahum, Belén,

and Bacum were first mentioned in a letter of 1652, Potam and Cocorit in 1653, and Huirivis last of all, in 1720. A census in 1676 named all the towns except Huirivis, implying that the mission comprised only seven communities rather than eight. The same document held that Belém had only recently come into existence and was almost entirely inhabited by Guaymas Indians, not Yaquis. As late as 1738, padre Ignacio María Nápoli lamented that most Yaquis still lived in "the hills and marshes, against the express wish of his Majesty," and not "in their pueblos, together and congregated." The process of the founding of towns was improvised over many generations and did not involve the forced movement of the Yaqui population. In the case of Torim and Vicam, the Jesuits simply rechristened preexistent Yaqui pueblos and called this reduction.¹⁷

A further truth that can be gleaned from the sources is that church building and ceremonial life were central to the creation of mission towns. The Jesuits began by preaching in lean-tos but tried as soon as they could to organize the building of larger structures for village ceremonies. "These churches cannot be built," wrote Pérez de Ribas, "unless the Padres act not only as overseers, but also as architects, and manual laborers, distributing offices to the people, and preparing their food." "Often," he continued, "six hundred persons work on cutting wood, bringing it on their shoulders, since they have neither oxen nor mules to haul it, and on the collection of stones and adobe." Padre Vicente de Águila wrote in 1638, "The Padres work tirelessly, as architects, overseers and sometimes stonemasons," to build churches beautiful enough to attract new converts. The Jesuits and their backers furnished rich ornaments, paintings, silk wall hangings, and musical instruments to embellish these churches, many of which were built on old Yaqui ceremonial sites. Painted images of the afterlife aided in the teaching of Catholic ideas of divine justice: they showed the souls of the righteous floating among the angels and those of the damned suffering in hell. Aesthetic pleasure was central to the Jesuit approach to evangelization. Choirs with instrumental music were attractions to the Jesuit faith, wrote Vicente de Águila, "masses sung with solemnity, processions with the adornment of banners, crosses, dances, and other curiosities, rich ornaments, and the adornment of altars, with taffeta hangings, or mats curiously painted." In the Yaqui mission as in all their missionary endeavors the Jesuits tried to preach the gospel by appealing to the senses.¹⁸

The collective enterprise of church building placed the Jesuits in a position of influence, distributing jobs, clothing, and food and demonstrating their commitment to working collaboratively with native people. Once the church was built, the priest could continue to exercise this sort of influence through

the selection of Indians to serve in the church offices of cantor, sacristan, catechist, and fiscal, all of which were paid out of the royal treasury. Churches thus became centers of both economic and ritual activity for each mission town and in this way may have attracted Indians to settle near them.¹⁹

The process of reduction was smoothed by the relatively modest approach to changing Yaqui customs the Jesuits were forced to adopt. They defined sacrilege narrowly and exploited the many analogies between Christian and native religious practices in order to facilitate the spread of the gospel. Drawing on Pope Gregory's advice to Augustine of Canterbury, the Jesuits studied Yaqui rituals and tried to incorporate as much of them as they could into Catholic ceremonies. One Jesuit wrote that the Yaquis danced most often as preparation to do battle with their neighbors and as a celebration of their victories. They would hang the scalps and heads of their enemies at the center of a circle of warriors, and the drunken warriors would dance to the rhythm of drummers who stood by the scalps at the center of the circle. The drummers would sing, and all the participants in the ritual would pass around bowls of wine. The Yaquis had another dance they performed at certain times of the year when, instead of going out to kill their enemies, they would go out in teams to kill rattlesnakes. "These serpents are the greatest enemies they have," the Jesuit wrote, "and they often die from their bites." The Yaquis would cut off the snakes' rattles and dance around them instead of around scalps. Jesuits studied customs such as these in order to isolate and destroy what they thought were idolatrous elements and then to incorporate the rest into mission religious practice.²⁰

"Such were the fiestas of their gentility," the Jesuit wrote, "and now we will describe the Christian ones into which they have changed by virtue of the evangelical doctrine." Every year Christian pueblos celebrated their patron saint's feast day. People would come from miles around and, in a further echo of Gregory's advice to Augustine, the Jesuits would slaughter six to twelve cows for the occasion. Other times a great deer hunt was organized, and one hundred deer would be slaughtered, prepared, and served to the celebrants. Altars would be set up in the four corners of the town plaza, and the night before the feast the Indians would dance by the light of candles, all their old supposed superstitions having been drained from the ritual; "and so it is with great joy that one sees these people forget their old pagan feasts that they used to dedicate to the devil, and now celebrate in honor of Christ and his saints." This strategy of making changes to existing rituals allowed Yaquis and Jesuits to interpret the rituals however they wished. The modesty of the Jesuits' ambitions at this early stage made them easier to realize. The distribution of enormous quantities of food

made the unfamiliar rituals of the Christians all the more attractive to those new in the faith.²¹

Jesuit documents and chronicles are full of stories about the slow, subtle replacement of old, "pagan" religious experiences with new, Christian ones. Very often Christian and non-Christian religious practices were carried out with the same purposes in mind, in the same ritual locations, and with elements drawn from both traditions. Pérez de Ribas described a Yaqui youth's anguished dialogue with a demon that had cured him with medicinal herbs. The demon tried to exact payment from the young man and danced with him the next day at a Christian ceremony in the church. The demon fled, however, when the dance ended and Mass began. Here and in various places Pérez de Ribas revealed that native dances, performed in churches located on native ritual sites, became a central element of religious practices on the Yaqui missions. To Jesuit readers, the devil's flight from the holy Mass may have symbolized the emptying of native ritual practices of their diabolical content. But these very sources divulge as well that Yaquis enjoyed great latitude in the interpretation of Christian ceremony.²²

However Jesuits and Yaquis interpreted mission ceremonies, it is plain that new Christian rituals had many of the same functions as the old indigenous ones. Pérez de Ribas reported that in Torim a penitential procession brought about the end of a drought: "The children made a procession of blood to a shrine of our Lady, that they had made on a little hill next to their pueblo, and the Lord, because of the prayers of the innocent, and the honor of his most blessed mother, sent copious rain over all the fields of that pueblo." A Jesuit wrote on March 31, 1638, that a relic from the body of St. Ignatius calmed the swollen waters of the Yaqui River. Both Yaquis and Jesuits believed Christian ritual had the same occult connection with nature that Yaqui ritual specialists claimed for themselves. Just as the demons offered remedies to unbaptized Yaquis, so angels provided miraculous cures to the baptized. A Yaqui lying in sickbed heard a voice say, "Rise up," and as he did so the Yaqui saw the image of a man floating in trees. "Rise up," the spirit said once again, "be healthy and go to the pueblo, confess your sins to the padre, and live well from now on." The Yaqui described the spirit he saw to the padre as resembling one of the angels in the paintings in the church, and so his vision was accepted as having been sent by the Christian God. Here again similarities between Christian and pre-Christian religious experience helped to bridge the cultural divide between the Jesuits and Yaquis.²³

By the mid-1620s the Jesuits had established a foothold in the Yaqui Valley, and most, though never all, the Yaquis seem to have reconciled themselves to

the Jesuits' presence among them. By 1622 there were five Jesuits living permanently on the Yaqui mission. The Yaquis were by then well on their way to taking full possession of Christian rituals and making them their own. The annual letter of 1628 reported that the Yaquis and Mayos both made holy week "processions of blood." Participants ritually flagellated themselves, offering blood to the Christian God that they once had offered to the devil. Jesuit claims of this kind at once highlighted the Jesuits' sense of triumph over Satan and underscored the many similarities between native and Christian rituals.²⁴

Padre Juan Ortíz Zapata gave the only direct testimony available from the later seventeenth century bearing on the formation of the eight Yaqui towns. His description of religious life on the Yaqui mission testified to the richly eclectic quality of mission culture and to the agonizing work involved in maintaining each church. Disease, floods, and migration to the region's mining towns had completely destroyed several Yaqui communities, but other towns were thriving. There were many Spanish speakers among the Yaquis, he wrote, and Yaqui church services were well attended. Ceremonial life was central to the Yaqui towns. The singers and musicians performed regularly in the churches of Cocorit and Torim, and dazzling ornaments were found in all Yaqui churches. Gilded chalices, paintings, and tapestries adorned the divine cult. Ortíz Zapata noted that several of the churches on the Yaqui mission had been destroyed by floods, but that the missions had petitioned for funding to build new ones. The mission itself was expanding, with the addition of the town of Belén, a town largely inhabited by Guaymas and Pima Indians.²⁵

Letters and church inventories from 1684 told a story of the mission's vigorous struggle to survive and expand and the brutal adversities it faced. The Vicam church had been wrecked by a flood in the period since the Ortíz Zapata report, but a new one was under construction. The Jesuits drew on the order's wealth to beat back the tides of time. Jesuits brought blue silk vestments from China, paintings and bronze sculptures from Spain, a trunk for church valuables from Michoacán, albs from Brittany, silver candlesticks and censers used in church processions, Moorish rugs, a book stand of gilded Muscovy leather, gold chalices, and jewel-encrusted silver crosses. A stupendous gilded altarpiece had been rescued from a flood and awaited placement in a reconstructed church. The retable was over twenty-four feet high and almost twenty feet wide, decorated with inlaid gold, with an image of the Virgin of Guadalupe. Building, maintaining, and decorating sacred structures was still a binding element of culture on the Yaqui mission.²⁶

Over time the eight towns would acquire enormous spiritual and political significance to the Yaquis. But the process by which this happened was as

significant as its results. Jesuits did not create the Yaqui towns by fiat. Yaquis and Jesuits created them together, in a slow, arduous, setback-ridden collaborative process. The making of these towns was also an enormously creative act, as the Yaquis adapted the artistic, architectural, musical, and doctrinal contributions of the Jesuits to their own needs and desires.

THE YAQUIS AND THEIR NEIGHBORS

Those Yaquis who welcomed the Jesuits did so largely for diplomatic reasons. The Jesuits served as intermediaries with Captain Hurdaide and all the region's Christian peoples. The Yaquis reaped benefits from this arrangement, gaining trading partners and allies against their non-Christian enemies. Over the course of the seventeenth century the alliance evolved. The Jesuits lost much of their centrality in diplomatic relations, and the Yaquis themselves took a more active role in dealing with the Spanish military. Soon after the Jesuits arrived in the Yaqui Valley in 1617, Hurdaide named Yaqui governors and *alcaldes* in each of the towns he visited. At some point in the mid-seventeenth century the office of the Yaqui captain general was created. This official's duty was to recruit, organize, and lead Yaqui militia forces outside the Yaqui mission (fig. 7). He, rather than the Jesuits, became the focal point of contact between the Yaquis and the Spanish military. By the 1680s at the latest the Yaquis had become military partners of the Spanish and were active in conquering expeditions as far afield as Baja California, Arizona, Chihuahua, and highland Sonora.²⁷

The Jesuits symbolized the Yaqui alliance with Hurdaide and all the other baptized peoples of the region. This meant peace with the Mayos and Nébomes, the Yaquis' closest neighbors and oldest enemies. Jesuits would serve as intermediaries between the Yaquis and all their neighbors. The Jesuits were well aware that they served as diplomats on behalf of native leaders and thought that this service was one of their most powerful tools for the dissemination of the gospel: "The padres nearest to the pagan nations invite their main *caciques*, gaining their affection with gifts of things they esteem, and show them the peace in which the Christians live, and how the Christians live without fear of their enemies. This is because, when they receive padres among them, they come under their protection and whatever nation attacks or molests them will be punished." Whatever they may have thought of the Jesuits' religion, the native peoples of the northwest regarded the padres as useful diplomatic tools.²⁸

Pérez de Ribas illustrated this principle by describing the resolution of a conflict between the Nébomes and Yaquis in the 1620s. A party of Nébomes traveled downstream from their home pueblos and into Yaqui territory to visit



7. A Yaqui militia ca. 1910. The Yaquis had experience as fighters alongside the forces of empire dating to the seventeenth century. (Library of Congress)

Pérez de Ribas. In spite of the arrows one Yaqui shot at them, one of the Nébome leaders pressed on to the Jesuit's house. Pérez de Ribas welcomed the man and then persuaded his allies among the Yaqui leaders to protect his visitors. They promised to hunt down the Yaqui who had shot at them and to escort the Nébomes back to the edge of the Yaqui territory. After returning the Nébome to his hometown, Pérez de Ribas discovered that the Yaqui culprit had lost a brother in an earlier war with the Nébomes. Pérez de Ribas tried to establish a lasting peace between them by placing a cross at the border between the two peoples, so as to establish both a boundary and a friendship. The Yaquis were hardly united behind the effort to make peace with their neighbors. But those who did support the Jesuits supported them in part because of the diplomatic role they played.²⁹

Pérez de Ribas brokered similar gestures of friendship with the Mayo people. When a delegation of Mayos came to complain that the Yaquis had a collection of Mayo scalps taken in a previous war, Pérez de Ribas asked his Yaqui friends to answer the complaint. They claimed at first to know nothing of the scalps but subsequently located them and offered to have them burned. The Yaquis,

Mayos, and Jesuit priests all watched as a bonfire in the center of a Yaqui pueblo consumed the bloody trophies. Pérez de Ribas reported that this ritual satisfied the Mayos and that they returned to their pueblos secure in the knowledge that conversion had ended the Yaqui menace. Indeed, there is no record of armed conflict in the colonial period between the Yaquis and Mayos after the arrival of the Jesuits.³⁰

Yaqui relations with the Guaymas people were more volatile. A Guaymas woman, convinced that the newly Christian Yaquis would treat her kindly, married a Yaqui headman, only to be attacked, killed, and dismembered by a band of drunken Yaquis. On hearing of the assault, Pérez de Ribas tried to help the woman but was detained by Yaqui Christians who warned him that the woman was dead. They went on to inform the priest that the woman's killers would not hesitate to kill him too. Pérez de Ribas returned to his house but went out later that evening to find the murderers dancing around the woman's body, which they had impaled on a stake. Pérez de Ribas had the body taken down and buried, and reported that the Christian Yaquis later made restitution to the Guaymas by admitting them into their pueblos and distributing farmland to them.³¹

Basilio made contact with the last of the Yaquis' immediate neighbors when he walked from the Yaqui mission to the territory of the Aibinos in 1622. The Aibinos greeted him warmly with decorated arches and processions with cane crosses. The Aibinos had long been hostile to the Christian Nébomes, and, after absorbing a Spanish punitive expedition, they were ready to make peace. They may have been further encouraged to take this step by the fact that there were Aibinos living alongside the baptized Yaquis on the Yaqui River. Basilio baptized most of the Aibinos on this first visit, but no Jesuits took up residence among them until 1627, when Aibinos handed over ten of their children to padre Martín Brujencio in exchange for perpetual peace with the region's Christian peoples.³²

The sparse but suggestive documentation for the middle and later seventeenth century suggests a steady expansion of contacts between the Yaquis and their neighbors. The report Ortíz Zapata made on the missions of the northwest in 1675 indicated that there were still many pagan tribes living among the largely Christian population of Sinaloa and Sonora. The Guaymas people lived in the dry, sandy territory near the mouth of the Yaqui River and were as yet unconverted to Christianity. Sustaining themselves from fish, roots, and river water, the Guaymas were poor and wanted baptism: "Because the lands are so sterile, many pagans who desire baptism, come to the nearest Yaqui pueblo, and they make their houses there, in the company of the old Christians of the Yaqui River, and since these sometimes go to see their pagan relatives, they

almost always bring a few of them, with whom the number of Christians of this nation has increased, and one hopes with the grace of God, that all those who remain in that nation will be baptised." Despite the diversity and eclecticism of their religious life, the Yaquis were by this time considered "old Christians." The Yaqui mission was a key point of transmission of Christianity to the unconverted peoples to the north. Perhaps most striking about this report is that it was possible for non-Yaqui Indians to settle in Yaqui communities. Christianity was the medium through which outsiders made peace with the Yaquis, became members of Yaqui communities, and thereby gained access to the material goods of the mission system.³³

Yaquis' contact with their neighbors was not passive, military cooperation being central to Yaqui-Spanish interactions. Captain Juan de Encinas wrote in 1685 that the Yaqui River represented a frontier with many pagan peoples to the north, and he praised the Yaquis for their assistance in dealing with the dangerous heathen Guaymas, Nébomes, and Vainos. When Encinas set out from the Yaqui town of Rahum to visit the pagans in Belén, he went in the company of two Spaniards, the Yaqui governor of Rahum, and many other Christian Yaquis. "The Yaqui nation has always come to my aid with the utmost loyalty," Encinas wrote, "accompanying me in the functions of service of your Majesty, may God preserve him, on account of the great risks one runs on this frontier." The Yaquis had become a pillar of the empire's frontier policy in the northwest.³⁴

Encinas went on to describe a visit to the Yaqui town of Vicam, which was in the midst of a standoff with unconverted Indians to the north. The pagans had killed and mutilated a Yaqui woman, slicing pieces of flesh from her back. Encinas observed that the Indians who had done these things had painted bodies and were wearing spectacular feathers. They had also erected a tall pole on the other side of the river, and ten smaller poles on either side of it, the tips of which were decorated with colorful plumes and "nerves" of animals. Encinas asked his Yaqui allies what this display meant and learned that the poles represented a challenge. Each of the smaller poles represented an enemy captain, and the largest one represented their overlord. The Yaquis went on to tell Encinas that the pagans were a constant menace and destroyed their cornfields and stole their cattle and sheep. As in the days of Hurdaide, the Yaquis and Spanish depended on one another for protection. The Yaquis accompanied Spanish soldiers in the land of unconverted Indians, and they asked the Spanish for help in fights with their most dangerous neighbors.³⁵

An episode during the Great Northern Revolt of the 1680s and 1690s illustrated the strength of the Yaqui-Spanish alliance. This period saw a wave of violence in northern New Spain that began in 1680 with the Pueblo revolt of

New Mexico and rippled hundreds of miles across the provinces of Nueva Vizcaya, Sinaloa, and Sonora. This bleak decade saw the fiercest attempt of the region's native peoples to beat back the tide of Spanish settlement. The Pueblos killed scores of Spaniards and drove the rest hundreds of miles south to the Spanish way station of El Paso del Norte. Tepehuanes and Tarahumaras in the sierras of Nueva Vizcaya added their forces to this vast campaign against the empire, burning and abandoning their missions, sabotaging the region's mines, and killing many settlers and missionaries. The Spanish counterattack, though eventually successful, cost the crown enormous sums of money and the blood of hundreds of Spanish soldiers and native allies. The rebellion transformed relations between native peoples and colonists. The Spanish reestablished their dominance of primary population centers in the region but became extremely cautious in their dealings with native peoples. They did not dare try to exploit Indians as brazenly as they had before, given the threat that the oppressed would exact a terrible revenge.³⁶

Whenever the Spanish caught wind of a possible revolt, they flew into fevered action. They investigated, threatened death and exile to those who defied them, and sent troops to patrol towns they believed to be on the verge of rebellion. So it was when a rumor of a possible Yaqui revolt arrived in the capital of Nueva Vizcaya in 1689. Spanish soldiers were immediately sent to the Yaqui mission. The relative wealth and martial prowess of the Yaquis were well known to the Spanish, as was the importance of the Yaquis to the larger strategic vision of Spanish imperialism in northwest Mexico. The government thus regarded the possibility of a Yaqui revolt with grave alarm. On August 13, 1689, Governor Juan Isidro de Pardiñas Villar de Francos ordered Alcalde Mayor Juan Francisco Goyeneche to visit the Yaqui Valley with twenty riflemen to investigate rumors of Yaqui unrest. Goyeneche was to go to each of the eight Yaqui towns and speak to their headmen as well as to the Yaqui captain general and in addition to interview the Jesuit missionaries at work there. The letters Governor Pardiñas received from Goyeneche and other Spanish officials in the Yaqui Valley must have relieved him. They reported that the Yaquis remained as loyal as ever to the Spanish crown and had no interest in killing or expelling Spaniards. The records of the Goyeneche expedition were unique in two important ways: they afforded a more detailed glimpse of Yaqui political life in the late seventeenth century than any other document, and unlike the majority of records from this period they chronicled the smooth functioning of the Yaqui-Spanish alliance rather than the breakdown of social order.

Before his arrival at the Yaqui mission, Goyeneche received word from the Jesuits Andrés Cervantes and Francisco Pérez Arroyo, who assured him that the

Yaquis were calm and in complete harmony both with the Jesuits themselves and with the local government. Cervantes illustrated this point by alluding to a recent Spanish expedition north of the Yaqui River on which the Yaquis sent eight hundred warriors to aid in the pacification of the region's "delinquents." Padre Pérez Arroyo described the Yaquis as "our firm friends and defenders," a turn of phrase attesting to the Jesuits' continuing dependence on the protection of their Yaqui hosts.³⁷

The Yaqui governor and *alcaldes* of Bacum greeted Goyeneche and his company warmly. The resident Jesuit was away preaching to people in the neighboring countryside, so the leaders of the town welcomed the visitors in the Jesuit's house. They pledged their obedience to the king and assured Goyeneche they had no desire to revolt or leave their communities. They explained that they had not left the mission to work in the mines because their harvests had been so abundant. They speculated that this may have deceived the miners into thinking they were in rebellion. The truth, they said, was that they did not need extra income from the mines that year, though they were happy to sell their maize to the miners who came to ask for it. The Yaquis emphasized their love of the Spanish and alluded to their service in earlier wars against pagan rebels.³⁸

Satisfied, Goyeneche set off for Torim. The Yaqui governor, *alcaldes*, and *alférez* of Torim met Goyeneche outside the town. Yaqui bowmen shot arrows into the sky to greet the visitors and escorted Goyeneche's company into the town, where padre Fernández awaited them. Fernández seconded the Yaquis' denial that they were in revolt and averred that some Spaniards may have thought the Yaquis' annual forays to harvest the fruit of the pitahaya cactus were something dangerous. A crowd of two thousand Yaqui men, women, and children stood by as the Yaqui officials swore obedience to the Spanish king and reiterated their willingness to serve in Spanish wars against Indian rebels.³⁹

Four hundred bowmen greeted Goyeneche in Vicam pueblo, shooting arrows in the sky, dancing, and pledging their undying loyalty to the Spanish crown. The Yaquis of Vicam also pointed to their abundant harvests and fervent attendance at the Catholic Mass as signs of their loyalty. The two thousand residents of Pótam greeted Goyeneche's party with the same ferocious enthusiasm as the previous towns and pointed to the many merchants who had come to them to buy their goods as evidence of their harmonious relations with the nearby mines. The Yaqui captain general, Andrés, a resident of Rahum, affirmed that he and all the Yaquis were loyal to the captain of the Villa de Sinaloa.⁴⁰

Goyeneche came away from the Yaqui pueblos with the impression that the Yaquis were the empire's strongest allies in the region, their loyalty cemented by their "ancient enmity" with their northern neighbors. In his visits to Yaqui

towns, Goyeneche dealt primarily with Yaqui officials and secondarily with Jesuits, an indication that by this time the Jesuits had lost some of their centrality as mediators between the Yaquis and the outside world. The Yaquis had regular dealings with the regional economy, selling either agricultural produce or labor to the local mines. Yaquis' contact with the outside world was also political and military. The Yaquis seem to have had established diplomatic customs for dealing with Spanish officials like Goyeneche. Each town sent its governor, alcalde, and alférez along with numerous archers to meet Goyeneche outside the town limits and escort him to the town center, where they swore obedience to the king.⁴¹

By the late seventeenth century the Yaqui mission was mobilized around the enterprise of frontier war. The Yaqui River had become the borderline between Christian peoples allied with the Spanish and their non-Christian enemies to the north. The Yaqui mission was an indispensable ally to the Spanish in maintaining their influence in the region and was deeply involved in Spanish military activities north of the Yaqui River. The existence of the Yaqui captain general illustrated how deep that involvement was. Padre Marquina, the mission priest of Potam, testified to the intensity of Yaqui allegiance to the Spanish in 1690. During an uprising among the Pimas and Tarahumaras, eighteen Yaquis, including Governor Don Tomás Notamea of Potam, were wounded by a blast from a rebel's harquebus. "The wounds they display on their faces . . . [testify] to their loyalty," he wrote. He went on to praise the Yaquis in strong terms: "In this uprising, I have heard nothing, not even a rumor, in these my pueblos of Rahum and Potam, but rather much loyalty, and much Christianity, and much obedience." Father Nicolás de Saldana offered further testimony of the extent of Yaqui loyalty when he wrote of large numbers of Yaquis setting out from the Yaqui pueblos to combat the rebel Tarahumaras. By the end of the seventeenth century Yaqui military ties with the Spanish had expanded beyond defense of the Yaqui towns and ran to offensive operations far from the Yaqui mission.⁴²

Baja California was the main theater of Yaqui operations outside the mission. Padre Eusebio Francisco Kino came to the Yaqui mission in October 1683 to gather supplies for the California missions. He took sheep, goats, beef, fish, shrimp, maize and wheat flour, horses, and mules. Pedro Marquina, a resident Jesuit among the Yaquis, added pomegranates and quinces grown on Yaqui mission lands. On another visit to the Yaqui mission in December 1684 Kino took with him sixteen horses, two mules, various pack animals, fifty-five gelded rams, two hundred and fifty *arrobas* of meat, sixty-one *arrobas* of fish, twelve bottles of mescal wine, twenty *fanegas* of maize, and twelve *arrobas* of

butter. Considering that an arroba was about twenty-five pounds and a fanega almost two bushels, this was a considerable haul. The Yaquis also supplied soldiers for the conquest of California. The Jesuit Juan de Ugarte approached the Yaqui captain general for help in the exploration of the peninsula: "For this voyage he asked for forty men of war from the chief or general of the numerous and warlike Yaqui nation." The Yaqui captain general "not only granted him the forty chosen men he had asked for, he also went with them to Loreto himself." A document from 1735 on the suppression of a revolt in California listed dozens of Yaqui soldiers and the amounts they were paid, Yaqui officers receiving twelve pesos each while the men they commanded each earned eight.⁴³

Whatever the Jesuits may have believed about native desire for Christian salvation, the primary motives for conversion were practical and political. The exchange of Yaqui children for Jesuits facilitated peaceful trade with Christian neighbors, freedom from the threat of Spanish violence, help in coping with disease, and military aid against non-Christian enemies. As the Yaqui-Spanish relationship deepened, the Yaquis became vital agents of Spanish exploration and conquest in regions to the north, east, and west of the Yaqui mission. The seventeenth century was anything but a period of quiescence and harmonious religious dialogue on the Yaqui mission. It was a period of dynamic, contentious change, one in which the Yaquis fell into an increasingly intense military alliance with the Spanish. Yaqui communities had extensive dealings with the world beyond the mission, most often as imperial militias sent out to crush native rebellions and conquer new territories for the crown.

MISSION AND EMPIRE

The Society of Jesus was no stranger to controversy, and the Jesuits had made powerful enemies soon after their arrival in New Spain. For the duration of their presence in Mexico, the Jesuits were in conflict with the Franciscans, the secular clergy, and the ecclesiastical hierarchy over the secularization of the northern missions. By law, missions were supposed to be transitory institutions. They were to convert Indians to Catholicism, teach them how to live in Spanish society, and then be transformed into secular parishes after a period of ten years. But the vast majority of Jesuit missions were not so transformed. Rather, they remained in existence for decades after their term was up. This fact, combined with mission Indians' legal exemption from the payment of tribute to the crown, infuriated many non-Jesuits. Franciscans like Carranco thought the Jesuits were lax and allowed pagan practices to persist on their missions. The

ecclesiastical hierarchy wanted to turn missions into tribute-paying secular parishes. Miners, ranchers, and other businessmen wanted access to the labor of mission Indians. Skirmishes over these issues fed a vast conflict between the Jesuits and their rivals that spread throughout the world, flared regularly into epic bouts of pamphleteering, litigation, and bureaucratic wrangling, and finally culminated in Charles III's expulsion of the Jesuit order from all of Spain's territories in 1767.⁴⁴

These conflicts first impinged on the missions of Sinaloa and Sonora in the 1630s, when the bishop of Durango proposed to create a new bishopric in the northwest to oversee the secularization of the region's Jesuit missions. The bishop made a series of charges against the Jesuits. He claimed that the missions were vast and rich in cattle, sheep, and fertile farmland. The Jesuits, he complained, exploited native labor for their own benefit, and the missions paid no tribute to the king. The Jesuits also paid the soldiers who protected the missions in kind rather than in money. For all these reasons, the northern missions should be secularized and subordinated to bishops.⁴⁵

Pérez de Ribas and his fellow Jesuits responded point by point, arguing that the bishop did not understand the mission system. They argued that the land was far more remote and dangerous and far less profitable than the bishop knew. The truth, they claimed, was that the Jesuits had a few cattle here and there, but that the Indians and the missionaries themselves were very poor. Wheat and cotton would not grow, and the Indians were often so destitute that they had to forage in the countryside for food. As for the alleged exploitation of Indian labor, the Jesuits claimed they paid all Indian officeholders in the church out of the royal alms. The Jesuits admitted that they sometimes asked Indians to sell corn from their family plots in order to buy decorations for the church. But generally the Indians were too poor to contribute to the church funds, and many left the missions to work in distant mines. Moreover, the Jesuits avowed, Indians were new in the faith and there were still more dangerous barbarians at large. Trying to extract tribute from them would be to risk a general uprising, like that of the Tepehuanes in 1616. The suppression of the Tepehuan uprising cost the crown nine hundred thousand pesos, and in addition the rebellion shut down the region's mines for three years and so choked the flow of tax revenues to Spain. Much the same might happen in Sinaloa, the Jesuits argued, but with even more costly repercussions. The Indians did not pay taxes, but the mines did, and a general uprising would bring payments of the royal fifth to a halt.⁴⁶

Pérez de Ribas would repeat this argument in explicit terms six years later, when Juan de Palafox y Mendoza, the archbishop of Puebla, cut off payments

of the royal alms to the Jesuit missions. The royal alms paid for the administration of the sacraments to remote Indian tribes and also gave the padres something with which to "caress" rebellious Indians and "keep them at peace and in obedience." Thus the royal alms "help prevent rebellions among those peoples, which are a great burden on the *real hacienda*, and greatly damage the king's vassals, and the silver mines near their lands, which sometimes rebels have destroyed." Pérez de Ribas argued in essence that Jesuit missions were a good investment. They kept the frontier peaceful, allowing the mines to work and to generate income for miners and government alike. A more important benefit for the king came in the form of the thousands of Indian souls the Jesuits saved for heaven.⁴⁷

These petitions shed light on the political pressures bearing on the Jesuit mission system and hint at some underlying motives of the Jesuits' relaxed approach to "spiritual conquest." If it could be proven that the Indians were fully acculturated to Spanish-Christian ways, then the mission's continued existence could not be legally justified. The Jesuits had a vested interest in keeping Indians in a semi-Christian state, or at least in depicting them as such to outsiders. Composed in the midst of the quarrel between the Jesuits and Archbishop Palafox, the chronicle *History of the Triumphs of Our Holy Faith Amongst the Most Barbarous and Fierce Peoples of the New Orb* emphasized the ferocity and recalcitrance of the region's native peoples, while at the same time stressing the heroic progress the Jesuits were making in their efforts to tame them. These were precisely the points the Jesuits were trying to make to the king in their response to the bishop's proposal. Indeed, Pérez de Ribas first described the native people of the northwest in the distinctive phrase "barbarous and fierce" (*bárbaras y fieras*) in petitions justifying the expansion of the Jesuit mission system in the north. Pérez de Ribas's vision of mission history was, in other words, quite compatible with the political interests of the Jesuit order.⁴⁸

Evidence bearing on the Jesuits' controversies in the mid-seventeenth century is fragmentary and partisan, and very often no documents remain from the opposite side of the controversy in which each document was embroiled. It is clear that from the 1630s at least a few Yaquis migrated to work in the region's mining camps and that this kind of migration expanded over the course of the seventeenth century, especially as mines were discovered near the Yaqui mission in the 1660s. The Jesuits tolerated but generally disliked and tried to minimize these kinds of Yaqui participation in activities outside the missions. The census of the Yaqui mission taken by Juan Ortiz Zapata in 1676 noted that it was impossible to count all the Yaquis because so many of them were away in

the region's mines. In 1684 father Marquina counted 977 out of a total of 7,431 Yaquis who went to the mines to work but returned to confess on the Yaqui mission. Almost every other census taken of the Yaqui pueblos during the colonial period would note that it was impossible to determine the precise population of the Yaquis since some number of them was always away at the mines.⁴⁹

As demand for native labor increased, the Jesuits worked to exert control over it. Several sprawling court cases testified to the Jesuits' tenacity in asserting their claims to Indian labor in the northwest. Luis Navarro García has provided a detailed chronicle of one tangled and inconclusive lawsuit from the 1670s. Fernando de Haro y Monterros, the judge presiding over the case in the high court of Guadalajara, accepted complaints that the Jesuits misused the fruits of native labor and ordered that all native workers on the missions be paid two and a half reales a day. But those who tried to carry these orders out were divided among themselves and were hampered by Jesuit legal maneuvering with the court and governor of Nueva Vizcaya. There is minimal surviving evidence of the impact of these events on the Yaqui mission. Juan Franco Maldonado was dispatched by the *audiencia* to enforce the court's decree and announced to the Yaquis that they were to do no work for the Jesuits if they were not properly paid. The Yaquis became "shameless," he wrote, and began to kill mission cattle. Maldonado ordered them to stop, explained that they were to honor their priests, and was stunned by the rapidity with which the Yaquis calmed down. This complex, suggestive episode is all we know about the case's impact on the Yaquis.

Though precise information is difficult to come by, several things are clear. The economic development of northern New Spain unsettled the Jesuits and placed ever-greater demands on the products and labor of the missions. The Jesuits responded by doing all they could to keep mission Indians in the northwest away from the corrupting influence of work outside the missions. But try as they might, the Jesuits could not control native commerce and movements outside the mission. A steadily growing stream of Yaquis traveled and worked in Spanish enterprises, gaining knowledge of the outside world, language skills, contacts, and savvy as to the workings of imperial commerce and politics. With the accession of the Bourbon regime in Spain in the eighteenth century, such opportunities would multiply. So would the Yaquis' interest in exploiting them.

By the end of the seventeenth century Yaqui society was deeply woven into the fabric of the Spanish empire in northern Mexico. The Yaquis had converted to Christianity, made frequent trips to work in the mines of Sinaloa, Sonora, Ostimuri, and Nueva Vizcaya, and were regular participants in Spanish military

expeditions throughout northern Mexico. Yet this should not be read as evidence of Yaqui submissiveness to colonial rule. The Yaquis had considerable power and autonomy in their dealings with the Spanish. The fragmentation of the colonial government and the swirling rivalries among the Jesuits, secular institutions, miners, parish priests, and Franciscans made it impossible to impose colonial rule on the Yaquis in a direct and intensive way. The empire relied on native officials to extract the services and goods required of native vassals. The Yaquis, in turn, extracted food and clothing, church ornaments, and Spanish assistance against their enemies.

The Yaqui-Spanish alliance was achieved through a complex, often violent process of negotiation and exchange. The Jesuits came to northwest Mexico in the hope of imposing sweeping cultural and political change on the region's peoples. But circumstances made this impossible. The region's isolation and the Yaquis' unwillingness to accept drastic change forced the Jesuits to scale back their ambitions and accede to the Yaquis' political, cultural, and economic demands. As the seventeenth century came to a close, the Yaquis, their indigenous neighbors, the Jesuits, and Spanish settlers had achieved a tense but workable accommodation. Most parties got enough from their relations with the others to avoid mass violence. This was a momentous collective achievement in view of the bloody years of the early seventeenth century. The eighteenth century saw the accession of the Bourbon regime to power in Spain and the coming of a new philosophy of government that transformed the negotiated relationships achieved in the seventeenth century.

CRACKS IN THE FOUNDATION: EARLY BOURBON REFORMS AND THE BREAKDOWN OF NEGOTIATED PEACE, 1700–1740

Political crisis might be considered a moment of nudity, propitious for applying the stethoscope to the social body.

—*Leslie F. Manigat, quoted in Mark Danner, Stripping Bare the Body*

In July 1739 two Yaqui leaders named Juan Ignacio Jusacamea and Bernabé Basoritemea presented themselves before the viceroy of New Spain. They had traveled overland for months, covering more than a thousand miles of rugged territory in their journey from the Yaqui mission to the viceregal palace in Mexico City. They had numerous grievances. They complained about the exactions of certain unprincipled Jesuits, the cruelty of the Jesuits' mixed-race attendants, and the meddling of both groups in Yaqui politics. They accused the Jesuits of removing them unjustly from the governorships of Rahum and Huirivis. Both men told of their service to the crown as militia soldiers and asked that their right to bear arms be respected. The two deposed governors wanted their work to be fairly compensated, and they wanted freedom to sell their produce and labor to whomever they wished. The viceroy deliberated over the two Yaquis' allegations and demands for several weeks. When at last he made his decision, Viceroy Juan Antonio de Vizarrón y Eguiarreta astonished the Jesuits following the case and delighted the Yaqui petitioners by assenting to nearly all the complainants' demands.¹

Both the Yaquis' demands and the viceroy's assent emerged from a matrix of long- and short-term political change in New Spain. As we have seen, the seventeenth century saw the slow transformation of the Yaqui people into an

integral part of the Spanish colonial enterprise. They became workers in Spanish mines, soldiers in Spanish wars, and recipients of imperial protection and gifts. Through an arrangement of Jesuit-mediated engagement with the empire, the Yaquis had gained extensive knowledge of imperial activities all across north Mexico. This period of Yaqui "political growth," to use Spicer's phrase, allowed the Yaquis to build strong ties with the institutions of empire, ties that afforded them both the legal standing to petition the colonial government and the political influence to win cases such as the one they brought before the viceroy in 1739.²

Whereas the evolution of Yaqui political consciousness was slow and negotiated, changes to the imperial government in the early eighteenth century were shockingly sudden. The collapse of the Habsburg monarchy in 1700 brought a storm of violence to the Iberian peninsula before elevating a French monarch to the Spanish throne. In the wake of the War of Spanish Succession, the government of the Bourbon king Philip V developed a sweeping program of reform. It sought to streamline the institutions of empire, to increase governmental efficiency, and to extract more revenue from Spain's colonies. Two tenets of the Bourbons' reforming creed bore strongly on the Yaqui mission: first, fringe regions such as Sonora were seen as the places most in need of improved government; and second, Bourbon reformers regarded America's native peoples as the empire's most important and underutilized resource. They reasoned that Indians had for too long been relegated to the status of political minors under the tutelage of the church. Reformers argued that the time had come for Indians to take their place in the mainstream of the colony's political and economic life.³

All this came as a shock to the Jesuits. The Jesuits had grappled with political enemies before, but they had never faced a government with so strong a commitment to undermining the power of priests in native communities. Never had they dealt with officials so willing to take the side of Indians who complained of clerical high-handedness. In the 1730s Jesuits and their allies began to express astonishment that Yaqui "rebels," "delinquents," and "little barbarians" began to find supporters in the imperial bureaucracy. One *vecino* of the Villa de Sinaloa complained in court testimony that "the Spaniards are entirely to blame" for the restiveness of the Yaquis. The Spaniards "envy the padres," he said, offering "much protection" to the Indians in all their evil deeds and "always tell[ing] the Indians they are right." Some Yaquis, in turn, came to understand that the new Bourbon regime offered them dazzling, if risky, opportunities to gain status, money, and freedom of movement outside the mission. In this heady atmosphere, politically entrepreneurial Yaquis like

Jusacamea and Basoritemea found allies both among the Yaqui people and within the institutions of Bourbon government. Yet large numbers of Yaquis were not seduced by the opportunities held out by the new Bourbon order. Many remained loyal to the Jesuits and to the political arrangements they had so painfully worked out over the seventeenth century.⁴

Jesuits, government officials, settlers, and Yaquis were thus galvanized and divided by the political changes brought on by the advent of Bourbon rule. Drawing on recent scholarship on state building, negotiation, and resistance in Mexico, I explore here the patterns of contention on the Yaqui mission in the early eighteenth century in order to place the insurrectionary violence of 1740 in perspective. By unearthing and examining the historical roots of the insurrection I want to shed light not only on the distinctiveness of this event but also on the religious, cultural, and psychological motives of the participants. William Taylor's *Drinking, Homicide, and Rebellion* provides context and brings these matters into focus. Using a massive database of village insurrections in colonial Mexico, Taylor argues that the majority of these incidents were confined to single villages, were spontaneous, and were lacking in revolutionary ideology. They were most often carried out in a disorganized fashion with improvised weapons like rocks and farm implements and were generally aimed at the redress of specific grievances against specific officials perceived to have broken with traditions of reciprocity. Peasant villagers were, in Taylor's words, "good rebels but poor revolutionaries." A principal finding of Taylor's study echoes the writings of the sociologist Georg Simmel: social conflict should be understood as normal and constant rather than exceptional and aberrant.⁵

The uprising of 1740 shared much with the rebellions studied by Taylor. It was directed against priests and officials who had violated traditional bonds of reciprocity with native towns. Some incidents mirrored the spontaneous effusions of anger Taylor identifies as being central to village rebellions. Most important, the rebellion rose out of a long tradition of bitter negotiation and conflict between Yaquis and outsiders. Most writings on the Yaquis in the colonial period describe 1740 as an aberration in the 150-year history of the Pax Jesuitica. The documentary record tells a different story. Yaqui relations with both Jesuits and secular authorities had ranged from violent conflict to alliance to tense and mutually suspicious peace. Disputes flared between the Yaquis and outsiders throughout the colonial period. The uprising in 1740 was more destructive than anything seen before on the Yaqui mission, but it emerged from a matrix of long-standing contestation and dispute.⁶

Yet in several respects the Yaqui insurrection was distinctive. It extended to multiple communities and ethnicities, not just one town. It was long and rela-

tively well-organized, not “spasmodic, localized, . . . and short lived,” to use Eric Van Young’s phrase for the kind of rebellion Taylor discusses. Beyond that, it diverged from the generally localist pattern identified by Taylor and elaborated on by Van Young in *The Other Rebellion*. The insurrection of 1740 responded directly to colonywide changes in royal policy. The leaders of the uprising were politically sophisticated and well informed about changes under way outside the mission. Moreover, they aimed not at an “atavistic vision of a peasant village utopia” but at greater engagement with commerce and enterprises far distant from the Yaqui Valley. In this sense the Yaqui insurrectionists were even more deeply engaged with supralocal affairs than the peasant rebels analyzed by Peter Guardino in *The Time of Liberty*. They were connected to the empire by ties of trade, shared religion, and shared symbols of colonial authority, but they also sought actively to take control of relationships with empire by seizing on newly promulgated political reforms. The irony of the 1740 insurrection, the most violent conjuncture in the colonial history of the Yaqui people, lay in its being essentially reformist in nature. Even the most radical of the Yaqui actors drew on the reformist agenda of the deposed governors in calling for expanded commerce between the Jesuit missions and their neighbors. Careful examination of the political disputes leading up to the revolt and of the macropolitical context in which it took place can thus be particularly revealing.⁷

THE BOURBON RAGE FOR ORDER

On November 1, 1700, King Charles II of Spain performed a service that filled his subjects with greater relief and delight than almost all of his previous official acts: he died. The disastrous thirty-five-year reign of the last Habsburg monarch had seen famine, revolt, economic collapse, and a precipitous decline in the Spanish population. Charles “the Bewitched” left no heir, and as a result the great powers of Europe were drawn into a war for possession of the Spanish throne. The War of the Spanish Succession (1703–13) turned much of the Iberian Peninsula into a battleground. The Mediterranean provinces of Valencia and Aragon sided with the Protestant English and Dutch invaders in an effort to install a Habsburg king. Castile joined forces with the French to install a Bourbon monarch and thus to deepen commercial ties with France.⁸

The treaty of Utrecht (1713) confirmed the Bourbon king Philip V in power, while making major concessions to his English and Dutch enemies. King Philip was different in almost all respects from his predecessor. He spoke French and maintained frequent contact with his grandfather, Louis XIV of

France. His personality was complex and bizarre. Henry Kamen has characterized Philip as a manic-depressive, a diagnosis supported by Philip's long periods of despair and sporadic outbursts of frenetic political activity. But as Philip's life wore on, his personality and mental disease became increasingly complex. By the 1740s the king had delegated many of his royal duties to his very capable queen, Elizabeth Farnese of Parma. Philip isolated himself in a royal retreat in Seville, reversed his sleep schedule, and insisted that an evil sunbeam had penetrated his shoulder and corrupted his internal organs. He sometimes expressed the view that he had been transformed into a frog and at other times that he was dead.⁹

Kamen suggests that historians have underestimated Philip because of his strange personality and his dependence on powerful women. This is still a minority view. But whether or not Kamen's relatively positive assessment is correct, one thing that is certain is that Philip brought about critical changes in the personnel at the top of the government. His first adviser to wield broad powers was the princess of Oursins, who came with him from France and exercised a deep influence during the early years of his reign. She left the government after the death of Philip's beloved first wife, María Louisa of Savoy, and the arrival of his second, Elizabeth Farnese of Parma, whom Philip also came to adore. Elizabeth's adviser, Cardinal Giulio Alberoni, effectively replaced Oursins as the most powerful individual in Philip's government. Short, fat, cunning, and ambitious, Alberoni created new government ministries over which he wielded great influence. He was instrumental in the creation of the intendancy system, a French-inspired network of regional potentates whom Philip used to consolidate his power over Spain's territories. Alberoni's career in Madrid ended, however, when he was blamed for the defeat of Spanish forces in an expedition to Sicily in 1719.¹⁰

From 1727 to 1736 José de Patiño came to replace Alberoni and exercised powers of similarly broad scope. Born in Milan and schooled in Spanish politics as intendant of Catalonia and Seville, Patiño presided over the crucial transfer of Spain's trade bureaucracy from Seville to Cádiz. As secretary of war, Patiño was responsible for the creation of a new standing army and navy, pillars of the emergent Bourbon state. Advisers like Patiño brought revolutionary change to the Spanish government. They brought peace to the Iberian Peninsula and overthrew the most burdensome provisions of the treaty of Utrecht. Patiño reformed the navy, oversaw the conquest of Sicily and Naples, and bequeathed an effective system of intendancies to Philip's successors."

The early Bourbon reforms had a tremendous impact in New Spain. Reformers drew on the writings of *arbitristas* and *projectistas*, political thinkers

and thoughtful bureaucrats active as early as the late sixteenth century, who proposed new methods for the subjection of the colonies to the power of the crown. The mercantilist theories of Louis XIV's chief minister Jean-Baptiste Colbert inspired reformers to remove obstacles to trade and economic growth within the Spanish realm. A major aim of the Bourbon reform program was to marginalize the clergy in the political and economic affairs of native communities and thereby force Indian labor and products onto an open market. Bourbon reformers thought the clergy had an outdated understanding of Indians as children in need of moral tutelage. Some reformers went further, arguing that since the heroic days of the "spiritual conquest" in the sixteenth century priests had become parasites on the body politic. The liberal minister José del Campillo y Cosío gave voice to this analysis in his tract on government, *Nuevo sistema de gobierno económico para la América* (1743): "The singular respect and veneration that Indians have for their parish priests is well known. . . . But intendants must make sure above all that no vestige remains of the self-interested and tyrannical practices which many say the priests and *doctrineros* employ with the poor Indians." Campillo went on to state that the economic development of the colony depended on freeing Indians from a church-sanctioned caste system. Indians who acted like Spaniards were to be treated as Spaniards: "All those who dress like Spaniards will have the same access as Spaniards of their class to the houses of the Governors, Intendants, and other Ministers, and the same place in the church and in all public functions. They will be able to enter brotherhoods, and obtain whatever honorific employment, that their merit makes them worthy of; in a word, they will be given the same treatment in all things as Spaniards of the same sphere." Reformers such as Campillo argued that the time had come to strip native villages of both the privileges and the burdens of their political minority and to usher them into the mainstream of colonial economic life.¹²

The Bourbon regime made the fringes of the Spanish-American empire central to its reform efforts. Fringe regions were often governed by the most archaic social and political structures to be found in the new world; they were vulnerable to attack from without; and very often they were host to large populations of unassimilated Indians. Beyond this, the very weakness of the government presence in fringe regions meant reformers would have greater freedom to bring about change. Northwest Mexico was a classic fringe. The Spanish occupying force there was weak, and the most powerful players among the Spanish were the Jesuits, a religious order notoriously independent of the crown's authority. The Jesuits jealously guarded their exclusive right to live in mission villages against the incursions of parish priests, Franciscans, and

Spanish settlers. The hybrid political arrangements and cultural institutions forged on the Jesuit missions over the seventeenth century were bound to offend the sensibilities of Bourbon reformers. Bourbon officials thought the Jesuit missions, designed to reduce the region's Indians, were now themselves in need of reduction. This time it would be royal authorities rather than religious ones that would bring order to the northwest. Crown officials were to comb through the region's tangle of overlapping jurisdictions, extirpating predatory interest groups, smoothing over conflicts, and creating a clean, lustrous new order.¹³

Throughout the seventeenth century the secular government of northwestern New Spain had been paralyzed by its own disorganization. For most of this period the Yaqui Valley was part of the *alcaldía mayor* of Sinaloa. Sinaloa, in turn, was part of the province of Nueva Vizcaya, whose capital lay hundreds of miles to the east, across the Sierra Madre, in Parral. In 1640 the Yaqui River became the boundary between the provinces of Sinaloa and Sonora. Boundaries were redrawn once again in 1666, when silver was discovered in Ostimuri, between the Yaqui and Mayo Rivers. The area between the two rivers was placed under the jurisdiction of an *alcalde mayor y capitán a guerra de S. Ildefonso de Ostimuri*, an official who was to be named by the governor of Nueva Vizcaya. Legally, the entire northwest of New Spain was under the jurisdiction of the high court (audiencia) of Guadalajara, which was hundreds of miles to the south. Yet in religious matters the northwest was subject to the archbishopric of Durango, which lay hundreds of miles to the southeast. The political, judicial, and religious institutions that were supposed to oversee colonial life in northwest Mexico were vastly distant, both from one another and from the region itself. The result was administrative chaos.¹⁴

Jesuits thrived in the absence of a functioning government. The distances separating the northwestern provinces from their centers of government facilitated corruption at the local level and hindered coordinated action against Indian enemies. These were the reasons given for the creation of a new political structure in the northwest. On March 14, 1732, King Philip V issued a royal order uniting the provinces of Sinaloa, Sonora, Ostimuri, Culiacán, and Rosario. He placed this vast new territory in the power of a single governor-for-life, who was accorded sweeping powers to set the region's political agenda and to appoint all but one of its *justicias* and *alcaldes mayores*.¹⁵

On April 24, 1733, Manuel Bernal de Huidobro became the first captain general and governor-for-life of Sinaloa and Sonora. He took possession of the office in the Villa de Sinaloa the following October 25. Huidobro's appointment was to be the culmination of a long career in the service of the Spanish crown. He had been a soldier, rifleman (*carabinero*), corporal (*cabo*), and

sergeant in the Regimiento de Órdenes Nuevo. During the War of the Spanish Succession he fought in the decisive battle of Almansa and in the Catalan campaign. He may also have fought on the North African coast near Oran. In return for these services Huidobro was awarded the *alcaldía mayor* of Huejotzingo in the Sierra of Puebla, to the southeast of Mexico City. He sailed for New Spain in August 1720 and took up duties in Huejotzingo on October 31 of that year. Huidobro served in this post until his appointment to the *presidio* of Sinaloa on October 23, 1723. As commander of this *presidio*, he was charged with keeping the peace in the region. He acquitted himself well, receiving the commendation of Brigadier Pedro de Rívera in 1727. Beyond Huidobro's suppression of a minor rebellion among the Seris and Tepocas in 1729–30, there was little evidence of unrest during his tenure as captain of the Villa de Sinaloa.¹⁶

Soon after rising to the office of governor-for-life, Huidobro gave his reforming zeal free rein. On January 22, 1734, he issued an *auto de visita*, announcing his plan to visit all the missions in the new province of Sinaloa and Sonora. He aimed to suppress laziness and vagrancy, form militia companies in the region, open up roads and pathways, look into allegations that idolatry persisted among mission Indians, examine the labor practices and finances of each mission, and make sure the Jesuits were not abusing the Indians in their care. This call for social, political, and economic renewal echoed, with the clarity of a bell, the reform program of Philip V. Like the king and his reforming ministers, Huidobro sought to promote commerce and communications, suppress religious archaism, and undermine the Jesuit missions.¹⁷

A revolt in Baja California prevented Huidobro from carrying out these ambitious plans. In October 1734 the native people of southern Baja California rose in rebellion against the Jesuit missionaries there. Huidobro soon received orders from the viceroy to abandon his visitation of the Sonoran missions and suppress the rebellion in California. Huidobro arrived on the far coast of the Sea of Cortés in December 1735, bringing with him a force of Spanish troops and Yaqui auxiliaries and leaving the administration of Sinaloa and Sonora to his underlings.¹⁸

Huidobro's course of action in the early years of his tenure as governor was unsettling. He issued an incendiary statement of his intentions and then left before carrying them out. He inflamed the hopes of those who stood to gain from the reforms and the fears of those who stood to lose. In the governor's absence, all parties began to take matters into their own hands. Miners and ranchers who wanted Indian labor tried to profit from Huidobro's assertion of political jurisdiction over mission Indians. Indians who wanted to try their fortunes outside the mission system began to petition officials in the new

government. Indians who preferred life on the mission were alarmed. And Jesuits, whose livelihood and sense of moral purpose depended on the extension of the political status quo, felt gravely threatened by the new regime.

REVERBERATIONS OF REFORM

The first echoes of Huidobro's reformist *auto de visita* were heard in the fall of 1735. Miners from San Antonio de Padua came to complain both to Huidobro and to Don Miguel de Quirós y Mora, the *alcalde mayor* of Ostimuri. They needed Indian laborers, they said. The Jesuits had ignored orders from the governor and the *alcalde mayor* that the Yaqui mission supply workers. In response, miners and settlers began to encourage Indians to present themselves before secular officials to complain that the Jesuits were restricting their movements and meddling in village politics.¹⁹

Yaquis began to exploit the emerging divisions among the Jesuits, settlers, and secular government. In 1735 the Yaqui governors Juan Ignacio Jusacamea, also known as Muni, and Bernabé Basoritemea went to complain to the *alcalde mayor* of Río Chico about Jesuit abuses. These two leaders would play a critical role in the events of the next five years. Jusacamea was born around 1703 and was the flag bearer (*alférez*) of a militia from the Yaqui town of Rahum, elected by the townspeople and confirmed in his office by Juan Bautista de Anza. He held the office for four years and alluded to his service in the suppression of uprisings among the Seri, Tiburón, and Baboroco peoples. Jusacamea had until recently been governor of Rahum. Basoritemea had a similar career and was connected to Jusacamea by ties of *compadrazgo* and shared militia service. He was older than Jusacamea by fifteen years but had served under Jusacamea's command in a Yaqui militia. He was married to a woman named Polonia Baossa, spoke Spanish, and was a mule driver by trade. He had until recently been governor of the Yaqui town of Huirivis.²⁰

The background of these men revealed a great deal about them and about the movement they would come to lead. Both Jusacamea and Basoritemea had much experience living outside the Yaqui mission. Both had served as militia soldiers, and Basoritemea must have traveled widely in the north of Mexico as a driver of mule trains. They were not backward-looking defenders of tradition against innovation and outsiders. They were comparable to the worldly *cabe-cillas* of the Mexican Revolution, like the mule driver Pascual Orozco and the ex-militia officer Pedro Crespo. These were leaders of rural resistance who gained contacts outside of the mission and perhaps prestige within it through their extensive travels.²¹

Jusacamea, Basoritemea, and the *compadres* who accompanied them to Río Chico were aggrieved over the behavior of three related groups. The Jesuit missionaries, Yaquis allied with them, and *coyotes*, people of mixed Indian and African ancestry brought to the missions as servants by the Jesuits. At some point in 1735–36 the captain general of the Yaqui mission removed Jusacamea and Basoritemea from the governorships to which they had been duly elected. Captain General Don Cristóbal de Gurrola, a Yaqui allied with the Jesuits, used his proximity to the priests to abuse his office. He allegedly whipped and imprisoned people unjustly, burned the bows and arrows of Yaqui militiamen, and generally acted like an arrogant bully. Gurrola and the coyotes treated their Yaqui enemies like slaves, stealing their goods and their freedom. Some even took Yaquis' tools from them in order to make it impossible to work their fields.²²

The coyotes were especially offensive to Jusacamea and Basoritemea. The coyotes Juan Frías, Ignacio "El Barrigón" Alipazaga, Simón Hernández and his son José Manuel, Gaspar Álvarez, and the mulatto Juan Manuel Samana served as sacristans and mayordomos to the Jesuits. They used their proximity to the missionaries to coerce the Yaquis to do their bidding. Some Yaquis complained that the coyotes conspired with Gurrola and the Jesuits to usurp Yaqui lands.²³

Alcalde Mayor Miguel de Quirós and other settlers encouraged the Yaquis to take their complaints to the Villa de Sinaloa in August 1736 to complain to Governor Huidobro. Huidobro, however, was in Baja California at the time, leaving his lieutenant Manuel de Mena to investigate. By chance Mena met Jusacamea, Basoritemea, and their party as they traveled to the provincial capital, and he instructed them to return to their homes and wait for him there.²⁴

Mena's actions in the Yaqui Valley were impulsive, shortsighted, and corrupt. They would have an abiding place in Yaqui collective memory for at least a decade. When Mena arrived at Potam, the Yaquis welcomed him with their customary ferocity. Armed warriors from Potam, Rahum, and Huirivis came out and escorted Mena into town. There, the Yaquis gave Mena provisions for his visit, including wine, bread, fruit, and other gifts. Mena then went to visit the Jesuits. Fathers Reynaldos, Fentanes, Duque, and González plied Mena with pearls and other valuables. By his sixth day on the Yaqui mission, Mena had turned against the deposed Yaqui governors. At the Jesuits' prompting, Mena ordered the imprisonment of the principal complainants. Jusacamea and his father, Vicente, were taken prisoner along with Basoritemea and their allies Juan Pinto, Juan Calixto, Juan Chichiali, Nicolas Cupé, Cristóbal Guairomea, and three men identified only as Melchor, Cristóbal, and Marcos. Mena interrogated them and demanded that they say they were forced by Alcalde Mayor

Quirós to make their complaint. When they denied that Quirós had put them up to anything, Mena threatened to bring them before the high court of Guadalajara. He even suggested that they might be stoned to death. In the meantime Mena kept the prisoners locked up and sent word to Río Chico that the *alcalde mayor* should come to Potam.²⁵

Word of these events soon reached the Yaqui leader Luis Aquibuameachay, who immediately set about organizing resistance to the imprisonment of Jusacamea, Basoritemea, and their followers. Some two thousand armed Yaquis from the towns of Potam and Vicam congregated around the *casa de comunidad* where their leaders were imprisoned. Aquibuamea's force came with bows and arrows, banners, and drums. Their roars for the freedom of the imprisoned men terrified Mena. When Jusacamea asked if he could speak to the crowd and try to calm them, Mena quickly agreed. Jusacamea appeared before the assembled warriors in chains. The crowd shouted that they did not want speeches and would not leave until the jailed men were freed. Jusacamea managed to calm them, however, as he spoke to them at length in the Yaqui language, saying their presence would probably not help the imprisoned men. If it came to armed conflict, the Spanish would probably kill the prisoners first, he said. Jusacamea said they all would be released if the crowd dispersed. The crowd did disperse, and sure enough all the prisoners were set free the next day. In October 1736 Jusacamea and Basoritemea were restored to office.²⁶

This was a critical moment in several respects. It taught vivid lessons in power politics to all who witnessed it. Yaquis learned that the Jesuits were at odds with elements of the secular government. They learned that the secular government was often willing to hear and support Yaqui complaints against the Jesuits but was also prone to corruption, indecision, and cowardice. Perhaps most important, they learned that a Yaqui populace united in threatening violence could exercise a powerful influence over its own destiny. Jusacamea and Basoritemea may not have been representative of all Yaquis' political ideals and aspirations, but their mistreatment at Mena's hands solidified the support of a large sector of the Yaqui population. Witnesses to the events of the next ten years would point to the protest, capture, and release of the deposed governors as a turning point in Yaqui relations with the Jesuits and secular government. A Jesuit named Ignacio María Nápoli, who would later distinguish himself both for his Machiavellian insight into mission politics and his contempt for insubordinate Yaquis, wrote, "Of course it is prudent to retreat in order to conquer later, but I must add a pained sigh at their being left triumphant." The result of Mena's releasing of the captives was, wrote Nápoli, "total disobedience to the ministers of Christ, disrespect for royal justice, and mortal hatred of whites

[*gente de razón*].” The governor of Potam, Ignacio Mauricio de Osuna, testified in 1741, “From the moment they surrounded the Señor Teniente General Don Manuel de Mena in the town of Potam, the signs of the rebellion, and the intention of the Indians, were evident . . . and from that time, they remained without obedience or punishment, which the Governor did not impose on them due to his opposition to the padres.” Osuna was one of dozens who testified that the successful challenge to Mena planted the seeds of insurrection.²⁷

The region’s miners soon took action in response to the deepening divergences between the Jesuits and the governor. A group of them signed a letter to Viceroy Vizarrón repeating the age-old claim that the Yaquis had long been fully acculturated to Catholic ways and that the Jesuits held onto their missions for purely financial reasons. The miners accused the Jesuits of reaping obscene profits from their monopoly on Yaqui labor. They said the Jesuits had poisoned acting governor Mena against them. The Jesuits had convinced Mena to imprison Alcalde Mayor Quirós, who had first given credence to the complaints of the Yaquis. Vizarrón did not order the secularization of the Yaqui mission, as the miners hoped, nor did he impose tribute payments on the Yaquis. But on March 26, 1737, he ordered that Quirós be freed and declared that the Indians were free to come to Mexico City to complain to him directly.²⁸

The Jesuit reaction to this ruling was immediate and furious. The Jesuit Diego González countered with an impassioned critique of the miners and their misuse of Yaqui labor. Writing from the Jesuit Colegio Máximo in Mexico City, he claimed that the “Catholic Kings” wanted above all that Indians live in an orderly, rational way, as part of the mystical body of Christ. The crown and the law maintained the salvation of Indian souls to be the first priority of the government of Spain’s colonies. The law held that only 4 percent of able-bodied workers on the missions should be sent to work in Spanish enterprises and only on the condition that their work be carried out near the missions, in places with a moral atmosphere similar to that of the missions. Royal law demanded that Indians be compensated for their work and not be kept from home too long. The miners of Sonora flouted these restrictions, González wrote, sweeping through the missions, demanding far more workers than they had a right to. The Jesuit wrote that Indians lived far from home, in mining towns that were cesspools of sin and where no priest knew their language. Without the benefit of the Mass and the moral guidance of the clergy, mission Indians soon followed the lascivious example of their Spanish employers. González argued that the settlers’ exploitation of the Indians was far worse than anything the Jesuits were accused of: the miners paid their workers in clothing rather than money, failed to pay for the workers’ transportation to and from the mines, and burdened

Indians with advance payments that placed them hopelessly in debt. They further exploited the Indians through legal tricks to confiscate Indian land and to sell them foodstuffs far above market value. The Jesuits did not profit from their missions, wrote González, but merely used the products of mission lands to sustain themselves and the impoverished mission Indians.²⁹

González's letter gave eloquent expression to the Jesuits' dismay at the advent of Bourbon rule. Under the lax oversight of the Habsburgs, the Jesuits had a free hand to negotiate their political and religious relationships with mission Indians. The Bourbon government now wanted to intrude on these relationships and in some cases even destroy them. In the eyes of the Jesuits, this attempt to bolster the structures of empire and to stimulate the imperial economy represented an assault on the religious ideals that justified the very existence of the empire itself. In the eyes of at least some of the Yaquis, the changes at work in the imperial government represented an opportunity. Navarro García notes that the conflicts of 1736 constituted the first contacts between Yaquis and miners who shared a grievance against the Jesuits: "It is no wonder that contacts were made between vecinos desirous for easier access to Indian labor, and some of the most discontented Yaquis, disposed to escape the authority of the ministers of the missions." This nexus of settler and Yaqui interests would torment the Jesuits throughout the 1730s.³⁰

As the Bourbon reforms brought about deep shifts in the balance of power among all parties in the northwest, they also brought changes in the nature of the imperial ironies at the heart of this book. As had happened in the first sustained encounter of Yaquis and Spaniards over a hundred years before, the Yaquis responded to changing circumstances by launching a hard-edged campaign of threat-backed negotiation with the forces of empire. But by the eighteenth century the Yaquis knew vastly more about the way the empire operated than they had in the 1610s. They appealed to far-distant officials, they made demands on the basis of long service in the colonial military, and perhaps most meaningfully they knew how deeply divided the Spanish were among themselves. The ability to recognize diversity, complexity, and shades of political difference among members of a foreign people represents a momentous step forward in one group's understanding of another. Many Spaniards had also taken that step. In the months after the Yaquis' armed protest to free their imprisoned leaders, government officials tried to fathom the origins of Yaqui discontent. They would question dozens of Yaquis in depth and carefully weighed commonalities and differences among the testimonies they heard. As was the case a hundred years earlier, the Spanish sought to overcome their small numbers and isolation by virtue of wit, improvisation, and force rather

than by force alone. Yet their methods were now vastly subtler than the mingled kindnesses and barbarities of Captain Hurdaide. Violence and negotiation were still intertwined whenever the Yaquis dealt politically with the Spanish. But in the 1730s the dealings took place against the background of a hundred years of collaboration. The cues that could spark violence between Yaquis and empire were not naked attempts at domination or revolt but differences and misunderstandings over the terms and nature of the alliance.

CONTROVERSIES OVER IGNACIO MARÍA NÁPOLI

The Jesuit Diego González was well suited to make his order's case in Mexico City. He wrote with passion and wit, he knew the relevant legal precedents, and he had recently lived among the Yaquis. But González's absence when he went to the capital left a gap on the Yaqui mission. A new Jesuit was needed to replace him, and on March 3, 1737, father Juan Antonio Oviedo appointed one. Oviedo wrote from Mexico City to Ignacio María Nápoli in Baja California. Nápoli had been a missionary there since 1734, when he followed Governor Huidobro on his campaign to suppress the rebellion. Nápoli had seen two fellow Jesuits die in the violence and had sustained an injury to his shoulder. He was in poor health and needed rest. But Nápoli had also developed a reputation for toughness and resolution that made him seem like the right man to take on insubordinate Yaquis like Jusacamea and Basoritemea.³¹

These two were serving, respectively, as governors of Rahum and Huirivis when Nápoli arrived. Conflict flared up almost immediately. The experience of defying Mena and the Jesuits seems to have galvanized the Yaquis. Jusacamea and Basoritemea seemed more confident than ever of their rights and prerogatives, and their self-assurance struck Nápoli as being insolent. The flashpoint of conflict between Nápoli and the Yaquis was the provisioning of the California missions. Nápoli accused various Yaquis of having stolen eight hundred pesos' worth of clothing bound for California. He thought Basoritemea failed in his duty as governor to investigate the theft and in fact had protected the thieves. Nápoli was thrown into a rage when he saw that Basoritemea, who had adopted the principle that Indians should dress like and be treated like Spaniards, was wearing silk stockings and high-heeled shoes that had been stolen from the California supplies. Nápoli was further enraged when he found out that Yaquis were selling maize grown on church lands as if it were their own.³²

When Nápoli confronted Basoritemea and Jusacamea, they said the king was rich and would not miss the clothing he had sent to California. The king, they said, had taken many things from them in the past, so it was fair to steal

from him. When Nápoli tried to talk them out of their arrogance, they slapped the table in anger and said they feared no man. It was their fearlessness that most troubled Nápoli. The Yaqui governors would not acknowledge what Nápoli regarded as his natural superiority. In a further act of defiance, Jusacamea refused to come to Nápoli's house when summoned there. Rather, he sent a message to Nápoli saying the Jesuit knew where he, Jusacamea, lived, and if he wanted to talk he could come find him. Nápoli wrote that Basoritemea treated him not like a father but like a "child pupil." Jusacamea and Basoritemea seemed to have been emboldened by their confrontation with Mena. They had demanded and received respect from secular authorities and now wanted the same from the Jesuits.³³

The various conflicting accounts of the ensuing events coincided in a single fact: Jusacamea and Basoritemea left political office. Whether or not their abdication was voluntary was a matter of dispute. A group of Spanish pearl divers signed a letter on October 20, 1737, claiming they had stopped at Nápoli's house a week before and found the Indians of Rahum, Potam, and Huirivis in an uproar. The pearl divers said the cause of the commotion was Jusacamea's proposal to begin paying tribute to the crown; the people of Huirivis were unanimous in not wanting to do so. The Yaquis who opposed paying tribute said they had barely enough to eat, let alone pay a new tax. They asked Nápoli to reason with Jusacamea, and the Jesuit agreed to do so. Nápoli asked Jusacamea to remain in office but to forget his ideas about paying tribute. According to the pearl divers, Jusacamea quit his office in a rage, throwing the governor's staff down onto a chair. Nápoli then said a Mass to prepare for the election of Jusacamea's replacement. A literate Yaqui known as Maestro Pinto presided over the nomination of three candidates by the townspeople of Rahum. Juan Turimea, whom the pearl divers described as "a very respectful Indian," was elected governor.³⁴

Nápoli wrote that something similar happened in the case of Basoritemea. He left office willingly, in this case because Huidobro had called for new town governors to be elected every year. Nápoli then said Mass, and the people of Huirivis elected Diego Marquina, a nephew of Basoritemea. Basoritemea, however, was not pleased with any of this and took matters into his own hands. Nápoli wrote that settlers from the town of Río Chico encouraged Basoritemea to fight back, and he did so by vandalizing Governor Marquina's house and seizing the staff of office back from him.³⁵

Yaqui leaders aligned with the Jesuits supported this version of events in a letter dated November 12, 1737. Captain General Cristóbal de Gurrola, Governor Juan Turimea of Rahum, Governor Diego Marquina of Huirivis,

Governor Joseph Vuitemea of Potam, and all the *alcaldes*, *tenientes*, *fiscales*, *topiles*, and *justicias* of the said pueblos claimed that Jusacamea and Basoritemea were inciting rebellion and spreading lies. The most pernicious of these was that the Yaquis wanted to secularize the mission and pay tribute to the crown. They also said that Basoritemea and Jusacamea were too powerful for them to quell. Yaqui allies of Nápoli and the Jesuits wanted to punish the rabble-rousers, but they were afraid to do so since they did not know if crown officials would back them. This letter testified to the dispersed, negotiated nature of power on the Yaqui mission. As the Yaqui defiance of Mena had shown, the maintenance of order on the Yaqui mission depended on the collaboration of the Jesuits, Yaqui officials, and the secular government. None of these factions could rule without the aid of the others.³⁶

Basoritemea and Jusacamea walked from Huirivis to the Villa de Sinaloa on November 29, 1737, to present a radically different version of events. Martín Cayetano Fernández de Peralta had taken Mena's place as acting governor and turned a more sympathetic ear to the complainants than his predecessor had. The dissident governors complained of the slanders and abuses of Mena and the evil rumors Nápoli had spread as a pretext for removing them from office. Nápoli had removed them from office, they said, for the single reason that they did not want to abuse other Yaquis. The men elected to replace them were all too willing to do so. Turimea, newly installed as governor of Rahum, was a cruel adulterer, and Marquina was a backstabbing gossip who threatened to chop off the complainants' heads if they appealed to outside authorities. Captain General Gurrola had gone so far as to threaten to stone them to death. Jusacamea and Basoritemea said they knew the king was the protector of Indians, and they asked Peralta to remove Nápoli from the Yaqui mission.³⁷

Peralta's response was circumspect. He sent one letter to Huidobro in California to inform him of the latest events and another to Don Manuel Gaspar de Flores, an official in the town of Baroyeca, ordering him to look into the allegations. He also ordered Flores to restore Basoritemea and Jusacamea to their governorships. Finally, he wrote to the Jesuit vice-rector of Sinaloa, Andrés García, asking him for his point of view.³⁸

García responded in similarly politic fashion. He sent word to Nápoli that the deposed governors had come to complain about him in Sinaloa and that Peralta seemed to be listening to them. He told Nápoli to cooperate with Flores's investigation and to calm the malcontents on the Yaqui mission however he could. García also instructed Nápoli to establish a legal paper trail documenting his every move in the matter. García's letter bore striking witness to the negotiated quality of mission politics when he suggested that in the

absence of an official judge Nápoli should certify his actions before the Yaqui town governors and captain general. In this matter the Jesuits vested Yaqui officials with the power and authority of judges. García then wrote to Peralta, reiterating Nápoli's version of events and warning that if a rebellion ensued among the Yaquis, the Jesuits could not be blamed for it. García seems to have gathered that Peralta was sympathetic to the complaints of the Yaqui governors and so informed Nápoli of this fact. In this second letter he told Nápoli to bring together all those Yaquis who opposed Jusacamea and Basoritemea in order to testify before Flores when he arrived. Nápoli received more detailed advice from the Jesuit Antonio Estrada, who suggested he should first welcome Flores cordially but should then tell him to suspend the restoration of the deposed governors. If Flores refused, Nápoli should say he was bound to work for the calm and order of the communities in his charge and would send word to his superiors that they should argue the case before the viceroy. In this smooth, politic fashion, Nápoli could resist efforts to restore the deposed governors to power by playing on Flores's fears of civil unrest and personal embarrassment.³⁹

Flores began his investigation on arriving in Rahum on December 19, 1537, with an interpreter from Río Chico. From there he proceeded to Huirivis on the twenty-first, where he talked with dozens of Yaquis of all stations and political affiliations as well as with the Jesuits and the coyotes allied with them. On the basis of this investigation he wrote a detailed report on the state of affairs in the Yaqui towns, which he sent to Peralta on December 30. Flores wrote that about thirty Yaquis greeted him in Rahum. This group included Gurrola, Maestro Pinto, and Turimea, and they all agreed that Jusacamea willingly left the office of governor. Nápoli, they said, then convened a meeting in Rahum's church to elect a replacement. Despite the fact that the meeting included many women and only a few men, they went ahead with the election. Nápoli proposed Turimea as an experienced, capable candidate, and those present elected him governor without any undue pressure from Nápoli.⁴⁰

They went on to say, however, that they knew Jusacamea wanted his old office back and that they were eager for him to return to it. Turimea was a fine governor, they said, but Jusacamea was better. Flores asked Captain General Gurrola if he had any reason to think Jusacamea was an insubordinate troublemaker. Gurrola said he did not: Jusacamea had been blameless in his activities as governor. Gurrola went on to say that Nápoli was a fine priest and had caused no one any distress.⁴¹

Support for Jusacamea became more intense the next day. Flores said some five hundred Yaquis came to express their support for him. They said the king had sanctioned Jusacamea as governor, and they knew that Peralta had ordered

his restoration to office. As for the election of Turimea, they said that many did not know an election was being held and so had no part in choosing him. Asked once again how they felt about Nápoli, they claimed to be happy with his good administration and his charity. If ever Nápoli had been angry with Jusacamea or other Yaquis, they blamed it on the vicious gossip of individuals like Maestro Pinto and Juan Page. Flores asked Jusacamea for his opinion, and he said he had left the office of governor out of anger with Nápoli but had done so with the proviso that he was going to confer with Acting Governor Peralta. Flores had a final conversation in Rahum with the non-Yaqui vecino Gaspar Álvarez and the coyote Ignacio Alipazaga. They followed Nápoli's line, saying Jusacamea was a troublemaker by nature and should not be returned to office. Flores informed the people of Rahum that he could not reinstate Jusacamea as governor until he consulted once again with Peralta, then moved on to the town of Huirivis.⁴²

In Huirivis, Flores met first with Governor Marquina, three elderly ex-governors of the town, and twenty-six other townspeople, all of whom supported Marquina. They knew Flores came with orders to restore Basoritemea to office, but they said Peralta had been misinformed. They said it was true that Nápoli had removed Basoritemea from office and that Marquina had been elected to replace him. Asked why Basoritemea had been deposed, they responded that this had happened because Basoritemea had been disobedient to Nápoli.⁴³

These voices were soon drowned out in a flood of support for Basoritemea. Six hundred people appeared to express their desire that Basoritemea be returned to office. Asked why Basoritemea had been deposed, the crowd roared that there was no good reason for it. They wanted him returned to office, since he had treated them well as governor and had administered justice fairly. Flores proposed that a new election be held to choose a compromise candidate. The crowd rejected the proposal out of hand and said no one but Basoritemea would please them. Then, unexpectedly, Basoritemea's father emerged from the crowd and said he was saddened to see his son embroiled in such controversy. Basoritemea himself said that he would renounce his desire to be governor in order to please his father. The crowd, however, refused to accept his resignation and clamored for his return to office. Flores demurred, telling the assembled Yaquis that he could render no decision in the matter until he spoke once again with Acting Governor Peralta. He then removed to Baroyeca to write his report.⁴⁴

Throughout Flores's visit the Yaquis expressed a preference for continuity and consensus. They thought Jusacamea and Basoritemea were good governors and wanted them to return to office. But they also held Nápoli in high esteem.

They did not share the deposed governors' contempt for the man who had removed them from office. They did not want Nápoli to go. Their support for Jusacamea and Basoritemea was premised not on their enmity toward Nápoli but on the skill and fairness of the two deposed governors.⁴⁵

On December 30, 1737, the Jesuit Andrés García wrote to Nápoli that Peralta would not restore the deposed governors to office until he received orders from Huidobro to do so. In the meantime García told Nápoli to solicit testimony from as many Yaqui enemies of the deposed governors as possible. Nápoli did this and more, writing to Peralta to defend himself. He knew Jusacamea and Basoritemea were on their way to Sinaloa once again and wanted to preempt them.⁴⁶

The impression the deposed governors made in the Villa de Sinaloa must have been a powerful one. They arrived at nine in the morning on January 14, 1738, followed by a train of thirty-one mounted Yaqui warriors carrying weapons, flutes, and drums. When Jusacamea dismounted, an assistant removed his spurs and tied up his horse. The whole Yaqui embassy then formed two lines and marched in lockstep to see Peralta. Peralta welcomed the Yaqui embassy and named Juan de Cota and Cristóbal Ruíz as interpreters. Over the course of three days of testimony Jusacamea and Basoritemea recounted the deceptions of Mena and the slanders of Nápoli and the coyotes. They spoke of Nápoli's removal of Basoritemea from office and of Jusacamea's resignation over the slanders against him. They added that the people of Rahum and Huirivis were disgusted with the replacement governors. Turimea had burned the weapons of his Yaqui enemies, a grave offense to men who had served as soldiers of the Spanish crown.⁴⁷

The testimony of the deposed governors revealed much in what it left out. Jusacamea and Basoritemea expressed no radical rejection of the imperial state. These were not insurrectionists like the Pueblo insurgents of 1680, who fought for the annihilation of all things Spanish. Basoritemea and Jusacamea couched their protest in the form of a petition to a royal official. Their complaint was against the infringement of time-honored privileges granted by the king to the Yaqui towns. They wanted to retain their right to elect leaders without undue interference from the Jesuits, the right to avail themselves of royal courts in the event of a crime or offense, and the right to bear the weapons they used in the king's service. The dissident governors would later amplify these demands. But here and in all their petitions they sought benefits for themselves and their own communities within, not outside, the changing framework of imperial government. Changes in imperial policy toward Indians caused a storm of political and legal activity among the Yaquis. The protests of the 1730s expressed the

Yaquis' will to defend their interests and expand their freedoms. But these protests also presupposed a long-standing negotiated relationship with the empire and indicated how finely attuned the Yaquis were to the complexities of imperial policy toward Indians.

The new Bourbon campaign to empower indigenous litigants placed new and confusing stresses on local officials. Acting Governor Peralta was paralyzed by the decision he faced after hearing the claims of the dissident Yaqui governors. Much of the testimony they presented was corroborated by Flores's report. Peralta was also aware of the government's dependence on the Yaquis: he wrote, "They are a very profitable nation because they are on a frontier with the Pimas and Seris. . . . The Yaquis have helped the royal arms in all the invasions that have occurred, in which they have always demonstrated their loyalty." He went on to praise the Yaquis for their work in the region's mines.⁴⁸

Yet the Jesuits threatened to excommunicate Peralta if he reinstated Jusacamea and Basoritemea as governors. Peralta hoped that Huidobro would resolve the problem on his return from California, and consequently sent the deposed governors back to their hometowns with an ambiguous ruling. He ordered that Jusacamea and Basoritemea be reinstated as governors but that they were suspended from the office. They did as Peralta ordered. Then, unexpectedly, they prostrated themselves before Nápoli on March 10, 1738, and asked for his pardon. They said they had been wrong to appear before Peralta. What motivated this sudden reversal of attitude is impossible to know. Whatever the motive, Nápoli did not believe the apology was sincere, and the deposed governors soon resumed their protests against him.⁴⁹

HUIDOBRO RETURNS AND THE CRISIS DEEPENS

Governor Huidobro returned from Baja California to Sinaloa in June 1738, arriving in the Yaqui Valley on July 1. He received letters in the town of Potam from the most prominent Yaqui opponents of the deposed governors. The Yaqui town governors Marquina, Turimea, and Juan Mateo Buimea as well as the Yaqui captain general Gurrola wrote to accuse the deposed governors of disobeying and disrespecting Nápoli. The governors alleged that Jusacamea and Basoritemea threatened their enemies, stole church goods, and failed to attend Mass. Yet certain aspects of the letters of accusation raised Huidobro's suspicions. Though the supposed authors were illiterate, the letters were written in the ornate Castilian style of a highly educated European. Marquina, for whom Spanish was a second language, was supposed to have written the following:

I, Diego Marquina, cacique, current governor of the Pueblo of Huirivis, present myself before your highness, and I tell you that, having been elected by all the natives of the said pueblo, together and congregated, at the touch of a bell, with the intervention of my Father Minister and the captain general, . . . I met with a group of Indians who do not live in the pueblo, but rather in the wilderness and swamps, captained by Bernabé Basoritemea, the outgoing governor, who made me come out to the community with them and into the *cabecera*.

In order to establish the authenticity of the letters, Huidobro questioned all four of their supposed authors. Gurrola expressed shock on hearing the words attributed to him. He swore that Jusacamea and Basoritemea had never given him reason for complaint and that Nápoli was in no danger. All rumors of rebellion, he said, were false. Turimea, Buimea, and Marquina also expressed astonishment at the content of the letters bearing their names.⁵⁰

Over the course of the investigation, Huidobro discovered that Nápoli had concocted the letters himself with the help of the coyote Alipazaga and a Spanish vecino of Potam named Don Juan María de Alcalá. They had folded the letters up without reading them to the men whose names they bore and then simply handed the letters over for delivery to Huidobro.⁵¹

Huidobro was convinced that Nápoli and his henchmen had conspired to deceive him. Having failed to do so, Nápoli wrote a long, impassioned indictment of Jusacamea and Basoritemea, trying to obliterate the memory of his own lies with fiery rhetoric. Indeed, if Nápoli had not been caught in a lie, he would have been a powerful advocate for his cause. A Sicilian Jesuit with wide experience working in terrifying conditions, Nápoli enjoyed the respect of his fellow Jesuits. Throughout the crises of the 1730s and 1740s he received letters of support from his colleagues. Nápoli was also trusted in matters of critical importance. He was given the task of supplying the nascent California missions with produce from the Yaqui mission lands. He maintained strong relationships with elements of the Spanish military throughout his career and may have met the famous conquistador Captain Juan Bautista de Anza during his stay in Baja California. Anza too was an admirer of Nápoli and sent him an ardent letter of sympathy when Nápoli asked him for help in his dealings with the Yaquis. The captain was unable to help Nápoli, however, since the Yaqui mission lay outside of his jurisdiction. Nápoli's cordial relationships with conservative military men were based on shared contempt for Indians.⁵²

This and several other aspects of Nápoli's personality emerged clearly in his correspondence. He was relentlessly aggressive in his pursuit of what he thought were the Jesuit order's best interests. He did not stop short of slandering his

enemies and lying to crown officials when he saw fit. His polemic against Jusacamea and Basoritemea also revealed a deep belief in the sanctity of social and ethnic hierarchy. When those he considered socially inferior acted as if they deserved respect, Nápoli regarded it as an appalling rupture in the social fabric. He was astonished when Jusacamea and Basoritemea received support from royal officials. When crown officials favored mere Indians over Jesuits, Nápoli saw it as a step toward the crumbling of all social order.⁵³

Nápoli pointed to Mena's failed imprisonment of Jusacamea and Basoritemea as the origin of all the ensuing evils. He wrote that the Yaqui mission was the "master key" to the whole region. The missions of California, he pointed out, could never survive without supplies from the Yaqui pueblos. If the Yaquis rebelled, the threat to the royal treasury would be grave. The Yaquis, Nápoli wrote, had sung their triumph over Mena in rhymed couplets. Many of them lived out in the hills and swamps, against the king's wishes. They had no fear of Spanish arms and no respect for Captain General Gurrola. Since defying Mena, Basoritemea, Jusacamea, and Luis Aquibuameachay had become a "diabolical trinity." Many Yaquis had kneeled before Jusacamea and worshipped him as a god. Nápoli wrote in a mood of indignant terror that the deposed governors wanted to live in the same dissolute conditions as their ancestors had enjoyed under Moctezuma. The "Demon" possessed them, and they wanted nothing more than to live under "Mohammed's Law." What provoked Nápoli so deeply? His main concern was the refusal of certain Yaquis to accept a humble station in society. Nápoli listed a series of offenses that followed from this refusal. They would not accept whipping for their crimes. They wanted to "govern" their priests, the missions, and their lands. They said they would expel Nápoli if he did not do their bidding. They even denied the Jesuit the right to have any servants from outside the Yaqui pueblos. Rather, the Yaquis gave Nápoli a servant who was a nephew of Jusacamea's and who read Nápoli's mail and spied on him. They demanded that Nápoli give them a daily count of the mission's sheep in order to keep the Jesuit from doing what he pleased with mission livestock.⁵⁴

Nápoli referred to this reprehensible behavior as "being a man" (*hombrearse*). The implication was that Indians were not men but children and that their acting with the dignity and self-regard of an adult was offensive. Jusacamea often accompanied Nápoli to church without removing his hat. Both Jusacamea and Basoritemea had sat down in the Jesuit's presence and had presumed to suggest that they eat with him. They tried to thwart Nápoli at every turn as he tried to supply the California missions. They stole cattle, sheep, and clothing from stores intended for California. In a telling statement of his impotence,

Nápoli said neither he nor anyone in the Yaqui missions dared reproach the offenders for these crimes, as their power and menace were too great. Nápoli attempted to mollify Huidobro by confessing that he had sent for help from Anza. He only did so, he said, because all the secular officials of Sinaloa and Sonora seemed to favor the rebels. He alleged that the Yaquis had boasted that they could do to Huidobro what they had done to Mena if he stood in their way. If any outsider tried to dominate them, they would rise up and put him in chains. Nápoli depicted Jusacamea and Basoritemea in tones intended to terrify. In his portrait, they strutted about in Spanish clothing brandishing swords and rifles. They celebrated their triumphs with thunderous drums and piercing flutes, dancing with all the diabolical splendor of a witches' sabbath. It was a Jesuit's nightmare. Nápoli thought Jusacamea and Basoritemea adopted all the worst aspects of both Spanish and Yaqui culture. They flaunted the haughtiness of Spaniards along with Spanish weapons and symbols of status. Yet at the same time they displayed all the worst kinds of Indian wildness, disrespect for the law, and reverence for the devil.⁵⁵

How much of this was true? Nápoli's letter was written with all the hyperbole that terror and prejudice could inspire. Yet there were elements of it that had the ring of truth. The insurrection Nápoli predicted did, in fact, occur. As Nápoli said, Jusacamea and Basoritemea were fiercely protective of their right to elect town officials without Jesuit interference. They were proud of their service as militiamen in the empire's battles with the Pimas and Seris. Nápoli's letter described Yaqui leaders who wanted to adopt and adapt the best elements of the colonial culture they had inherited. They wanted commerce with the outside world and the rights, respect, material culture, and tools of the Spaniards. They also wanted to enjoy the culture, language, and political distinctiveness of the Yaqui people. And in later episodes they revealed a desire to practice a religion embracing both traditional Yaqui dance and the Catholic Mass. More than anything else, the protests of the dissident Yaqui governors revealed a Yaqui society deeply interwoven with the colonial culture surrounding it.

Huidobro was inclined to agree with the dissident governors in many ways. He was skeptical of Nápoli's claims, especially in light of the fraudulent letters Nápoli had produced to deceive him. On July 22 Huidobro read a letter from the viceroy aloud in the plaza of Potam. Captain General Gurrola and the governors of Potam, Huirivis, and Rahum heard the viceroy's written condemnation of Mena's conduct and his reaffirmation of the Indians' right to complain to him directly in Mexico City. These were proclamations that supported the claims of the dissident governors and undermined those of Nápoli and his allies among the Yaquis and coyotes.⁵⁶

Huidobro then summoned Jusacamea and Basoritemea to testify on their own behalf. They renewed their complaints against Nápoli and his allies, decrying Nápoli's demands that they work for him, forcing them to cultivate the land without pay or tools, and whipping them when they failed to do his bidding. Jusacamea added that a rancho of his had been taken on the pretext that he had stolen some cattle. This rancho was now in the hands of the church. He further complained that he had been whipped for losing a key that everyone knew to have been lost by the son of the coyote Simón Hernández.⁵⁷

Huidobro read out the charges Nápoli made against him, and Jusacamea denied them all. He said his only offense was going to complain in Río Chico and that he was incapable of the kinds of "heresies" of which Nápoli accused him. Huidobro asked Jusacamea to respond to the charge that he failed to remove his hat and greet Nápoli as they passed one another in the road. Amid the somber tedium of the court documents, Jusacamea's answer had the glitter of a gem. He admitted that something of the kind did happen, and he could understand why Nápoli got the impression he did. But he failed to greet the Jesuit and remove his hat only because he and the soldier Sebastián de Acosta were looking for the lost scabbard to Acosta's sword. Their eyes were fixed so intently on the ground that they did not see Nápoli. They meant no offense.⁵⁸

Basoritemea echoed much of Jusacamea's testimony but elaborated on the sins of the coyotes. He claimed that the coyote Juan Frías abused his power, whipping Indians without cause, and forcing whatever women he chose to "accede to his foul appetites." Women were also forced to work on church lands in harsh conditions in order to supply the California missions. The Jesuit Diego González ordered Yaqui craftsmen to make a spiked staff with which to torture and punish Yaquis. Asked about Nápoli's allegations against him, Basoritemea denied most of them and mitigated others. He said that Nápoli had illegally removed him from office and installed Marquina as governor. Nápoli justified these actions by accusing Basoritemea of refusing to whip certain Yaquis alleged to have stolen clothes meant for California. Marquina had neither the desire nor the right to be governor, said Basoritemea. For that reason the people of Huirivis rose up and took the staff of office from him and gave it back to its rightful owner.⁵⁹

Huidobro also questioned Aquibuameachay of Rahum, the leader of the armed protests against Mena. Aquibuameachay reiterated the complaints of the deposed governors against Nápoli and added several crucial details. He said that the assets of the Yaqui mission were in unprecedented demand. The mission had sent between five and six hundred head of cattle to California, two to three hundred head to Álamos, and an equal number to the Villa de Sinaloa,

in addition to cattle that had been given to *alcaldes mayores*, *tenientes*, and others. Asked why he had led the armed protest against Mena, Aquibuameachay said he did not do so out of disrespect for royal authority. Rather, since he and his followers were militia soldiers who had always been prompt in the service of the crown, they would command more respect from the royal authorities if they came armed, he said. It is difficult to know precisely what he meant. Did he mean that Mena would feel obligated to the Yaqui militias out of gratitude for the services they had rendered? Or did the armed throng of shouting Yaqui militiamen simply threaten violence? The evidence was not clear. Perhaps Aquibuameachay intended a combination of both messages: we deserve gratitude and respect for our military service; if we receive neither gratitude nor respect, we will take vengeance.⁶⁰

As the depositions continued, Nápoli and his allies suddenly changed course. Nápoli appeared before Huidobro alongside Marquina, Turimea, and Buimea. The three governors resigned their offices, and new elections were called the next day. On July 31, 1738, Andrés Betem was elected governor of Potam. On August 1, Jerónimo Goy was elected governor of Rahum. Nápoli objected, as was his legal right, and Huidobro named Juan Mateo Utemea—referred to elsewhere as *el maestro Pinto*—to be governor. Pablo Bobot was elected governor of Huirivis on August 5, and Juan Mateo Buimea was elected governor of Vicam the next day.

Why Nápoli took these actions is not clear. Perhaps by calling new elections he hoped to confer greater legitimacy on his chosen candidates than had been enjoyed by those he proposed before. Whatever the case may be, this rapid chain of events answers some questions and raises many more. The records of Huidobro's visit disclosed more vividly than any other colonial documents the inner workings of Yaqui town politics. A group of around fifty men from each pueblo appeared in each of the pueblos' *casa de comunidad* and presented three or so candidates for the governorship. The nominating group then voted on the candidates, and if there was a draw, as happened in the case of Jerónimo Goy, lots were drawn to determine the winner. The town's Jesuit had the right to reject the winner if he so chose, in which case the captain of the Villa de Sinaloa could select a replacement, albeit with the consent of the voters. Thereafter, subordinate officials were named: *teniente*, *alcalde*, *topil*, *alguacil*, *ministro de vara*, and others. It was unclear in the documents who, exactly, did the naming. But in each case, Huidobro asked for and received the consent of the assembled voters.

These documents uncover the basic structures of Yaqui community government in the mature colonial period. Much as a high wind blows sand away

from the ruins of an ancient palace, revealing its outlines and perhaps a cracked inscription, so these documents revealed the outlines and a few fascinating details of Yaqui political institutions. This government depended on the consent of many disparate groups from within and outside the communities: the Jesuits, the secular government, and the Yaquis themselves, each of which were further subdivided into a myriad of factions. This delicate political structure was carefully balanced, easily shattered, and reassembled only with great difficulty. It was at once dependent upon and productive of relationships of trust. When any of the interested parties defected to pursue their own interests at the expense of the others, the possibility of chaos loomed. Other questions remain unanswered. Why did all the parties involved accept the new governors? And where were Jusacamea, Basoritemea, and their supporters in all this? According to the Spanish historian Navarro García, this was the moment at which Huidobro prevailed upon Jusacamea and Basoritemea to exercise their right to travel to Mexico City and petition the viceroy in person.⁶¹

LEGAL VICTORY AND POLITICAL BREAKDOWN

Ignacio María Nápoli was, as it turned out, singularly ill suited to the tasks he was assigned. His clumsy attempts to suppress dissent among the Yaquis provoked them to ever more vigorous and radical dissent. His attempts to deceive the secular authorities into supporting him led those authorities to dismiss his cries for help when things really were getting out of control. Nápoli's job was made all the harder by government pressure on the Jesuit mission system itself. The crown was carrying out the long-held wishes of Franciscans, miners, and other settlers by secularizing Jesuit missions to the south. The Jesuits responded by expanding their activities in Sonora and California, an enterprise that placed great pressure on the resources of the Yaqui mission. Only a Jesuit with enormous energy and political skill could have succeeded in Nápoli's position. Nápoli did not lack energy, but he had all the political skill of a cornered bear.⁶²

Governor Huidobro granted permission to Jusacamea and Basoritemea to travel to Mexico City to petition the viceroy in October 1738. The interpreter Felipe Tacococay and five others accompanied them. Their absence from the Yaqui pueblos, which at first seemed to have resolved the conflict, only aggravated it. The Jesuits claimed a conspiracy was afoot in the summer of 1739, and Huidobro sent Juan Pedro Maldonado to investigate. If Huidobro was skeptical of Nápoli's allegations, Maldonado's report could only have made him more so. Maldonado sent word that there was not the slightest sign of incipient revolt.

He reported that Nápoli had coached witnesses to support his claims and then threatened Maldonado with excommunication when it became clear that he thought no revolt was brewing.⁶³

There was more to anger Huidobro and the miners. Joseph de Acedo, the *alcalde mayor* of Ostimuri, reported to Huidobro that Nápoli refused to sell Yaqui corn to outsiders who needed it—or rather, he claimed he could not sell it but then secretly did so to a favored few. Nápoli claimed to be destitute, but Acedo reported that Nápoli had dozens of Yaquis working for him in the enterprise of supplying the California missions. This also happened to make it impossible, the Jesuit said, to spare any Yaqui laborers for work in the mines. Not content to alienate the secular government, Nápoli enraged many Yaquis by dismantling silver altarpieces and sending crosses, candelabra, and chalices from the Yaqui mission churches to those of Sonora and California. In attempting to save mission valuables from a revolt that had yet to occur, Nápoli only hastened the coming of violence.⁶⁴

Though Nápoli was at once devious and rigid, Maldonado was a fool to dismiss his warnings. Nápoli coached witnesses in trying to prove that violence was imminent, yet there was overwhelming evidence that Nápoli was right. In June and July 1739 Nápoli received the testimony of various Yaquis and Spanish *vecinos* about crimes in the pueblos of the lower Yaqui Valley. A sixteen-year-old Yaqui named Gerónimo confessed to having dug a hole in the adobe wall of the priest's house in Belén and removed various church ornaments. He then turned these over to Antonio Basoritemea, the brother of the absent Bernabé.⁶⁵

Antonio Basoritemea and other allies of the dissident ex-governors cut up the decorative lace and velvet stolen from the church and made clothing out of it. They then flaunted it before the eyes of the Jesuits. Asked why this was done, Gerónimo and other witnesses claimed they had received a letter from Jusacamea in Mexico City informing them that the viceroy had taken the Yaquis' side in all their complaints against the Jesuits and placed three gold crowns on his head. (The coyote Alipazaga asked, quite logically, "If he has only one head, where did he put the other two crowns?") The letter purportedly said the Jesuits had power only to baptize children, say Mass, and minister to the dying. But all their claims to political and economic power were void, Jusacamea supposedly wrote, and the Yaquis should do all they could to run the Jesuits out of the missions.⁶⁶

The followers of Jusacamea and Basoritemea had tried to recruit the residents of Belén to their cause but had failed. They stole Belén's church ornaments as revenge. They salted these wounds to the Jesuits' honor by dancing a *matachín* while wearing the stolen cloth. They danced before the padre's eyes

and through the pueblos of Huirivis, Rahum, and Potam. A Yaqui named Juan Sichimse testified that he had heard the residents of Rahum and Huirivis say that father Nápoli was not from their pueblos, had no lands there, had no fathers or grandfathers from there, and for these reasons had no right to live there.⁶⁷

On August 28, 1739, on a visit to Potam, Nápoli and his fellow Jesuit Bartolomé Fentanes received the most chilling news yet. At ten that night the Jesuit Miguel Fernández came from Huirivis, where he was doing business for the California missions. Six boys accompanied him, as did a Spaniard from the Real de Álamos named Francisco Marcello Morales. They said the Indians of Huirivis and Rahum were gathering arms in order to kill all the coyotes of the river and then to hunt down the coyotes of Baroyeca. The coyotes of Huirivis fled in terror and passed through Potam later that night. They informed the Jesuits there that they were going to take refuge in Torim. Rumors flew that the Yaquis had plans to kill all the vecinos of Álamos and take their children as slaves.⁶⁸

In a letter of September 2, 1739, Nápoli wrote to a Jesuit colleague in Mexico City that unrest on the Yaqui missions was growing worse by the day. The Indians were brandishing arms and threatening the Jesuits and coyotes with death. The Spaniards all seem to side with the rebels, he wrote, and the Jesuits were left to their plight. He made a request for money and asked that the Jesuits do all they could to detain Jusacamea and Basoritemea in Mexico City. Nápoli may have intended to keep the dissident leaders away from their followers and so retard the uprising. The effect was the opposite. The absence of Jusacamea and Basoritemea convinced many Yaquis that they had been assassinated and that all-out war was the only solution to the conflict.⁶⁹

This failure of communication tilted the situation toward violence at precisely the time that the dissident governors' appeals to the law were at the brink of triumph. In July 1739 Jusacamea and Basoritemea presented a petition to the viceroy with fourteen demands: They wanted to be declared innocent of all the charges brought against them; that Nápoli, González, and the coyotes be expelled from the missions; that Mena compensate them for their unlawful imprisonment; that they be allowed to bear arms; that their labor be fairly paid for and their lands respected; that their elections be freed from Jesuit meddling; and that their work on mission lands be reduced. They wanted to be able to sell their produce and labor freely to whomever they wished, and they wanted Miguel Quirós to become the protector of the Yaquis. Finally, Jusacamea requested that the rancho expropriated by the Jesuits be returned to him. The crown attorney moderated some of these requests and forwarded them to Viceroy Vizarrón, who acceded to them all on February 26, 1740. The Jesuits

objected to the viceroy's ruling and successfully delayed a final disposition for months. But at that point it was too late to prevent the Yaqui Valley from spiraling into violence.⁷⁰

The intentions and ideologies of the main non-Yaqui actors in the 1730s are relatively easy to discern. Like his sponsors in the Bourbon government, Governor Huidobro worked to marginalize the Jesuits, to streamline government functions, and to bring about a major shift in the relationship between the government and its native subjects. The Bourbon reformers wanted native peoples to participate more actively in the political and economic life of the colony, as producers of agricultural goods and workers in colonial mines and enterprises. This did not mean that the reformers abandoned their commitment to European supremacy. But it did mean that they were willing to show native people greater respect, allow native people greater freedom, and, more than ever before, lend stronger support to native people in their complaints about priests. Government support for Yaquis like Jusacamea and Basoritemea was a means of effecting changes in the nature of colonial power. By expanding the rights and privileges of Indians at the expense of priests, officials like Governor Huidobro sought to make the laws of commerce, rather than the laws of the church, the most powerful forces governing the lives of native peoples.

Jesuits, by and large, represented a reactionary force in the early eighteenth century. They saw themselves as besieged by a government that disrespected their achievements in the civilizing of savage native tribes, and accordingly they did everything they could to protect what they had built over the previous century. Jesuits like Ignacio María Nápoli advanced a vision of colonial society in which priests represented a gilded link in a mystical chain of paternal authority stretching from the godhead down through pope, king, viceroy, priest, sacristan, all the way to the lowliest Indian. The unequal, yet reciprocal, relationships at every point in the hierarchy were suffused with familial emotions. Jesuits saw their relationships with Indians as those of fathers and children. When insubordinate Yaquis began to find a receptive audience in royal courts, the Jesuits felt viscerally that the most sacred bonds between fathers and their political sons were under attack. In Jesuit eyes, the insubordinate behavior of their native wards was undermining the sacred order of the universe. Worse still, they thought, Yaqui delinquents were being abetted by fools in government. Faced with such existential threats, the Jesuits worked furiously to thwart the Bourbon revolution in government and to keep Indians in line.

The desires and ambitions of the Yaquis in these years are more difficult to define. This is not only because of their unequal representation in the written

sources, though that is certainly a problem. It is also because of the diversity, eclecticism, and sophistication of Yaqui political thinking. There were certainly those who longed for continuity with the past. In a violent and unpredictable world, there are always people like Cristóbal de Gurrola, the Yaqui captain general, who prefer an unequal stasis to what they imagine to be an egalitarian chaos. But even those who were not eager for change could be galvanized to act by official corruption. The five thousand Yaquis who rose to protest the imprisonment of the deposed governors were not all instinctive revolutionaries.

The deposed governors, Jusacamea and Basoritemea, were interested in political change, but their ambitions were complicated, ironic, and resistant to easy classification. They wanted reform but were not interested in overturning the colonial order. They never called for the expulsion of Jesuits from Yaqui lands. Their concerns were both local and supralocal: they wanted clean town elections and respect for personal property, while at the same time pressing for expanded trade outside the mission and recognition for their service as militia soldiers. The manner in which the deposed governors made their demands was as meaningful, and ambiguous, as were their stated objectives. Their willingness to travel long distances to engage with imperial institutions implied knowledge about the power such institutions had over local communities and about the opportunities held out by changes in imperial policy. The pomp and ceremony with which these Yaqui militiamen dismounted and marched to see the acting governor signaled to all that they were men who knew they deserved respect.

The issue of respect was central to their demands and was tied in complicated ways to the issue of violence. Though armed conflict erupted only after the departure of Jusacamea and Basoritemea for Mexico City, the possibility of violence hung in the air at every moment of legal confrontation. Yaqui demands for respect provoked revulsion among Jesuits, who saw them as a violation of social order. Yaqui crowds threatened violence when Manuel de Mena imprisoned the deposed governor. The lockstep approach of the Yaqui militiamen to the residence of Acting Governor Peralta was a vivid reminder of the kinds of organized violence the Yaquis were capable of. Jusacamea and Basoritemea represented sophisticated reformism backed by threats of violence; defense of community and political tradition linked to a strategic interest in deepening ties to the empire; an iron fist of political ambition in a velvet glove of diplomacy and litigation. The measured change the deposed governors worked for and the measured aggression with which they pursued it reflected long experience in grappling with the empire. They and their more radical successors would continue to draw on the experience of mingled violence and negotiation that had characterized mission life since the early seventeenth century.

“NOW GOD WANTS ALL THIS TO END”:
THE SHATTERING OF THE COLONIAL
PACT, 1740–1744

Where *fortuna* and *virtú* do their damndest, only the details reveal the reason
for the result.

—John Womack, “*The Mexican Revolution*”

On January 21, 1740, a black slave named Francisco Parralo told Governor Huidobro the tale of his captivity among the Yaqui rebels. Placed under oath and interrogated in the mining town of Álamos, Parralo recalled his journey out of Sonora carrying one hundred marks of silver for his owner, Francisco Rojo. Riding south with a train of three mules toward Rojo's home in Culiacán, Parralo was assaulted by five hundred Yaquis in a place called El Sauze, near the Mayo River. The rebels took the silver and supplies Parralo was transporting and were at the point of killing him when one of the rebels took pity on him and let him go. Parralo had heard of another band of Yaqui rebels in the area, so he fled inland toward the sierras. Traveling by night on back roads, he came to the town of Tepahui, some eighteen miles up the Mayo River, not realizing that the inhabitants of this town were also in revolt. They captured and beat Parralo and held him for three days. They took him to the Mayo town of Camoa and then to another Mayo town called Tesia. There he was pressed into service as a slave of a Yaqui rebel leader named Nicolás and was given the role of drummer for the rebel army. He stayed with the rebels for several weeks more and learned much about the rebel movement. He told Huidobro that a Yaqui from Rahum named Juan Calixto Ayamea had become the leader of the rebels and that Ayamea was convinced Huidobro had murdered the Yaqui governors who had left to plead

their case in Mexico City. (They would in fact return unharmed later in 1740.) The rebels had taken revenge for Huidobro's supposed betrayal by sacking numerous towns near the Yaqui River and killing dozens of Spaniards. Ayamea and his men planned to besiege Álamos, where Governor Huidobro was now gathering his forces. Huidobro must have been alarmed to learn that the rebels' fondest hope was to capture him and to force him to run barefoot to the Yaqui mission and there to whip him in retaliation for all his supposed misdeeds.¹

Asked about the methods and motives of the rebels, Parralo told a frightening tale. The rebels called Ayamea their captain general, and his word was law among the Yaquis, Mayos, and other peoples in rebellion. Parralo made it clear that the rebels were both highly organized and had a distinctive cultural agenda. Each rebel town had named captains and other military officials. "Their constant occupation," Parralo recalled, "is to dance and sing in celebration of their victories with spoils taken from Spaniards they have killed, such as their scalps." The rebels stole cattle and church decorations and made sacred vestments into women's clothing: "The enemies make church decorations into garments, and their women use sacred albs as shirts." Rebel women adorned themselves with "valuable clothing, pearls, wrought silver, mirrors, . . . and other decorations." Such violence and mockery were dreadful for government officials to hear about, but they were not terribly difficult to understand. The rebels were incensed at Huidobro's betrayal and were systematically destroying and degrading everything the settler government held dear.²

Yet certain elements of Parralo's narrative complicated the picture. He said there were many Spanish prisoners among the rebels but that few of those prisoners had shown much desire to escape the rebels' clutches. Indeed, some captives had joined with the rebels in their raiding expeditions. Evidently, the rebellion was not aimed specifically at Spaniards, and rebel communities were quite willing to welcome non-Yaquis. Parralo said there was a Jesuit named Antonio de Estrada living among the rebels. The rebels "treat him with great reverence," Parralo recalled, but "they do not permit him the slightest liberty, such that he can only do what they want. The padre has control of nothing whatsoever in the missions." The rebels never laid down their arms, Parralo said, and even brought their weapons with them to Sunday Mass. The Yaqui rebels were armed to the teeth as they listened to Estrada's sermon, their bodies painted red for war, and their heads adorned with traditional fox fur hats. Parralo concluded his testimony with an account of his escape from the rebel forces in the midst of a skirmish with Spanish soldiers.³

Parralo's narrative captured many of the ironies of the insurrection of 1740: despite their violent methods, the rebels shared the experience and political

aspirations expressed in the legal petitions of Jusacamea and Basoritemea. Like them, the rebels drew on a century of alliance with the empire during which both violence and negotiation were ongoing. Both the absent governors and the rebel leaders were militiamen with broad experience outside the Yaqui mission and, as Parralo testified, had formidable abilities in the organization of soldiers. Both the absent governors and the rebel leaders demanded respect from colonial authorities and strove to humiliate all those who denied it to them. And both expressed a kind of sophisticated ambivalence toward the symbols of Spanish colonial power: they reveled in the ornate filigree of Catholic ritual and wove elements of native culture into it, while at the same time stifling the clergy's aspirations to political power. The Mass described by Parralo was an eloquent representation of the desires of petitioners and rebels alike: they wanted to remain a part of an imperial Catholic community, but they wanted control over the ways in which they participated in it. They wanted to hear Mass, but they wanted to do so with their bodies painted for war and bearing weapons that symbolized their privileged status within colonial society. This kind of measured participation in the imperial community was what both the legal petitioners and the rebels aspired to. Diverse and eclectic though it was, the rebel movement never attempted to kill or expel all Spaniards and thus cannot really be described as anticolonial. The unifying desire of rebels was rather to seize control of relations with the empire and to get maximum profit from it.

THE POLITICAL BANDITS ATTACK

In February 1740 the settler Don Nicolás Feliz Romero found that several head of cattle were missing from his rancho in Aquihuiquichi, nine miles southeast of the Yaqui mission. Romero pursued the thieves to the nearby rancho of Cabora, where he found the missing animals and accused the rancho's *mayordomo* of the theft. The *mayordomo*, an Indian named Agustín, denied having committed the crime and implicated a group of Yaquis camped nearby. Romero let the *mayordomo* go free, and soon Agustín returned with a man he claimed was the thief. Romero bound the thief but was soon confronted by a party of sixteen Yaquis from Bacum armed with bows and arrows, their bodies painted red for war. They freed the bound man and disappeared into the countryside. A Mayo named Javier Francisco Jusacamea was the only one of the thieves to be captured and punished, receiving twenty-five lashes on February 19, 1740.⁴

Joseph de Acedo, the Spanish captain of the mining town of Ostimuri, received further chilling news on February 25 from the *estancia* of Miguel

de Lucenilla. Gregorio Hurtado, the mayordomo of this property, reported that armed Indians had stolen a herd of thirty sheep from the rancho of Tosimuri. He said that armed Indians had also stolen sheep from the rancho of Vasitos, the property of a settler named Don José Campoy. A letter from the mayordomo of Vasitos, an Indian known as Piedras Verdes, seconded the allegation. Acedo recruited fourteen armed men to travel on horseback to the rancho of El Cajón, where the thieves had reportedly taken the sheep. There is no record of the result of this expedition, but it did not suppress the banditry.⁵

The settler Francisco Javier Campoy wrote on March 7, 1740, that things were getting worse. Yaquis armed for war had stolen sheep from his rancho and had also stolen a new mule. The vecinos Don Juan Feliz and his brother Don Gerónimo confirmed all this on March 10, testifying before Acedo that armed Indians had occupied the rancho of Vasitos and were terrifying everyone with their drumming and war songs. The Yaquis shouted, "Kill them" when they saw the Feliz brothers and whipped a cowboy named Rafael and the mayordomo Piedras Verdes. Acedo wrote to Governor Huidobro on March 12, telling him that Yaquis of Bacum were stealing entire herds of cattle, horses, and sheep and were threatening death to all who tried to stop them.⁶

A mulatto named Pedro Nolasco testified before Acedo that he had traveled with a group of Indians who had set up camp in El Cajón but who subsequently had moved to the canyon of Xicatampo, where there was a better supply of water. Nolasco, an unmarried slave owned by Doña Rosa de Flores, said that of the many Indians in the raiding party, he knew only a few: the leader, Martín of Cocorit, Francisco Elocano, also of Cocorit, another Indian named Pablo, an unnamed Apache or Eudeve cripple, a man Tomás and his brother, both from Huirivis, and a man named Chocomuji, who had been implicated in earlier raids. There were about fifty men in total, with wives and children, he said. They sent out raiding parties of about a dozen men each morning, and these parties returned at dusk with two or three horses, which they would slaughter and eat. "In their conversations," Nolasco reported, the raiders said they "would wait only until holy week to see if their relative Muni [Juan Ignacio Jusacamea] came back, and if not, they would have to kill all the Spaniards, and until then they only would rob." Nolasco's testimony underscored the intimate connections between the political struggles of the 1730s and the banditry of early 1740. The bandits were acting partly out of retaliation for perceived mistreatment of Yaqui leaders. As was the case before, violence and negotiation were bound together. The robberies, threats, and violence this group was visiting on the vecinos were, in essence, acts of political speech.⁷

The settler Gerónimo Feliz wrote to Governor Huidobro to express his horror over these events, saying that Acedo did nothing to stop the depredations of the rebels. When "a multitude" of Yaquis had come and stolen his livestock, wrote Feliz, his sister-in-law had confronted them in tears, holding up a print of the Virgin of Loreto and crying to heaven for mercy. A hundred Yaquis later attacked the rancho of Vasitos and kidnapped cowboys, mayordomos, and a servant. They stripped the prisoners naked, hogtied and whipped them, then celebrated all night in the corral, slaughtering and feasting on the rancho's cattle. Rafael de Robles, one of those whom the Yaquis bound and whipped, said the Yaquis danced till dawn and in the morning took the mayordomo, Piedras Verdes, and his wife, their tools, and chickens with them as well as four herds of sheep and thirty cows. The rebels took captive the wife of the settler Agustín Valenzuela, along with Cristóbal Moreno, and Tomás the cowboy. The Yaqui Luis de Paicolitta of Cocorit and the Mayo Agustín, alias el Siboli, of Cuirimpo, led the bandit-rebels. Siboli left Vasitos with the warning that the whole Yaqui River was up in arms. As if this were not enough to terrify his victims, he said the apocalypse was at hand. Many vecinos were on the verge of fleeing the region in terror. Gerónimo Feliz himself was resolved to stay and fight and asked for Huidobro's support.⁸

Acedo in the meantime sent word to Cristóbal de Gurrola, the Yaqui captain general, to come with eighty armed men for service at the Rancho of Yorijiobe. While he waited for Gurrola, Acedo took a smaller group to track the rebels. They found campsites with smoldering cook fires and the carcasses of slaughtered animals as well as footprints heading for the Yaqui River—but no rebels. Acedo arrived in Baroyeca, a mining town between the Yaqui and Mayo Rivers, on the eighteenth and found out the next day that Lajas and Yorijiobe had been attacked.⁹

The Yaqui attack on Feliz's rancho in Yorijiobe brought about the first armed confrontation of 1740. Juan de Salas, a soldier on patrol near the Mayo River, reported from the hacienda of El Mezquite on March 20 that Feliz had come to him in distress. Salas said that a group of Yaquis and Mayos had come to Feliz's rancho in Yorijiobe, taken it over, and threatened to burn it down with his family inside. Salas took eight men to the rancho and found that the attackers had tried to set it on fire and then had left. The fires had yet to do any serious damage, but the Indians had broken the door down and stolen everything inside the house, leaving the trunks empty and taking twenty-five fanegas of maize, a quantity of meat, and some two hundred pieces of cheese. Salas learned that the attackers had moved on to the house of Juan de Arce and had taken it over. This house was less than a league away, so Salas led his men there,

warning them to make no sign of wanting war. The plan, he said, was simply to tell the thieves to return everything they had stolen and thus avoid a fight.¹⁰

This plan did not last long. Salas and his men spotted the thieves roping horses in Arce's corral. Fifty Indians immediately took up their arms and rushed out to confront the approaching soldiers. Salas ordered a retreat to a nearby hill. The Indians gave chase, and once they were in the open, Salas and his men turned to confront them. The soldiers killed several rebels and injured most of the rest, who then fled. Santiago de Hollón, a servant of Gerónimo Feliz's, was killed in the fray. Of Salas's men, Miguel de Aro, Manuel Germán, Ignacio María Báez, Nicolás de Acuña, and Sebastián de Acosta were all hurt, Acosta sustaining a life-threatening injury to his face.¹¹

Huidobro soon received word of this battle in the Villa de Sinaloa and wrote back ordering Salas to contact Ignacio Valenzuela, the captain general of the Mayo mission, and command him to bring the bandits to heel. Huidobro then sent eight men to deliver powder and ammunition to Salas and dispatched orders to Álamos and the fort of Montesclaros to send thirty men each. Salas, on receiving Huidobro's letter, moved to the Mayo town of Camoa on March 25, where he awaited the governor.¹²

Meanwhile, Acedo was gathering his forces in Baroyeca. He had sent for reinforcements from various nearby communities but had gotten bad news from the Yaqui town of Rahum. A man named Gabriel de Santa Cruz wrote that he had tried to recruit soldiers there to reinforce Acedo's troops but had found it to be impossible. Evil Yaquis had, he said, convinced many Yaquis to flee to the sierras, and of the three men willing to go help Acedo, one was a spy for the rebels. He described the Yaqui captain general Gurrola as a good person but a bad soldier and a worse leader. Troops under Gurrola's command had spoken often of their plan to abandon Acedo after joining him.¹³

When Gurrola arrived in Baroyeca with twenty-seven soldiers on March 23, he offered a different account of events on the Yaqui River. He said all was calm there, though many people were hungry and had gone to the countryside to hunt and gather food. He admitted that there were and always would be a few evildoers in a nation as numerous as the Yaquis, but he thought that generally all was well. The Jesuit Patricio Imaz expressed a darker view. In a letter of March 24 he informed Acedo that the pueblo of Tepahui could not provide any troops because so many of its people had fled to the countryside. Imaz said that many foreign marauders had joined forces with former servants of the Spanish and were using the canyons of Salitre as a base for plundering expeditions. On April 2 twenty more Yaquis arrived in Baroyeca, bringing to forty-seven the number of men under Gurrola's command. Acedo ordered Gurrola to take

the twenty new men to join Captain Salas to guard the Mayo town of Camoa. The remaining twenty-seven Yaquis were to stay with him in Baroyeca.¹⁴

Between March 25 and April 17 Salas was in Camoa investigating the spread of lawlessness. He questioned the captains general of the Yaqui and Mayo Rivers, Gurrola and Ignacio Valenzuela, as well as Marcos Obomea, governor of the Mayo town of Santa Cruz, and Manuel Quijano, a man born in the Philippines. In the midst of these investigations Gurrola appeared out of the countryside with el Siboli, the man known to all as the leader of the rebels, and turned him over to the Mayo governor of Cuirimpo, Siboli's hometown. Yaqui families began to appear in Camoa with articles stolen from Gerónimo Feliz. They turned over an image of the Holy Virgin, a staff, church ornaments, and various other articles, but none of the stolen food, which had all been consumed. The families then headed for the Yaqui Valley, the captains general escorting Siboli with them. About a league into this journey, however, Siboli shouted, "Come out, my Yaqui *compañeros*, surround these people and take them." Seeing the number of attackers, Gurrola and Valenzuela let Siboli go. All those Yaquis friendly to the Spanish fled back to the Yaqui pueblos. Gurrola, evidently shocked that so many Yaquis were in rebellion, informed Salas that Siboli was the only Mayo among the rebels and that all of Siboli's followers were Yaquis.¹⁵

THE INSURRECTION SPREADS

On April 6, 1740, the Jesuit Ignacio Duque wrote from the Yaqui mission of his desperate hope that the government would at last heed the warnings of the Jesuits. The insolence of the Yaquis, so widespread and so threatening in the past, was only deepening now, he wrote. Duque pleaded with Alcalde Mayor Acedo to believe him when he said he had heard the Yaquis making plans to rebel. They were preparing to attack near the Mayo River in order to draw Spanish forces there and then to launch a larger attack near the Yaqui River. The Jesuit Bartolomé Fentanes seconded these claims, saying the Yaquis had lost all respect for God and his priests. He said he had seen groups of Yaqui cattle thieves meeting with Pimas on the north shore of the Yaqui River and planning the extermination of the non-Indians in Baroyeca. Fentanes had sent six Indians with a breviary to try to calm the rebels north of the river, but they had disappeared, and Fentanes feared they were dead.¹⁶

Whether his emissaries were dead or not, Fentanes himself had good reason to be afraid. At eleven a.m. on April 17 some three hundred Yaquis, organized into two squadrons and painted red for war, marched into the town of Bacum

and headed for the Jesuit's house. They said they were coming for the padre and planned to take him to Navojoa. They placed Fentanes on one of the horses they had brought with them, whereupon Fentanes requested that some mules be brought to carry his bed and other possessions. The captain of Bacum said, "No, Padre, the soldiers have already taken your bed and saddlebags." The warriors then whipped the Jesuit's page, the mayordomo of a rancho, and a justicia of Bacum. At the sound of a trumpet they formed two lines and marched to an outlying rancho with the Jesuit in tow. The witness to these events, a coyote named Juan Ignacio Romero, said he knew those involved and that most of the attackers were from Bacum, though he recognized a few from Cocorit.¹⁷

In the confusion of the next few days Fentanes apparently arrived in the Mayo town of Navojoa, where he met with the Jesuit Manuel Díaz. The Mayos of Cuirimpo came to ask that Díaz come to their town, and Fentanes accompanied him on this journey along with Salas and forty soldiers. But when they arrived at the Mayo town of Tesia on April 23 they found the town's residents armed and painted red for war. Díaz tried to calm them, but they seized him and threatened to kill him if Salas or any of his soldiers tried any action against them. They then exchanged Díaz for two hostages, Valenzuela and Francisco Naguilachay, captain of the Mayo town of Cuirimpo. These two seem to have been the Mayo counterparts of the Yaqui Gurrola: Indians appointed by crown officials who retained some loyalty to the colonial power. As such, they were enemies of the rebellion and thus were held captive. After Salas had retreated, Valenzuela and Naguilachay were stripped naked, tied up, whipped, beaten, and transported to the north shore of the Mayo River. There they were handed over to Calixto Taquelachay of Bacum, a rebel leader.¹⁸

Padre Francisco de Aldámez offered an analysis of the previous week's events to Governor Huidobro on April 28. He wrote that certain Yaquis from Bacum and Cocorit had approached him and asked him to speak on their behalf to Huidobro and to tell the governor they were not among the evil group that had been terrorizing the Jesuits and vecinos. Aldámez noted that the rest of Sonora was at peace but that the Yaqui River was "all drums and arrows." He suggested that the return of Juan Ignacio Jusacamea, "Muni," would calm the Yaquis and bring order to the Yaqui Valley—a further indication that the robberies and kidnappings of 1740 were connected to the political struggles of the 1730s. They were the violent face of the protests expressed legally and politically by Jusacamea and Basoritemea.¹⁹

Governor Huidobro made his first foray into the war zone in late April and early May 1740. He set out from the Villa de Sinaloa on April 20 and reached

the fort of El Fuerte soon thereafter. Around the twenty-fifth, Huidobro received a letter signed by the Jesuits Díaz, Estrada, and Fentanes raising the alarm that the Yaquis were in revolt. Huidobro mustered ninety soldiers and, in preparation for the coming conflict, he ordered that the residents of Camoa, Tesia, and Navojoa come together and swear their obedience to him. He took an ambiguous position toward the rebels, declaring that all those who did not come and swear obedience would be considered guilty of rebellion—but also making it clear that the rebels would not be punished. In this way, he hoped, “the largest part of the Yaqui people would lose their fear and would render their obedience.” Here and throughout the coming months Huidobro demonstrated extreme reluctance to resolve matters by violent means.²⁰

Huidobro received conflicting reports on April 29. Joseph de Acedo wrote that some one hundred Yaquis from Potam and Huirivis had volunteered for service against the rebels and that the rebels to the north of the Yaqui pueblos were preparing to surrender. The Yaqui Martín Guitorimea had written to Acedo, “From now on, we will be good sons to you . . . and so that our Justicia Mayor will pardon our sins for the love for God, from now on we want to serve you, and to die as good Catholic Christians with quietness and calm.” Yet the settler Gerónimo Feliz sent more disturbing news. Writing from the rancho of Mesquite, he said that enemies had descended on his property and stolen 140 mules and 150 horses. He and his men had given chase, but the rebels had attacked them with arrows and wounded several of his men, one seriously.²¹

In testimony before Huidobro, Nicolás Feliz seconded his brother Gerónimo’s dire assessment and provided an analysis of the unrest and its origins:

[Feliz] said that the foundation of the present uprising was laid many years ago in these parts, since . . . the malevolent Indians of the pueblos of the [Mayo] River and that of the Yaqui, do not want to live subject to the obedience of the father ministers and justicias. They do not meet their obligations as Christians and vassals of the King our Lord; they always gather in various places in the swamps and areas between the two rivers, and from there they continually steal cattle and horses from the vecinos and owners of the ranchos in this vicinity. This has been more extreme since January of this year.²²

The testimony was a further indication that the thieving, threats, and violence of the spring of 1740 had a political edge. This may seem an obvious point, but it is an important one given that the uprising of 1740 has been called “an uncoordinated series of disturbances” stemming from hunger and political

disarray. Hunger played into the uprising of 1740, but political concerns were more important; 1740 was a chaotic year, but many rebels had strategic goals.²³

Trying to assess the strength of the rebellion, Huidobro made a census of the Mayo towns of Tesia, Navojoa, and Cuirimpo on May 4. He then summoned the native elders of both the Yaqui and Mayo Rivers to warn them to remain calm in their towns and to continue their lives in an orderly fashion. Representatives from the Yaqui towns came on May 10 to express their tearful repentance and humility before the governor. Apparently satisfied with these declarations, Huidobro sent ten men under Salas's command to patrol the Mayo River. Huidobro then withdrew to Ba'royeca.²⁴

Soon after Huidobro arrived in Ba'royeca on May 10, he heard that violence had broken out on the Mayo River once again. Rebels took their cue from Huidobro's passivity. According to Valenzuela, fifty rebel Yaquis came from the mining towns of Batopilas, Norotal, and Sivirijoa to the Mayo town of Santa Cruz. Their leader was a Yaqui from the town of Bacum who called himself Juan Ignacio Jusacamea Muni, who had declared himself to be "King, Pope, God, and Virgin." This information came from a Mayo witness hostile to the uprising and echoed the demeaning analysis of Jesuits who thought that Indians who failed to submit humbly to colonial rule aspired to being messianic dictators. Nevertheless, Valenzuela's testimony established further links between the legal battles of the 1730s and the violence of 1740. The leader of the rebels took the name of the dissident Yaqui governor Jusacamea and claimed titles for himself that displaced existing authorities.²⁵

THE DEVASTATION OF HIPÓLITO ÁLVAREZ

The rebels shared many of the same motives as the deposed governors, but they used far harsher methods than anything seen to date. In early May Huidobro ordered a soldier named Hipólito Álvarez to lead thirty presidial troops to search for a rebel hideout in the swamps near the Mayo River. If they found any rebels, Álvarez and his men were under orders to return them to their pueblos with a minimum of violence. After various detours through depopulated villages and ranchos, they reached the Mayo town of Santa Cruz on May 13. Álvarez and his men were alarmed to find it full of armed men painted red with war paint and gathered under a threatening flag. Anticipating a fight, Álvarez ordered his men to change to fresh horses. An Indian named Bautista came out to greet the cavalymen. He asked Álvarez if they came in peace or wanted war, to which Álvarez responded that he came on a peaceful mission from Governor Huidobro and only wanted to return them to their pueblos. He

said he had no interest in a fight. Álvarez had a letter from the governor stating his mission, and he showed it to Bautista. Bautista had a relative read it to him and then went to the largest group of Indians to apprise them of the letter's contents. He returned to Álvarez and said his people were alarmed that Álvarez's men were changing horses, which they rightly interpreted as a preparation for war. Álvarez improvised, saying he always told his soldiers to change mounts when they got to a town so that their spent horses could graze and rest. Álvarez nevertheless ordered his men to stop what they were doing in order to calm the Indians.²⁶

The Yaquis then lowered their war flag and raised a flag announcing peace. Bautista invited Álvarez and his men to come, unarmed, to talk with the rebels. Álvarez later testified that he told his men to stay where they were and to hold on to their arms and that he went alone and unarmed to make peace with the rebel leaders. But a pardo witness named Julián de la Parra testified that Álvarez ordered his men to disarm and that they did so before going over to the Indians. The Indians, armed to the teeth and painted red for war, embraced the unarmed soldiers and said, "Now we are friends, now we are at peace, let the four men who are guarding the horses come and greet us too." In an act of staggering gullibility, the soldiers did as the Yaquis asked, whereupon a group of rebels took possession of the soldiers' horses and weapons. Huidobro would later rebuke Álvarez for his "execrable" performance as commander.²⁷

Bells began to toll, and two women emerged from the town church of Santa Cruz bearing images of Jesus and the Virgin. The rebels ordered Álvarez and his men to kneel, bow their heads, and to pray to the images. The rebels then informed the captive soldiers they had no priest to say Mass and to baptize or marry the residents of the town. They ordered Álvarez and his men to leave their weapons in trust with them and go to Conicari to get padre Miguel Fernández Somera and bring him to Santa Cruz. Bautista assured the soldiers that their weapons would be kept safe under lock and key. That afternoon at four, Álvarez and his men were provided with horses and a guide and were directed toward Echojoa, where they arrived after evening prayers. Thus ended the rebels' tour de force of intimidation and deceit. They controlled the dialogue through their emissary Bautista, kept their intentions secret, and were studiously brazen and unpredictable. By the end of the day, without striking a blow, they had reduced Álvarez and his men to impotent bundles of confusion.²⁸

Once Álvarez and his men had arrived in Echojoa they made contact with Ignacio Valenzuela (a compadre of Álvarez), unsaddled the horses, and placed them in a corral. One can scarcely imagine the terror Álvarez felt when he

began to hear the shrieks of owls and coyotes—cries the Yaquis were known to make before attacking an enemy. The rebels closed in on the hapless unarmed soldiers from all sides, scattered their possessions and tore their saddles and reins to shreds. The rebels then stripped the soldiers naked and slashed all those who resisted with spiked clubs. They surrounded the naked prisoners, beat their drums, and taunted them, shouting for their death. Some among the attackers said now was not the time for killing, but that they would execute Álvarez and his men at leisure the next day. The rebels kept the prisoners naked through the night beneath a cold and unforgiving desert sky and at dawn began to drive them back to Santa Cruz. They ran most of the way. Whenever someone slowed or fell down because of the cuts and abrasions to their naked feet, the captors would stab them with arrows and taunt them. The rebels said they wanted the captives to arrive in Santa Cruz so exhausted they wouldn't mind the death that awaited them there.²⁹

Once in Santa Cruz, the rebels ordered the naked, terrified soldiers to sit on a bench, where they were given water. The leader of the rebels singled out the captive Ignacio Redondo and had him tied up and hung by his hands from a mesquite tree, his feet dangling a *vara* from the ground. The rebel "king" pointed a rifle at Redondo's chest and accused him of killing his kinsmen. "If you don't confess," the rebel leader said, "I will kill you and every one of your friends." With remarkable presence of mind Redondo answered obliquely, telling the story of a terrified Indian woman he and the other soldiers had given sustenance to a few days before. The rebel interrogator demanded to know why the shields they had left behind had the marks of having been shot with arrows and why their lances were covered in blood. Redondo, again mustering remarkable wit, said that the lances were covered in the sap of the pitahaya cactus, not with blood, and the soldiers themselves had scarred the shields when they were testing their strength. The rebel leader disliked these answers and pulled the trigger. The weapon failed to fire. He pulled it again, and again nothing happened. He then gave up and returned to his people, saying the misfire was a sign of Redondo's innocence.³⁰

Redondo was left hanging for three hours while the rebel leader spoke with his kinsmen. The rebel was overheard saying he was "King, Pope, God, and Virgin." At one moment the rebel leader entertained suggestions that all the prisoners be shot and mauled to death with arrows and clubs and at another was seen weeping profusely and embracing his companions. At last, he settled on the punishment of six lashes for each of the imprisoned soldiers. One soldier, Juan de Luque, avoided punishment by swearing loyalty to the rebel king and joining his army. The rebels then gave Álvarez and his men some horsemeat to

eat and let them go on May 14. They wandered naked through several villages, then dispersed, some heading for Álamos and others for the Villa de Sinaloa.³¹

The rebels' treatment of Álvarez and his men offered some clues to their motivations. Rather than killing the enemy soldiers, the rebels demolished their self-respect. They stripped the soldiers naked and lacerated their bodies. The rebels reduced the prisoners to a state of total dependency, in which they had no ability to predict, much less control, their future. The rebels seasoned their cruelty with unpredictable flashes of kindness and reasonableness as well as effusions of intense but incomprehensible emotion. The effect of all this was the total mental and physical degradation of the captives. In a colonial society laced with fine gradations of status and respect, in which the law held that only Indians could be whipped, this kind of humiliation made a powerful political statement. The rebels demanded respect while denying it to those who stood in their way. Brutal though it was, the message the rebels lashed into Álvarez's men was predicated on the continuing existence of a shared colonial society. The humiliation of imperial soldiers and settlers would have meaning only within a colonial society with hierarchies of status and dignity. Killing Álvarez and his men would have signaled a clean break with the empire. Releasing naked, traumatized soldiers back into the imperial population sent a more complicated message: it represented a demand for respect and autonomy within the continuing structures of empire.³²

When Huidobro learned of the disaster that had befallen Álvarez, he sent a detachment of fifty men under the command of Sergeant Pedro Bohórquez to recover the weapons the rebels had taken in Santa Cruz. Bohórquez set out from Camoa on the evening of May 20 with the guides Pedro Nolasco and Juan Lázaro. They were to head toward Tesia but then changed direction and headed for Santa Cruz, taking this circuitous route in order to confuse their enemies. They spent the night on the plains of Bacuachi but then got lost the next day. They captured an Indian who said he could guide them to the *camino real* near the Mayo town of Echojoa. There, they got lost once again, however, and ended up by the Mayo River downstream from Echojoa.³³

Echojoa was surrounded by thick forest, making it almost impossible to maneuver on horseback. Bohórquez and his men must have been alarmed when the church bell of Echojoa began to ring and the town filled with shouting. As the soldiers were changing to fresh horses, more than one thousand Indians suddenly surrounded Bohórquez and his men. Bohórquez tried to communicate with the rebels, but they rushed up close to the Spaniards and tried to seize the reins of their horses. Antonio Domínguez, a soldier under Bohórquez's command, reported the next day that the Indians surrounded

them, ambushed them, and forced them to retreat to a cliff with quicksand at its base. The rebels wounded every man in the party with their arrows. The Spaniards were able to fire a single volley with their guns, killing many enemies, but the assault was so furious they could not reload. The sandy quagmire made it impossible for them to defend themselves. The rebels killed three Spanish soldiers with the guns they had taken from Álvarez and his men. The Spaniards managed to fight their way out nevertheless, their horses wounded and eight of their guns fallen into the sand. Bohórquez ordered Joseph de Buelna to take the wounded men to the Real de Álamos and to warn its residents of the rebellion. He took his men to Camoa, where he warned the soldiers and Jesuit there of the danger, raised the alarm in the hacienda of Agua Caliente, and finally retreated to Álamos.³⁴

In light of the disasters of the previous week, Huidobro wrote to the governor of Nueva Vizcaya asking that four hundred Tarahumara auxiliaries be sent to help him contain the rebellion. He asked for reinforcements from Culiacán, Sinaloa, Santiago, and Río Chico as well and ordered the troops in Camoa to withdraw to a safe place with the Jesuit Antonio de Estrada.³⁵

On May 24 Pedro Martínez de Mendíbil asked Huidobro for permission to go to the Yaqui Valley to see if he could calm the unrest. Mendíbil said he was widely respected among the Yaquis and claimed he could talk them out of their diabolical conspiracies. Huidobro referred this request to the vecinos of Baroyeca. They agreed that Mendíbil should communicate with the Yaqui rebels, and Huidobro subsequently allowed him to do so. The vecinos further said that the Yaquis were utterly ferocious, and they requested that Huidobro retreat with them to the Valley of Cedros, which was well provided with food, pasturage, and water and was more easily defended than Baroyeca. The Jesuit Juan Antonio Arce offered further justification for this retreat, spreading word that Pimas from Cumuripa, Suaqui, Belén, and Buenavista had joined the Yaqui and Mayo rebels. Dire news came from the Real de Río Chico on May 25. Ignacio Díaz Félix reported that some eight hundred armed Indians—Yaquis and Pimas from Belén, Buenavista, Suaqui, and Cumuripa—were lurking some two leagues from the town.³⁶

Better news arrived on the twenty-sixth in the form of a delegation of Yaquis under the command of the Yaqui captain general Gurrola. These included several town governors and captains of war. With Mendíbil and Don Francisco Aldámez serving as "interpreters of peace," Gurrola told Huidobro in Baroyeca that the majority of the Yaquis had nothing to do with the recent robberies, killings, and outrages committed near the Mayo River. He admitted that some Yaquis who had married into the Mayo pueblos had participated, but they did

not represent the Yaqui people as a whole. Gurrola handed over a letter from Francisco Guogoli, Luis Jecpaomea, and Martín Juitoriamea, alias Movelachai, three Yaquis thought to be leaders of the insurrection. The letter asked Huidobro for his pardon and said the three wanted peace. Gurrola went on to confess that many Yaquis were unhappy with him and with their governors for their inability to control the "evil ones." He tendered his resignation, and Huidobro named Luis Xicanamea of Rahum as captain general and Agustín Tatabuctemea of Huirivis as his lieutenant. Huidobro then sent the Yaquis back to the Yaqui pueblos with Mendíbil and Aldámez, ordering them to name new governors and restore good order there. If they saw any rebels on their way through the Mayo pueblos, they were to tell the rebels to give back the weapons and horses they had stolen.³⁷

At nine in the evening of May 26 Huidobro received word from the vecinos of Álamos. They wrote that they were getting news from all directions that the Indians were serious about attacking and plundering their town. Álamos had few troops and firearms, little food, and much material of value. Álamos was vulnerable, they said, and the Tepague and Macoyague Indians Huidobro had sent to help them were not trustworthy. They therefore asked that Huidobro come to protect them. Outside the town of Álamos hundreds of armed Indians had gathered under a menacing flag. They had stolen cattle and killed the cowboys that herded them. Some neighboring vecinos had fled south to Culiacán. Huidobro responded that he had no men to send to Álamos and informed them that he and his men were retreating to Cedros. Cedros was between the two embattled towns of Río Chico and Álamos; he would try to do what he could for both of them from there. Huidobro and his troops arrived in Cedros on the evening of the twenty-seventh.³⁸

THE RISE OF JUAN CALIXTO AYAMEA

Sometime between May 15 and May 30, 1740, a Yaqui named Juan Calixto Ayamea became the leader of the insurrectionary movement. In various respects Ayamea linked the legal struggles of the 1730s to the violent phase of the insurrection in 1740. He was from Rahum, the community of which Jusacamea was governor, and, like Jusacamea and Basoritemea, he was a militia leader with considerable experience outside the Yaqui Valley. Ayamea's years as a militiaman afforded him knowledge of the workings of colonial politics. He understood the forms of address required in dealings with Spanish officials; he knew that various factions among the Spanish were at odds; and he knew that the Yaquis stood to gain from these divisions. In his correspondence, Ayamea also

drew an explicit connection between his rebellion and the disappearance of Jusacamea and Basoritemea. Ayamea was the violent face of the reform movement led by Basoritemea and Jusacamea.³⁹

Ayamea later testified that the Yaquis who had tricked, stripped, and whipped Álvarez and his men in Santa Cruz returned to the Yaqui towns and told everyone that the absent governors had been tortured to death. A page serving padre Nápoli confirmed the rumor, Ayamea said, and Nápoli himself claimed to have letters from Mexico City proving that Jusacamea and Basoritemea were dead. Around May 20 Ayamea became the leader of the revolt and was acclaimed captain general of the Yaqui River by a Yaqui populace convinced that the Spaniards had committed a terrible betrayal.⁴⁰

In an extraordinary letter to the vecino Juan de Aldámez, Ayamea announced his plans for war on May 20, 1740:

Letter from Juan Calixto, Captain of Rahum.

My dear sir: I wish you, the lady your wife, your little children, and the other gentlemen perfect health, and offering you mine, I say we are all very well, and are forever at your service (thanks be to God). My dear sir, I hereby inform you that the time has come for war to break out in the name of God, and the King my lord (may God keep him many years); now it is all over, now God wants all this to end. My lord Don Juan, after you see this letter, try to come here at once, to the Yaqui [River], where your brother Don Francisco Aldámez, and father Pedro Mendíbil, are now, who have been our advocates, and who have told me and everyone else that they will die among us. . . . Do not think this is a lie or a fable, but rather that it is completely true and undeniable, that they have tricked us. But now, sir, the trick has been discovered. They killed our relatives who went to Mexico. It is true that our relatives came back safe and sound to the Villa of Sinaloa. It was there that they died, over the course of three days, and as the fourth day dawned, the poor men died. Now the whole nation has been summoned together, and now there is no reason to wait. . . . I remain, praying to God that he keeps you many years. Cocorit, May 20, 1740.

Your humblest and most affectionate servant kisses your hand,

Juan Calixto Ayamea, Captain of Rahum

. . . PS: Be careful with the possessions of Mr. Aldámez.⁴¹

In its manner and content the letter revealed an enormous amount about its author. Ayamea was probably not literate himself, but he had access to scribes who were and understood the importance of diplomatic correspondence in colonial politics. He also was well versed in the formalities such correspondence demanded, and he used them to excellent effect. Ayamea's

elaborate deference to his reader signaled that he was a man of the world and experienced in the political rituals of the colony. The warm courtesies Ayamea offered Aldámez also underscored the deliberateness of the choices he was making. Ayamea let the reader know that he was in perfect control of his faculties and had come to the conclusion that the Yaquis had suffered a heinous betrayal. There may also have been a threat implicit in his allusions to the health of Aldámez and his family—as if he were implying that they might not enjoy their health much longer. Finally, it is also clear that Ayamea drew sharp distinctions between those non-Yaquis he wanted to remain friends with and those whom he planned to attack. Ayamea was not an apocalyptic revolutionary determined to expel all Spaniards. Rather, the letter conveyed the message that Ayamea was seeking a violent remedy in answer to specific grievances within an ongoing political relationship.⁴²

With Huidobro's approval, Juan de Aldámez accepted Ayamea's invitation to come to the Yaqui pueblos and brought with him the secular priest Pedro de Mendíbil. Arriving with the interpreter Manuel Valenzuela on May 26, Aldámez and Mendíbil watched as Yaqui outrage and hatred of Huidobro became more intense. Rumors had begun to circulate that Ignacio Alipazaga, a coyote allied with the Jesuits, had killed a Yaqui. In retribution, Alonso Uteam, a Yaqui from Rahum, attacked Alipazaga with a club. Another Yaqui named Gerónimo shot Alipazaga with an arrow, and Uteam cut off Alipazaga's head with a knife in the middle of Cocorit's town square. The crowd then fell on Alipazaga's body and dragged it through the dust, some howling for Huidobro's blood.⁴³

In a letter describing the Yaqui mission in the midst of the rebellion, Mendíbil told of his efforts to calm the Yaquis. He carried a letter from Governor Huidobro offering a general pardon for all rebels in exchange for a return to peace. In Cocorit, he wrote, "a multitude of people, armed and unarmed, received us, some of them dancing the Gori [*sic*], seemingly with great joy, and we dismounted at a lean-to by the house of the padre, where there were three seats, and we sat down, and they all came to greet each of us, men and women; and after a short conversation, we told them through the interpreter why we had come." Mendíbil held up the letter and read the pardon Huidobro offered them. The Yaquis' reaction was not what he had hoped for. "There was an outburst among them, many did not believe it, since your highness has deceived them so many times, and some of them clamored to take up arms, saying that after us the soldiers were coming." Mendíbil tried to calm them down, saying he had not come to trick anyone, but he was drowned out by the "indecorous" shouting of the Yaquis. Some screamed that they wanted to go see Huidobro

and ask about Jusacamea. Mendíbil tried to dissuade them from this plan, but his efforts, he said, were nothing but "an incentive to their audacity." Mendíbil and his companions fell silent in terror. "We can assure your highness, we do not know how we got out of there."⁴⁴

There were deep divisions among the Yaquis, however, and these allowed Mendíbil and Aldámez to survive their visit. "We passed on to Rahum," Mendíbil wrote, "watering the road with our tears." They found the town empty of men and were greeted by women, "who welcomed us with embraces, and shedding tears . . . for the acts carried out by their husbands." Mendíbil said Mass there, and they moved on to Torim. A man met them outside the town carrying a letter from a Yaqui named Francisco de Gogoli pledging his loyalty to the king and inviting Mendíbil into the town. Mendíbil said he broke up various fights and reconciled the parties in conflict with his preaching. Gogoli and other residents of Torim tearfully swore their loyalty to the holy mother church and Governor Huidobro. The town of Vicam welcomed Mendíbil and his party in even more enthusiastic fashion, dancing and singing in their honor and praising the visitors as angels sent by God. The town of Rahum sent out a war party to greet Mendíbil and his companions "with much joy." In the town they saw a line of men and a line of women by the church and a group of women carrying an image of the baby Jesus and another of the Virgin Mary beneath an awning. Mendíbil's party threw themselves to the ground and shed tears of joy.⁴⁵

While Mendíbil and Aldámez shared these happy moments with some Yaquis, other Yaquis were venting their outrage on the town of Baroyeca. Ayamea and his troops arrived there on May 27, shortly after Huidobro had departed town for Cedros. The vecino Francisco Javier Campoy recorded a battle between four hundred Yaquis and sixty Spanish troops that resulted in the death of five Spaniards and fifty Yaquis. The Spanish survivors of the battle, including twenty-four wounded men, fought their way out and caught up to Huidobro in Cedros. In Baroyeca, Ayamea's men stole maize and cattle, plundered the house of Don Luis Flores, and killed an old lady named Doña María Corea in the nearby hacienda of Espíritu Santo. After smashing windows, breaking down doors, and stealing the horses of this hacienda, Ayamea and his men united and headed for Cedros, where they hoped to kill or capture Governor Huidobro.⁴⁶

Huidobro received word of their intentions on May 31, and, to the consternation of the region's vecinos, he ran away. A slave of Don Joseph de Valenzuela came to Cedros to tell Huidobro that Yaquis led by Calixto Ayamea had killed Ignacio Alipazaga and attacked Baroyeca. Ayamea and his troops came with

drums and trumpets and were determined to kill the governor for his supposed betrayal of Jusacamea and Basoritemea. Huidobro reasoned that his forty men were no match for the thirteen hundred angry Yaquis marching against him. He thought the abundant water and livestock surrounding Cedros could sustain the Yaquis through a long siege, and so he ordered the retreat to Álamos. They arrived on June 2 after a rugged two-day journey.⁴⁷

When Ayamea and his followers arrived at Cedros on June 3, they wasted no time in burning down the main house, tearing up various religious images, stealing or profaning some church ornaments and destroying others. In his confession seven months later Ayamea said "each one took what he could, as when you throw maize to many chickens, and some can get a lot, and some a little, and some none." The rebels killed Santiago de Valenzuela and his two sons and Francisco Coronado. They also took seventy-eight captives and forced them to strip naked and walk to the Yaqui mission. A slave known as Juan Ignacio "Chiquito" later testified that he had witnessed the sack of Cedros as a prisoner. A fifteen-year-old half Yaqui and half coyote, Chiquito testified that he had seen "many pagan dances, especially after a Yaqui brought the scalp they had taken from Juan Martín in the place of Bacusa where they killed him, a blind Spaniard that came fleeing from Baroyeca, in the company of some women, that they say are now captives in the town of Camoa . . . and they have the scalp on a post and danced by it every night." This testimony bears witness to the remarkable persistence of pre-Hispanic Yaqui customs more than a century after the arrival of the Jesuits in the Yaqui Valley. Early seventeenth-century documents report identical ceremonies taking place among unconverted Yaquis. Yet here, as in previous confrontations between rebels and Spaniards, Yaqui ritual took place within the confines of an ongoing political relationship between Yaquis and outsiders. The rebels did not attempt to exterminate the colonials but instead killed some and ritually humiliated others.⁴⁸

On learning that Huidobro had escaped to Álamos, the rebels split up into bands and headed variously for Batacosa, Mutica, El Sauz, Tepague, and Bacum. Those who went to Batacosa killed six vecinos of Baroyeca: Salvador, Miguel, and Joseph Valenzuela, Luis Romero, Miguel de Figueroa, and Luis de Herrera. The rebel leader Baltasar Baojisuaime brought the widows and children of these men to the Yaqui pueblos as captives. Aldámez wrote that the captives arrived in Rahum naked and that Ayamea and his followers "committed such acts of insolence, such murders, that I am horrified to recount them." Pedro Mendíbil was shocked to see his mother and brother, Miguel Mendíbil, among the captives, along with Miguel's wife and children, who had all been

stripped naked. The rebels then tried to kill Luis Xicanamea, the man Huidobro named to be the new captain general, alongside his lieutenants. Whether they succeeded is unclear, but they did whip the ex-Captain General Gurrola and may have done the same to his successor. Aldámez managed to escape to Belén on June 15 and then to Tecoripa, where he warned the sergeant major of Sonora of the rebels' plans to attack him. Mendíbil remained on the Yaqui mission, where he persisted in his efforts to make peace.⁴⁹

HUIDOBRO THROWS FUEL ON THE FLAMES

On arriving in Álamos, Huidobro learned that the Indians of Mochicahui and Charay had joined the Yaquis along with some two hundred Mayo warriors. He immediately sent letters asking for help from Culiacán, Rosario, Batopilas, Copala, and Nueva Vizcaya, the last of which he hoped would send two hundred Tarahumaras to his aid. Huidobro soon learned that the rebels had attacked the nearby rancho of Los Tanques and sent out twelve vecinos under the command of the soldier Francisco de Peñuelas to look into the matter. They were to patrol the plains around Los Tanques in order to prevent the rebels from cutting off the supply routes from Sinaloa.⁵⁰

Huidobro had by this point changed his attitude toward the rebellion. Whereas earlier he had seen it as a matter of banditry, he now saw it as an organized threat to colonial rule. Since the Yaquis had sacked a number of haciendas outside the Yaqui Valley and now had access to all their livestock and supplies, Huidobro believed the rebels held a strategic advantage. He tried to counter this by sending word to Sonora that Agustín de Vildósola, the sergeant major of the Sonoran militia, should take forty soldiers experienced in Apache wars and some three hundred Indian auxiliaries to attack the Yaqui Valley from the north.⁵¹

The vecinos of Sinaloa begged Huidobro to come protect them, but Huidobro decided to stay where he was—perhaps for strategic reasons, perhaps because the vecinos of Álamos threatened to kill him if he tried to leave. Cristóbal de Gurrola, the former captain general of the Yaqui pueblos, staggered into Álamos on June 13 bringing bad news. He told Huidobro that Ayamea and his followers were furious over the supposed execution of Jusacamea and Basoritemea, had killed Alipazaga, and whipped Gurrola himself for his failure to support their cause.⁵²

During Huidobro's stay in Álamos, the region's vecinos began to see him as weak, dithering, and cowardly. In a letter written three years later, the vecinos of Álamos alleged that Huidobro was paralyzed with fear of the rebel hordes. It

was also during this period that Vildósola began to demonstrate the impatience, swiftness to action, and penchant for impetuous violence that would bring him to power in the coming months.⁵³

On hearing of the revolt from Huidobro on June 9, Vildósola quickly marched from his home in Tetuache to Tecoripa, where he gathered a force of 70 men, including 16 Spanish soldiers. He hoped to gather a total force of 150 men, including Indians, to attack the Yaquis. Vildósola explored the region around the Yaqui Valley and found its inhabitants horrified, many haciendas burned down, and the towns of La Ventana, Baroyeca, Guadalupe, El Mortero, Río Chico, and Santa Ana all empty of inhabitants. "The enemies have taken some Spanish men and women captive, and they have them naked in their lands, having raped the girls," Vildósola wrote to Huidobro. "See how accursed they are," he continued, "even a hundred years after their conversion!" Despite the governor's wish that he recruit more men in Sonora, Vildósola proposed to immediately attack the Yaquis from the north while Huidobro attacked the Mayos from the south. Huidobro, further tarnishing his reputation among the vecinos, refused.⁵⁴

The insurrection was spreading. The vecino Don Miguel de La Vega wrote on June 27 from the town of El Fuerte that he had news of a rebel force of Yaquis, Mayos, Tehuecos, Sivirijoas, Charais, Mochicahuis, Ahomes, Ocoronis, and others causing trouble near the town of Tesila and trying to attract the Tehuecos to their cause. Vega sent out a force of thirty-five men under the command of his lieutenant Don Alejo on the twenty-fifth to try to calm the rebellion and keep Tehueco from joining the rebels. Alejo conferred with the Jesuit father Valladares in Tehueco, but neither could discern what it was the rebels wanted. As a gesture of peace, the rebels had returned to the Spaniards an image of the Virgin Mary and a cross they had taken. Alejo sent an ambassador to the rebels bearing a cross as a sign of peace. The rebels responded that they would be happy to reconcile with Alejo, provided he and his men lay down their arms first. The actions of the rebels betrayed their words. Alejo and his men saw two lines of rebels, one under a white flag, the other under a red one, surrounding their position. The rebels attacked, but Alejo and his men fought their way out, two of them sustaining injuries, and returned to El Fuerte.⁵⁵

Padre Valladares remained in Tehueco and was subjected to humiliations and horrors before being released to the care of his fellow Jesuits. The rebels tore his clothes off, gave him simple cloth pants to wear, dragged him into the wilderness, and taunted him with threats. They terrified him with "dances so obscene and immodest that he had to cover his face with his hands, which they

forcefully removed to make him see their obscenities." Whatever else the rebels wanted, it seems that the humiliation and intimidation of Spaniards were among their most visceral desires.⁵⁶

The rebels then followed Vega and his men to El Fuerte and laid siege to it on June 28. The siege was repelled, with the loss of twenty-three Yaqui lives. On hearing of this attack, Huidobro sent Vega twenty-five men under the command of Manuel de Villavicencio, with an arroba of gunpowder and four hundred bullets.⁵⁷

In the midst of the escalating violence Juan Calixto Ayamea sent two revealing yet complicated letters to Governor Huidobro. As in his letter to Aldámez, Ayamea encoded messages about his desires and identity in both the style and content of the letters. The first was an elaborately deferential petition signed by several rebel leaders and claiming to speak for all the Yaqui towns. After expressing warm wishes for the governor's health and great reverence for the governor's office and character, Ayamea asked that Pedro de Mendíbil, the secular priest, be made the official parish priest of the Yaqui towns:

We all find ourselves content, pleased, quiet, and calm, the main cause of which is the arrival of Señor Bachiller Don Pedro Mendíbil, among us for our greater good, who with great care, attention, and efficacy, and much charity, from the first day he arrived, has given us thousands of spiritual consolations, for which we are inexpressibly grateful. We shed tears of consolation, hearing the word of God from him, which has moved us so profoundly that at present, it seems impossible to disturb us, gazing as he always has on us with such love, and we on him with corresponding and equal love. For these reasons, since your grace is our father and protector, welcoming us under your protection, and looking on us with charity, you desire the best for us, and so we must strive to merit your attendance, by the love of God, and the holiest Virgin, to our request: it is that your grace do all that is possible, writing to the Bishop of Durango, in order that he make the said Father Don Pedro de Mendíbil our legitimate minister, and true priest, and he, as a pastor of souls, will doubtless attend to that which gives us such pleasure and consolation. And the opposite would cause us great sorrow, and indeed trouble could occur among the sons, which we, as their leaders and fathers, are trying to prevent.

Like a man at arms clothed in a courtier's velvet and lace, this letter disguised its basic aggressiveness with florid rhetoric. Ayamea dwelled on the humble religiosity of the Yaquis and their immense reverence for the governor. But the letter implicitly attacked the Jesuits and the political order in which the Jesuits had thrived. The political core of the letter lay in its request that the governor replace the Jesuits with a parish priest. This request made it clear how closely

Ayamea's ambitions mirrored those of the absent governors. Like Jusacamea and Basoritemea, Ayamea was well informed about politics far afield of the Yaqui mission and about the factions embroiled in debate over Bourbon reforms of the church. He knew, for instance, that the Jesuits opposed secularization and that Huidobro and the bishop of Durango supported it. There is also a distinctive *mélange* of negotiation and violence in Ayamea's approach to getting what he wanted from the empire. Haciendas were burning and corpses were rotting in the roads as Ayamea composed this letter, and he knew it. It would have been easy to perceive the threat in Ayamea's comment that trouble might ensue if Huidobro refused his polite request.

Ayamea's second letter had an even sharper threatening edge. Addressing Governor Huidobro once again on behalf of all the Yaqui towns, Ayamea wrote,

Only God can relieve the great sadness I, Captain Don Juan Calisto, and all the towns of the Yaqui River, and all the sons, feel when we see the Spaniards, and the vecinos, and their settlements so unprotected, and their peace of mind impossible to restore, and the cause has been us. But beginning on the 28th of June, 1740, by the pity of God, I swear and tell your grace before God that the whole River, without exception, is unanimous and in conformity with your orders, and with our full hearts, we submit to your grace, all of our arms, with the sincerity of our hearts, because we wish to live in the grace of God in our towns, peaceful as before, because the lord knows how sad we are in seeing these things. . . . My Lord, only God can remedy what has happened, and so every one of us asks you for a general pardon, for our calm and peace. Seeing your grace in the land of Los Álamos with many soldiers, it makes us very sad, and so by God, we ask your grace, that you withdraw all your arms, and we promise that, from the instant we write, all will be finished on this river. . . . The carrier of this letter is Ignacio Mendizábal, who is married in Potam, and knows everything, and because he is safe, and has obligations here, we ask your grace that you send the general pardon with him, so that we can all be consoled, and all the vecinos can come to trade, work in their mines, and engage in commerce as before, which is our desire.

Here again Ayamea clothed aggressive demands in deferential finery. He lamented the mayhem he and his followers had visited on their Spanish neighbors while at the same time absolving himself of all responsibility for it. "What a shame the Spaniards are exposed to such horrors," he seemed to say. "But only God can help them. In the meantime, please lay down your arms and send us a general pardon." Once again negotiation was intimately bound up with violence. The letter would have made no sense in the absence of the

destruction Ayamea had caused. And here, as had been the case throughout the 1730s, Yaqui demands were predicated on a desire to maintain and seize control of political and economic ties with the empire.⁵⁸

In response to these overtures Huidobro convened a council of Álamos's leading vecinos and asked what they thought he should do next. Eight of them voted that Huidobro should concede the general pardon, while nineteen voted for him to prosecute the war against the rebels. The testimony of Ignacio Mendizábal, the messenger from Ayamea to Huidobro, must have strengthened the vecinos' resolve to attack the rebels. Mendizábal, a Spaniard married to a Yaqui woman in Potam, testified that Ayamea was the supreme head of the insurrection and had brutally whipped Yaquis who opposed him. He had also overseen the capture and killing of Spaniards and the plunder of Spanish churches and haciendas. Huidobro was further convinced of Ayamea's deviousness by the attack on El Fuerte, which took place on the same day Ayamea had dispatched his ingratiating letters.⁵⁹

On July 2 Huidobro addressed a letter to Ayamea, Xicanamea, and various others in the Yaqui Valley expressing what was obvious by then: the rebels' offer of peace was not credible. Huidobro listed the rebels' many offenses and crimes and said these prevented him from making peace. Huidobro then made a remarkable rhetorical shift: "I do not deny you, nor will I ever deny you peace, if you ask for it in the proper way," he wrote. He demanded the freedom of all the captives the Yaquis had taken and the restitution of their property. He reminded the rebels that he had taken no captives from among the many Yaquis and Mayos living and working outside their missions and exhorted the rebels to follow his example. Huidobro never mentioned any kind of punishment for the rebels and even said that once the peace was concluded he would ask the bishop of Durango to grant the rebels' wish that the Jesuits be replaced by Pedro de Mendíbil. This conciliatory message must have been in part the product of Huidobro's pacific—perhaps even timid—character. Many Jesuits and vecinos wanted desperately for Huidobro to visit terrible punishments on the rebels. But Huidobro's attitude toward the rebellion also indicated the strength of his very Bourbon-reformist attitudes toward indigenous peoples. They were to be treated with respect, freed from the oppression of predatory priests, and brought into the colonial mainstream. Not even the bloody destruction the rebels had wreaked seems to have shaken Huidobro's faith in these principles.⁶⁰

Huidobro's letter did not reach its addressees as quickly as he might have hoped. Some eighty Indians stopped Mendizábal in the road as he returned to the Yaqui Valley. The messenger noticed some were carrying booty and another had what looked like scalps recently hacked off their victims hanging from each

arm. They asked Mendizábal why he was not bringing priests with him. Mendizábal replied that padre Díaz was sick and padre Somera was taking care of him. The rebels became angry and accused Mendizábal of lying. At length it was decided that an Indian named Francisco, who had grown up among the Spaniards, would return to Álamos with Mendizábal to ask the priests why they did not want to go to the Yaqui Valley. The Jesuit fathers Imaz and Somera told him they would not return until the release of the Jesuits Estrada, Valladares, and Mazariegos, and that Díaz would probably never return on account of illness.⁶¹

Huidobro's decision to refuse Ayamea's offers of peace must have seemed all the more reasonable when he heard of the next and best organized of the recent rebel attacks. At dawn on July 6 some five hundred rebels, including Yaquis, Guaymas, and Pimas, had attacked the town of Tecoripa to the north of the Yaqui River. Vildósola, wrote one witness, leaped out of bed without shoes, took up his armor, shield, and arms, and shot back at the attackers. Vildósola and his troops repelled the attack and in the process killed some twenty-eight rebels, including the governor of the town of Xauqui and two captains, one named Miguel from the town of Xetacarue, the other from Bacum, the rebel leader Baltasar Baojisume. The rebels had tried to free four Yaquis captured by Vildósola in Río Chico, but all four captives were killed in the fighting. Vildósola took two more rebels captive, decapitated the dead men so as to display their heads by the road as a warning, and left the rebels' flags, trumpets, staves, and drums scattered across the battlefield. Later accounts added an important detail of these events. Juan Frías, a Yaqui from Huirivis, reported that Juan Calixto Ayamea refused to go on the expedition to Tecoripa. Frías took this as an indication that there were divisions among the rebels over tactics and strategy.⁶²

Vildósola learned that the Indians of Tepague were choking off his lines of communication with Álamos, so he sent Don José de Uzárraga and seventeen men to dislodge the rebels. They fought at dawn on July 15, and Uzárraga's men killed twenty or more of the rebels and took another one prisoner. Without waiting for orders from Huidobro, Vildósola sent his subordinate Ignacio de Figueroa to the Yaqui towns to liberate the captives there.⁶³

Uzárraga passed on to Álamos, where he informed Huidobro of the recent battles on July 18. Huidobro ordered Uzárraga back to Tepague on the following day. But on July 20 a party of Yaqui rebels ambushed Uzárraga and his men in Conicari. The black slave Francisco Parralo was a prisoner of the Yaquis who attacked Uzárraga's party. He escaped to the Spanish side and gave an account of the ambush to Huidobro on July 21. Ten Yaquis under the command of

Nicolás Mochi were killed, and the rest fled into the hills after the battle. But they did considerable damage, injuring seven of Uzárraga's men and Uzárraga himself.

Late July and early August saw little action on either the rebel or government sides. This is a time of crushing heat in northwest Mexico, and it would hardly be surprising if the summer had reduced Spaniards and Indians alike to a state of sweltering lethargy. Whatever the reason for the lull, late summer was a time for all parties to regroup and reflect on the previous months. On August 3, 1740, the Jesuit Joseph Xavier Molina wrote a letter to the provincial of the Jesuit order that expressed in lucid terms what many people were thinking at the time. The rebellion, he wrote, should have been easy to suppress, but Huidobro let it spin out of control: "The cowardice of the Governor (after refusing for years to believe there was an uprising, even as it was beginning) has given audacity to the Indians and placed all these provinces in manifest danger of being lost." The governor, Molina went on,

who fled from Baroyeca, and then from los Cedros, and now wanted to flee from [Álamos] to Sinaloa, has not done so only because he encountered such resistance from the vecinos, who have watched over him at night many times, and have even threatened him with death if he left them. His flight from los Cedros is the main reason for the loss of this land: he left it at midnight, being in a house that was defended by thousands of Indians and twenty [Spanish] men. . . . He left meat, supplies, bullets, and powder; and he did not even inform the men guarding the horses so that they could follow him. He now has four hundred men at arms and he does not dare leave to defend the surrounding country; nor does he allow Don Agustín de Vildósola to go to the battlefield.⁶⁴

This letter marked a seismic shift in the politics of northwestern Mexico. Before the insurrection, the Jesuits and vecinos were at each others' throats over control of native labor. Molina gave evidence of this long-standing conflict in a weary aside: "The Yaquis' sole desires were to dance and work in the mines." As the insurrection unfolded across Sinaloa and Sonora, however, vecinos and Jesuits were galvanized to join forces in opposition to the uprising and to the governor whose passivity abetted it. The short-lived alliance between Jesuits and vecinos would be the key to the destruction of the rebels.⁶⁵

July 1740 was the insurrection's high-water mark. In a series of cunning, audacious attacks the rebels had taken control of the Yaqui and Mayo Valleys and all the territory between. They threatened the Fuerte River settlements and Álamos as well as towns to the north of the Yaqui River in Sonora. The letters

and actions of the rebels paint a vivid portrait of their eclectic and sometimes contradictory aims. Time and again the betrayal of Jusacamea and Basoritemea was mentioned as the leading cause for the insurrection. These two would later return to the Yaqui Valley, as if from the dead, after a long, complicated voyage back from Mexico City. Bureaucracy and the difficulties of early-modern travel, rather than betrayal and execution, had held them up. Yet the fact that the rebels fought in the name of Jusacamea and Basoritemea establishes an iron link between the legal protests of the 1730s and the insurrection of 1740. So too does the testimony of the slave Parralo, who said the Yaquis wanted a Jesuit among them and attended Mass regularly but at the same time deprived the Jesuit of all worldly power. This was a logical, if extreme, expression of the legal demands presented by Jusacamea and Basoritemea in Mexico City.

The Yaquis appropriated livestock and religious ornaments from properties located near the Yaqui River and thoroughly humiliated outsiders who tried to cramp their ambitions. Yet even in the most heated moments of the uprising Yaqui rebels expressed their desire for continued commerce with the Spanish, continued work in Spanish mines, and the continuation of Catholic religious ceremonies. Theirs was a struggle not to throw off Spanish rule but to take control of their relationship with the colonial power and to conduct business with it on their own terms.

TWILIGHT OF THE INSURRECTION

Juan Calixto Ayamea was at the height of his power in late June 1740, a fact he flaunted in his obliquely menacing letters to Huidobro. He wrote that he wanted to end the uprising and to resume friendly relations with the secular government but set stringent conditions for the armistice. He demanded a blanket pardon for all those who had participated in the violence, replacement of the Jesuits with secular priests, and the full withdrawal of Spanish troops from the Real de Los Álamos. These demands were made in elaborately deferential language, but they were pointed nevertheless. Ayamea and his men had just ravaged Spanish haciendas in Ostimuri and still had many Spanish prisoners. They had also proven themselves to be masters of the veiled threat and confidence trick. Having been duped and humiliated before, Huidobro rejected Ayamea's demands.⁶⁶

Ayamea seems not to have wanted to visit mayhem on all of northwest Mexico. Juan Frías, a coyote fugitive from the Yaqui Valley, testified that Ayamea had "repented" of the violence he presided over in Baroyeca. For this reason he did not participate in the assault on Tecoripa. Nevertheless, Ayamea

was more than willing to kill those he thought responsible for the death of Jusacamea and Basoritemea. Ayamea, Frías alleged, "has promised them he will not abandon them until he has decapitated the present Lord Governor, and killed the Spaniards of this Real, and the Villa del Fuerte, that of Sinaloa, and the Real of Batopilas."⁶⁷

It was in this mood of renewed belligerence that the second assault on Tecoripa was launched. At 10 a.m. on August 26 roughly two thousand Indians from Huirivis, Rahum, Potam, Vicam, and Torim descended on the town. Vildósola came out to meet them with twelve horsemen and sent Luis de León to ask if they came in peace or war. The response came in the form of a spear hurled from among the rebels that buried itself in the neck of León's horse. Rebel drums began to thunder and rebel pipes shrieked the attack. Vildósola and his men lured the attackers into the middle of the town, where sixty more armored horsemen waited to ambush the rebels. After three hours of fighting, the Spaniards had received injuries to five men, had killed thirty-six of their enemies, had captured thirteen mules, some copper tools, quivers, and arrows, and finally put the rebels to flight. This defeat was the first nail in the insurrection's coffin. Further nails were driven in Bacori on August 9 and 28, with two victories over rebel forces.⁶⁸

The insurrection was buried not by Spanish soldiers, however, but by Bernabé Basoritemea and Juan Ignacio Jusacamea. Their inconvenient failure to die deflated the movement that had held them up as martyrs. Basoritemea arrived in Álamos on the evening of August 24. He bore documents from the viceroy absolving him and Jusacamea of the charge that they fomented an uprising and naming Jusacamea as captain general of the Yaqui mission. Basoritemea arrived in the Yaqui Valley on September 7, and according to Pedro de Mendíbil he was immediately successful in securing the surrender of the rebels.⁶⁹

Mendíbil wrote that he had traveled through the Yaqui towns with Basoritemea and had, despite some resistance in Bacum and Rahum, been successful in pacifying the rebels. Basoritemea wrote to Huidobro that some Yaquis asked after Jusacamea and were "incredulous" until they saw him face to face. Jusacamea had arrived in Álamos on October 2 and in Bacum sometime between then and the writing of Basoritemea's letter on October 6.⁷⁰

Basoritemea, Jusacamea, and others would then return to the Real de Los Álamos, traveling through the Mayo town of Camoa, where they were joined by the Jesuit Antonio de Estrada. Estrada brought a number of captives from the Mayo towns. Basoritemea, Jusacamea, Mendíbil, and Estrada informed Huidobro of the pacification of the revolt on October 8. It was decided soon

thereafter that Huidobro should make an official visit to the Yaqui pueblos in order to confirm the peace.⁷¹

Estrada arrived in Álamos on October 13 with assorted Mayo justicias who came to swear their allegiance to Huidobro. Two days later Basoritemea informed Huidobro of the arrival of the Spaniards and servants the Yaquis had taken captive. One hundred and two men, women, and children of all ages and conditions arrived along with sacred images taken from the church at Baroyeca. Mendíbil arranged for them to enter the town at six in the evening, on account of the nakedness of the women. Huidobro sent two files of cavalry to escort them into the town. They came before the church, where Mendíbil sang a "te deum laudamus" and Huidobro ordered Miguel de Lucenilla to arrange accommodations for the tattered band of captives.⁷²

The next morning Huidobro received Jusacamea, Basoritemea, and Ayamea himself in front of his residence in Álamos. They swore obedience to Huidobro and returned a great many of the items the rebels had taken: livestock, weapons, and domestic goods, though not the pearls that once decorated the image of the Virgin of Loreto in Baroyeca. Jusacamea was confirmed in his office of captain general, and Basoritemea's title of *alférez* was read for all to hear.⁷³

After gathering a large force of Spanish soldiers and Indian auxiliaries, Huidobro would spend most of November in the Mayo Valley, traveling from town to town, making a careful census of their inhabitants, hunting down rebel leaders, naming new governors, and returning Valenzuela to the office of captain general of the Mayo River. Working in the company of Jusacamea and Basoritemea, Huidobro recovered stolen property, gathered and burned the rebels' weapons, and left orders that each pueblo should cut down the forests and flatten the land within a quarter league of each pueblo. Huidobro ordered the execution of three rebel leaders, Joaquín Jucojoley, Cristóbal Purigui, and Lorenzo Bailon, who were stoned to death in the town plaza of Camoa on November 14. Others were given punishments of twenty-five lashes. Huidobro dispatched Jusacamea and Basoritemea to the Yaqui pueblos on November 28 to prepare their constituents for his arrival.⁷⁴

Huidobro arrived in the Yaqui pueblos on December 18. The governor and his entourage met with Vildósola and Jusacamea in the town of Cocorit. Following Huidobro's orders, Jusacamea had arrested Ayamea and six of the insurrection's main leaders. Over the course of his stay, Huidobro, Vildósola, Jusacamea, and Basoritemea worked to corral the remaining rebels and to make a detailed census of the towns. They found many of their inhabitants to be away working in the region's mines, and others working to supply the nascent Jesuit mission in Baja California. The united front of secular officials and Yaqui

governors struck the rebel movement like a punch. Stunned surprise and humiliation now drove many to blame a few ringleaders, when, in the heat of war, many had joined in the rebellion willingly. Ayamea returned the favor, maintaining in his confession that those who had followed him had actually forced him to be their leader on pain of death. He only went along with the mayhem, he said, in order to rein it in. Calixto's confession would not have the intended effect of averting its author's execution.⁷⁵

AFTERMATH

Huidobro would never finish his work in the Yaqui Valley. The complaints of vecinos and Jesuits had wound their way through hundreds of miles of pathways and roads, through the corridors of the colonial bureaucracy, and finally to the highest levels of the government of New Spain. The new viceroy, Duque de la Conquista, turned a more sympathetic ear to such complaints than his predecessor had. He decided on a complex plan to satisfy as many of the players in the Sonoran drama as possible, while bringing the violence to an end. Criticism of Huidobro was shading into hatred and contempt, and so the governor was sacrificed to the viceroy's new strategy. Word arrived on January 1, 1741, that Huidobro was to be removed from office for cowardice and incompetence, to be replaced temporarily by Agustín de Vildósola. The viceroy addressed two of the Yaquis' central demands by forbidding Jesuits to name or depose Yaqui town governors and ordering the expulsion of coyotes, *lobos*, and mulattos from the Yaqui pueblos. The viceroy extended a general pardon to the insurgents and sent three new Jesuits to replace the priests who had, in the viceroy's view, provoked the rebellion with their harsh and impolitic temperament. Huidobro learned of his dismissal in Torim and yielded the reins of government to Vildósola with minimal protest.⁷⁶

In conformity with the viceroy's orders, Vildósola extended a pardon to all those who had revolted, freed the prisoners Huidobro had taken, and dismissed 296 of the 426 soldiers under Huidobro's command. Huidobro departed on January 9, 1741, and arrived in Mexico City on April 26, at which point he began to try to regain his old office. Meantime, Vildósola made a general visit of the Yaqui pueblos and the surrounding towns. He released captive rebels and burned the weapons of all Yaquis. He also prohibited them from ever bearing arms again.⁷⁷

In the subsequent months Vildósola visited the Mayo and Fuerte regions and returned to make a census of the Yaqui pueblos. He became increasingly suspicious of Jusacamea and Basoritemea, who had been favored by Huidobro

and the former viceroy Vizarrón. Vildósola regarded them as the secret promoters of the uprising of 1740 and thought they were preparing a third attack on Tecoripa. Whether the conspiracy was a reality or a pretext, Vildósola arrested Jusacamea and Basoritemea in a surprise attack on June 14, 1741. They were accused of insubordination and sent to Buenavista, fourteen leagues from Torim. Vildósola ordered their execution by stoning nine days later.⁷⁸

Jusacamea was accompanied to his death by the Jesuit Ignacio Duque and was heard to say that he and Basoritemea had been "loyal to the king and obedient to their ministers." Looking directly at the Spaniards, he twice declared, "I die an innocent man." Basoritemea, accompanied by Pedro Martínez de Mendíbil, asked that his blindfold be removed. When this was done, he turned to Vildósola and said, "Señor Governor, I am going to die, there is no remedy, and I will not last long. Tell me, sir, what is the cause I am dying for, so as to ask God for mercy, because I do not know what it is." No one answered. Mendíbil spoke out saying, "Lord Governor," but was interrupted by Don Pedro de Cañas, who said, "Father, now is not the time." Mendíbil turned to Basoritemea and said, "Let us go, my son, do not faint, for you are going to a better place." Jusacamea and Basoritemea were then stoned to death as traitors to "Both Majesties." Their heads were displayed in the Yaqui pueblos as a warning to all others who questioned Spanish authority. Vildósola went on to execute twelve more suspected revolutionaries, including Juan Calixto Ayamea and Agustín el Siboli.⁷⁹

Huidobro in the meantime had already begun a campaign to overturn the charges against him and return to the office of governor-for-life. Viceroy Duque de la Conquista died in August 1741, and his successor, the Count of Fuenclara, restored Huidobro to office in November 1743, only to be bombarded with the outraged letters of the Jesuits and accusations against Huidobro. Fuenclara split the difference between the complaining parties: he suspended Huidobro's return to the governorship indefinitely while dismissing all charges against him. Vildósola was elevated from interim governor to governor in July 1744.⁸⁰

Thus the drama of the insurrection came to an end. The liberalizing policies of the Bourbon government were shelved, and the ambitions of Yaquis who wanted to take advantage of those policies went unfulfilled. For a time, conservative settlers, Jesuits, and Yaqui loyalists of the old regime held sway. Yet the structural causes of the uprising were not seriously addressed. New institutions for the reconciliation of clashing interests in northwest New Spain did not soon come into existence, and the same conflicts among Yaquis, Jesuits, and government would flare to life time and again in the coming years. It was not

only Bourbon reform and its proponents in government that failed in 1740. Yaqui attempts to take advantage of those reforms failed too. Jusacamea and Basoritemea, the toughest, most audacious, and most politically savvy Yaquis, following clear signals from the government that their petitions would be accepted, campaigned to expand Yaqui political and economic freedoms, only to find to their horror that their lives would be sacrificed in the interest of ending a revolt they never wanted.

Though the uprising of 1740 did not bring about a reordering of colonial society, it did crystallize more clearly than any other event in the colonial period the ironies of Yaqui history. The main debates among the Yaquis were not about whether to collaborate with the agents of empire, but how to do so. Yaquis loyal to the Jesuits, the reformist governors, and Juan Calixto Ayamea all pursued their interests and desires while at the same time placing a high value on their reciprocal ties with empire. Negotiation continued even at the moments of intensest violence. And the Spanish, divided and vulnerable though they were, eventually deployed both guile and force to maintain their sway in the region.

The events of 1740 revealed other imperial ironies. The Yaquis have long been famous for their tenacity in maintaining their ancestral traditions. And indeed, the records of the insurrection provide a great deal to substantiate this notion. Witness after witness testified to the widespread use of native clothing, dances, and language among the Yaquis over the course of the revolt. The use of animal cries in battle, the stripping of captives, and the taking of scalps did not emerge from any European military tradition. Yet at the same time, many Yaquis demonstrated extensive and refined knowledge of Spanish imperial politics, policies, customs, and institutions. They brought lawsuits in imperial courts far from the Yaqui mission and made demands that were predicated on knowledge of imperial politics. Though the most salient Yaqui leaders of the late 1730s and early 1740s found their ambitions thwarted, and indeed many of them were killed, other leaders would continue to wield their strategies in later years. A combination of tenacious traditionalism and worldly sophistication would continue to distinguish the Yaquis. The flexibility and adaptability of Yaqui culture and the creativity the Yaquis displayed in stitching elements of native and colonial culture into wholly original tapestry would be hallmarks of Yaqui tradition for centuries to come.

REORIENTATIONS: THE COLLAPSE OF THE MISSION AND THE REBIRTH OF THE YAQUI TOWNS, 1744–1810

There is no Nation of Indians more profitable to the
Monarchy than that of the Yaquis.

—*Rafael Rodríguez Gallardo, 1761*

On July 10, 1744, the Jesuit Lorenzo José García wrote to the father visitor, Lucas Luis Álvarez, of rumors that the Yaqui were preparing a second insurrection. Representatives of the government rushed to the Yaqui Valley to investigate reports of Yaquis stockpiling weapons in hideouts near the mission. They carefully questioned many Yaquis and vecinos and at length came to the conclusion that the reports were false. The investigators were perturbed, however, to find that Yaquis were performing dances and rituals that Governor Agustín de Vildósola had expressly forbidden. García wrote that his fellow Jesuit Agustín Arriola had allowed the dances to proceed, despite the objections of the governor. García himself opposed the dance and found to his dismay that he would soon be forced to witness it. In the town of Potam, García joined Arriola, a Spanish lieutenant named Buelna, and “almost the whole river,” to watch the Paccola ceremony. García tried and failed to get the dancers to perform the dance without drums, masks, and pipes. “What a bitter pill this was for me,” he wrote, “having opposed the dance so vehemently.” García thought it would be a terrible mistake to contradict his fellow Jesuit in the presence of thousands of people. And so, doing his best to save face, García stood and addressed the crowd: “The lord governor has correctly forbidden you to dance with masks, drums, and flutes, because of the disorders that you

commit during the performance; but because you will not commit them at my house, I give you permission to do it here. But I warn you, though I give you this license, you do not have permission to dance at your homes; only at mine.”¹ García clung stubbornly to the belief that he had authority over the ritual and political life of the Yaqui pueblos. When he discovered that he had none and that the Yaquis would do what they pleased, he stood up and announced that he was letting them do it. García was further humiliated the next day when he went to Huirivis to say Mass. “There,” García wrote, “the same speech of exhortation was repeated, and the same dance, with different masks, drums and flutes and new decorations from the missionary houses and missions of Potam and Huirivis.” Once again the Yaquis ignored the prohibitions of both the governor and the Jesuits. García claimed to have had better luck in stopping the dance in the town of Torim, but by then it was plain to all that the Jesuits were losing whatever influence they had previously enjoyed over the cultural life of the Yaqui towns.²

The period from the end of the insurrection of 1740 through the independence of Mexico in 1821 saw the steady erosion and then the violent termination of Jesuit authority in north Mexico. Native peoples, settlers, clergy, and government had to work out new modes of communicating and negotiating among themselves as native action and Bourbon policy forced Jesuits closer and closer to the margins of mission life. Yet the imperial ironies of Yaqui history persisted in this period of transformative change. As they had throughout the 1730s and 1740s, the Yaquis deployed both weapons and words in their ongoing dialogue with representatives of empire. They negotiated hard to achieve the objectives their leaders had laid out in the years leading up to the insurrection: Yaquis wanted and often obtained the freedom to practice rituals such as the Paccola, while at the same time obtaining Catholic spiritual care and paid work within the structures of empire. Clergy, settlers, and government officials too deployed both words and weapons in their dialogue with the Yaquis. They learned from the harsh experience of 1740 that they had to be subtle, judicious, and respectful of local customs, while at the same time willing to brandish the iron fist of violence when dealing with their Yaqui allies.

Crumbling societies often leave chaotic records of their final years, an axiom that held true for late colonial Sonora. But the surviving records of the Yaqui mission’s last years, though fragmentary, are more abundant and more suggestive than scholars have realized to date. Visitation records, Jesuit correspondence, Bourbon inquests, and clerical reports on efforts to revive the mission after 1767 afford remarkable access to the renegotiation of the colonial pact. By the end of the eighteenth century the Yaqui people had worked extensively in the region’s

mines and forged deep relationships with the region's secular government. These relationships marginalized the Jesuits and, later, the secular priests who succeeded them. Yet at the same time, the Yaquis were remarkably successful in keeping Spaniards out of their space. Furthermore, they traveled often between their home territory and the region's mines and haciendas. The Yaquis were thus able to integrate themselves deeply into the global structures of empire while negotiating for greater political autonomy and pursuing a creative program of cultural bricolage, braiding together old and new forms in original ways.³

DECADENCE

In the years after the insurrection of 1740 the Jesuits did little to improve their standing in the Yaqui mission. Agustín de Arriola, perhaps the most level-headed of the Jesuits on the Yaqui mission, described his life as one of "a thousand thorns and afflictions" and wrote that the state of the Yaqui mission left him "utterly mortified." The main cause of his distress was the hatred between two of his fellow Jesuits, Lorenzo José García and Francisco Ortíz. García was a man who took great pleasure in the exercise of power and placed heavy emphasis on the importance of rules. Ortíz thought that charity and compassion were the main virtues of good missionaries and had a serious weakness for drink. Ortíz thought García was a martinet; García thought Ortíz was a slob. Their mutual loathing defined the late 1740s on the Yaqui mission.⁴

Ortíz began his tenure among the Yaquis on a hopeful note. He had served as a church canon in the Philippines before his transfer to Sonora in 1744. It is unclear why this transfer occurred, but Ortíz seems to have been happy about it. He wrote a brief history of the Yaqui mission's early years and lavished praise on both the founders of the Yaqui mission and on the Yaquis themselves. To Ortíz, Tomás Basilio, one of the first Jesuits to live among the Yaquis, represented the pinnacle of spiritual achievement. In Ortíz's account, Basilio slept on the ground, subsisted on roots and grass, and sacrificed his health and safety to save thousands of Yaqui souls. The Yaquis themselves were, to Ortíz's eye, model mission Indians. Thanks to the work of Basilio and men like him, the Yaquis were tremendously devout, attending Mass regularly and making sacred processions on Sundays and feast days. "They have no abuse or superstition worthy of reporting," he wrote, save "those common in Europe." Beyond this, the Yaquis were "corpulent," strong, and capable of performing amazing feats of endurance, such as walking dozens of leagues without water in the blistering desert heat. Ortíz was particularly impressed by the Christian charity with which the Yaquis treated one another.⁵

This lavish praise of the Yaquis and early Jesuits was an implicit critique of the Jesuits then at work on the Yaqui mission. If the Yaquis were such angels, why would they have revolted in 1740? Ortíz saw an answer to this question in the vicious character of the Jesuits presiding on the mission in the 1730s and 1740s. Chief among them was García, a man known to all for his severity. Arriola wrote that many Yaquis testified that García “treats them with too much rigor: both in whippings and in work, without leaving them space to tend to their *milpas*, and with food supplies scarce, and for whatever reason they receive clubs and blows.” Arriola feared the Yaquis would revolt if García was allowed to continue this line of behavior. Ortíz went further and accused García of killing the *temastían mayor*, the chief lay religious teacher of the community. On this “most delicate matter” Arriola said he did not believe Ortíz was right: the *temastían*’s wounds antedated the beating he took from García. But since many Yaquis blamed the Jesuit for the man’s death, Arriola wrote, “we have proceeded as if walking on hot coals.”⁶

Ortíz was passionate to the point of intemperance—even insanity—in his crusade to protect the Yaquis from García. Once, when Ortíz found two Yaqui *justicias* leading two Yaqui prisoners in chains from Torim to Bacum, he became apoplectic with rage. Ortíz surmised that García was responsible for chaining the two men, and so he freed them. He then began to rave, according to Arriola, “like Don Quixote de la Mancha, uttering marvels against padre Lorenzo.” The *justicias* informed García of these events, and he immediately saddled his horse and rode in pursuit of Ortíz and the freed Yaqui prisoners. García caught up to Ortíz near Bacum, whereupon Ortíz declared “a thousand follies” and tried to attack García with the reins of his horse. When García ran away, Ortíz dismounted, threw himself to the ground, and called out for the secular priest Pedro de Mendíbil to come and hear his confession.⁷

These and other similar deeds persuaded many witnesses that Ortíz was crazy. The judicious Arriola wrote that at some moments Ortíz would give “no particular sign of madness,” while at others he “does such things, that show he is insane, such as the freeing of the captives, and desiring to send armed Indians to seize the corn owed by father Lorenzo.” Arriola thought Ortíz was at least half crazy and that his illness was exacerbated by drink. He had dismissed García’s accusations of alcoholism as the slanders of an interested party. But this changed when Arriola saw Ortíz guzzle a half bottle of *aguardiente*, commit “a thousand crazy acts,” and then take up pen and paper to write three letters to padre García.⁸

Ortíz’s letters to García are some of the most remarkable documents in the history of the Yaqui mission, in that they allow the reader unfiltered access to the author’s id. In a letter to García, Ortíz wrote in hectic, splattered hand,

Despicable Thief! . . . Not only are you not a Jesuit, you are a despicable liar, enemy of God and of poor people. . . . The Indians are going to whip you and tie you up. . . . I will swear on the gospels that you donned the robe of the Company to steal, rob and slander. Sacrilegious liar, mulatto, little wolf, worthless, cruel, sacrilegious beast . . . mulatto dog, and if you aren't that, you're worse. . . . Useless thieving liar, the galleys are too light a punishment for your tyrannies, cruelties, and robberies. . . . You piece of shit, and shit of a worthless man. . . . The Indians want to whip your ass, mulatto . . . put that in your archive of shit!⁹

These were the drunken ravings of a broken man. When he was sober Ortíz berated himself for not being a better priest and denounced the failures of his fellow Jesuits. He loved the Jesuit order and said he would happily serve as a kitchen servant to his brethren, washing their dishes and licking their plates for sustenance, if only he could be transferred to the college of Tepotzotlán. When drunk, Ortíz fell apart. His correspondence documented the downward spiral of a man at the disintegrating edge of the Jesuit mission system.¹⁰

Yet the records of Ortíz's struggles on the Yaqui mission are significant for reasons beyond their documenting a curious case of emotional breakdown. Conflicts among Jesuits were openings for Yaqui political action. Both Ortíz and García had supporters among the Yaquis, and each tried to enlist them in their campaigns against the other. The Yaquis, in turn, used the dispute to lobby for privileges for themselves. Juan Paamea, the Yaqui mayordomo of the town of Cocorit, took García's side in the dispute and wrote a letter in the Yaqui language outlining his complaints against Ortíz. García translated it and passed it on to the Jesuit Lucas Luís Álvarez:

This paper by Juan Paamea, Mayordomo of the Pueblo of Cocorit, which I receive today, the 19th of March, 1747, at night, translated faithfully to the Castilian language, says the following:

Padre Lorenzo Joseph, May god preserve you and greatly help you. My dear Father, I tell you my sorrow in all truthfulness. I am a poor man who knows nothing; this you already know. This is what Padre Francisco Ortíz said to me when he arrived: He asked me: has padre Lorenzo come and visited these pueblos? And I said the following: yes he has come, and he came very sick. Then he said the following: the Padre is not sick, but rather he drinks wine, indeed very strong wine. And with this, he left. And having gone to Potam to see padre Agustín, he came, and then he asked me for maize. No, Padre, I said. He said, and how many *fanegas* are there in the store? And I responded, padre there are ten *almudes*. So he said to me, he had to send me to Pitic, because I did not want to take care of anything

and he was going to bury me alive, because the sheepskins had rotted. And he also said to me that he was going to slit my throat and my wife's with lashes, and would take away the keys from me, and that he would keep them. And so I will no longer hold this office, or place myself before the padre, when his reverence receives the mission. But this is not important. Even outside the house, I will do what I am ordered to do, and will work, when I am not in sight or presence of the Padre. This way I will be happy. Because I do not understand everything he says to me. And he wants to remove all the officials of the house, the fiscals, and the justices: and he said that there should not be more officials than the governor and the fiscal mayor, and single catechist, and a single cook. And for that reason he says he is going to kick us all out of here, and we all have to leave. This padre loves no one and is content with no one. And we say, Who is going to be happy with the padre if he wants only one person to have the offices, and for that person to work with no help? This is what I have heard; I tell the truth, and nothing more. And I say so because I have heard it myself from the Padre, and I have great pain and sadness to know these things. Padre, suffer and take pity on us, by God. We are sad indeed. Enough: see, my dear father, that I am without pleasure or consolation; I am very ashamed and sad: It is I who writes to you: Juan de Paamea, Mayordomo of Cocorit.

In order that the translation be faithful and legal, I sign in Torim, March 20, 1747, Jhs, Lorenzo Joseph García [rubric]

This letter is faithfully translated from the Yaqui language to the Castilian, Torim, March 20, 1747. Jhs. Agustín de Arriola [rubric]¹¹

Paamea's self-deprecating plea for protection was a clever bid for power. By denouncing Ortíz, Paamea sought to preserve paid offices in the church for his community. In ordinary times such a plea might go unheeded. But in the midst of a bitter dispute among the Jesuits, Paamea was able to obtain the support of García and Arriola and so was more likely to be heard by higher authorities.

Paamea's support of García placed him in a distinct minority. Despite his flaws Ortíz had much more to offer his Yaqui supporters than the despotic García. In 1749 the Yaqui captain general and governor of Torim corresponded with Ortíz and backed his attempts to denounce García before the provincial government. The two Yaqui officials testified before investigators from the Jesuit college of Sinaloa that García's parishioners hated him. Padre Juan Salgado offered a shrewd analysis of the Yaquis' willingness to support Ortíz: such was "the capricious character of these Indians, and such their voracity . . . , that for a piece of meat or a little corn, they will testify before Jesus Christ that they saw a fight between two Jesuits, and the most discontented among them

will make use of the dispute for their own particular ends." We see this every day, he said. "If they see a Padre disgusted, either with some Spaniard, or especially with some relative of his, they leave no stone unturned to stoke the flames." In the end, the Jesuit order took García's side in the dispute and removed Ortiz from the Yaqui mission in May 1751. But for as long as padres Ortiz and García were at each other's throats, the Yaquis exploited the differences between them for their own benefit.¹²

MISSION AND CIVIL GOVERNMENT, 1741–1767

Throughout the insurrection of 1740 the Jesuits continually sent letters of support for Agustín de Vildósola at the expense of Governor Huidobro. While Huidobro wrung his hands and ran away, Vildósola took the fight to the rebels, beat them in various battles, and executed their leaders. Vildósola's brutal treatment of the rebels endeared him to the Jesuits and to many of the region's settlers. Yet at the end of the uprising, Vildósola began to appropriate Yaqui workers for his own projects. The warm relations between Governor Vildósola and the Jesuits cooled and eventually froze into mutual hatred. The Jesuits brought complaints against Vildósola in Mexico City and persuaded the viceroy to investigate and finally to remove Vildósola from office. Between the insurrection of 1740 and the expulsion of the Jesuits in 1767, the Yaquis took advantage of these conflicts to pursue an agenda much like that of the reformist governors Juan Ignacio Jusacamea and Bernabé Basoritemea, seeking wealth, power, and cultural autonomy within the changing structure of Bourbon colonial government.¹³

Responding to Jesuit complaints, the viceroy sent two expeditions to the northwest to look into the region's governance and to recommend reforms. Rafael Rodríguez Gallardo led the first of these. In one crucial regard, Rodríguez supported the Jesuits, procuring Vildósola's removal from office in 1747. But while he carefully avoided questions of religion, Rodríguez nevertheless proposed reforms that would diminish the influence of the clergy in the political life of the region. The promotion of commerce was central to Rodríguez's program. He saw the economic backwardness of the region as the root of its problems. Because the region was so distant from central Mexico, Sinaloa and Sonora received commercial goods only after they had passed through the hands of various middlemen, each of whom raised prices on the next. The exorbitant cost of imports drove most people in northwest Mexico into the barter economy. The scarcity of circulating currency exacerbated the problem. To address these issues Rodríguez recommended the promotion of maritime trade in the Gulf of California to reduce prices and undercut the merchant clique

that got rich supplying the region. Rodríguez thought an indirect benefit of this policy would be to reduce the economic isolation of mission Indians.¹⁴

The preponderance of Indians in the population of the northwest troubled Rodríguez. He regarded most of Sonora's Indians as barbarians whose uncivilized condition made them dangerous to the colonial state. Spanish and Creole settlers were few and scattered. Those who did come to the northwest often left after realizing how dangerous it was. Rodríguez advocated the violent repression of uprisings and the congregation of "vagabond," or nomadic, Indians in towns. But Rodríguez's attitude toward sedentary Indians was quite different. He engineered the indefinite suspension of the Indian head tax in order to remove incentives for the sedentary Indians to flee the missions. And he recommended the expansion of Indian—especially Yaqui—participation in the government's campaigns against nomads.¹⁵

In the long-running dispute between Jesuits and miners over indigenous labor, Rodríguez compromised, but in a way that favored business and Indians over Jesuits. He agreed that mission towns should not be depopulated: he supported the 4 percent limit on the number of workers per town a settler could demand. Rodríguez also argued for strict enforcement of the rule that all Indian labor should be paid, and in money rather than in kind. But he argued for a rule that prohibited the imposition of religious duties beyond Sunday services on Indian workers, thus making it easier for them to work at a distance from their home villages. While avoiding a direct attack on the mission system, Rodríguez made proposals that cut against the grain of Jesuit desires. In this sense he was a subtle agent in the Bourbon government's ongoing campaign to reduce the role of the church in the political and economic affairs of native communities.¹⁶

The second royal investigator sent to the northwest was the naval officer Fernando Sánchez Salvador. He took a harder line than Rodríguez against the Jesuits, but his objective was the same: the gradual integration of the region's native peoples into the mainstream of colonial economic life. Sánchez advocated the secularization of all the Jesuit missions up to and including the Yaqui Valley and argued for the imposition of the Indian head tax. Sánchez took special note of the Yaquis, pointing out that many of them spoke Spanish fluently. This laudable skill had been developed, he said, in their frequent dealings with Spaniards outside the Yaqui Valley. Surely they had outgrown the mission, he reasoned. Like Rodríguez, Sánchez regarded the Yaquis as ideal Bourbon Indians: settled in their towns and aware of their separate status, while at the same time being active, industrious participants in the political and economic affairs of the colony. But Sánchez was more aggressive and, in the end, less effective than Rodríguez. The Jesuits thwarted the execution of

Sánchez's proposals by pointing out the disastrous effects of similar policies during Huidobro's tenure as governor.¹⁷

Though the Jesuits managed to stymie the most radical of the Bourbon reforms, the times slowly forced them to revise their thinking about the Yaquis. Abandoning the reactionary views of men like Ignacio María Nápoli and Lorenzo José García, they began to echo the relatively sanguine views Rodríguez and Sánchez expressed on the Yaqui mission and people. In a general visit of 1756 the Jesuit Juan Lorenzo Salgado wrote that, while the Yaqui mission churches and other buildings were in ruins and father García had fallen ill, the Yaqui mission as a whole was in robust health. Fathers Arriola and Ignacio Lizasoain were in good shape, he wrote, and made sure almost all the Yaquis took communion at least once a year. Perhaps the most striking measure of the Yaqui mission's well-being was the size of its livestock herds. Bacum and Cocorit shared 281 head of cattle, 225 of horses, 91 mules, and 10,000 head of sheep; despite their sizeable debts, Torim and Vicam shared 800 head of cattle, 398 of horses, 80 mules, and 6,000 head of sheep; Potam had 889 head of cattle, 9,926 sheep, 11,958 goats, 389 horses, and 32 mules; Rahum had 253 head of cattle, 2,000 sheep, 125 horses, and 25 mules; and Huirivis had 1,000 sheep. The insurrection of 1740 had caused much chaos and left the physical plant of the Yaqui mission in disrepair, but the mission's agricultural wealth remained more or less intact.¹⁸

Salgado took note of the fact that Yaqui involvement in economic activities outside the mission made it impossible to rebuild some of the mission churches and buildings. There was no church in Belén; it was impossible to build one because "every time one tries to begin the work, they [the Indians] go off to the mines." Beyond this, Salgado recorded that each mission bought, sold, and traded extensively with people from outside the mission. Even before the expulsion of the Jesuits, the Yaqui towns seem to have lost much of their missionary character. They had become well integrated into the larger economic networks of northwestern Mexico.¹⁹

This fact caused the Jesuits no pleasure, and they sought in the 1750s and 1760s to curb Yaqui movements outside the mission. They appealed to secular and ecclesiastical officials for assistance in this matter. Thirteen years after making his original report, Rodríguez weighed in on the topic in 1761. Writing of a community of Yaquis in the Valle de San Buenaventura in northern Chihuahua, he argued against their resettlement in the Yaqui Valley: "The Yaquis are of a hardworking spirit and inclination, very dedicated to mining, which they love, and for that reason, in distinction from other Indian nations, they are hardly rooted, if at all, in their home soil; and they are of a spirit so

haughty and generous that it impels them to travel, soliciting commerce and trade with the Spaniards at long distances from their own land, where the large number of these Indians, and the limited space in their pueblos, would fill them with bastard thoughts."²⁰ Rodríguez went on to explain that the Yaquis' dependence on flood farming in the Yaqui mission made the food supply unpredictable. In drought years Yaquis were forced to leave in large numbers to find sustenance or work outside the mission. Rodríguez contended that this flow of Yaquis into the labor markets of the north made them indispensable to the imperial enterprise:

In my conception, there is no Nation of Indians more profitable to the Monarchy than that of the Yaquis, since, although they leave their lands, it is to become vecinos, and to root themselves in the haciendas and mines of the Spaniards, soliciting their commerce, and trade, and enthusiastically embracing the work of mining, and the cultivation of the fields; and one can say that in Sonora and [Nueva] Vizcaya most of the mines were found and discovered by the Yaqui Indians; from this, one can infer how useful and beneficial they are for mining and agriculture, which are the two principal pillars of the conservation of the kingdom; and so the policy of reducing them, or congregating them in pueblos, which has been tried not a few times, with religious or pious motives, I consider, hold, and have held to be inimical to . . . the conservation of the state.²¹

To the Jesuit complaint that work in the mines morally corrupted the Yaquis, Rodríguez countered that most of the Yaquis spoke Spanish and were perfectly capable of hearing Mass in that language when away from the missions. This analysis testified to the deep integration of the Yaquis into the imperial world of northern Mexico, the dependency of the empire on their continued service, and the exceptional degree to which they maintained a distinct cultural identity even as they lived and worked far from their ancestral home.

The reforming bishop Diego Tamarón y Romeral went even further than Rodríguez and suggested that trying to confine the Yaquis in their villages would cause another revolt. Tamarón was one of the best informed and most intelligent observers of the political scene in north Mexico and offered his superiors a glittering treasure trove of information in his *Demonstration of the Supremely Vast Bishopric of Nueva Vizcaya*, 1765. His analysis of the role of the Yaquis in the society of northern New Spain is one of the most important that survives, because of his rare fluency in both fine-grained research and synoptic analysis. He traveled all over north Mexico and observed the Yaquis both on their home territory and in their far-flung enclaves. He said the Yaqui mission towns were

more populous than any others in the region but that fully two-thirds of the Yaqui population lived away from home. He counted two thousand Yaquis in Soyapa alone, and "multitudes" in Chihuahua, Parral, and Santa Barbara. Everywhere he went Tamarón was besieged by Jesuits who wanted the Yaquis to return to their mission. But he interviewed many others who told him that the Yaquis were by nature a wandering people with a strong propensity for mining. They were highly skilled in all facets of mining work and had a peculiar knack for finding new veins of silver and gold. For these talents and for their reputation as hard workers, miners all over the north sought Yaquis out and prized them. "And," Tamarón continued, "if all of them are confined to the small precinct of their towns, in which they have no occupation other than farmwork, the same would happen as occurred in 1740, when they revolted and caused consternation in all these provinces, even Vizcaya, and they were subjugated more by deception than by force." Considering all these facts, Tamarón opined that "it is a special providence of the Most High that this haughty, strong, and warlike race is so inclined to travel abroad, since, when they were gathered together, they were able to annihilate these provinces." The Yaquis were thus an integral part of the economy of north Mexico and exerted considerable leverage in their dealings with the imperial power. Their excellence in skilled labor freed them to range many miles from their hometowns, and their intimidating ferocity in war kept imperial officials from trying to shackle them in any one place.²²

Documents from the mining town of Parral, located hundreds of miles from the Yaqui Valley, confirmed aspects of both the Jesuit and crown analyses of Yaqui activity in the mines. Yaqui workers had set up a neighborhood all their own in Parral. A set of police documents from 1799 collected the testimony of many witnesses, who said the Yaquis drank much alcohol, gambled, and generally disturbed the peace. Several vecinos reported that in the "little village of los Yaquez . . . there was a great gathering of men and women, both white [*de razón*] and of the Yaqui Nation, some occupied in drinking what they call *tesgiüino* [corn beer] and *aguardiente*, and others fighting, and others gambling, and the rest doing what one should infer between men and women." When confronted, the Yaqui leader of los Yaquez blocked the entryway to the building where most of the partying was going on and dared the police to try to stop them. Meanwhile, the revelers escaped out the back window. Asked if this was common among the Yaquis, one witness replied, "The disorders are continuous in that pueblo," and "The people who attend these meetings are the same Indians who work as mine laborers, shepherds, tailors, weavers, and other vagabonds, and many women, gambling, drinking, and probably committing other

excesses." The investigators decided to release those they had arrested with a strong warning and a command that they maintain public order. The authorities refrained from further action, however, since punishing the Yaquis might induce them to run away.²³

Much as the Jesuits feared, the moral strictures on Yaquis seem to have been more relaxed in this mining town than in the Yaqui Valley. And as Rodríguez had observed, the Yaquis acted defiantly when confronted. This encounter also demonstrated how deeply worn the pathways between the Yaqui Valley and the northern mines had become. Yaquis of both sexes came in large numbers and established entire villages of their own, with their own customs and culture. The Yaquis did many types of jobs in and around the mines and were so valuable to those communities that they were given a good deal of leeway by the law. In this and later times the Yaquis used their participation in Spanish enterprises as a lever to gain freedom and mobility.

The military continued to be a critical point of contact between the Yaquis and the civil government. Throughout the eighteenth century Seris, Pimas, and, increasingly, Apaches invaded and raided Sonora. Under these circumstances, the Spanish military drew increasingly on Yaqui auxiliaries to protect the northern frontier. Yaquis came to form the majority of the soldiers staffing the presidio of Buenavista, and the Yaqui mission provided much of the food and supplies for this base. The Jesuits reluctantly cooperated in this enterprise but were never comfortable with the power and prestige that frontier defense conferred on Yaqui soldiers. Jusacamea, Basoritemea, and Juan Calixto Ayamea, leaders of Yaqui resistance in years past, had all been militia officers. Military service opened the eyes of some Yaquis to the possibilities of life outside the mission and to the advantages of engagement with empire.²⁴

The Yaquis may not have gotten their way with the civil government in the insurrection of 1740, but in the years thereafter they achieved many of the goals the rebels had fought for. By dogged persistence and careful attention to the political divisions within colonial society, the Yaquis secured greater control over cultural life on the mission and greater freedom of movement outside of it. They also traded extensively with the world outside the Yaqui Valley. Yet both at home and in distant mining towns such as Parral and San Buenaventura they maintained a distinctive cultural identity.

EXPULSION

In July 1767, Viceroy Carlos Francisco de Croix, Marqués de Croix, relayed the order of expulsion of the Jesuit order to Sonora. Having 678 priests and

brothers, an archipelago of missions, and a network of colleges for the Creole elite, the Society of Jesus was a pillar of New Spain's society. Their expulsion from all Spanish realms in 1767 marked what D. A. Brading has called a "violent watershed" in the political life of viceroyalty. Pedro Rodríguez de Campomanes, King Charles III's crown attorney, claimed that the Jesuits had been the secret authors of the Esquilache riots in Madrid and were plotting to undo the Bourbon reforms. He said the Jesuits were more loyal to the pope than to the king and so were parasites on the body politic. Their missions amounted to a state-within-a-state whose sole purpose was the enrichment of the Jesuit Order through the exploitation of Indians.²⁵

The expulsion of the Jesuits was greeted with consternation throughout Mexico. Riots flared across the diocese of Michoacán. In the northern mining city of Guanajuato mobs hurled rocks at the buildings housing the treasury, tobacco monopoly, and gunpowder monopoly—all symbols of the Bourbon state. Pátzcuaro and other native communities took up arms in protest. Visitor General José de Gálvez, the official charged both with the expulsion of the Jesuits and with the general visitation of New Spain, responded with astonishing severity. In Guanajuato he imprisoned 600 people for questioning, and of these he sentenced 148 to prison terms, 31 to life imprisonment, and 9 to death. He executed the native leaders of the community revolts and abolished their local governments. In all, Gálvez flogged 73 people, hanged 85, banished 117, and sentenced 674 to prison. These were harsh blows against both the church and the Creole elites so strongly associated with the Society of Jesus. Many historians have suggested that the Jesuit expulsion was so traumatic as to become a motive for the participation of Creoles and clerics in Mexico's struggle for independence.²⁶

In Sonora, too, the expulsion of the Jesuits came as a shock. Governor Juan Claudio Pineda received orders to round up the Jesuits on July 11, 1767, in San Miguel de Horecasitas. Pineda quickly mustered five officers, assigned each a set of missions, and ordered them to bring the resident Jesuits to the port of Guaymas for deportation. Pineda ordered the officers to respect the possessions and persons of the Jesuits and to use as little force as possible. Civilians were appointed as royal commissaries to inventory and administer the goods of the mission. Indians were not informed as to what was happening or why, but they were told that they were now under the sovereign protection of the king, would be allowed to live in "civil liberty" and to communicate and reside with Spaniards, "just as they do with their brothers."²⁷

Captain Lorenzo Cancio was responsible for assembling the Jesuits on the Yaqui mission and transporting them to Guaymas, where they would await

transportation to central Mexico. Cancio was a military officer with strong reformist convictions. In a letter of 1766 to Visitor General Gálvez he had advocated the gradual integration of the Yaquis into the surrounding society. He argued that Spanish families should be allowed to settle on the Yaqui River and should be rewarded for doing so with land and water rights. Thereafter, he reasoned, "Spanish men will soon marry Indian women, and Spanish women will marry Indian men, forgetting their barbarian customs and abominable vices in which they are now so blind, such that they horrify nature itself." This curious argument, that the Yaquis were abominable sinners with whom Spaniards should intermarry at their soonest convenience, displayed a certain ambivalence on Cancio's part. While condemning Yaqui vices, Cancio nevertheless found a great deal to admire in the Yaqui people and would collaborate closely with them in the deportation of the Jesuits. On September 19, 1767, he began work with the Yaqui captain general Andrés Gurrola and ten assistants from Vicam to assemble the Jesuits. Cancio observed the inhabitants of Huirivis, Rahum, and Potam and found them to be in a state of "consummate tranquility, very happy with the extraction of the padres." The padres themselves were miserable. Languishing in the hot, humid port of Guaymas, they whispered conspiracy to the Yaquis. Cancio heard it said among the Yaquis that a Jesuit had told them "America would be lost, and that in a short time it would no longer be of our monarch; and that the king of England had written to the Governor of Tlaxcala promising him that he would be made king if he acquired the Indians of this kingdom for his cult." Cancio soon put a stop to such talk, and the expulsion proceeded without further incident.²⁸

In the period immediately after the expulsion, Cancio forged strong bonds with the Yaquis. On October 1, 1767, he wrote that the natives of Bacum were so content with the new government that "without any order from me, they gathered forty Indians from Cocorit and Bacum and went to attack the enemy Sibubapas, having learned that on the twenty-eighth they had been at the oasis of Álamo and killed two travelers there." The Sibubapa rebels had also attacked the rancho of Vasitos, where they killed one woman, injured another, captured three little girls, and mortally wounded a mule driver. The Yaqui captain Calixto sent frequent reports on his pursuit of the enemy and promised to see all thirty of the rebels killed. Cancio wrote that he was utterly satisfied with Calixto's performance and that he intended to let the Yaqui captain know it: "I promised him a reward," Cancio wrote, "but since these Indians only believe what they can see, and dislike waiting, I invited him to this *presidio*, where I gave him shirts, stockings, leggings of colored leather, a scarlet lapel, and an ordinary Chinese cane, because he said that, with it, he would be more

respectable." Cancio was evidently experienced in the art of negotiating with Yaqui soldiers. He knew both the benefits of treating such allies well and the dangers of keeping Yaqui warriors waiting for their recompense.²⁹

Cancio offered further evidence of his deepening relationship with the Yaquis in a letter he sent to Governor Pineda on October 3, 1767. In the town of Torim, 130 Yaqui soldiers assembled for his review with their arms and supplies. Operating according to what he called the Yaquis' "mode of thought, I ordered that they be given two *reales* from the mission of Bacum. . . . You know well that these miserable people only believe what one tells them if it is accompanied by some gift to satisfy their hunger: I learned this when, after the review was over, I ordered them to give the 'long live the king!,' and they not only did so but also repeated it voluntarily." His willingness to learn and adapt to Yaqui cultural practices smoothed Cancio's dealings with the Yaquis in subsequent months.³⁰

Cancio worked hard to win the Yaquis' respect. In November 1767 he wrote to Pineda that the Jesuits on the Mayo and Yaqui Rivers had always run schools for native children in which they learned Christian doctrine, the Spanish language, "civility and good customs." Cancio instructed the procurators for the two former missions to keep the schools running exactly as they had under the Jesuits. The students, however, were naked, he said, so "it seems right to me to sell some cows so that the youths can cover themselves in this cold season." On another occasion Cancio intervened when he found the commissaries of the Yaqui mission selling cattle and other goods from the mission for unauthorized purposes. Cancio immediately stopped them because, he wrote, "selling the cattle and horses of the missions would make so terrible an impression on the spirit of the Indians, that it could lead us to a dreadful, indeed catastrophic, result." However he may have disdained Yaquis' perceived superstitions, Cancio clearly felt affection for the Yaquis and at the same time respected their capacity for extreme violence.³¹

Cancio's liberality afforded him access to the deliberations of Yaqui town governments. A Yaqui chaplain of Torim informed Cancio of the town's discontentment with its current governor, and accordingly he went to oversee the election of a new one. "It is true," he wrote, "that the governor of Torim is a very good man, but it is also true that he treats the other Indians with excessive asperity." Cancio thought it would be wise to remove this governor as well as the justicias of all the Yaqui towns because, he said, they were products of the old Jesuit regime and perpetuated its authoritarian ways. Governor Pineda expressed some doubts about this plan since it originated in secret councils of discontented Yaquis. But Cancio dismissed the possibility of an insurrection

because the malcontents had brought their concerns directly to him: "Their having come to me proves that there is not the slightest bad faith in their actions." Politics on the Yaqui mission, though in a state of flux, nevertheless displayed a familiar combination of delicate negotiations and threatened violence.

The transition to the post-Jesuit era of Yaqui history was surprisingly smooth. This was owing partly to Cancio's political acumen and partly to the fact that the expulsion of the Jesuits fulfilled the aspirations many Yaquis had held at least since the 1730s. The Yaquis would at last be able to take advantage of freedoms offered by the Bourbon regime without meddling by the Jesuits.

THE DISTURBANCES OF 1771

No political regime pleases all who live under it. In the late 1760s and early 1770s there were factions among the Yaquis who took violent measures to satisfy their desires. Cancio reported leading hundreds of Yaqui auxiliaries against Yaqui rebels on the Fuerte River in 1768. On June 23, 1771, Pedro Corbalán, the governor and intendant of Sinaloa and Sonora, heard rumors that a massive rebellion was being planned. Informers said several Yaqui pueblos were up in arms and had gone into the hills to ally with a band of Zuaque rebels. The next day Corbalán visited the Yaqui towns and was cordially greeted by the Yaqui captain general and governors. The rumors of the brewing rebellion were false, it seemed. Corbalán nevertheless asked to hear the complaints of the Yaqui officials and promised to redress any injustices they had suffered. "Although there are various issues that exasperated the Yaquis," he wrote, "I understand from the reports that there were four main problems." The first was that they objected to the personal service and work for the community they were sometimes forced to do by the secular priests who had replaced the Jesuits. They were exempt from such work, they said, "since they were as free as the Spaniards," an allusion to the promise of freedom they were given when the Jesuits were expelled. They went on to say that various parties had told them they should work for no one, not even the king, if they were not paid in advance. Yet at other times they heard they should work for the king for free. These conflicting messages had caused much confusion, they said.³²

The Yaquis' second complaint, which they shared with many native people in the northwest, was that various Indians had escaped from California in canoes and had told the Yaquis horror stories about work there. In light of these reports, the Yaquis refused to work in California. The third complaint was that, in the wake of Visitor General Gálvez's visit to northwest Mexico, they were

being charged the head tax. They could not pay it, they said, and were thinking of fleeing to the hills. Their final grievance was that Mayos had come to take salt that the Yaquis had refined and stored.³³

Corbalán responded that the only duty the Yaquis had to perform was to plant one *milpa* for the parish priest and one for the community. They were excused from paying parochial fees and cultivating a second community plot. Corbalán tried to convince the Yaquis that they were being assessed tribute not because they were bad but because they were the king's most loyal vassals in the region and were to serve as examples to the other tribes in the area. Since they had no silver, Corbalán said, they could pay in maize, wheat, beans, garbanzos, or salt. At this point the Yaquis agreed "with one voice" to pay the tax. Corbalán further assured them that whatever salt the Mayos took would be properly paid for.³⁴

These measures did not have the calming effect Corbalán had hoped for. A month later Juan Joseph Lumbreras, commander of the presidio of Buenavista, wrote to Corbalán to say that a servant, Ignacio Buitemea, "of the Yaqui nation, raised in my house and very truthful and faithful, who esteems me highly," had told him a secret. The servant swore him to silence for fear of being killed for revealing it. "The Yaquis," the servant said, "are prepared to rise in rebellion in alliance with the Pimas, and this he heard in secret in the pueblos of Cocorit and Bacum." Word had been sent out to all the Yaqui servants in the region's haciendas that they should come and join the rebellion or be killed with the Spaniards. Lumbreras sent word out to all the region's haciendas, presidios, and missions to be prepared for violence.³⁵

Despite Buitemea's protestations, Lumbreras swore in witnesses and a translator to take Buitemea's formal testimony. Buitemea described the conspiracy that was afoot and named one Calixto as its author. Two other Yaquis, Mateo Chinche, of Cocorit, and Antonio Goysuay, a mule-driver from the Hacienda of Cedros, threatened Buitemea, saying he should ally with the rebels or be killed. Buitemea had also seen Calixto meet with his coconspirators in the house of an old woman named Victoria. Calixto had said he would leave for the north side of the river, where twenty Pima allies awaited him. Speaking under oath, Chinche confirmed everything Buitemea said and added that Calixto was threatening to revolt because Governor Corbalán had threatened his life. Goysuay expanded on this claim, saying the people of Cocorit were scared the Spaniards were going to come and kill them all. They were planning to ally with the Pimas "in order to do first to the Spaniards what these [Spaniards] were planning to do to them." Lorenzo Huatemea added that various other Yaquis tried to persuade Calixto not to rebel but that Calixto had dismissed

them as his personal enemies and said he would soon leave to be with his Pima allies.³⁶

On hearing of these developments Governor Corbalán flew into action, notifying authorities throughout the province and mustering thirty soldiers to secure the Yaqui pueblos. On August 26, Miguel de Encinas, the parish priest of Cocorit, wrote that Calixto had left for the hills to join his Pima allies. Encinas went on to report that he had gathered the people of Cocorit to try to dissuade them from rebellion. Encinas wrote two days later that he was doing all he could to persuade the Indians of Cocorit and Bacum to stay calm and be loyal to the king. Calixto remained in the countryside, and for the moment the rest of the Yaqui pueblos kept calm and showed no signs of incipient rebellion. In a note to the captain of the presidio of Buenavista, Juan Manuel Díaz de Frías gave a contradictory account: a former soldier in Calixto's party had witnessed an encounter between Calixto and a one-eyed Pima messenger on the outskirts of the Yaqui mission. Calixto was planning to raid the sheep herds of the Yaqui mission and asked the messenger what the captains—later revealed to be a Pima and a "Piato"—said. The messenger responded ambiguously that the captains were very well and sent Calixto their enthusiastic greetings.³⁷

Calixto's planned uprising seems to have had supporters, but neither he nor they took any further action. Father Encinas took this moment as an opportunity to open a dialogue with the rebels. He sent word to Calixto expressing his willingness to talk and attend to whatever concerns the rebel leader presented him.³⁸

Governor Corbalán wrote from the presidio of Buenavista to second this offer of reconciliation with Calixto. The letter he sent to Captain General Gurrola testified to the delicately negotiated relationships between the government, clergy, and Yaqui people:

Letter to the Captain General of the Yaqui River:

My Lord: I believe Your Grace to be sufficiently informed of the latest changes to have occurred in the pueblo of Cocorit, and I trust that your fidelity will have taken the most effective measures to prevent even the lightest consequences that could result from them. But since I find myself in this Presidio of Buena Vista, I nevertheless intend to travel to this river for the purpose of attending personally to whatever its natives ask. I will confirm this tomorrow afternoon with some soldiers, whose number should not cause anyone any fear, since Your Grace will assure everyone that they will not receive the slightest harm if they do not give any reason for it. Your Grace may even send word to Captain Calixto, who is said to be in the countryside, that I esteem him, and that both he and some of his allies can present

themselves before me without suspicion to tell me what has moved them to such a decision, assured that I will satisfy them in all that is just. In conclusion, finally, I hope that your grace will apprise me of any new events that take place . . . in the said town of Cocorit, where I hope to be on the same day in the morning.—May God keep your grace many years, Buenavista, August 30, 1771.³⁹

Corbalán seems to have understood that his presence was disruptive and that his visit could very well have been the occasion of violence. Recognizing the risks he was taking in visiting the Yaqui towns, he contacted the Yaqui captain general ahead of time and gave him a full account of his peaceful intentions. He addressed the captain general, a Yaqui, in strikingly deferential terms, as “My Lord,” (*Señor Mío*) and “Your Grace” (*Vuestra Merced*). Corbalán recognized the captain general’s importance to the success of his visit. Corbalán’s letter was a diplomatic overture to a powerful ally capable of turning suddenly against him. The governor was aware of his own power and hinted that he too was capable of threatening those who did not respect him: “They will not receive the slightest harm,” he wrote, “if they do not give any reason for it.” This was an exchange between two strong and mutually dependent civil governments. The clergy were marginal to their relationship. Corbalán did inform father Encinas that he would soon be visiting the Yaqui pueblos, but he did so in a much more cursory and informal manner than he did with the Yaqui captain general.

Corbalán arrived on September 1 and immediately began trying to figure out what rebel activity was going on and why. The first witness he swore in was Francisco Guatemala, a Yaqui militia soldier from Cocorit who had served under Calixto Valencia. He testified that ten days earlier Calixto had come to his house in the middle of the night and ordered him to get up and get his weapons in order to hunt down three criminals. Guatemala said he obeyed and went with Calixto to the house of Luis Sopamea, another militia soldier under Calixto’s command, who was given the same orders. The three of them went to the sheep pasture of Cocorit. There, Calixto introduced them to an “ambassador” from the Pimas, who said the Pimas wanted all the Yaquis to bury their supplies and to bring their families to the north side of the Yaqui River in preparation for an attack on the Spanish. Another sworn witness, Luis Sopamea, confirmed Guatemala’s testimony but said he had never heard Calixto suggest they should rebel. Pablo de la Cruz, the Yaqui governor of Cocorit, came forward with testimony that Calixto did indeed plan to rebel. He said Calixto appeared before various residents of Cocorit and said to them, “You are all to blame for my sadness. If you were men, not women, you would

take up arms and help me revolt against the Spaniards." Cruz said no one took Calixto seriously.⁴⁰

Governor Corbalán was a subtler politician than his predecessors Huidobro and Vildósola, and he showed it in his speech to the people of Cocorit. He stood up before the assembled officials and residents of Cocorit and made a long speech exhorting them to remain loyal to the crown. "They responded," wrote Corbalán, "in one voice that they had not the slightest thing to complain of and are very content." After soliciting cheers of support from the townspeople, Corbalán went on to compliment them warmly for being "Christians and true vassals of the king." He said he came to prevent the harm that was threatened by Calixto's incipient rebellion.⁴¹

Having won a measure of confidence from his listeners, Corbalán then took a darker turn. He said the Yaqui population was large, and for that reason it would be impossible for them to hide their women, children, and old people if the Spanish came to punish them. Since Yaqui men were dispersed in so many mines and haciendas, it would be the most vulnerable Yaquis who first felt "the rigor of arms." He proclaimed that no distinction could be made between good and evil Yaquis. Where, he asked, would they hide their possessions that the Spaniards could not find them? What land could they aspire to live on that was more fertile, abundant, and beautiful than the one they already enjoyed? They would surely lose it if they followed the "perverse maxims of the said Calixto." The fight, Corbalán said, was futile, since the king would send a hundred Spanish soldiers for every rebel and exact terrible revenge.⁴²

James Scott has identified the many crafty ways oppressed people resist their oppressors without resorting to violence. The activities of Corbalán in the Yaqui Valley indicate that in the absence of overwhelming power, domination in northwestern Mexico had to be a subtle art as well. Corbalán's speech before the people of Cocorit was a tour de force of mingled affection and menace. He carefully created circumstances in which the people of the Yaqui Valley would be willing to listen to him and then vividly illustrated both the comforts of peace and the horrors of war. He ended his discourse with a flourish of false bravado. Even if the king and his governor wanted to do so, they could never have mustered one hundred soldiers for every rebel. Imperial rule required an illusion of invincibility and an aura of legitimacy. Corbalán was a master illusionist and managed to overcome his isolation and vulnerability by casting a verbal spell. Very few Yaquis would follow Calixto's lead into rebellion.⁴³

Though few followed him, Calixto himself remained an outlaw through 1771 and 1772. An unnamed civil official reported in June 1772 that Calixto had hidden in the thick reedbeds near Vicam. Word had been sent to Calixto that

he should come back to settle in Cocorit and that no action would be taken against him. Corbalán passed the problem off to Andrés Gurrola, the Yaqui captain general, with instructions to tell Calixto he would be pardoned in the king's name if he came back to live in Cocorit. All this was to no avail. Much the same message was sent to Calixto on August 8, 1772, with the same result. Father Francisco Joaquín Valdés wrote two days later, "Regarding captain Calixto, I am still taking measure to see if it is possible to get him to abandon the . . . hills and to return to his pueblo . . . and I will omit no measure until I achieve that end." But neither Valdés nor anyone else made any progress. And there, it seems, the issue died. There is no record of Calixto's having returned to Cocorit or of any pardon having been issued. Nor is there any indication that the Yaquis rebelled.⁴⁴

The disturbances of 1771 illustrated the nature of Spanish relations with the Yaquis and the limitations of Spanish power over them. As had been the case throughout the colonial period, the Spanish were a powerful force in regional politics but never had the means to coerce the Yaquis to do their bidding. For the most part, the Spanish dealt with the Yaquis politically, not militarily, and relied more heavily on words than on weapons in their efforts to manage this key strategic ally. The disturbances of 1771 illustrated change as well as continuity. The expulsion of the Jesuits eliminated a key intermediary between the Yaquis and the Spanish civil government. This created new challenges to mutual understanding and required the creation of new channels of communication between Yaquis and Spanish officials. As Yaquis and Spaniards tried to renegotiate the fiscal and political terms of their alliance, the clergy played an ever-diminishing role. Direct correspondence between the Spanish governor and the ever more prominent Yaqui captain general became the order of the day. There were stumbles, errors, and misunderstandings in the post-Jesuit era. But the Yaquis' overwhelming opposition to the rebellion proposed by Calixto signaled their relative satisfaction with the liberties and challenges of this new era.

REORIENTATIONS, 1772–1810

On June 14, 1784, the Yaqui captain general Felipe de Jesús Álvarez wrote to the lieutenant Joseph María Areñas to tell him to stop meddling in Yaqui affairs. Areñas had detained an Indian lieutenant general, and Captain General Álvarez was not happy about it. "You do not have command of Indians," he wrote, ". . . with Indians, I and the lieutenant general [do]; thus, my friend, let the lieutenant go, since he is doing nothing that he was not ordered to do; I sent

him because I cannot go myself. . . . he goes with my order to do what I told him to, and I did not put it in writing because he is known up and down the river to be the lieutenant general; if he bothers any white person [*de razón*], let me know . . . and if he does so with any Indian, leave him alone.”⁴⁵ Here, a literate, self-assured Yaqui captain general rebuked a Spaniard in order to protect his jurisdiction. This was a pattern that would repeat itself in the final years of the eighteenth century and the first years of the nineteenth. With the partial consent of the Bourbon authorities, the Yaquis would take an increasingly assertive role in the local politics of the Yaqui River.

Yaqui political control of the former mission towns was facilitated by the relative absence of non-Yaquis; very few were permanent residents of the Yaqui Valley. A report from 1784 held that Cocorit and Bacum “are both of the Yaqui nation, use their old language, and few speak Spanish. In [Cocorit] there live ten or twelve families of Mulattos and vagrants [*vagos*].” This investigator noted the predominance of Yaqui language and culture among the Yaquis and the relative absence of non-Yaquis in the historic Yaqui mission towns. A secular priest named Francisco Joaquín Valdés fleshed out these data in a long letter of August 3, 1790. Basing his judgments on twenty-three years of living in the Yaqui towns, he wrote, “Many of these Indians speak Spanish, especially those who frequent the mines, placers of gold, and Haciendas. . . . Rarely do they speak it [Spanish] in their homeland, and they never confess in it.” The Yaquis were by this time thoroughly bicultural, maintaining their language and traditions at home while engaging in extensive trade with Spaniards: “They observe a regular harmony with the Spaniards in their dealings and reciprocal commerce.” He noted, however, that while dealings between the Yaquis and Spanish were extensive, they were not affectionate or free from mutual suspicion. Valdés echoed many others in writing that very few non-Yaquis had settled in the Yaqui towns, another measure of Yaquis’ strict control over affairs in their home territory.⁴⁶

Valdés wrote of having labored for years to improve the moral and material quality of life among the Yaquis. But he gave the impression that he was struggling to beat back a rising tide of disorder, moral laxity, laziness, and unwarranted self-regard. “There are eight towns on the Yaqui River,” he wrote, “which are not proper *pueblos* but rather *rancherías* dispersed along the river’s floodplain.” Like the Jesuits before him, Valdés saw the dispersion of the Yaquis outside towns as a sign of social disintegration: good Indians lived in Spanish-style settlements; bad ones lived scattered in the wilderness. Yaqui children, Valdés wrote, were ill raised and disrespectful and were “striding with giant steps, so to speak, toward their ruin.” Drunkenness was rampant, he

wrote, and the Yaquis misused the prodigiously fertile land they lived on. They did not cultivate it intensively, growing only what they needed in the short term, and spent a great deal of time working in Spanish mines and haciendas. The land itself seemed to conspire with the Yaquis to make life loose, mobile, and unpredictable in precisely those areas where Valdés thought it should be orderly, clean, and lawful. The river flooded regularly, making it impossible to create permanent towns and settlements, and the changing course of the river altered landmarks and boundaries, making it impossible to create stable titles to land. In the absence of such land titles it was impossible to divide and sell the land, as José de Gálvez had ordered.⁴⁷

Bourbon officials had abetted the moral decline of the Yaquis in various ways, wrote Valdés. They allowed Yaquis to travel abroad without papers and to work in morally degenerate environments. In a decree of June 8, 1787, Viceroy Croix had forbidden priests to punish Indians corporally and given this responsibility to Yaqui town governors and the captain general. These Yaqui officials rarely used this power, and so Yaquis increasingly did what they pleased. The effect on the religious life of the towns was, in Valdés's opinion, predictably dire. Yaquis confessed and went to Mass less frequently, young people failed to formalize their sexual relationships in marriage, and old people died without sacraments.⁴⁸

This gloomy interpretation of Yaqui life in late-Bourbon Sonora is not the only one available. In 1804 the subdelegate of the province of Ostimuri, Don Jacinto Álvarez, reported on the same topics, in far greater detail and without the moralizing tone of father Valdés. On a reconnaissance trip to the former Yaqui mission, Álvarez saw that some of the Jesuit era churches were in disrepair, but that they were still perfectly functional for regular services. The Yaqui towns comprised no fewer than twenty thousand Yaqui families, in addition to those Yaquis who were away working at the mines. There were a few white families scattered throughout the Yaqui towns, and all sustained themselves by the superabundant harvests from the riverside fields. As they had three hundred years before, the Yaquis harvested two crops a year. Corn, beans, squash, and wheat all grew in abundance, and fruit trees produced copious figs, guavas, pomegranates, pears, and peaches. Yaquis sold sugar cane and cane syrup for cash. Such was the productivity of Yaqui agriculture, wrote Álvarez, that "the Yaqui Indians sustain the whole province, as much by their produce as by their personal work in the mines and haciendas, both for silver refining and stock raising, as well as in the gold placers, to all of which they are strongly inclined." Álvarez's portrait of the Yaquis at the end of the colonial period was one of a colonial-native society in robust health.⁴⁹

That is not to say that life in the Yaqui towns was easy. The vagaries of the weather played havoc on the Yaquis. Dry years killed crops and cattle and reduced the Yaquis to gathering roots and the edible parts of the mescal cactus, fishing in the river and selling salted fish in the region's mining towns. Salt deposits were a further hedge against bad harvests. Salt was a key component in silver refinement, and they sold it in bulk to the nearby refining mills. Álvarez reported that Yaqui involvement with small-scale manufacturing was extensive. He saw many Yaqui women producing wool cloth on looms in their homes, and father Valdés, despite his low opinion of Yaqui morals, encouraged Yaqui women to plant flax for the production of linen cloth. A second parish priest named Acosta helped build an *obraje* for the production of wool and brought a master weaver from Querétaro to train ten young Yaqui apprentices in the business. A master hatmaker trained six Yaqui apprentices in Rahum, and a master potter stationed in the same town did the same until his untimely death. Rahum also had a master metalworker expert in casting bells and other instruments. Agriculture formed the core of the ex-mission's economy, but it was certainly not the only industry in which the Yaquis excelled.⁵⁰

Father Valdés must have revised his low opinion of Yaqui abilities by the nineteenth century, since he had by that time founded a school for the training of native priests. He supplied fourteen Yaqui youths with clothing, food, and a *maestro* to teach them letters and the Spanish language. Of these, two achieved the status of priest. Other Yaquis excelled in other trades without the benefit of formal training. "The Yaqui people are very talented," Álvarez wrote, "and among them there are many carpenters, tanners, musicians, and other people of other arts, which they exercise out of their natural inclination, because they have no teachers." Art was a field in which Álvarez reported stunning Yaqui achievements: "From canes, they make sweet flutes that they play with such perfection that it seems they were taught by Bacchus himself." Yaqui woodworkers carved violins, harps, guitars, and other instruments that the Yaquis played with exquisite skill.⁵¹

At few other times before or after the late eighteenth century did the Yaquis exercise such extensive control over their own cultural, political, and economic life. They retained almost total dominion over former mission lands and excluded non-Yaquis from them. They pursued a wide variety of economic activities within and outside the Yaqui Valley. Bourbon law and Yaqui will placed unprecedented power in the hands of the Yaqui governors and captain general. The Yaquis had a vibrant ceremonial and religious life in which Spanish clergy played an ever-dwindling role. The enthusiasm and

supposed superstition of Yaqui religious activities offended clergy and Bourbon reformers alike. But it also indicated the extent to which the Yaqui people had taken control of their fate.

The mid- to late eighteenth century was a fraught, complicated time for native peoples under Spanish colonial rule. Changes in Bourbon political philosophy presented Indians with new challenges and new opportunities. Bourbon officials departed from their Habsburg predecessors in thinking Indians capable of greater self-rule and entitled to more extensive participation in the colonial economy than had ever been the case before. Rather than conquering and converting native peoples, the Bourbon government sought to entice them into the colonial mainstream. In many instances this enticement took the form of attracting native migration to urban centers, where their ethnic distinctiveness would fade. Yaquis, Ópatas, Mixtecs, and Otomís were to become *Indios* and eventually *Mestizos*, thus eliminating the threat they posed as foreign, often discontented entities within the body politic. In frontier regions Bourbon policy dictated that gift giving and alliance making were to govern imperial relations with native peoples. The hope was that dependence on Spanish gifts would both mollify and enfeeble uncontrolled Indian subjects. As Viceroy Bernardo de Gálvez wrote in his *Instructions for Governing the Interior Provinces of New Spain*, "It is my intention to establish with the Indians a commerce which will attract them to us, which will interest them, and which will in time put them under our dependency." In many instances the political assimilation of native peoples was violently coercive. Where mining towns boomed, demand for agricultural farmland rocketed upward, missions were secularized, and Indians were pushed off territory they had lived on for decades, if not centuries.⁵²

Comparison with the neighboring Ópata people throws the distinctiveness of the Yaqui experience into high relief. Whereas the Yaquis have become famous for their endurance as a distinct ethnicity, the Ópatas are known, if at all, for having disappeared. Nobody identifies himself as an Ópata today. The anthropologist David Yetman traces the disappearance of the Ópatas to six root causes: the Ópatas had never been a united people, and their towns were geographically remote from one another; Ópata lands were excellent and hence coveted by outsiders; disease killed many Ópatas; mining work attracted many others away from the social milieu that allowed for the continuation of their traditions; Apache raids forced the Ópatas to ally with Europeans and therefore to acquire their customs; and the absence of the Ópata men who worked in mining camps made their hometowns vulnerable to exploitation.⁵³

The Yaquis suffered many of the same travails. They worked in Spanish mines, died of European diseases, and lived on land that was fiercely desired by outsiders. But unlike the Ópatas, the Yaquis lived in close geographical proximity to one another. They annoyed their employers in mining towns by maintaining their ethnic cohesion in Yaqui *barrios*, and they insisted on returning to the Yaqui mission for some three months of the year in order to plant their crops and practice their ceremonies. There is minimal evidence of Apache, Pima, or Seri raids on the Yaqui pueblos. If such a raid were to occur, service in regional militias provided the Yaquis with the experience and arms to defend themselves. Indeed, Yaqui militiamen traveled far and wide to assault the *Indios bárbaros* on their home ground. The Yaquis thus shared less with the doomed Ópatas than they did with the vecinos of New Mexico, who seized on political change in the Bourbon era to deepen the distinctiveness of their culture while taking an active part in imperial economic life.⁵⁴

In the transformative years after the insurrection of 1740, the imperial ironies of Yaqui colonial history persisted in new forms. The Yaquis continued, with greater success than ever before, to pursue their collective desires and interests within the changing structures of imperial government. They deployed enormous skill and determination in negotiating the best possible deal they could get from the empire they lived within.

Though the colonial period never saw another explosion of violence like the insurrection of 1740, violence was nevertheless a fact of life in and around the Yaqui mission. Jesuits whipped Yaquis and, in the extraordinary case of Francisco Ortíz, physically attacked other priests. Yaquis threatened to revolt, sometimes did revolt, fled to the wilderness, whipped up conflict among Spaniards, openly challenged Spanish military authorities, and continued their extensive involvement in imperial conquests and counterinsurgency campaigns outside the Yaqui Valley. All the while, the Yaquis continued their dialogue with the agents of empire, trading, collaborating, and fighting rebels shoulder to shoulder with Spanish military men. To the Yaquis, the violence of the colonial period was not a forest fire that ravaged the land and was then extinguished; it was, rather, a scattering of continuous, semicontrolled bonfires, some of which slowly burned out while others flamed suddenly to life. The fires of violence were an integral part of the Yaqui colonial experience, sometimes threatening and destroying, sometimes illuminating and warming the negotiations that went on between them and the empire.

Over the course of the colonial period the Spanish accumulated a great deal of knowledge of how best to survive and exploit their holdings in northwest Mexico. They had long known the folly of attempting violent conquest and had

long relied on strategic allies in the region. The Yaquis were the lynchpin of this strategy. Yaqui military officials had long been the main point of contact between the civil government and the Yaqui people. Much of the political drama of the eighteenth century can be traced to its origin in Bourbon attempts to strengthen direct governmental ties to the Yaquis and thereby diminish the mediating role of the clergy.

Taken together, the rich records of the Yaqui mission in the eighteenth century tell the story of an exceptionally resourceful people who were industrious and sophisticated in their struggle to make their relationship with empire as profitable as they could. The achievement of the Yaquis lay not in fighting the empire to a standstill and raising a fist in victory, like Arminius the Goth over the vanquished legions of Rome. It lay, rather, in the perceptiveness with which the Yaquis read their imperial adversary and the skill with which they created, managed, and manipulated their relationship with it. Into the far darker and more destructive nineteenth century, the Yaquis carried knowledge of the outside world, experience dealing politically with outsiders, and a carefully preserved yet flexible native culture. This combination of deep roots and worldly wisdom would make the Yaquis uniquely formidable opponents to an implacable and uncomprehending Mexican state.

EPILOGUE: REPUBLICAN IRONIES

The Yaquis, whose powerful structural organization and whose energetic intellectual activities make them capable of acquiring a high level of culture, must soon disappear as a race, and they are at present undergoing a period of transition, after which they will enter definitively into the ranks of contemporary civilization, and, impelled by the omnipotent evolutionary force of progress, they will march, mingled together with their brethren, toward the indefinite perfection of humanity.

—Fortunato Hernández, *Las razas indígenas de Sonora*

In January and February 1828 the provincial governor of the independent Mexican state of Occidente issued two decrees that rang the death knell of the old regime in the Yaqui Valley. The first offered a blanket pardon to former rebels who had risen under the leadership of Juan Ignacio Jusacamea, better known as Juan de la Cruz Banderas, and restored their citizenship in the Mexican Republic. The second created a new political unit comprising the eight Yaqui communities, with the presidio of Buenavista as its head town. It also ordered that Indians and whites were to be treated in terms of rigorous equality and decreed that whites were to be given tax incentives to settle among the Yaquis. It empowered the presidio of Buenavista to oversee both the common lands of each Yaqui town and the private real estate of each of the Yaquis. Its final measure allocated two thousand pesos for the improvement and development of Yaqui fields.¹

Almost all of these new laws masqueraded as acts of generosity, while being, in reality, attacks on everything the Yaquis held dear. Citizenship and the relations of equality with people of other ethnicities that it implied represented an attack on the special rights, privileges, and cultural peculiarities the Yaquis had developed over the course of the colonial period. The powers granted to

the presidio of Buenavista deprived traditional Yaqui officeholders of their long-held jurisdictions. Encouraging the mixture of whites with Yaquis, while seeming to be a prescient nod toward racial equality, contravened the desires the rebels had expressed time and again over the past three years that *yoris* be kept out of their lands. The granting of money for the improvement of Yaqui agriculture was perhaps the most ominous gesture of all. Improvement, in the parlance of early Mexican liberalism, almost always meant giving title to individual plots of land to individual Indians, incentivizing self-interested productivity and the commodification of real estate.²

Two new decrees, issued in September 1828, fulfilled these dark promises: one created a new form of government for Indian towns, and the other ordered the division of native land into private parcels. Under the new regime, the old native militias would be abolished and their members would be integrated into a new state militia. Indians were to have full citizenship and were ordered to take part in all popular elections. The ancient native offices of captain general and lieutenant general would cease to exist. The lands of native towns were to be cultivated by both the Indians and the whites who had settled among them, and the proceeds were to be used to maintain parish churches and to support public education. Children were to learn their letters in each town's school, and the most promising students were to be sent away for advanced studies in Guadalajara and Mexico City.³

Crown officials had contemplated various similar acts before independence. Lorenzo Cancio had fantasized about wholesale intermarriage between Yaquis and Spaniards in the 1760s. Father Francisco Joaquín Valdés had instituted a school for the education of Yaqui children in the 1770s. José de Gálvez had even ordered the parceling and distribution of lands in 1769. But none of these initiatives had made much of a dent in the old order on the former Yaqui mission. Moreover, the reforms had never been put forward as an integrated program or imposed with such aggressiveness. The aggressiveness of the state government toward Indians was of a piece with larger shifts under way in Mexico as a whole. Bourbon officials knew that in order to control New Spain's northern borderlands, they had, as Brian DeLay has put it, "to recognize the limits of their own power" and "to entertain complicated stories about regional and continental power, stories in which native peoples could play decisive roles." Independent state governments at first followed in the footsteps of their Bourbon predecessors but soon became ambivalent. They gradually abandoned Bourbon policies and began to approach native peoples in much the same spirit the United States did, expecting stateless native peoples either to assimilate to the mainstream or to disappear.⁴

Some idea of the threat these new policies represented can be obtained by reading them in light of an account of the Yaqui towns written in 1784 by Bishop Antonio de los Reyes. "The Indians," he wrote, "live dispersed along the shores and fields by the river, where they plant wheat, maize, beans, and other crops, it being impossible to fix their fields in any determined plot of land, because of the river's strange and terrible floods." This was still the case in 1790, when father Valdés wrote that no marking or division of lands had yet occurred. The reason, he said, was that "each one cultivates his land, always according to what he desires, and where he can settle without anyone hindering him, making the land he levels his own with only this title; and since there is no stability in these lands, it seemed best to me that they subsist in the same condition, . . . and to make no changes." Valdés went on to wonder at the notable efficiency of the Yaqui town governments in all matters *except* the question of the demarcation and distribution of land. On that issue alone they could not, or would not, move forward. The continual movement of the river course made things yet more difficult by making it impossible to say which space belonged to whom. When floods left the land damp and fertile, the Yaquis ate like kings. In times of drought, they turned to hunting, fishing, and gathering wild fruit. Unpredictable though it was, the Yaqui way of managing land, space, and agriculture had been tremendously successful. By all accounts it supported populations higher than those of any other native people in the region. The imposition of a new, liberal regime of landholding, facilitating the sale of land and the invasion of outsiders, threatened the Yaquis with a profound disruption of their way of life. So too would the creation of a new form of local government and new relationships between Yaqui town authorities and the authorities of the regional government.⁵

The Yaquis responded to the new liberal reforms with a far more radical kind of insurgency than anything seen in the colonial period. The English traveler Robert Hardy witnessed much of the uprising and was intrigued by its leader, Juan de la Cruz Banderas. Banderas earned his name from a flag (*bandera*) he carried with him at all times, which he said had been stolen from the Aztec emperor Moctezuma by Spanish invaders three hundred years before. "He is said to be small of stature," wrote Hardy, who seems never to have met the man face to face, "but endowed with a natural flow of eloquence quite extraordinary, and with a talent and activity which have kept up the revolution for two years." Hardy offered a specimen of the leader's eloquence in a speech before Mayo leaders whom he wished to attract to his cause:

By imitating our example in the struggle for liberty, you would have proved yourselves worthy of its reward—worthy to be called the descendants of the

brave and too-confiding Moctezuma. I offered you a share in the glorious enterprise; but the wisdom, spirit, and valor of your ancestors is a flame that burns no more;—the earth has consumed it—the water has extinguished its fire. I offered you the prize of freedom, because I supposed you worthy of it. But I see that I have deceived myself; slavery has brutalized your souls; you have disgraced our forefathers, and you will be the contempt of our sons' sons. I found you slaves, and slaves may you continue.⁶

Hardy may have added to this account a touch of Henry V's "once more unto the breach" address from Shakespeare's history play, with its command to "dishonor not your fathers." But there are elements of Hardy's account of this oration that echo Banderas's surviving letters. In one published proclamation, Banderas wrote, "I say, the flag of our sovereign king Moctezuma . . . , I inherited from my lady of Guadalupe, and it is in Spain. And so I say to all the nations, Yaquis, Pimas, Mayos, Ópatas, Eudeves, Apaches, Papagos, and Seris, you must not favor the *gachupines* [a derogatory term for Spaniards], but rather join with me to win the crown that I seek." It is clear from the writings of both Hardy and Banderas himself that the demands of this insurgency were fundamentally different from anything the rebels of 1740 had called for.⁷

To be sure, there were similarities, beginning, remarkably, with both the name and surname of leading players in these two movements: Juan Ignacio Jusacamea. Both men who went by that name—one called Muni in 1740 and the other who went by Banderas in the late 1820s—indicated in both words and deeds that they wanted some things to remain constant. Catholic Christianity was important to both Jusacameas. Banderas may have wanted to don the crown of Moctezuma, but he did not call for a return to the cult of Quetzalcoatl. Beyond that, Banderas drew on some deeply European ideas when he envisioned the future of Sonora: the idea of nation was central to his program, both in the archaic sense in which the Jesuits used the term, that is, to refer to native groups, and in the more modern sense of an independent nation-state. Moreover, Banderas published his writings in Spanish, not Yaqui. Though he called for native unity against Europeans, the very idea of interethnic alliance against empire was alien to the pre-Hispanic native peoples of northwestern Mexico. They were never united in their response to the Spanish. The idea that the many distinct native societies of northwest Mexico should all be placed in the single category of Indian was very much a product of the colonial past.

But despite such continuities between the colonial and postcolonial revolts, there were deep differences between them. The call for the expulsion of *gachupines* was a profound innovation and almost certainly derived from Yaqui experience in the Mexican independence movement. The call for a return to

the rule of Moctezuma was also radically new. The only people who ever discussed such a notion in the colonial period were reactionary Jesuits who, in the same breath they used to impute radical motives to reformist Indians, accused the Yaquis of yearning for the days of Moctezuma and wanting to live under "Mohammed's Law." For the first time ever, a Yaqui really did propose returning to a pre-Hispanic way of life—whatever that may have meant to him. And he did propose a pan-Indian union against the depredations of the whites. This was unlike anything ever seen among the Yaquis before. Yaqui resistance to empire, no matter how violent, was almost always embedded in a shared understanding that colonial relationships would persist after the violence died down. By the 1820s this was no longer so.⁸

The radicalism of the Banderas movement responded to the malignant surgery the government wanted to perform on the Yaqui towns. Under the new regime, old authorities were to be abolished, old lines of communication between Yaqui and Spanish authorities were to be severed or totally changed, and all the special privileges the Yaquis had negotiated for were to go up in smoke. Yaqui society was to be thrown into a liberal melting pot and assimilated into a state in which all were theoretically equal and all the rights and practices the Yaquis had worked to protect were scheduled to disappear. The final irony of this story is that empire, with all its connotations of racial hierarchy and violent domination, was in many ways much better for the Yaquis than liberal democracy ever would be, at least until the 1930s. Imperial ironies that balanced resistance and cooperation, violence and dialogue, diplomacy and domination gave way to vastly more brutal republican ironies, in which the ideals of freedom, democracy, and development served as the glimmering disguise of a genocidal leviathan state.⁹

The Yaquis were in revolt for most of the nineteenth century. As the United States expanded its dominion westward and Mexico slowly began to integrate its northern territories into itself, the Yaqui Valley gained greater and greater access to large consumer markets. Mexican and United States entrepreneurs became ever more interested in the Yaquis' stupendously valuable agricultural land and persuaded themselves that the Yaquis were unconquered barbarians, incapable of functioning as members of a modern state. Banderas was executed in 1833. Political turmoil and division prevented the government of Sonora from making good on its promise to turn Yaquis into Mexicans. But the accession of Porfirio Díaz to power in 1876 brought renewed pressure on the Yaquis.¹⁰

The remarkable José María Leyva, known as Cajeme, led the Yaquis in their struggle against Mexican forces beginning in 1875. Commanding a force of

roughly three thousand fighters, Cajeme defended a virtual Yaqui state-within-a-state until a government onslaught brought him and his movement to a violent end in 1886. After Cajeme's death, many Yaquis surrendered to the government or fled to the Sonoran highlands and thence to Arizona. Juan Maldonado, known as Tetabiate, gathered the scattered remnants of Cajeme's forces and kept up the fight against the government into the final decade of the nineteenth century. The task of resistance was made more difficult by the fact that the railroad had arrived in Sonora in 1880. The railroad brought with it a wave of economic development, eventually under the auspices of the Richardson Construction Company of Los Angeles. Richardson sought to develop Yaqui Valley land through a program of colonization and irrigation. Many Sonoran grandes stood to gain from this development and were eager to eradicate the rebels still operating under the command of Tetabiate. In 1901 they succeeded at last, killing the rebel leader in a mountain redoubt.

A striking continuity marked the ideologies and ambitions of the governments the Yaquis confronted over the course of the nineteenth century. They wanted Yaquis to be Mexican citizens and to act as such. They wanted Yaquis to participate in the Mexican political process as voters and candidates, not as revolutionaries. And they wanted landholding in the Yaqui Valley to be determined by market forces, not religious practices, ancestral rights, or sacred rituals. What changed over the course of the nineteenth century were the resources the government could deploy in pursuit of these goals and the virulence of the racist ideology that backed them. By the end of the nineteenth century, liberal intellectuals like Fortunato Hernández were calling for the total destruction of Yaqui culture and the absorption of the Yaquis into the surrounding society. To Hernández, Yaqui religion crystallized all that made the Yaquis resistant to the forces of progress. It was, he said, an evil brew of Catholic obscurantism and native mysticism: "an absurd mixture, an incestuous confusion of star-gods and semihuman, semibestial gods; of fiery purgatories and Batzu-Uni lagoons; of stone idols and wooden saints; and all this floating in the shadows of Yaqui ignorance, like the phantoms of a nightmare in the brain of an idiot." Thus Hernández dismissed one of the Yaquis' most distinctive achievements: the creation and refinement of a deeply original hybrid religion. Such creativity had no place in the efficient, modern, ever-progressing, ever-evolving capitalist state Hernández envisioned."

The Yaquis rightly perceived liberalizing initiatives as a threat and dug in to resist them. Between 1890 and 1910 the Porfirian government responded with a brutal military occupation, first taking control of Yaqui strongholds in the Sierra de Bacatete and then attacking the rebels' base of support among

the peaceful Yaquis in the eight ancestral towns. Pedro Corbalán had warned the Yaquis in 1771: “Where can you hide with your women and children and elderly people where the Spaniards cannot find them and punish them? Since your nation is so scattered in diverse mining towns and haciendas, can you not see that it is they who will first feel the rigor of arms?” In the 1890s and 1900s the Porfirian government at last made good on Corbalán’s threats, deporting thousands of Yaquis as slave laborers to the plantations of Yucatán and the Valle Nacional in Oaxaca (fig. 8).¹²

Yet Yaqui guerrillas fought on. Many Yaquis fought alongside the Constitutionalist forces of Venustiano Carranza in the Mexican Revolution, only to be betrayed by him and later by the Sonoran warlord Álvaro Obregón. But the Yaquis’ enduring militancy in defense of their culture, interests, and land favorably impressed President Lázaro Cárdenas. In 1937 he gave the Yaquis 1.2 million acres of prime agricultural land as an *ejido*, or communal land grant held in perpetuity. Though this amounted to less than a third of the land the Yaquis considered theirs by ancestral right, it was nevertheless the largest ejido in all of Mexico and the single such grant ever made on the basis of ethnic identity. In all cases but this one Cárdenas sought to assimilate native peoples



8. Yaqui refugees, ca. 1910. (USC Digital Archive)

to the mestizo mainstream. He made an exception for the Yaquis, allowing them "special territorial autonomy over their eight sacred pueblos, while at the same time they would be tied to the state and the national economy through land reform, federally sponsored development projects, and the expansion of agricultural production and commerce." They were thus able to resume their religious and secular practices and begin to reconstruct the communities that had been so ravaged by government aggression over the previous sixty years. The ferocity of the Yaquis and their willingness to involve themselves in struggles far afield of the Yaqui mission earned them a special relationship with the revolutionary Mexican state as well as greater territorial power and autonomy than the vast majority of the native peoples of Mexico.¹³

This resolution to the Yaqui wars of the nineteenth century strangely echoed the order of the colonial period: Yaquis had an exceptional degree of control over their lands and deep connections to the political and economic structures of the world beyond the Yaqui Valley. The creative hybrid culture the Yaquis had developed, their attachment to their homeland, their willingness to travel far and wide for work, their sophisticated deployment of violence and negotiation, threats and kindnesses, were products of their long, contentious collaboration with the forces of empire. Those skills have helped the Yaqui people endure and are with them still. The Yaqui experience offers ideas to peoples throughout the world confronting the great question forced on them by modernity: How do we remain true to ourselves and to our traditions amid all the whirling glitter and horror of life in the modern world? The Yaqui example of creativity, flexibility, ruthlessness, and endurance is one that all can look to as a source of inspiration.¹⁴

ABBREVIATIONS

AGI	Archivo General de Indias, Seville
AGN	Archivo General de la Nación, Mexico
AHES	Archivo Histórico del Estado de Sonora, Hermosillo
AHH	Archivo Histórico de Hacienda
AHN	Archivo Histórico Nacional, Spain
AP	Archivo de Parral
ARAG	Archivo de la Real Audiencia de Guadalajara
ARSI	Archivum Romanum Societatis Iesu
BL	Beinecke Rare Book and Manuscript Library, Yale University
BNMAF	Biblioteca Nacional de Mexico, Fondo Franciscano
CU-BANC	Bancroft Library, University of California, Berkeley
HGS	Historia General de Sonora
MM	Monumenta Mexicana
NL	Newberry Library, Chicago
TXU	University of Texas Library, Austin

NOTES

INTRODUCTION

1. The literature on liberal developmentalism in nineteenth-century Mexico is vast. See Katz, "Liberal Republic"; Kourí, *Pueblo Divided* and "Interpreting"; Caplan, *Indigenous Citizens*; Hale, *Mexican Liberalism and Transformation of Liberalism*; Thompson, *Patriotism*; Mallon, *Peasant and Nation*; Guardino, *Peasants*; Craib, *Cartographic Mexico*; Vanderwood, *Power of God*; Wells and Joseph, *Summer of Discontent*; and Lund, *Mestizo State*. On the Yaquis in the nineteenth century and the attempted genocide perpetrated by the Porfirian government, see Turner, *Barbarous Mexico*; Madero, *Sucesión presidencial*, 156–59; Molina Enríquez, *Grandes problemas*; Hernández, *Razas indígenas*; Troncoso et al., *Guerras*; García y Alva, *México y sus progresos*; Fabila, *Tribus yaquis de Sonora*; Spicer, *Yaquis and Cycles of Conquest*; Hu-DeHart, *Yaqui Resistance and Survival*, 155–200; Dabdoub, *Historia del valle del Yaqui*, 139–57; and Padilla Ramos, *Yucatán, fin del sueño Yaqui*. Evans, *Bound in Twine*, 73–75, has an excellent discussion of the Díaz policy of extermination.
2. Knight, *Mexican Revolution*, 2:172; Dwyer, *Agrarian Dispute*; Vaughan, *Cultural Politics in Revolution*, 137–62.
3. Razo Zaragoza y Cortés, ed., *Crónicas de la conquista*, 278–79.
4. Juan Calixto Ayamea to Don Juan Aldámez, May 20, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, cuaderno 2, ff. 923r–924r.
5. Fussell, *Great War*, 7–8; on violence and irony, see Winter, *Legacy of the Great War*, 165; and Faust, *This Republic of Suffering*, 207; for a deep exploration of irony and disillusionment among the Jesuits of northern New Spain, see del Valle, *Escribiendo desde los márgenes*; on irony and empire, see Schwartz, "Brazil: Ironies of the Colonial Past."
6. Mancio Sierra de Leguizamo, September 15, 1589, "Testament," in Prescott, *Conquest of Peru* 3:312–14; White, *Middle Ground*. White and others have cautioned scholars who find "middle grounds" in every borderland they examine. There is much in the middle ground that was exquisitely peculiar to the Great Lakes region of North America. There are aspects of it, however, that can indeed be found elsewhere. White

- has described them in this way: “a rough balance of power, mutual need or a desire for what the other possesses, and an inability by either side to commandeer enough force to compel the other to change.” White, “Creative Misunderstandings,” 10.
7. Quoted in Malcolm Gladwell, “The Gift of Doubt: Albert O. Hirschman and the Power of Failure,” *New Yorker*, June 24, 2013.
 8. For a critique of romantic images of the vanishing Plains Indians, see Limerick, *Legacy of Conquest*, 213; and Castaneda, *Teachings of Don Juan*; for a critique of Castaneda, see Kelley, *Yaqui Women*, 24–25.
 9. The key text for native people as political entrepreneurs is Stern, *Peru’s Native Peoples*; for other Andean cases, see Dean, *Inka Bodies*; Mumford, “Aristocracy on the Auction Block”; for comparable cases in New Spain, see Borah, *Justice by Insurance*; Chipman, *Moctezuma’s Children*; Haskett, *Indigenous Rulers*; Pérez-Rocha and Tena, *La nobleza indígena*; on Tlaxcala, see Gibson, *Tlaxcala in the Sixteenth Century*; Offutt, “Women’s Voices from the Frontier”; Kranz, “Visual Persuasion”; and McEnroe, *From Colony to Nationhood*. For a definition of imperial fringes, see Lockhart and Schwartz, *Early Latin America*, 253–304.
 10. Neil Whitehead is the thinker on cultures of violence in empire who has had the strongest influence on this analysis. See Whitehead, “Cultures,” “On the Poetics of Violence,” *Dark Shamans*, and *Hans Staden’s True History*; Ferguson and Whitehead, “Violent Edge of Empire.” On violence on the north frontier of New Spain, see Rabasa, *Writing Violence*; on the role of culture in varying expressions of violence, see Clendinnen, “Fierce and Unnatural Cruelty.”
 11. Scott, *Domination and the Arts of Resistance*, *Seeing Like a State*, and *Art of Not Being Governed*. For a parallel exploration of the Spanish arts of domination, see Ruíz Medrano, *Reshaping New Spain*; Altman, *War for Mexico’s West*; and Matthew and Oudijk, eds., *Indian Conquistadors*, particularly the essays by Altman, Matthew, and Blosser; Owensby, *Empire of Law*, and Cutter, *The Legal Culture*, expand on the idea of domination through judicial mediation propounded by Tutino in “Agrarian Social Change”; Yannakakis offers further refinements on the argument that mediators were key agents of Spanish domination in *Art of Being In-Between*; on this theme, see also Metcalf, *Go-Betweens and the Colonization of Brazil*, and Karttunen, *Between Worlds*.
 12. Spicer, *Yaqis*, 333–60, “Linguistic Aspects,” Potam, *Cycles of Conquest*, Pascua, *People of Pascua*; Spicer and Crumrine, *Performing the Renewal*; Giddings, *Yaqui Myths and Legends*; Skaggs et al., *Chronicles of the Yaqui Expedition*; Valenzuela Kaczurkin, *Yoeme*; Kelley, *Yaqui Women*; Moisés, Holden, and Kelley, *Tall Candle*; Painter, *With Good Heart*.
 13. Erickson, *Yaqui Homeland and Homeplace*, 80; Shorter, *We Will Dance*, 4; Evers and Molina, “Hiakim: The Yaqui Homeland,” “Holy Dividing Line,” “Yaqui Deer Songs / Maso Bwikam”; Figueroa Valenzuela, *Por la tierra y por los santos*; Sands, “Singing Tree”; McGuire, “Ritual, Theater, and the Persistence of the Ethnic Group,” in *Politics and Ethnicity*.
 14. DeLay, “Introduction,” *North American Borderlands*, 4. Five edited volumes offer avenues into the study of cultural encounters in the borderlands: de la Teja and Frank,

Choice, Persuasion, and Coercion; Griffiths and Cervantes, *Spiritual Encounters*; Guy and Sheridan, *Contested Ground*; Cayton and Teute, *Contact Points*; and DeLay, *North American Borderlands*. Key monographs include Anderson, *The Indian Southwest*; Boccara, *Guerre et ethnogénèse*; Ganson, *Guaraní Under Spanish Rule*; Merrill, *Indians' New World*; Weber, *Bárbaros and Spanish Frontier*; DuVal, *Native Ground*; Gallay, *Indian Slave Trade*; Gutiérrez, *When Jesus Came*; Mann, *Power of Song*; Blackhawk, *Violence over the Land*; and Taylor, *Divided Ground and American Colonies*. An important strand in this literature focuses less on hybridization and mixing than on the definition and hardening of ethnic boundaries in the borderlands, Lepore, *The Name of War*; Merrill, *Into the American Woods*; Silver, *Our Savage Neighbors*; and Hämäläinen, *Comanche Empire*. My book falls somewhere between these two bodies of literature in the sense that it explores the development of Yaqui group identity as it emerged from dialogue with empire. A North American parallel to the Yaqui experience and my book's approach to it lies in David Silverman's *Red Brethren*. Silverman focuses on the political and cultural strategizing of the Brothertown and Stockbridge Indians in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries. These remarkable communities decided at an early moment to adopt Christianity and white ways and eventually to petition the U.S. government for citizenship, which they received in the mid-nineteenth century. By bending to the will of the governments they lived under, these groups avoided the breaking of their own will to survive. *The Yaquis and the Empire* explores a similarly farsighted set of native strategies for survival. The Yaquis were more numerous than the Brothertown and Stockbridge Indians, lived in a more remote setting with a weaker imperial government, and resorted to force of arms more willingly than they. The Yaquis were thus able to drive a harder bargain with their imperial antagonists than the Brothertown and Stockbridge Indians did, faced harsher oppression in the nineteenth century, and in the end achieved greater success in preserving their way of life. Nevertheless, the strategies the Yaquis and Brothertown and Stockbridge Indians shared much: both were pragmatic and insightful about life under imperial and, later, republican rule. See also Fisher, *Indian Great Awakening*, for a subtle exploration of the ways native peoples engaged with transatlantic religious, political, and educational institutions.

15. Perhaps the most sophisticated restatement of the "black legend" of Spanish wickedness is Jennings, *Invasion of America*; some, though not all, the essays in Langer and Jackson, *New Latin American Mission History*, depict missions and missionaries in the most damning tones. Jackson, "Introduction," and Sweet, "Ibero-American Mission," are particularly harsh. James Sandos provides a useful analysis of the ways "Christophilic Triumphantist" approaches to California mission history have been replaced by an equally vehement and unilluminating "Christophobic Nihilist" viewpoint. Sandos, *Converting California*, xiii. In *Aztecs, Ambivalent Conquests*, "Fierce and Unnatural Cruelty," and other works, Inga Clendinnen has demonstrated the possibilities for writing about violence in a way that neither underplays the suffering of victims nor oversimplifies the motives of perpetrators. On the overpraise of native qualities, see DeLay, "Narrative Style," which, while underscoring the lavish narrative virtues of Fred Anderson's *Crucible of War*, criticizes it on the grounds that "Indian actors in this

book often seem too rational, or, more exactly, only rational—even mechanical.” Pekka Hämäläinen, in the process of making a compelling case for Comanche military prowess, claims that the Comanches, who numbered at most forty thousand but were more likely closer to twenty, became a “territorial superpower” of “hemispheric dimensions,” *Comanche Empire*, 55, 3. Considering that most university football stadiums today seat more than twice the maximum number of Comanche men, women, and children combined, this claim is something of a stretch. When Susan Sleeper-Smith describes the native convert Marie Rouensa as an exemplar of “Catholicism as a source of female empowerment,” she comes close to making a woman who knew nothing about female empowerment into a feminist icon, *Indian Women*, 35. I select Anderson, Hämäläinen, and Sleeper-Smith as examples not because they are bad historians of native peoples, but because they are among the very best. The temptation to overpraise one’s subject matter is understandable, and I am certainly not immune to it. The eminent Sinologist Jonathan D. Spence has written, “In my studies of China, I must often plead guilty . . . of a certain overestimation of the object of affection,” *Chinese Roundabout*, 3. But this kind of affection can blind scholars to the fact that regarding native peoples as the true equals of Europeans means recognizing that Indians were capable of both good and evil, genius and folly. Just as native and nonnative peoples have the same capacity for compassion and achievement, so they share equally in the potential for stupidity, cruelty, and mean-spiritedness. Leaving these ugly qualities out of historical writing about native peoples makes them seem less complex and hence less completely human than they were.

16. Hu-DeHart, *Missionaries, Yaqui Resistance and Survival*, “Development and Rural Rebellion.” Sheridan, “How to Tell the Story,” offers a critique of Hu-DeHart’s approach to Yaqui history.
17. Deeds, *Defiance and Deference*. Yetman and Shaul, *Ópatas*, addresses many of the same questions explored by Deeds and shows how linguistic and cultural diversity, geographical fragmentation, susceptibility to disease, dispersal into mining camps, Apache attacks, and the possession of coveted lands eventually led to the extinction of the Ópatas as a distinct cultural group. Griffen, *Indian Assimilation and Culture Change and Shifting Populations*, are useful analyses of the settlement patterns in Nueva Vizcaya; Merrill, “Conversion and Colonialism,” deals with the Tarahumara response to Christianity; and Sheridan, *Empire of Sand*, provides extensive documentation of the long Seri struggle for autonomy.
18. Key works on the modern Mexican “negotiated state” include Joseph and Nugent, *Everyday Forms*; Wells and Joseph, *Summer of Discontent*; Vaughan, *Cultural Politics*; Becker, *Setting the Virgin on Fire*; Mallon, *Peasant and Nation*; Alonso, *Thread of Blood*; Nugent, *Spent Cartridges*; Vaughan and Lewis, *Eagle and the Virgin*; and López, *Crafting Mexico*. For similar work on earlier periods, see Radding de Murrieta, *Wandering Peoples and Landscapes of Power and Identity*; Van Young, *Other Rebellion*; Yannakakis, *Art of Being In-Between*; and Guardino, *Time of Liberty*.
19. Radding de Murrieta, “Colonial Pact,” 52–53, *Wandering Peoples, Entre el desierto y la sierra*, “Peasant Resistance on the Yaqui Delta,” and *Landscapes of Power and Identity*; del Río, *La aplicación regional, Conquista y aculturación*; Almada Bay, *Breve*

historia de Sonora; Ortega Noriega, del Río, and Atondo Rodríguez, *Tres siglos de historia sonorense*; Ortega Noriega et al., eds., *Historia general de Sonora*; Braniff, *Frontera protohispánica*, ed. La gran Chichimeca; Doolittle, *Pre-Hispanic Occupance*; Hausberger, “Violencia en la conquista espiritual”; Reff, *Disease and Plagues, Priests, and Demons*; de la Torre Curiel, “Conquering the Frontier”; Riley, *Frontier People*; West, *Sonora*.

20. Kamen, *Empire*.

21. Whitehead, “Tribes Make States.”

CHAPTER 1. A FAILED CONQUEST

1. On conquistador dreams, see Flint, *No Settlement, No Conquest*, 3; on geography, Gerhard, *North Frontier*, 244–45; on pre-Columbian native subsistence practices, Reff, *Disease*, 36–43, Obregón, *Historia*, 99–100.
2. Ruíz, *Relación*, 32–33.
3. *Ibid.*, 36.
4. *Ibid.*, 36–37.
5. Summary and analysis of the recent explosion in studies of the Spanish conquest of Mexico can be found in Schroeder, “Introduction”; Oudijk and Restall, “Mesoamerican Conquistadors”; Stern, “Paradigms of Conquest”; Schroeder, *Conquest*; and Rabasa, *Tell Me the Story*; on the north, see Hassig, “Aztec and Spanish Conquest in Mesoamerica,” 99–100; the literature on contact, conquest, alliance, and negotiation throughout the borderlands of the Americas is vast: Weber and Rausch, *Where Cultures Meet*; Daniels and Kennedy, *Negotiated Empires*; Guy and Sheridan, *Contested Ground*; Cayton and Teute, *Contact Points*; and de la Teja and Frank, *Choice, Persuasion, and Coercion*, offer a rich sampling of studies on frontiers throughout the Americas. For explorations of parallel dynamics of native dominance and European subordination in North America, see White, *Middle Ground*; DuVal, *Native Ground*; Silver, *Our Savage Neighbors*, 3–37; and in South America, Grahn, “Chicha in the Chalice.” David J. Weber has argued that Spaniards effectively paid tribute to Indians throughout the fringe regions of the Americas in the eighteenth century, *Bárbaros*, 9, 27, 136, 191, 192. Such inversions of colonial power were even more widespread in the sixteenth century; see Powell, *Soldiers*, 204–26, and “Peacemaking,” for analyses of early Spanish policies of “peace by purchase,” whereby the Spanish simply paid Indians they could not conquer to leave them alone. For a theoretical overview of frontier wars and native resistance, see Ferguson and Whitehead, “Violent Edge of Empire.” For insight into the difficulties empires faced in controlling remote and especially mountainous regions in the early modern period, see Scott, *Art of Not Being Governed*.
6. West, *Sonora*, 2; on the aboriginal cultures of the northwest, see Reff, *Disease*, 17–96; on the cultural geography of the region, see Radding de Murrieta, *Wandering Peoples*, esp. 21–47.
7. Gerhard, *North Frontier*, 244; on Sonora as the meeting point of Aztlán and Mesoamerica, see Sauer and Brand, *Aztatlán*; Kelley, “Mobile Merchants of Molino,”

- 83–86; Kelley, “The Aztatlán Mercantile System”; Adorno and Pautz, *Cabeza de Vaca, His Account*, 2:331–34.
8. Stern, “Paradigms of Conquest,” xxxiii; Klarén, *Peru*, 37; Lockhart and Schwartz, *Early Latin America*, 80–84; Nuño de Guzmán was perhaps the prototypical infamous conquistador; on his career, see Altman, *War for Mexico’s West*, and Chipman, *Nuño de Guzmán*.
 9. Ortega Noriega, “Penetración,” 28; Diego de Guzmán, *Relación*, is the first account of Diego’s voyage to the Yaqui River; a second account of this voyage can be found in Razo Zaragoza y Cortés, ed., *Crónicas de la Conquista*, 270–84. Though this account has come to be known as the “Second Anonymous Relation,” Adorno and Pautz have identified its author as Jorge Robledo, one of Guzmán’s henchmen, *Cabeza de Vaca, His Account*, 2:123. Hereafter, I will refer to it as Robledo, *Relación*.
 10. West, *Sonora*, 1–15; Sheridan, *Empire of Sand*, 23–25.
 11. West, *Sonora*, 16–26; Pfefferkorn and Treutlein, *Sonora*, 46; Beals, *Aboriginal Culture*, 10–12.
 12. Beals, *Aboriginal Culture*, 11–14. The Yaquis also employed the fire drive technique in warfare. They came close to annihilating a Spanish war party in 1610 by using it. See chapter 3, below, for details. Pfefferkorn and Treutlein, *Sonora*, 46; West, *Sonora*, 24–26. Reff aggregates various population estimates that place the number residents of the Mocorito, Sinaloa, Fuerte, Mayo, and Yaqui Rivers at one hundred thousand, *Disease*, 36. Basilio, *Arte*, 138, 180–90, 195.
 13. Reff, *Disease*, 36; Sauer and Brand, *Aztatlán*, 41; Beals, *Aboriginal*, 21–32.
 14. West, *Sonora*, 16–26; Sauer and Brand, *Aztatlán*, 54; Beals, *Aboriginal*, 40–42; Basilio, *Arte*, 35, 135; Riley, *Becoming*, 165–66.
 15. Robledo, *Relación*, 278–79; Guzmán, *Relación*, 332
 16. Juan Francisco Goyeneche described a scene (see chapter 4 below) in which the Yaquis came out of their town to meet him, danced and shouted, then escorted him into the town of Potam. Goyeneche, “Auto,” October 29, 1689, AGN, Provincias Internas, vol. 30, f. 226r.
 17. Robledo, *Relación*, 278–79; Guzmán, *Relación*, 332; Guzmán gave a lower number of horses injured and a higher one for people: ten and two, respectively.
 18. The anthropologist David Delgado Shorter records a dialogue in 1993 with Felipe, a Yaqui informant, who expressed frustration with the prominence this battle is so often given in accounts of the Yaqui past: “I like to imagine that encounter as much as you do,” Felipe said. “But all that language of being the ‘fiercest fighters in the New World.’ Who does that serve? Do we want our children proud of that quality instead of others?” Reading the story closely, one can find some of the other qualities Felipe alluded to. One can discern not only Yaqui ferocity but also Yaqui foresight, shrewdness, caution, prudence, diplomacy, and willingness to make friends. Shorter, *We Will Dance*, 161.
 19. Adorno and Pautz, *Cabeza de Vaca, His Account*, 1:99–101.
 20. Pfefferkorn and Treutlein, *Sonora*, 20–71.
 21. Obregón, *Historia*, 150; West, *Sonora*, 18; Doolittle, *Pre-Hispanic Occupance*, 58–91; Riley, *Frontier People*, 39–90.

22. Adorno and Pautz, *Cabeza de Vaca, His Account*, 1:236–37.
23. Ibid.
24. There are also good reasons to believe these were not in fact the Yaqui people. The first is the obvious one that the term *Yaqui* is an anachronism. There may well have been another name that better described the people of the lower Yaqui River in these years, but we do not know what it was. Here I use the term *Yaqui* as shorthand for the Cáhita-speaking people or peoples of the lower Yaqui River. Another reason for doubt is that careful scholars from Carl O. Sauer to Adorno and Pautz have pieced together data from Cabeza de Vaca's *Relación* and Gonzálo Fernández de Oviedo's *Historia General* to guess that the place where Cabeza de Vaca received the gift of maize was somewhere on the Sinaloa River. This site lay at a distance of some 150 kilometers from the Yaqui River, and if the people who led them there were based close by, they could not have been Yaquis. I find the identification of "those who held the frontier" with the "Yaquis" to be compelling, but the sources leave ample space for debate on the issue. See Sauer, *Road to Cibola*, 19, and Adorno and Pautz, *Cabeza de Vaca, His Account*, 1:236–37, 2:348–51, on the "highland retreat," and 2:351–58 for discussion of the theme of Spaniards as "men from the sky." Vicente de Águila, "Relación de la misión de Sinaloa en la Nueva España," January 6, 1614, ARSI, *Provincia Mexicana*, vol. 19, f. 113r. For discussion of the term *Yori*, see Spicer, *Yaquis*, 349, and Erickson, *Yaqui Homeland and Homeplace*, 12.
25. "Carta del Padre Pedro Méndez de treinta de Julio de noventa y quarto," July 30, 1594, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 15, f. 58v; Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 24; Diego Martínez de Hurdaide, "Autos," February 6, 1606, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, ff. 3–4. Normally, one would refer to Hurdaide by his first surname, Martínez, but writers from Pérez de Ribas to the present have called him Hurdaide, a convention I follow. Most of Hurdaide's extant correspondence is in AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, a volume that is in a terrible state of decay. Fortunately, a student of Herbert Eugene Bolton's made a typescript copy of it in the early twentieth century, which now resides in the Bancroft Library's Bolton papers, in file C-B 840. This is the copy I consulted, and I use its pagination throughout the book. AGN, *Misiones*, vol. 25, is in somewhat better shape, but I nevertheless consulted the Bancroft typescript copy of it and so use the Bancroft pagination here.
26. Hurdaide to the Governor, February 27, 1616, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, f. 194; Hurdaide to the Viceroy, May 25, 1622, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, ff. 3–4.
27. Almada, *Breve historia*, 41–46, 69.
28. Flint, *No Settlement*. Riley, *Frontier People*, 39–96; Ortega Noriega, "Penetración," 30–31.
29. Obregón, *Historia*; Ruíz, *Relación*; Díaz del Castillo, *Conquest*.
30. Mecham, *Ibarra*, 61–63; Obregón, *Historia*, 91.
31. Obregón, *Historia*, 98. Reff and Kelley, "Saints, Witches, and Go-Betweens," 247–55. Reff and Kelley analyze Luisa's extraordinary career as the interpreter for the Coronado and Ibarra expeditions and for the Jesuits in the early seventeenth century. For wide-ranging studies of women and cross-cultural negotiation in the Spanish borderlands, see Barr, *Peace Came*; in central Mexico, Townsend, *Malintzin's*

- Choices, and Chipman, *Moctezuma's Children*; on Mexico's southern frontier, Herrera, "Concubines and Wives"; and in Brazil, Karasch, "Damiana da Cunha," and Metcalf, *Go-Betweens*.
32. Obregón, *Historia*, 108–10, 137; Ruíz, *Relación*, 20.
 33. Obregón, *Historia*, 138–40. For a calculation of the dates based on comparison of several mutually contradicting accounts, see Mecham, *Ibarra*, 163.
 34. Obregón, *Historia*, 140–46.
 35. Ruíz, *Relación*, 23–24. Obregón said they went from the Mayo River up a northwesterly tributary of the Mayo called the Cedros and from there inland to towns in the region of Corazones. The two accounts were not necessarily at odds. If Corazones was indeed on the Yaqui River, the two accounts differed only in the precise location at which they said the expedition met the Yaqui River. Obregón placed that point several leagues upstream of where Ruíz did. Ruíz was better versed in the geography, cultures, and languages of the region and is the more reliable of the two narrators. Obregón, *Historia*, 147.
 36. Obregón, *Historia*, 174. David Yetman identifies the source of native arrow poison as a plant called *Sebastiania bilocularis* S. Watson, "a member of the Euphorbiaceae family widely used by native peoples of the Sonoran Desert for arrow poison," *Ópatas*, 282. On the aboriginal cultures of the "Sonora River" peoples, see Doolittle, *Pre-Hispanic Occupance*, 58–91; Riley, *Frontier People*, 39–96; Radding de Murrieta, *Wandering Peoples*, 21–32; Reff, *Disease*, 53–68; and Yetman, *Ópatas*, 11–79.
 37. Obregón, *Historia*, 183; the decision to return to the lower Yaqui River is a further indication that Ruíz was correct to say that Ibarra had visited it on their way north.
 38. Obregón, *Historia*, 206, 208; Ruíz, *Relación*, 28–29.
 39. Obregón, *Historia*, 217.
 40. *Ibid.*, 218–19.
 41. *Ibid.*; *chiltecpin* was probably *chiltepín*, what Yetman describes as "a fiery little chile . . . found in every rural household in the Mayo region," *Mayo Ethnobotany*, 254. Ruíz made no mention of the conflict between the Yaquis and Mayos and said simply that Ibarra sent word from the Yaqui River to the residents of San Juan de Carapoa, who thought Ibarra had been killed. According to Ruíz, the vecinos then gathered provisions of maize biscuits, chickens, and other food and met Ibarra in the Mayo Valley. They stayed there for a short period and left the Mayos "in peace and calm," *Relación*, 29.
 42. Mecham, *Ibarra*, 223.
 43. The dating of these events is complicated. Using Ibarra's *probanza de méritos*, Mecham argues that Ibarra had to have been present in Carapoa at least until 1566 and draws on Mota Padilla, *Nueva Galicia*, to date the collapse of Carapoa to 1569. Ruíz unfortunately offered no dates. And Pérez de Ribas oddly omitted the entire episode. Mecham, *Ibarra*, 184; Ruíz, *Relación*, 33–34.
 44. Ruíz, *Relación*, 35.
 45. *Ibid.*, 35, 37.
 46. *Ibid.*, 43–44, 47.
 47. *Ibid.*, 60.
 48. *Ibid.*, 65.

49. "Comisión dada por el Virrey Marqués de Villamanrique a Gonzálo Gómez de Cervantes para poner en libertad los indios de las Provincias de Guaynamota, Sinaloa, y Nuevo Reino de León, Tomados y condenados injustamente como esclavos por los Gobernadores Hernando de Bazán y Luis de Carvajal y la real Audiencia de Guadalajara," 1589, AGI, Patronato, ramo 4. Reprinted in Sempat Assadourian, *Zacatecas*, 516–27.
50. Ruíz, *Relación*, 68.
51. Ibid.
52. Reff, *Disease*, 97–140.

CHAPTER 2. A MESTIZO CONQUEST

Epigraph: Hurdaide to the Father Visitor, June 12, 1627, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, f. 201.

1. Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 89–92; "Anua del año de mil seiscientos y dos," AGN, *Historia*, vol. 15, f. 127v.
2. On violence as cultural expression, see Whitehead, *Dark Shamans*, 232–52; Whitehead, "On the Poetics of Violence"; Rabasa, *Writing Violence*; Blackhawk, *Violence over the Land*.
3. On the cultural tolerance and ethnographic curiosity of Jesuits, see Grafton, "West vs. the Rest"; Spence, *Memory Palace*; and Axtell, *Invasion Within*, 43, which quotes the Jesuit Pierre de Charlevoix on the Jesuit missions among the natives of new France: "The best mode of Christianizing them was to avoid Frenchifying them"; Fernando Cervantes offers a lucid analysis of the tolerance Jesuits displayed toward foreign cultures, and their simultaneous implacable hatred of idolatry. By accepting the nominalist distinction between nature and grace, the great Jesuit thinker José de Acosta freed himself to admire the achievements of Asian and Amerindian cultures without abandoning his antipathy for their religious beliefs: "Even when dealing with the irksome question of conversion, Acosta's insistence on the need to preserve those pagan rites and ceremonies that did not conflict with Christianity seemed to echo St. Gregory the Great's advice to St. Augustine of Canterbury, and was in perfect tune with the current Jesuit missionary practice which produced its most remarkable representatives in China and India with Mateo Ricci and Roberto de Nobili," Cervantes, *Devil*, 27. On the role of disease in native people's decision to convert, see Reff, *Plagues, Priests, and Demons*, 122–206.
4. Whether the region was well controlled in the twentieth century is itself a matter of some contention. See Truett, *Fugitive Landscapes*, for an account of the many failed attempts to control the Sonora-Arizona borderlands in the twentieth century. Daniel Murphree argues that, in the case of colonial Florida, something close to the opposite of a mestizo conquest took place. The disparate European factions—Spanish, English, and French—who tried to colonize the peninsula were diverse and mutually antagonistic in the beginning but were progressively united by shared failure and a shared belief that Indian savagery caused that failure. Murphree argues that the Europeans came together as white Floridians, and they increasingly lumped the exquisitely distinctive native peoples of the region together as Indians, Murphree, *Constructing Floridians*, 48–49. Whether or not this argument correctly describes the history of

early Florida, it is a good description of what did not happen in Sonora. Those Spaniards who established an enduring presence in northwest Mexico were able to do so because they were meticulous in their efforts to understand the ethnic diversity and political divisions among the region's native peoples. As late as the 1780s, when crown policy sought explicitly to break down divisions between native and nonnative subjects, government officials nevertheless took note of the diversity of languages and subsistence strategies among the region's native peoples.

5. Hsia, *World of Catholic Renewal*, 27; O'Malley, *First Jesuits*; Ignatius, *Exercises*, paras. 107, 108, 124–25, cited in Spence, *Memory Palace*, 15; on Jesuit art, see Mâle, *L'art religieux*; Bailey, *Art on the Jesuit Missions*, 3, and *Between Renaissance and Baroque*; on the diffusion of the "Spiritual Exercises" through lay confraternities in Mexico, see Schroeder, "Jesuits," 44–46; on the Jesuits in Mexico more generally, see Alegre et al., *Historia de la provincia*; Decorme, *Obra de los jesuitas*; Zambrano, *Diccionario bio-bibliográfico*; and Zubillaga, *Monumenta mexicana*; on Jesuit missions in north Mexico, see Bolton, *Rim of Christendom* and "Mission as a Frontier Institution"; Bannon, *Mission Frontier*; Dunne, *Early Jesuit Missions*, *Pioneer Jesuits*, *Pioneer Black Robes*, and *Andrés Pérez de Ribas*; Deeds, *Defiance and Deference*; Radding de Murrieta, *Wandering Peoples and Landscapes of Power and Identity*; Reff, *Disease and Plagues, Priests, and Demons*; Polzer, *Rules and Precepts*; Hausberger, "Vida cotidiana" and "Violencia"; Ortega Noriega, "Sistema de misiones jesuíticas"; del Valle, *Escribiendo desde los márgenes*; and Martínez Serna, "Vineyards in the Desert." The literature on the Jesuits in Mexico is vast, and that on the Jesuits in the rest of the world is immeasurably more so. For synoptic treatment of missions and the Mexican north, see Weber, "Turner, the Boltonians, and the Borderlands," and "John Francis Bannon"; and Deeds, "Pushing the Borders." For an overview of recent work on the Jesuits worldwide, see Ditchfield, "Of Missions and Models."
6. Acosta, *De procuranda*, 587–93; on Jesuits in Asia, see Spence, *Memory Palace*; Hsia, *A Jesuit*; Gernet, *China and the Christian Impact*; Županov, *Disputed Mission*; Brockey, *Journey to the East*; Standaert, "Christianity Shaped by the Chinese"; Elisonas, "Christianity and the Daimyo"; Elison, *Deus Destroyed*.
7. "Misiones de la Nueva España, o México, en especial de Sinaloa," ARSI, Mexico, vol. 19, f. 162r. The document lists neither an author nor a date, but internal evidence suggests that it was written by Pérez de Ribas or someone close to him in the early to mid-1620s. It spoke of Diego Martínez de Hurdaide, who died in 1628, as if he were still alive, and it discussed the experience of the first missionaries among the Yaquis, who arrived in 1617. The document narrated an episode which Pérez de Ribas related in the first person in *Historia*, 322. Pérez de Ribas recounted his supervision of the burning of Mayo *cabelleras* as a prelude to a truce between Yaquis and Mayos; the ARSI document recounted an identical episode on f. 135v. The document's rich descriptions of pre-Hispanic Yaqui rituals indicate that it was written when the pre-Christian era of Yaqui history was in living memory.
8. On Pérez de Ribas's career, see Reff, "Critical Introduction" and "'Predicament of Culture'"; and Dunne, *Andrés Pérez de Ribas*; on Jesuit finances, see Brading, "Jesuit Triumphs."

9. Pérez de Ribas et al. to the King, AHH, vol. 2009, exp. 1, f. 14. For accounts of native unrest in the early seventeenth century, see Gradie, *Tepehuan Revolt*, and Deeds, "Indigenous Rebellions," 31–40; Giudicelli, *Guerre, identités et métissages*; Reff, "Predicament of Culture."
10. AHH, vol. 2009, exp. 1, f. 14. On the political involvement of the Jesuits, see Simmons, "Palafox and His Critics"; Álvarez de Toledo, *Politics and Reform*, 70–74. Jonathan I. Israel describes Pérez de Ribas as a member of the "extreme anti-Palafox wing of the Jesuit order," *Race, Class, and Politics*, 147, 217–23.
11. Shiels, *Gonzalo de Tapia*; "Anua del Año del Colegio y Misiones de Cinaloa de los años de 1625, y 26," AGN, *Misiones*, leg. 25.
12. "Anua del año de 1593," AGN, *Historia*, vol. 15, ff. 22v–24r.
13. Tapia, "Anua del año de 1593," AGN, *Historia*, vol. 15, ff. 22v–24r. Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 5, 8, 12.
14. Tapia, "Anua del año de 1593," AGN, *Historia*, vol. 15, f. 28v.
15. Pedro Méndez, "Carta del Padre Pedro Méndez de treinta de Julio de noventa y quatro [July 20, 1594]," AGN, *Historia*, vol. 15, ff. 62v–63v. "Anua del año de 1594," AGN, *Historia*, vol. 15, f. 39r. Some sense of the distinctiveness of Jesuit attitudes toward native religion can be gleaned from Steven Hackel, *Children of Coyote*, 132: "Franciscans, whether they saw Indians as innocents or savages, perceived little in native culture upon which they could build a belief in Catholicism, and they concluded that Indian culture had been fertile ground for superstitious beliefs and practices that had to be eliminated before Christianity could take root."
16. "Anua del año 1602," AGN, *Historia*, vol. 15, f. 141r. Alan Greer notes a similar dynamic in New France, as priests competed with native shamans for souls: "Passing through once-thriving native villages suddenly transformed into sick wards and charnel houses, the missionaries were desperate to baptize the dying. They sometimes tried to cure the ill, distributing sugar, raisins, and other medicinal substances, but their motives were frankly strategic, a matter of gaining the Indians' confidence and beating the devil-worshipping shamans at their own game. What really mattered was the harvest of souls. Every gravely ill Indian was, to a Jesuit, the prize in a contest with the highest possible stakes: either she would die outside the church and suffer eternal torment, or she would confess her sins, enter the fold, and live forever in perfect happiness," *Mohawk Saint*, 6.
17. Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 19. The approach the Jesuits took in New France was almost identical. Richard White describes it well: Jesuits "sought to emphasize the transformative aspects of Christianity, but in seeking to convert Algonquians by attacking native beliefs, they, for tactical reasons, often themselves accepted native premises. The Jesuits ridiculed the Manitous, but they did so in Algonquian terms. They often did not challenge the Algonquian logic of why fish or game appeared or did not appear. Instead, they denied credit to the Manitous and gave it to Christ. Success in war, success in the hunt, survival after falling through the ice, all were evidence of the power of Christ," *Middle Ground*, 26. Greer makes the important point that native peoples investigated the Jesuits much as the Jesuits investigated them: "Modern scholars sometimes treat Christianization as something imposed upon hapless native victims, but the

history of Kahnawake suggests a very different process. Converts might better be viewed as active investigators proving the exotic myths and arcane rituals of a complex foreign religion," *Mohawk Saint*, 111. Though the Franciscans were more bitterly skeptical about native intentions, superstitions, and cultures than the Jesuits were, they nevertheless lived in a similarly God-infused, demon-plagued, mental universe: "Franciscans believed that they were sent by God as his servants to work in California's missionary field. Their faith was strengthened further by their conviction that God's work in California had long preceded their own. Specifically, Franciscans who served in Alta California knew about the seventeenth-century Franciscan nun, María de Jesús de Agreda, who claimed to have been transported numerous times by angels to preach among the Indians of New Mexico," Hackel, *Children of Coyote*, 133.

18. Pérez de Ribas, "Anua del año de 1613," BL, M-M 227, 464; "Anua del año de 1596," AGN, *Historia*, vol. 15, ff. 68r–69r; Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 60. It is important to underscore that the distinction between native culture and native religion was entirely in the minds of the Jesuits. Many of the cultural practices the Jesuits condoned had deep religious meanings to native peoples.
19. "Relación de la muerte del Padre Gonzálo de Tapia, Superior de la Compañía de Jesús de Sinaloa, que sucedió a los once de Julio de Mil Quinientos noventa y quatro en el Pueblo de Tovoropa" (hereafter "Relación de la muerte"), July 11, 1594, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 15, 42r; Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 49–50; "Carta que Los Yndios Tarascos, que están en Sinaloa, escribieron a todos los Tarascos de la Provincia de Mechoacán, sobre la muerte del Padre Gonzálo de Tapía, por relación que les dió el Yndio Tarasco, que estava con el Padre quando lo mataron," July 1594, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 15, 47v–48r. There were many similarities between the attitudes of the Jesuits toward missionaries killed in the mission field and those of the Franciscans studied by Ramón Gutiérrez in *When Jesus Came*. Both orders regarded the fallen missionaries as martyrs, and, were it not for strong Counter-Reformation doctrines to the contrary, they would almost certainly have regarded them as saints. See Gregory, *Salvation at Stake*, on martyrs and martyrologies in the world of early modern Catholicism. Both Franciscans and Jesuits regarded martyrdom as one of the most desirable outcomes of a missionary's career. Indeed, Pérez de Ribas's chronicle, *Historia de los triunfos*, derived its title from St. Jerome's axiom that the suffering of martyrs is the "triumph of God." Implicit in the notion of Christian triumph is that of non-Christian defeat, and it is in this sense that Gutiérrez's provocative analysis of Franciscan martyrdom is apposite: "Though the martyrdoms of these Franciscans may appear like supreme acts of pacifism, they were, quite to the contrary, supreme acts of aggression. The Indians were provoked to murder only when they were pushed beyond their human limits. More to the point, the Spanish soldiers always retaliated with brute force whenever the Indians killed their friars," *When Jesus Came*, 130. There is little doubt that Indians perceived the aggressiveness of the Jesuits' behavior, first in their disruption of native ritual and sexual practices, then in their self-exposure to the violence of native leaders, and finally in the terrible revenge the Spanish military inevitably took for each martyr's death. There were also many fascinating differences between Franciscan and Jesuit attitudes on this score. Jesuit writings on the topic generally lacked the sadomas-

ochistic eroticism Gutiérrez has found in Franciscan martyr stories. A further difference between the two orders lay in the Jesuits' focus on emergent Counter-Reformation doctrines on the moral and theological status of martyrs. Franciscans, at least as Gutiérrez describes them, took it as given that Franciscans killed by mission Indians were martyrs and should be revered as such. Jesuits, by contrast, anxiously defended their illustrious dead against critics who said they had not really died for their faith. Indians, the criticism ran, had killed the Jesuits not because they preached Christianity, but because it was in the Indians' savage nature to kill people. Not so! the Jesuits responded. "On such occasions, . . . it is obvious that [Indians] do not kill them like beasts, or enemies whom they find in the country or on a path, but rather, they do so having considered and discussed it in their diabolical witch cabals, through which, at the demon's prompting, they oppose and persecute our holy faith and divine law," Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 417. Pérez de Ribas also preemptively defended his own treatment of Jesuit martyrs against accusations that he was claiming they were saints. Pérez recognized a decree of Pope Urban VIII, promulgated in 1625 and confirmed in 1634, prohibiting the publication of books about men celebrated for saintliness or famed as martyrs or which contained talk of magic or revelations or divine intervention. His chronicle conformed to the decree, he argued, because it claimed that only human, rather than divine, authority backed the veracity of the martyr stories he told. Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, xiv.

20. "Relación de la muerte," AGN, *Historia*, vol. 15, ff. 42v–44r. Pérez de Ribas gave a different, distinctly less plausible version, in which the wounded Tapia staggered to the church, knelt, and prayed before the cross before the apostates finished him off. This version was written decades after the fact, depicted Tapia in a more saintly light than earlier accounts, and lacked the vivid spontaneity of the earlier, more frantic, less dignified version. Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 50.
21. On redemptionist orders, see Edwards, *Spain of the Catholic Monarchs*, 214; on Jesuit schools for Moriscos, see Ehlers, *Between Christians and Moriscos*, ix, 86, 136; and Harris, *From Muslim to Christian Granada*, 23; on the treatment of Morisco children after the Revolts of the Alpujarras, see Lea, *Moriscos*, 39, 265.
22. Morales Padrón, *Teoría y leyes de la conquista*, sections 142 and 143. The literature on native captive exchange and cross-cultural slave systems is among the fastest growing subfields in borderlands studies, but the literature on Sinaloa and Sonora in the period under discussion is thin. I know of no book or article that explores the role of captives in the early history of the Sinaloa-Sonora missions. Brooks, *Captives and Cousins*, is perhaps the key text for understanding borderlands captive exchange; Barr, *Peace Came* and "From Captives to Slaves," analyze the gendered dynamics of captive exchange in early Texas and Louisiana. On Indian slaves in New Mexico, see Gutiérrez, *When Jesus Came*, 101–27. For exploration of native captivity in other areas of the Americas, see Galloway, *Indian Slave Trade*; Schwartz, "Indian Labor and New World Plantations"; Saignes, "Métis et sauvages"; Zavala, *Esclavos indios en Nueva España* and "Esclavos indios en el norte de México, siglo XVI"; Stern, "Social Marginality and Acculturation on the Northern Frontier of New Spain"; Magnaghi, *Indian Slavery, Labor, Evangelization, and Captivity*; Operé, *Indian Captivity in*

- Spanish America*, esp. 136–66; Socolow, “Spanish Captives in Indian Societies”; on Philip III and the Araucanian children, see Korth, *Spanish Policy in Colonial Chile*, 95. For broader theoretical discussions of captivity in imperial borderlands, see Chaplin, “Enslavement of Indians in Early America,” Voigt, *Writing Captivity*, and Whitehead, *Hans Staden’s True History*.
23. Reff and Kelley, “Saints, Witches, and Go-Betweens”; Snyder, *Slavery in Indian Country*, 105, 111; Rushforth, *Bonds of Alliance*, 46, 63, 64.
 24. The notion of hostage as collateral or surety had deep roots in medieval Europe. See Kosto, “Hostages in the Carolingian World.”
 25. Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 40.
 26. Tapia, “Anua del año de 1593,” AGN, *Historia*, vol. 15, f. 30r.
 27. “Carta del Padre Pedro Méndez,” July 30, 1594, in *ibid.*, f. 57r.
 28. Juan Bautista Velasco to the Provincial, April 10, 1601, in *ibid.*, ff. 108–9; Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 96; “Carta del Padre Pedro Méndez,” July 30, 1594, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 15, 57v.
 29. Diego Martínez de Hurdaide, “Autos,” January 3, 1606, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, f. 40.
 30. “Anua del año de 1612,” BL, M-M 227, 462; Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 212.
 31. “Annua del Colegio, y Misiones de Cinaloa de los años de 1625, y 26,” May 1626, AGN, *Misiones*, vol. 25, 673; Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 214; Brooks, *Captives and Cousins*, 40.
 32. Hurdaide to the Padre Visitador, June 12, 1627, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, ff. 203, 206.
 33. “Misiones de la Nueva España, o México, en especial de Cinaloa,” ARSI, *Provincia Mexicana*, vol. 19, 137r. Ian Wood, “The Mission of Augustine of Canterbury to the English,” *Speculum* 69, no. 1 (1994): 5. “Anua del año de 1610,” BL, M-M 227, 431. Juan Bautista Velasco to the Provincial, 1601, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 15, f. 125.
 34. Hurdaide to the Viceroy, 1604, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, ff. 15–15v; “Anua del año de mil quinientos noventa y siete,” September 30, 1597, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 15, f. 75; Hurdaide to the Viceroy, April 10, 1615, in *ibid.*, vol. 316, f. 81. Powell, *Soldiers*, 218–19. David Weber provides an ingenious interpretation of this sort of gift giving in frontiers throughout Spanish America. Though the Spanish never admitted it, Weber argues, they survived in frontier regions by paying tribute to the local Indians (a curious reversal of roles, when compared to the tribute the Spanish extracted from Indians in the core regions of the empire). Much of this chapter and the next argue that frontier practices such as this one, which Weber explores for the Bourbon era, had deep historical roots in the Habsburg era of Spanish presence in north Mexico. Weber, *Bárbaros*, 9.
 35. Hurdaide to Padre Visitador, June 12, 1627, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, f. 201; Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 164–65.
 36. Pérez de Ribas, Reff, Danford, et al., *History*, 293. I have found minimal evidence that this practice continued in the colonial era after the period of early contacts between Jesuits and Indians. But it must have continued in some form because it resurfaced in the early nineteenth century and was described by the English traveler Henry Hardy: of his purchase of two children from “Axtia” Indians near the mouth of the Colorado River, he wrote, “I was led to suppose, that while we remained aground, there was a

decided advantage to be derived from the purchase of children, conceiving that the affections of their parents might perhaps be a sort of check to the Indians, in any projected attack, from a fear that the lives of these children would be put in jeopardy; and this plan had answered remarkably well during the time the captain and interpreter were my prisoners. Besides, as I could not understand a word of the language of these people, I concluded, that if any hostile measure were proposed, the countenances of these children might serve as a sort of index, since they appeared perfectly happy on board; and even refused to converse with their parents whenever they approached the vessel while she was still on shore. . . . The practice of parents selling their children is another proof of poverty and wretchedness. Indeed they know that by thus disposing of them they are brought up among the white population of Sonora, by whom they are kindly treated, clothed, and fed; and when the boys are grown to be men, they not unfrequently returned to their own country. Women, however, never return. They marry among other Indians who reside in the neighborhood of their mistresses whom they serve. The Axüas would indeed be most unnatural beings, if they could dispose of their own flesh and blood for motives less cogent than their own absolute wretchedness. . . . Our safety, and liberty, in some measure, depended upon our taking these children, who are now free, and are bringing up in the two most excellent families with whom I am acquainted in Sonora, namely Don Victores Aguilar, and his brother, Don Dionysio." Hardy, *Travels*, 365–72. Setting aside Hardy's uncomprehending analysis of native motivations, it seems the purpose here was identical to that of the exchanges of children described two hundred years before: to make friends across ethnic lines, establish trust, prevent war, and provide for the future welfare of the children.

37. "Carta que Los Yndios Tarascos, que están en Sinaloa, escribieron a todos los Tarascos de la Provincia de Mechoacán, sobre la muerte del Padre Gonzálo de Tapía, por relación que les dió el Yndio Tarasco, que estava con el Padre quando lo mataron," July 1594, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 15, f. 46v; "Anua del año de 1597," in *ibid.*, f. 81r; Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 47, 81, 84–86, 87–93.
38. Hurdaide to the Viceroy, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, f. 15v; "Informe de Diego Martínez de Hurdaide sobre Sinaloa," February 9, 1602, MM, vol. 7, 758; Hurdaide to the Viceroy, n.d., AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, f. 13v.
39. Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 87; "Anua de 1602," AGN, *Historia*, vol. 15, f. 137r; Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 102.
40. Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 105–6.
41. *Ibid.*, 148–49.
42. *Ibid.*, 165–66.
43. *Ibid.*, 182–83.
44. *Ibid.*, 184, 188.
45. *Ibid.*, 188. Andrés Pérez de Ribas, "Anua del año de 1613," BL, M-M 227; Thomas, *Conquest*, 242–43; Taylor, "Santiago's Horse"; see also Graham, *Horses of the Conquest*.
46. *Ibid.*, 237. Hurdaide to the Marqués de Salinas, February 2, 1610, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, f. 29. Unlike several other tribes in the region, the Mayos did not accompany this request with an offer of child hostages. Nor, so far as can be discerned in the

surviving documents, did Hurdaide or the Jesuits ask for them. Perhaps the long-standing relationship of mutual service that the Mayos had established with the captain of the Villa de Sinaloa was the reason.

47. On war as a “savage schoolmaster,” see Kagan, *Peloponnesian War*, xxv.

CHAPTER 3. THE JESUIT REDUCTION

1. Shorter, *We Will Dance*, 111–46. Shorter usefully collects and analyzes twelve versions of the “Legend of the Talking Tree” gathered by anthropologists between 1932 and 1997.
2. Erickson, *Yaqui Homeland and Homeplace*, 23–36.
3. Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 289, 293–94. In this, the Jesuits shared much with the bureaucrats described by James Scott in *Seeing Like a State*, 2–3. Cynthia Radding de Murrieta makes explicit the contrast between barbarian / nomadic and reduced / Christian Indians. *Reducción*, she writes, was “closely related to Catholic status, living in a polity accorded legitimacy to native peoples. The reconstitution of indigenous communities in the mission pueblos constituted a key element of the imperial project. ‘Reduced’ Indians were distinguished from nomads and freed from the threat of enslavement as *piezas de rescate* [ransomed pieces].” Radding de Murrieta, *Landscapes of Power and Identity*, 165.
4. Hu-DeHart, *Missionaries*, 23; Spicer, “Spanish-Indian Acculturation in the Southwest,” 663–78; Hu-DeHart, “Development and Rural Rebellion,” 73; Spicer, *Yaquis*, 13: “Some of the population remained outside the towns and offered passive resistance, but the overwhelming majority, without any direct application of force, accepted the mission community regime.” Spicer, “Social Structure and Cultural Process,” 437; Sheridan, “How to Tell the Story.” Sheridan lays out the main critiques of both Spicer and Hu-DeHart and offers a challenge that I take up in this chapter: that historians should make use of the ethnographic record to understand the Yaqui past. Chapters 3 and 4 of Shorter, *We Will Dance*, offer thoughtful suggestions as to how that may be done, many of which I have accepted in the account below.
5. James Axtell notes something similar among the French Jesuits in Canada, *Invasion Within*, 23–91. Del Valle, *Escribiendo desde los márgenes*, chronicles the misery of north Mexican Jesuits whose humanitarian dreams were shattered by their uncooperative parishioners.
6. What is purely metaphorical in this case is made concrete in Wake, *Framing the Sacred*, 204, 231, 250. Wake shows how images of psychotropic *sinicuiche* cacti found their way into church frescoes of the ecstasy of St. Clare, Christ’s blood was represented as a maize cob on church sculptures, and Nahua speech glyphs emerged from the stone mouth of a sculpted angel’s trombone. Edgerton, *Theaters of Conversion*; Lara, *City, Temple, Stage*; Gruzinski, *Águila y la sibila*; and others explore related themes (see chapter 4, below).
7. Luciano Velázquez, a Yaqui interviewed by Larry Evers and Felipe S. Molina in 1982, said that the Surem who refused baptism “stayed around and went into the ocean and

- underground into the mountains. There in those places the Surem now exist as an enchanted people. Those who stayed behind are now the modern Yaquis, and they are called the Baptized Ones,” *Yaqui Deer Songs / Maso Bwikam*, 37–38, quoted in Shorter, *We Will Dance*, 139–40; Guzmán, *Relación*, 332; Robledo, *Relación*, 278–79; Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 282–86. Pérez de Ribas to Padre Provincial, April 13, 1617, BL, M-M 227, 581.
8. Reff, *Disease*, 36–43; Adorno and Pautz, *Cabeza de Vaca, His Account*, 1:231; Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 96; Diego Martínez de Hurdaide to Marqués de Salinas, February 2, 1610, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, f. 24.
 9. Vicente de Águila, “Relación de la misión de Cinaloa en la Nueva España,” January 6, 1614, ARSI, *Provincia Mexicana*, vol. 19, ff. 118v–122v, hereafter cited as Águila, “Relación.”
 10. *Ibid.*, f. 119r.
 11. Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 286–87; Águila, “Relación,” 120r–v.
 12. Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 287.
 13. *Ibid.*, 288.
 14. *Ibid.*, 287; Hurdaide to Marqués de Salinas, February 6, 1610, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, f. 29.
 15. Águila, “Relación,” f. 120v; Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 288; Pérez de Ribas, Reff, Danford, et al., *History*, 330–31.
 16. Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 288; Águila, “Relación,” f. 120v.
 17. Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 289; Águila, “Relación,” f. 121r. Though each account offers different numbers of Spanish horsemen, Hurdaide himself was in the best position to know. He said that he had nineteen men under his direct command and his *alférez* had eighteen. Hurdaide to Salinas, February 2, 1610, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, ff. 23–24.
 18. There are many discrepancies between the various accounts of this battle and its aftermath. Águila and Juan Mateo Mange, a late seventeenth-century chronicler, placed the number of Indian allies Hurdaide brought at two thousand, while Pérez de Ribas and the annual letter of 1610 put the number at twice that many. Águila made no guess as to the number of Yaqui fighters in the field, whereas Pérez de Ribas estimated that there were seven thousand, and Mange said eight thousand. Águila claimed it was *alférez* Zambrano who abandoned Hurdaide on the field of battle, and Pérez de Ribas said it was an unnamed *sargento*. Águila said Hurdaide was left on the battlefield with eighteen Spaniards and no Indian allies by his side, Hurdaide himself said nineteen Spaniards remained with him, the 1610 annual letter said the number was twenty, and Pérez de Ribas said he was left with twenty-two Spaniards and a single Indian ally. Águila said the Tehuecos deliberately abandoned Hurdaide to sabotage him, and Pérez de Ribas and the annual letter shared Hurdaide’s opinion that the Tehuecos ran away out of cowardice. Águila wrote that Zambrano abandoned the field because he and his men were overwhelmed by the enemy and only later claimed they thought Hurdaide was dead, whereas Pérez de Ribas said it was when they were in the midst of battle that they came to think Hurdaide had been killed and abandoned the field specifically for that reason. Águila said the Yaquis let Hurdaide go because they thought he would die soon, while none of the other accounts offered an explanation

for the Yaquis' behavior. Águila said Hurdaide left the battle weak and exhausted and was terrified that his former Mayo allies would kill him and his men, whereas Pérez de Ribas and the others made no mention of such fear.

Setting aside the minor numerical discrepancies, the overall impression given by the accounts is that, of the five, Pérez de Ribas most often tended to inflate the number of people involved in the conflict and to overstate the regard in which both native and Spanish people held Captain Hurdaide. Pérez de Ribas also tended to suppress Hurdaide's moments of terror, confusion, and panic. Águila was perhaps the least self-conscious of the narrators and included many dramatic moments and facts unflattering to the Spanish side that Pérez de Ribas left out. In his letters Hurdaide focused on his own excellence, on the massive dangers he overcame, and the large quantities of money he deserved to be paid. The annual letter of 1610 offered the least information on this battle but focused on the diplomatic exchange thereafter. Mange was the most fanciful of all the above, but he may have had access to documents now lost. Though it is tempting to do so, it would be unwise to ignore him. Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 289–90; "Anua del Año de 1610," BL, M-M 227, 430; Águila, "Relación"; Juan Mateo Mange, *Luz de tierra incógnita*, 333–35; Hurdaide to Marqués de Salinas, February 2, 1610, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, ff. 23–24; Hurdaide to Padre Visitador, June 12, 1627, in *ibid.*, f. 207.

19. Águila, "Relación," f. 121v; Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 291.
20. Águila, "Relación," f. 121v; Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 291–92.
21. Águila, "Relación," f. 122r.
22. Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 292; Águila, "Relación," f. 121r.
23. "Anua del año de 1610," CU-BANC, M-M 0227, 433.
24. Bancroft, *History of the North Mexican States*, 218; Spicer, *Yaquis*, 15; Hu-DeHart, *Missionaries*, 28; Shorter, *We Will Dance*, 169–70; Águila, "Relación," f. 122r; Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 293–94.
25. Hurdaide to Salinas, February 6, 1610, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, f. 23; Hurdaide to the Padre Provincial, 1618, in *ibid.*, f. 74.
26. Reff, *Disease*, 42, 65; Hedrick, *Mesoamerican Southwest*, 56; Underhill, "Intercultural Relations," 663–78; Clendinnen, "Fierce and Unnatural Cruelty," 76–78, offers an analysis of the differing cultures of war that clashed in the battle for Mexico–Tenochtitlan. Much as happened in that earlier conflict, acts that may have been considered honorable on one side of the cultural divide were often considered cowardly or contemptible on the other. Hurdaide was both mystified and delighted that so "valiant" a nation as the Yaquis suddenly "became cowardly" (*se acobardaron*). Hurdaide to Salinas, February 2, 1610, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, f. 23.
27. Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 295–96. "Anua del año de 1610," BL, M-M 227, 430; Juan Bautista Velasco to the Provincial, 1610, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 15, f. 119v. *Ibid.*, f. 96. James Brooks offers a penetrating description of the ways such exchanges often functioned in the greater southwest: "Grounded in conflict, the pattern developed through interaction into a unifying web of intellectual, material, and emotional exchange within which native and Euramerican men fought and traded to exploit and bind to themselves women and children of other peoples," *Captives and Cousins*, 31.

28. "Anua del año de 1610," BL, M-M 227, 430; Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 296.
29. Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 297–98.
30. *Ibid.*, 298; "Anua del año de 1610," BL, M-M 227, 431, recorded only two demands: that the Yaquis never harbor fugitives from Spanish justice and that they turn over Lautaro and Babilonio. The question of how the Jesuit writers knew how the Yaquis reacted to Hurdaide's gifts is as important as it is fascinating. Almost all the documents and all scholars agree that no Jesuit lived among the Yaquis until 1617. But letters from Hurdaide (see below) recorded attempts by the Jesuits to convert the Yaquis in 1608 and 1610, and so it is possible the Jesuits were eyewitnesses to the Yaquis' deliberations.
31. "Anua del año de 1610," BL, M-M 227, 431; Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 299–300; "Anua del año de 1610," BL, M-M 227, 431, specifies the number of children the Yaquis offered as fourteen, and that only four of them were studying with the Jesuits. Hurdaide wrote that the total number of captive children was only four. Whatever the number was, all accounts indicate that the Yaquis offered children as "hostages of peace," *rehenes de paz*, or guarantors of their goodwill in times to come. Hurdaide to Salinas, February 2, 1610, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, f. 23. Clendinnen, "Fierce and Unnatural Cruelty," 70. Maurice Godelier articulates the dynamic in this way: "The act of giving seems to create simultaneously a twofold relationship between giver and receiver. A relationship of *solidarity* because the giver shares what he has, or what he is, with the receiver; and a relationship of *superiority* because the one who receives the gift and accepts it places himself in the debt of the one who has given it, thereby becoming indebted to the giver and to a certain extent becoming his 'dependent,' at least for as long as he has not 'given back' what he was given." If this was indeed the dynamic at play between the Yaquis and Spanish, there is every reason to think the Yaquis considered themselves the winners of the conflict, not the losers, and were generously establishing solidarity with the Spanish and superiority to them by handing over these children. Godelier goes on to connect gift exchanges of this type with violence: "The giving of gifts may ward off direct violence or physical, material, and social subordination, but it also may stand in their stead. And there are countless examples of societies where individuals sell themselves or their children into slavery, ending up as the property, the 'possession' of those who had bestowed gifts on them," *Enigma of the Gift*, 12. This substitution of gifts for violence was clearly under way in the negotiations between the Spanish and the Yaquis. In a fascinating exchange (see below), a Jesuit witnessed Mayo and Yaqui leaders negotiating over him as if the priest were a possession to be traded. My thanks to Gary Clayton Anderson for pointing me toward Godelier's writings.
32. "Anua del año de 1610," BL, M-M 227, 433; Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 300.
33. Spicer, "Spanish-Indian Acculturation in the Southwest," 663–78; Deeds, "Legacies of Resistance," 54–58, and "Indigenous Rebellions," 32–51.
34. On the parity of power, see White, *Middle Ground* and "Creative Misunderstandings and New Understandings," 9–14; on gendered negotiations across cultures, see Barr, *Peace Came*; Sleeper-Smith, *Indian Women and French Men*; Herrera, "Concubines and Wives," 127–44; Townsend, *Malintzin's Choices*; and Anderson, *Indian Southwest*. On violence, see Blackhawk, *Violence over the Land*; Whitehead, *Violence*; and Whitehead and Wright, *In Darkness and Secrecy*.

35. Spicer, *Yaquis*, 20.
36. Hurdaide to Marqués de Salinas, May 10, 1610, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, f. 33. “Anua del año de 1611,” May 5, 1611, BL, M-M 227, 441–42; Hurdaide to the Viceroy, April 10, 1615, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, f. 78.
37. “Anua del año de 1613,” BL, M-M 227, 466–67; “Anua del año de 1614,” in *ibid.*, 522; “Anua del año de 1615,” in *ibid.*, 539; Hurdaide to the Viceroy, January 20, 1614, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, f. 158.
38. Hurdaide to the Governor, February 27, 1616, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, f. 184.
39. Hurdaide to the Viceroy, April 10, 1615, in *ibid.*, f. 81; Hurdaide to the Viceroy, March 5, 1617, in *ibid.*, f. 105; Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 301; Hurdaide to the Governor, January 10, 1617, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, f. 97.
40. Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 301; Hurdaide to the Governor, January 10, 1617, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, f. 97.
41. Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 303–4; Pérez de Ribas to the Provincial, June 13, 1617, BL, M-M 227, 951; Gradie, *Tepehuan Revolt*.
42. Pérez de Ribas to Padre Provincial, April 13, 1617, BL, M-M 227, 581–84. The question of Tesano’s existence is an intriguing one. I have found no reference to the town in the colonial period after it was first mentioned by Pérez de Ribas in 1617. But a map made of the Sierra de Bacatete and the Yaqui Valley in 1900 identifies a Cerro de Tesamo a few kilometers upstream from the most inland Yaqui town. The hill was thus exactly where Pérez de Ribas said the town of Tesano was. “Sierra de Bacatete en 1900,” Mapoteca Manuel Orozco y Berra, 5347-CGE-7215-B-2.
43. Pérez de Ribas to Padre Provincial, April 13, 1617, BL, M-M 227, 584; Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 306–7.
44. Pérez de Ribas to the Provincial, June 13, 1617, BL, M-M 227, 583; Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 307.
45. Pérez de Ribas to the Provincial, June 13, 1617, BL, M-M 227, 496. Daniel Reff, the leading authority on disease in northwest Mexico, places the population of the Yaquis at 60,000 in 1500, at 35,000 in 1617, 20,450 in 1624, 25,725 in 1638, 13,318 in 1656, 7,549 in 1678, 6,733 in 1720, 16,000 in 1741, and 21,912 in 1759. Though most censuses note that the population numbers were skewed downward by Yaqui migration to Spanish mining centers, Reff notes that that migration did not get under way until the 1670s, when mines were discovered near the Yaqui missions. The horrific population decline reflected in the census numbers for earlier years was thus very real. Reff also notes that the impressive increase in population in the early to mid-eighteenth century was also plausible given the well-attested productiveness of Yaqui agriculture. Reff, *Disease*, 214–18.
46. Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 309.
47. *Ibid.*, 315.

CHAPTER 4. MISSION AND EMPIRE

1. “Report of the voyage of Captain Francisco de Lucenilla to the Californias in 1668,” 1668, Newberry Library (NL), Ayer Manuscript 1125; “Relación verdadera de el estado que tiene la gentilidad y cristiandad en las provincias de Sonora y Sinaloa y en las demás hasta

- Guadalajara . . . escripta por el Padre fray Juan Caballero, lector de Teología, año de 1669," May 1, 1669, BNE, MSS 18758.13, f. 2r. Caballero, "Relación verdadera" hereafter. To be precise, the Yaquis greeted the Franciscan with the music of *chirimías*, or shawms, a double-reeded instrument similar to the oboe. See Mann, *Power of Song*, 78.
2. Caballero, "Relación verdadera," f. 2r.
 3. *Ibid.*, ff. 2v, 3v.
 4. On the development of silver mining in Sonora, see West, *Sonora*, 44–59; Atondo Rodríguez and Ortega Soto, "Entrada de los Colonos," 90–110.
 5. Juan Bautista du Quesnay, "Memoriales," November 9, 1738, CU-BANC, C-B 840, no. 271, p. 464, cites Rahum's "Libro de Visitas," and Juan Lorenzo Salgado to Ignacio Calderon, March 8, 1756, AHH, leg. 17, no. 39, f. 1r, mentioned the "Libros de administración" and "libros de gasto y recibo" for each of the Yaqui mission towns. Pérez de Ribas describes the recording of baptisms in *Historia*, 148.
 6. Literature on the subaltern resistance to and negotiation with empires and states informs this analysis. For works in this field, see Radding de Murrieta, *Wandering Peoples and Landscapes of Power and Identity*; Deeds, *Defiance and Deference* and "Legacies of Resistance"; Guy and Sheridan, *Contested Ground*; see also Ruíz Medrano and Kellogg, *Negotiation Within Domination*; Yannakakis, *Art of Being In-Between*; and Joseph and Nugent, *Everyday Forms of State Formation*; Wells and Joseph, *Summer of Discontent*; Vaughan, *Cultural Politics in Revolution*; Mallon, *Peasant and Nation*; and Scott, *Domination and the Arts of Resistance, Seeing Like a State*, and *Art of Not Being Governed*.
 7. Hu-DeHart, for instance, has written of the imposition of "profound changes on all aspects of Yaqui life and society" and of general Yaqui acquiescence to "directed cultural change," *Missionaries, Miners, and Indians*, 23; Spicer has written of the sixty years following the Jesuits' arrival in 1617 as a period of "unusual tranquillity," with little rebellion or cultural resistance, during which "the new religion was undergoing a most thorough and peaceful integration with the native beliefs and practices." He went on to write that the Yaquis "worked with practically no friction with the missionaries," *Cycles of Conquest*, 49.
 8. Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 332. This quotation echoes a passage in Spicer, *Yaquis*, describing the untranslatable concept of *huya aniya*, "tree world" or "brushland": "The *huya aniya* is one of the two parts into which the universe is divided with respect to inner, 'spiritual,' or 'spiritual power' aspects. The 'brushland' characteristic is merely a marker with respect to these other, deeper and more important characteristics. The *huya aniya* refers not merely to those places where one gets cane for a score of different kinds of household utensils and for mats and for house walls or where one finds the mesquite posts to hold up the house roofs, or where grow for the picking the many kinds of greens, the cactus fruits, the seeds, or where range the small game and the deer. The *huya aniya* is also full of places where great beings had once lived and perhaps still live, giving their names to those places," 64. On the role of the devil in colonial discourse, see Cervantes, *Devil* and "Devils of Querétaro"; Souza, *Devil and the Land of the Holy Cross*.
 9. Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 312, 316.

10. Ibid., 316, 381, 328. Pérez de Ribas to the Provincial, April 6, 1617, CU-BANC, M-M 227, 579–83.
11. Hurdaide to José Pérez de Lomas, April 29, 1622, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, ff. 17–18; Nicolás de Anaya, “Anua del año de 1621,” CU-BANC, M-M 227, 662–63.
12. Hurdaide to the Oidor, September 5, 1620, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, f. 103; Hurdaide to the Viceroy, April 4, 1622, in *ibid.*, f. 89; Nicolás de Anaya, “Anua del año de 1621,” CU-BANC, M-M 227, 665; five years later Hurdaide claimed in a letter to his superiors that he had visited a terrible punishment on the Yaqui conspirators and that this was the cause of the Yaquis’ quiescence in subsequent years. I have found no evidence from 1622 that such a punishment actually took place. Hurdaide to the Padre Visitador, June 12, 1627, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, f. 211.
13. “Disposiciones de algunos virreyes (conde de Monterrey, marques de Montesclaros, marques de Salinas, marques de Guadalcázar, marqués de Gelves) sobre doctrinas y presidios del Yaqui y Mayo, recopilados en 1627,” BL, WA MSS S-810 Z86; “Anua del año de 1622,” AGN, *Misiones*, vol. 25, ff. 354–55; Hurdaide to the Padre Visitador, June 12, 1627, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, f. 213.
14. “Carta Annua de la Misión de San Ignacio destos Rios, de Hiaqui y Maio, 1652,” April 6, 1653, AGN, *Misiones*, vol. 26, 358, 360; Diego de Marquina, “Memoria de los Pueblos de Yaqui y Mayo,” June 20, 1684, AHH, *Temporalidades*, leg. 279, no. 72, f. 2; Francisco Parralo, “Declaración,” July 21, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, 244 B, Cuaderno 2, f. 1076r; Lorenzo José García to Lucas Luís Álvarez, July 10, 1744, Jesuítas, leg. 1–11, exp. 15, f. 87v.
15. Taylor, *Magistrates of the Sacred*, 59–62.
16. Hurdaide to the Governor, February 27, 1616, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, f. 185; Pérez de Ribas to the Provincial, June 13, 1617, BL, M-M 227, 947; “Anua del año de 1621,” April 30, 1622, in *ibid.*, 661; Pérez de Ribas to the Provincial, June 13, 1617, in *ibid.*, 582; Hurdaide to the Padre Visitador, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, f. 202; Nicolás de Anaya, “Anua del año de 1621,” April 30, 1622, BL, M-M 227, 661. Radding de Murrieta describes this sort of negotiation with native leaders over mission space as going on across most of the Sonoran missions, *Landscapes of Power and Identity*, 62–65.
17. Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 331. The reference to Vicam refers to events that took place sometime between 1615 and 1625, however. “Padre Visitador Augustín Carta to Padre Provincial Juan Antonio Baltasar,” March 1, 1652, AHH, vol. 2009, exp. 39 [unnumbered folios]; “Mission de Nuestro Santo padre Ignacio de Mayo y Hiaqui Annua 1653,” AGN, *Misiones*, vol. 26, 395; ARSI, 1720, *Provincia Mexicana*, vol. 18, f. 20v; Ignacio María Nápoli to Manuel Bernal de Huidobro, July 21, 1738, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, cuaderno 1, 528r. This contrasts with the experience of Indians nearer to the silver mines in the Sierra Tarahumara, where “the congregation of Indians was not necessarily related to their previous settlement patterns; the determining criterion was relocation near Spanish extractive activities,” Deeds, *Defiance and Deference*, 58.
18. Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 335; “Annua del colegio de la V.a de Zinaloa, y sus Miss.es desde el año de 1632 hasta el de 1638 inclusive,” March 31, 1638, AGN, *Misiones*, vol. 25, 928. For the role of aesthetic pleasure in Jesuit missions, see Bailey, *Art on the Jesuit Missions*, and Mann, *Power of Song*.

19. Andrés Pérez de Ribas to the King, September 12, 1638, AHH, vol. 2009, exp. 1, f. 5r.
20. ARSI, *Provincia Mexicana*, vol. 19, f. 162v.
21. *Ibid.*, f. 163r.
22. Perez de Ribas, *Historia*, 336.
23. *Ibid.*, 330, 337; Vicente de Águila, “Anua del colegio de la V.a de Zinaloa, y sus Miss. es desde el año de 1632 hasta el de 1638 inclusive,” February 2, 1638, AGN, *Misiones*, vol. 25, 926.
24. “Anua del año de 1621,” April 30, 1622 BL, M-M 227, 661. “On the great rivers of Yaqui and Mayo,” a Jesuit wrote in 1626, “which are below the Nébomes toward the sea, it is a great proof of their fidelity and Christianity, that this year, with the death of the captain and unrest among the *cimarrones* and Nébomes, they have been very calm and have attended to the things of the church, always giving signs of growing in the faith.” One must take Jesuit claims of this kind with a grain of salt. But the Jesuits’ willingness to admit it when things were going badly for the missions lends some credence to their claims that things were going well. “Anua del Colegio, y Misiones de Cinaloa de los años de 1625 y 1626,” May 1626, AGN, *Misiones*, vol. 25, f. 683; Guillermo Díez, “Carta Anua del año de 1628,” May 25, 1629, in *ibid.*, f. 817; see Tomás Basilio, “Puntos p.a el Anua del año de 1635 destas mis. nes de San Ignacio nro. Pr.e la Prov.a de Cinaloa,” March 26, 1636, in *ibid.*, ff. 907, 910, 913. Basilio wrote this letter from the Yaqui mission and mentioned the many baptisms and marriages he had overseen but none of the threats, attacks, and uprisings that threatened him through the sixteen-teens and twenties. Pedro Zambrano reported that all was calm on the Yaqui mission in 1650: “Relación de los religiosos que atienden el rio de Hiaqui,” AGN, Jesuítas, leg. 1–11, exp. 110, f. 366.
25. Juan Ortíz Zapata, “Relación de las Misiones que la Compañía tiene en el Reyno y Provincias de la nueva Viscaya en la Nueva España,” CU-BANC, C-B 840, no. 265, pp. 697–701.
26. “Memoria of Padre Diego de Marquina,” July 8, 1684, AHH, *Temporalidades*, leg. 279, exp. 76; “Memoria del Padre Diego de Marquina,” n.d., in *ibid.*, exp. 80; “Memoria del Padre Francisco Pérez Arroyo,” n.d., in *ibid.*, exp. 78; “Memoria del Padre Andrés de Fernández,” n.d., in *ibid.*, exp. 73.
27. The analysis presented here parallels that of Radding de Murrieta in *Landscapes of Power and Identity*, 69: while granting the importance of disease in early relations between native and European peoples, Radding de Murrieta writes, “patterns of warfare among the native peoples of Sonora and Chiquitos created a matrix for defining power relations between Indians and Europeans. . . . War and the taking of human captives . . . threatened the survival of indigenous communities and engendered an environment of fear perhaps as potent as that of disease in conditioning the cultural politics of mission towns.” The history of the Yaquis in the seventeenth century was of an ever-tightening integration of Yaqui and Spanish military forces in a shared struggle against non-Christian natives.
28. “Misiones de la Nueva España o México, en especial de Sinaloa,” ARSI, *Provincia Mexicana*, vol. 19, f. 136r. There are certain analogies between the Jesuits’ role in Sonora and that which they played in New France, where “traders obtained their

furs and the Jesuits their converts, but also they became the mediators of a regional Algonquian alliance,” White, *Middle Ground*, 23. But White’s account mentions few if any instances in which Jesuits served as intermediaries, not between Indians and Frenchmen but among indigenous groups. The records of the Sinaloa and Sonora missions document numerous instances of Jesuits mediating both between Indians and Spaniards and between Indians and Indians. Why this was so in northwest New Spain and not in New France is a puzzle. One possible explanation is that Christian conversion took on more immediate political meanings in New Spain than in New France, given the close collaboration between Jesuits, Captain Hurdaide, and the captain’s native Christian soldiers. These circumstances conferred political and diplomatic roles on Jesuits that they may not have had in New France. Further comparative research may yet shed light on the origins of this intriguing contrast.

29. “Misiones de la Nueva España o Mexico, en especial de Sinaloa,” ARSI, *Provincia Mexicana*, vol. 19, ff. 136v–137r.
30. Pérez de Ribas, *Historia*, 322.
31. *Ibid.*, 320, 322. Juan Varela, “Misiones de la Provincia de Cinaloa,” February 16, 1628, AGN, *Misiones*, vol. 25, f. 835.
32. Hurdaide to the Viceroy, September 5, 1620, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, f. 100; “Carta anua de 1623,” May 16, 1624, AGN, *Misiones*, vol. 25, f. 520; Hurdaide to the Padre Visitador, June 12, 1627, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 316, f. 201.
33. “Descripcion de las misiones de Cinaloa,” February 29, 1675, ARSI, *Provincia Mexicana*, vol. 17, f. 338v.
34. Juan de Encinas, “En el pueblo de Raon . . .,” AHH, *Temporalidades*, leg. 278, no. 22, ff. 31–33.
35. *Ibid.*, f. 32.
36. Deeds, “Legacies of Resistance,” 89–135. Knaut, *Pueblo Revolt*; Forbes, *Apache, Navajo, and Spaniard*, 200–250.
37. Andrés de Cervantes to Juan Francisco Goyeneche, September 9, 1689, AGN, *Provincias Internas*, vol. 30, f. 223v; Francisco Pérez Arroyo to Juan Francisco Goyeneche, October 6, 1689, in *ibid.*, f. 219r.
38. “Juan Francisco Goyeneche, Auto,” October 20, 1689, AGN, in *ibid.*, f. 224v.
39. “Andrés de Cervantes to Juan Isidro de Pardiñas Villar de Francos,” October 29, 1689, in *ibid.*; “Juan Francisco Goyeneche, Auto,” October 24, 1689, in *ibid.*, f. 225r.
40. “Juan Francisco Goyeneche, Auto,” October 29, 1689, in *ibid.*, f. 227r.
41. “Juan Francisco Goyeneche to Juan Isidro de Pardiñas Vilar de Francos,” November 9, 1689, AHH, *Temporalidades*, vol. 30, f. 235r. This statement contradicts Hu-DeHart’s claim that in the seventeenth century, “unlike later missions established on the dangerous Apache frontier of the Pimeria Alta, the early Yaqui mission existed within the bounds of a pacific Jesuit domain.” She continues, “With no constant threat to their security, these Sinaloa missions consequently felt little need for military positions.” The documents from the Goyeneche expedition indicate that the Yaqui mission seems to have been on a war footing for most of the seventeenth century. Hu-DeHart, *Missionaries*, 35.

42. Diego de Marquina, "Memoria de los pueblos del Rio Yaqui y Mayo," AHH, *Temporalidades*, leg. 279, no. 104, f. 2.
43. Bolton, *Rim of Christendom*, 133–5; Clavigero, *Historia de la Antigua o Baja California*, 60; Esteban Lorenzo Rodríguez and Jaime Bravo, "Lista de Soldados y Indios que sirvieron en la sublevación de algunas misiones de Californias," AGN, *Californias*, leg. 80, ff. 33–38.
44. O'Malley has analyzed anti-Jesuit animus in various places throughout his copious oeuvre: see generally *Trent and All That* and *First Jesuits*, 1. See also Brading, *Church and State*, 3–19, and *First America*: 184–212 on José de Acosta, 166–83 on Andrés Pérez de Ribas, and 228–50 on Juan de Palafox y Mendoza. Israel, *Race, Class and Politics*, provides good detail on the Jesuits' controversies with Juan de Palafox y Mendoza, the bishop of Puebla who later became archbishop of Mexico and interim viceroy.
45. Andrés Pérez de Ribas et al. to the King, September 12, 1638, AHH, vol. 2009, exp. 1, f. 2v.
46. Pérez de Ribas to the King, 1643, AHH, vol. 1126, exp. 44, f. 2v.
47. Ibid. Pérez de Ribas, like Herbert Eugene Bolton four hundred years later, was well aware that the mission was a "frontier institution of the Spanish Empire" and served both as a school of civilization and a counterinsurgency measure. Bolton, "Mission as a Frontier Institution," 42–61.
48. Andrés Pérez de Ribas to the King, 1643, AHH, vol. 1126, exp. 44, ff. 1–10. Andrés Pérez de Ribas et al. to the King, September 12, 1638, AHH, vol. 2009, exp. 1, f. 9v; Stagg, *First Bishop of Sonora*, 57–58.
49. Andrés Pérez de Ribas et al. to the King, September 12, 1638, AHH, vol. 2009, exp. 1, f. 4v; Juan Caballero, "Relacion verdadera . . .," May 1, 1669, BNE, MSS 18758.13, f. 9r; Diego de Marquina, "Memoria de los Pueblos de Yaqui y Mayo," June 20, 1684, AGN, *Misiones*, vol. 26; AHH, *Temporalidades*, leg. 279, no. 072, f. 1; Navarro García, *Sonora y Sinaloa*, 38–39.

CHAPTER 5. CRACKS IN THE FOUNDATION

1. "Memorial Ajustado," AGI, *Guadalajara*, vol. 89, ff. 34v–38v.
2. Spicer, *Cycles of Conquest*, 50.
3. On emergent Bourbon thinking on America's native peoples, see Weber, *Bárbaros*, chap. 1.
4. Anza to Nápoli, January 2, 1738, AGN, *Californias*, vol. 64, exp. 8, f. 150r; Vildósola to Nápoli, April 10, 1738, in *ibid.*, f. 159r; Andrés Cotta, "Declaración," July 16, 1739, in *ibid.*, f. 145v. On shifting relations among crown, clergy, and native towns, see Taylor, *Magistrates of the Sacred*.
5. Taylor, *Drinking, Homicide, and Rebellion*, 113–51. Since the publication of Taylor's study, an enormous amount has been published about rural rebellion in eighteenth-century Spanish America. Salient contributions to this vast and growing literature include Deeds, *Defiance and Deference*; Patch, *Maya Revolt and Revolution in the Eighteenth Century*; Serúlnikov, *Subverting Colonial Authority*; Thomson, *We Alone Will Rule*; Viqueira Albán, *Encrucijadas chiapanecas*; Van Young, *Other Rebellion*;

- Walker, *Smoldering Ashes*; and Guardino, *Peasants and Time of Liberty*; on Sonora, see Salmón, “Marginal Man,” and Mirafuentes Galván, “Colonial Expansion and Indian Resistance.”
6. To date, few historians have explored the insurrection of 1740 in depth. As early as the late eighteenth century, antiquarians and local historians opined about it: see Alegre et al., *Historia de la provincia*, 4:391–94; Velasco, *Noticias estadísticas*; Bancroft, *History of the North Mexican States*, 521–23; Dávila, *Sonora histórico*, 11; Troncoso et al., *Guerras*, 49; Astraín, *Historia de la Compañía*, 7:313–16; Alessio Robles, *Bosquejos históricos*, 378; Fabila, *Tribus yaquis de Sonora*, 80–81; Ocaranza, *Crónicas y relaciones*, 1:128–29; and Decorme, *Obra de los jesuitas*, 2:334–40. Serious study of the insurrection began in 1966 with the publication of *La sublevación yaqui de 1740*, by the eminent Spanish historian Luis Navarro García. Beyond his discovery of an astonishing trove of documents on the event in the Archive of the Indies in Seville, Navarro García’s main contribution lay in his unravelling of the chronology and basic facts of this exceedingly tangled uprising. He did not, however, place emphasis on the Yaqui point of view, and he failed to examine a great deal of documentation in U.S. and Mexican archives. More recent studies have had the opposite problem: fine attention to native acts and voices but limited archival research. Edward Spicer’s views of the insurrection shifted over time, from an early view of the revolt as a watershed to a later opinion that it was little more than “an uncoordinated series of disturbances” inspired by hunger and political confusion. Spicer offered little documentary support for either position: see *Cycles of Conquest*, 46–86, and *Yaquis*, 50–57. Hu-DeHart’s take on the events of 1740 displays characteristic wit and efficiency but generally attempts to fit the uprising into a narrative of undying Yaqui resistance to outside oppressors; she gives short shrift to the Yaquis’ subtle, shifting views of the empire: *Missionaries, Miners, and Indians*, 60, and “Peasant Rebellion in the Northwest,” 142–43. Susan Deeds’s “Indigenous Rebellions” provides a useful comparison of an early messianic revolt with the Yaqui uprising of 1740 but draws on a relatively limited base of primary research. Close reading of rebel behavior is the basis of Cynthia Radding de Murrieta’s subtle contributions to our understanding of 1740. Though Radding de Murrieta also relies mainly on secondary sources, she rightly emphasizes the importance of culture to the process of insurrection and shows how deeply it affected the later politics of region. Most important, she listens to the rebels themselves and underscores both their sophistication and ambivalence: they resented arrogant outsiders and at the same time sought commerce with them. See Radding de Murrieta, “Misiones de Ostimuri” and *Wandering Peoples*, 283.
 7. Van Young, “Raw and the Cooked,” 312, and *Other Rebellion*, 1–36; Guardino, *Time of Liberty*, 285–86.
 8. Brading, “Bourbon Spain and Its American Empire,” 112–62.
 9. Kamen, *Philip V*.
 10. Ibid., 127; Barbara and Stanley Stein, *Silver, Trade, and War*, take a much more negative view of Philip’s reign than Kamen does, identifying the origins of Spain’s decline in Philip’s reign and tracing its steady progress through the eighteenth century.
 11. Kamen, *Empire*, 451–53.
 12. Taylor, *Magistrates of the Sacred*; Weber, *Bárbaros*, 181–82, 337; Campillo y Cosío, *Nuevo sistema*, 107, 108, 127, 128.

13. The term *fringe* and its definition come from Lockhart and Schwartz, *Early Latin America*, 253–304. My understanding of the early Bourbon reformers and their ambitions with regard to the native peoples of the Americas derives from Stein and Stein, *Silver, Trade and War*; Brading, *First America*, 465–648; Taylor, *Magistrates of the Sacred*, provides a magisterial analysis of the changing relations among church, crown, and peasant villages in eighteenth-century Mexico. On the creation of Sinaloa and Sonora, see del Valle Borrero Silva, *Fundación y primeros años*; and del Río, “*El noroeste novohispano*,” 193–201.
14. Gerhard, *North Frontier*, 266.
15. “Real cédula,” March 14, 1732, AGI, *Guadalajara*, vol. 234; HGS, vol. 2, f. 154. The king retained the right to name the *alcalde mayor* of Sonora.
16. “Propuesta de Casafuerte a Patiño, México,” August 1, 1730, and “Noticia de la erección del gobierno a S. M., Mexico,” February 19, 1734, AGI, *Guadalajara*, vol. 135; “Relación de Títulos . . .,” in *ibid.*, vol. 188; “Memorial ajustado,” in *ibid.*, vol. 89, f. 235; Naylor and Polzer, *Pedro de Rivera*, 82.
17. AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 A, cuaderno 5, f. 17. Stein and Stein, *Silver, Trade, and War*, 224; on later Bourbon attempts to streamline and standardize the mestizo-baroque religious practices of Mexico, see also Brading, *Church and State in Bourbon Mexico*; Voekel, *Alone Before God*, 4–5; and Larkin, *Very Nature of God*, 15–16.
18. Del Río, *Conquista y aculturación*, 207–24; AGN, *Californias*, vol. 80, ff. 33–38, lists thirty-five Spanish soldiers and a mixture of eighty-seven Yaqui, Guaymas, and Sinaloa auxiliaries.
19. AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 327–46, 365, 373, 374.
20. Previous scholarship has generally referred to these men as Muni and Bernabé. This is an unfortunate decision since colonial officials generally referred to them by their first names as a way of belittling them. Rather than repeating this colonial convention, I refer to them by their surnames. Manuel Bernal de Huidobro, “Autos,” December 19, 1735, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, f. 381r. In a declaration of 1738, Jusacamea said he did not know his age, but the scribe said he looked about thirty-five, in *ibid.*, f. 562r; Bernabé Basoritemea, “Declaración,” July 23, 1738, in *ibid.*, f. 562v, 571r; Bernabé Basoritemea, “Testimonio,” March 17, 1736, in *ibid.*, f. 391v; Pedro Reynaldos, Ignacio Duque, and Diego González, “Memorial,” AGN, *Jesuitas*, leg. 1–12, exp. 273, f. 2009v.
21. Knight, *Mexican Revolution*, 1:176; Joseph, “Fragile Revolution,” 39–64; Wells and Joseph, *Summer of Discontent*.
22. “Testimonios,” March 17–April 4, 1736, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, cuaderno 1, ff. 386v–408v.
23. Juan Ignacio Jusacamea and Bernabé Basoritemea, “Acusación y comparecencia de los Yndios, contra las personas que se expres.n,” January 14, 1738, in *ibid.*, ff. 61r–70v.
24. “Declaración de Juan de Salas,” August 25, 1738, in *ibid.*, f. 622r.
25. The custom of greeting visitors armed and at a distance from the Yaqui pueblos dated back to the early seventeenth century, if not earlier. See Pérez de Ribas to the Provincial, June 13, 1617, BL, M-M 227, 584; and Juan Francisco Goyeneche, “Auto,” October 20, 1689, AGN, *Provincias Internas*, vol. 30, f. 224v; Gaspar Álvarez, “Testimonio,” July 7, 1738, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 450v–455v.

26. Juan Ignacio Jusacamea and Bernabé Basoritemea, "Acusación y Comparecencia de los Yndios, contra personas que se expres.n," January 14, 1738, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, cuaderno 1, f. 61v; Manuel de Mena, October 29, 1736, "Despacho," in *ibid.*, f. 49r.
27. Nápoli to Huidobro, November 13, 1737, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, cuaderno 1, f. 105r; Ignacio Mauricio de Osuna, "Declaración," CU-BANC, M-M 1875 1, f. 170r.
28. "Declaración de Juan Botiller," October 14, 1741, BL, M-M 1875, ff. 212v–214r.
29. González to the Viceroy, August 9, 1737, AGN, *Provincias Internas*, vol. 87, ff. 126–41.
30. Navarro García, *Sublevación*, 33.
31. Oviedo to Nápoli, March 3, 1737, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 392, ff. 455–56.
32. Nápoli to Huidobro, November 13, 1737, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 102r–112v.
33. *Ibid.*, f. 106v.
34. Juan Ignacio García de Puertas, Joseph Carranza y Arce, and Joseph de Villalta, "Certificación de la Lealtad de los Indios de Raum," AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 51r–56v.
35. Nápoli to Huidobro, November 13, 1737, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, f. 111v.
36. Who actually wrote the letter is open to question since its supposed authors contradicted it in later testimony.
37. Bernabé Basoritemea, "Escripto," December 14, 1737, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 17r–20v.
38. Peralta to Huidobro, November 29, 1737, in *ibid.*, f. 7r; Peralta to Flores, November 29, 1737, in *ibid.*, ff. 7v–8v; Peralta de García, November 29, 1737, in *ibid.*, ff. 9v–12r.
39. García to Nápoli, December 9, 1737, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 392, f. 495; García to Peralta, December 9, 1737, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 12r–16r; García to Nápoli, December 15, 1737, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 392, f. 498; Estrada to Nápoli, December 21, 1737, in *ibid.*, 511.
40. "Informe del Comisario Flores," December 30, 1737, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 30r–40v.
41. *Ibid.*, f. 32r.
42. *Ibid.*, ff. 33v–34r.
43. *Ibid.*, f. 35v.
44. *Ibid.*, ff. 36v–40v.
45. *Ibid.*, ff. 30r–40v.
46. García to Nápoli, December 30, 1737, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 392, f. 493; Nápoli to Peralta, December 30, 1737, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 42v–46v.
47. Lucas Luís Álvarez to Peralta, February 6, 1738, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 155v–160v; Martín Cayetano Fernández de Peralta, "Auto de Nombramiento de Intérpretes," January 14, 1738, in *ibid.*, ff. 59r–61.
48. Martín Cayetano Fernández de Peralta, "Despacho," April 20, 1738, in *ibid.*, f. 128r.
49. Navarro García, "Sublevación," 37; AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 81–101, 166, 167, 168, 519–24.
50. Diego Marquina, "Escripto," July 1, 1738, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, f. 433v.
51. Cristóbal de Gurrola, "Escripto," July 1, 1738, in *ibid.*, ff. 431r–433r; Diego Marquina, "Escripto," July 1, 1738, in *ibid.*, ff. 433v–435r; Juan Gurimea, "Escripto," July 1, 1738, in *ibid.*, ff. 435r–436r; Joseph Vuimea, "Escripto," July 1, 1738, in *ibid.*, ff. 436r–437r;

Gurrola, Vuimea, Turimea, and Marquina would all claim in later testimony that they could not sign their name because they did not know how to write. Cristóbal de Gurrola, “Declaración,” July 12, 1738, in *ibid.*, f. 485r; Joseph Vuimea, “Declaración,” July 12, 1738, in *ibid.*, f. 488r; Juan de Turimea, “Declaración,” July 16, 1738, in *ibid.*, f. 493r; Diego Marquina, “Declaración,” July 16, 1738, in *ibid.*, f. 498v; Diego Marquina, “Escripto,” July 1, 1738, in *ibid.*, f. 433v; *ibid.*, ff. 478–519. In addition to exposing Nápoli’s fraud, Gurrola, Turimea, Vuimea, and Marquina all gave testimony that was identical to that which they had given to Flores months before. Their story never changed.

52. Anza to Nápoli, January 2, 1738, AGN, *Californias*, vol. 64, exp. 8, ff. 136–71.
53. Nápoli to Huidobro, July 21, 1738, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, f. 527v.
54. *Ibid.*, ff. 527v, 529r, 531v, 534v, 543v, 558r.
55. *Ibid.*, f. 535r.
56. Manuel Bernal de Huidobro, “Auto,” July 22, 1738, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, f. 325.
57. Juan Ignacio Jusacamea, “Declaración,” July 23, 1738, in *ibid.*, f. 557r.
58. *Ibid.*, f. 561v.
59. Bernabé Basoritemea, “Declaración,” July 24, 1738, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, f. 564r, 566r.
60. Luis Aquibuameachay, “Declaración,” July 24, 1738, in *ibid.*, f. 573v.
61. These community relationships are comparable in many respects to those described in Katz, *Life and Times of Pancho Villa*; Navarro García, *Sublevación*, 44, citing Francisco Peñuelas, “Declaración,” 1741, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 A, ff. 510–539v.
62. On the secularization of Jesuit missions, see Deeds, *Defiance and Deference*, 131–32.
63. Felipe Tacococay, “Declaración,” October 9, 1741, BL, M-M 1875, f. 203v; Navarro García, *Sublevación*, 45; Maldonado to Huidobro, August 4, 1739, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 C, f. 437.
64. Acedo to Huidobro, September 25, 1739, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 C, 437; Juan María de Alcalá, “Declaración,” in *ibid.*, f. 266.
65. “Juicio Eclesiástico . . .,” June 28, 1739, AGN, *Californias*, vol. 64, f. 136v.
66. “Juicio Eclesiástico . . .,” June 30, 1739, in *ibid.*, f. 147v. It is unclear whether this letter ever existed. If it did, I have not found it, and its contents, as reported in this dispute, were at variance with the viceroy’s actual, much more limited rulings, which are described below.
67. Juan Sichimse, “Declaración,” July 18, 1739, in *ibid.*, f. 143r.
68. Ignacio María Nápoli, “Declaración,” August 28, 1739, in *ibid.*, f. 170v.
69. Nápoli to Andrés Xavier Sarnia, September 2, 1739, AHH, *Temporalidades*, vol. 17, f. 1r.
70. “Memorial Ajustado,” AGI, *Guadalajara*, vol. 89, ff. 34v–38v.

CHAPTER 6. “NOW GOD WANTS ALL THIS TO END”

1. Francisco Parralo, “Declaración,” July 21, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, cuaderno 2, ff. 1073v–1074r.
2. *Ibid.*, ff. 1079r–v.
3. *Ibid.*, f. 1079r.

4. The documents often describe Yaqui warriors as being *embijado*, painted with red dye derived from the *bija*, or annatto tree, known also as the achiote in Mexico; “Causa Crim.l de la R.l Just.a Sobre haver robado unas Bacas a Nicolás feliz = Juez D.n Joseph de Azedo, Alc.de, M.or.,” February 10–19, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 793v–794v; “Auto y Diligencia,” February 20, 1740, in *ibid.*, ff. 163v–164v.
5. Joseph de Acedo, “Auto,” AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 734r–735v.
6. Campoy to Acedo, March 7, 1740, in *ibid.*, f. 777r; Joseph de Acedo, “Auto,” March 10, 1740, in *ibid.*, ff. 737r–v; Acedo to Huidobro, March 12, 1740, in *ibid.*, f. 652r.
7. Pedro de Nolasco, “Declaración,” March 12, 1740, in *ibid.*, ff. 739v–740r.
8. Acedo, “Auto,” March 25, 1740, in *ibid.*, f. 750v; Rafael de Robles, “Declaración,” in *ibid.*, ff. 740r–742v; Feliz to Huidobro, March 15, 1740, in *ibid.*, f. 649r. The kidnapped Piedras Verdes and Cristóbal Moreno later turned up in the Yaqui town of Torim.
9. Acedo, “Auto,” March 12, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, f. 649r; Acedo, “Auto,” March 17, 1740, in *ibid.*, f. 744v; Juan de Salas, “Auto,” March 20, 1740, in *ibid.*, f. 689v.
10. Salas, “Auto,” March 20, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 685r–689v.
11. *Ibid.*, f. 689r.
12. Huidobro to Salas, March 20, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, f. 691v; Huidobro, “Auto,” March 23, 1740, in *ibid.*, f. 659v.
13. Acedo, “Auto,” March 22, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, f. 748v; Gabriel de Santa Cruz to Acedo, March 19, 1740, in *ibid.*, f. 788v; “Memorial Ajustado,” AGI, *Guadalajara*, vol. 89, f. 275.
14. Acedo and Gurrola, “Auto,” March 23, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, f. 749r; Imaz to Acedo, March 24, 1740, in *ibid.*, f. 780r; Acedo, “Auto,” April 2, 1740, in *ibid.*, f. 755r.
15. Salas to Huidobro, April 11, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 663v–664v.
16. Duque to Acedo, April 6, 1740, in *ibid.*, f. 665r; Fentanes to Acedo, April 6, 1740, in *ibid.*, ff. 666r–668r.
17. Juan Ignacio Romero, “Declaración,” April 21, 1740, in *ibid.*, ff. 768v–771v.
18. Navarro García, *Sublevación*, 59–60.
19. Aldámez to Huidobro, April 28, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 715r–718r.
20. Huidobro, “Auto,” April 29, 1740, in *ibid.*, f. 678r.
21. Acedo to Huidobro, April 29, 1740, in *ibid.*, f. 719r; Martín Guitormeas to Acedo, April 29, 1740, in *ibid.*, f. 722v; Feliz to Acedo, April 29, 1740, in *ibid.*, f. 777v.
22. Nicolás Feliz, “Declaración,” May 4, 1740, in *ibid.*, f. 724v.
23. Spicer, *Yaquis*, 50–57.
24. Huidobro, “Auto,” May 7, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, f. 729r. He found seventy-six families in Tesia, fifty-eight in Navojoa, and eighty-seven in Cuirimpó; “Razón de haver pedido perdón los de cocorin [. . .],” May 12–14, 1740, in *ibid.*, ff. 813v–815v; Huidobro, “Auto,” May 7, 1740, in *ibid.*, f. 731r.
25. Valenzuela, “Declaración,” November 19, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, f. 801; cited in Navarro García, *Sublevación*, 65. For a discussion of the state’s delegitimizing depictions of popular insurgencies, see Guha, “Prose of Counterinsurgency,” 45–89.
26. Hipólito Álvarez, “Declaración,” May 28, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 912v–912v.

27. Julián de la Parra, “Declaración,” May 22, 1740, in *ibid.*, f. 894v; Huidobro, “Auto,” May 29, 1740, in *ibid.*, f. 918v.
28. Hipólito Álvarez, “Declaración,” May 28, 1740, in *ibid.*, ff. 912v–914v.
29. *Ibid.*, ff. 915r–v.
30. *Ibid.*, ff. 916r–v.
31. *Ibid.*, ff. 917r–918r.
32. Huidobro, “Auto,” May 18, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 816v–820v.
33. Pedro Bohórquez, “Declaración,” May 28, 1740, in *ibid.*, ff. 905r–v.
34. Antonio Domínguez, “Declaración,” May 23, 1740, in *ibid.*, f. 838r; Pedro Bohórquez, “Declaración,” May 28, 1740, in *ibid.*, f. 909r.
35. Huidobro to Belaunzarán, May 24, 1740, BL, C-B 840, no. 314, ff. 1–6; Huidobro, “Auto,” May 23, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, f. 840r.
36. Mendibil to Huidobro, May 24, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 841r–844r; “Junta de los Vecinos,” May 24, 1740, in *ibid.*, ff. 845v–848v; Arce to Segesser, May 24, 1740, AGN, *Jesuitas*, leg. 1–12, exp. 1, ff. 181–183v; Díaz Félix, “Exhorto,” May 25, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 850r–852r.
37. Huidobro, “Autos,” May 26, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 854r–859r.
38. Vecinos de los Álamos, “Consulta,” May 26, 1740, in *ibid.*, ff. 864v–869v.
39. Ayamea was, ironically, one of those militia soldiers summoned by Huidobro to garrison Baroyeca in early May 1740; Juan Calixto Ayamea to Juan de Aldámez, May 20, 1740, in *ibid.*, ff. 923r–924r.
40. Juan Calixto Ayamea, “Confesión,” December 24, 1740, in *ibid.*, f. 1414v; Manuel Bernal de Huidobro, “Padrón,” December 28, 1740, in *ibid.*, f. 1438r.
41. Ayamea to Aldámez, May 20, 1740, in *ibid.*, cuaderno 2, ff. 923r–924r. The letter’s postscript was likely a message for the bearers of the letter, who were to help Aldámez relocate to the Yaqui towns.
42. In his confession Ayamea said he could not sign his name, but many other Yaquis who were interrogated in late 1740 and early 1741 could and did sign their names and were probably literate. Ayamea, “Confesión,” December 24, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, cuaderno 2, 1419r; the Yaquis Sebastián Sotomea, Antonio Mahuri, Manuel Quibuamea, and others signed court documents in 1741: “Declaración de Sebastián Sotomea, natural del pueblo de Torim,” July 17, 1741, CU-BANC, 1875.1, f. 173r; “Declaración de Antonio Mahuri, natural del pueblo de Vicam,” August 31, 1741, in *ibid.*, f. 178v; “Declaración de Manuel de Quibuamea, natural y then.te de Gobernador del pueblo de Bacum,” September 27, 1741, in *ibid.*, f. 197r.
43. Juan Calixto Ayamea, “Confesión,” December 24–26, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, f. 1419r.
44. Mendibil to Huidobro, June 6, 1740, in *ibid.*, ff. 1039v–1040r.
45. *Ibid.*, ff. 1041v–1044r.
46. Francisco Javier Campoy to Pedro Joaquín Campoy, May 27, 1740, AGN, *Jesuitas*, leg. 1–12, exp. 268, ff. 1986v–1987r; Juan Calixto Ayamea, “Confesión,” December 24–26, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 1410v–1424v.
47. Manuel Bernal de Huidobro, “Auto,” June 3, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 919r–923r; Huidobro to Buenaventura de Echeverría, June 3, 1730, AGN, *Jesuitas*, leg. 1–12, exp. 272, ff. 1992–1995.

48. Juan Calixto Ayamea, "Confesión," December 24–26, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, f. 1422v; Navarro García, *Sublevación*, 88; Juan Ignacio "Chiquito," "Declaración," July 19, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 1067r–v.
49. Aldámez to Huidobro, June 21, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 1048r–1052r.
50. Huidobro, "Auto," June 3, 1740, in *ibid.*, ff. 919r–923r.
51. Huidobro, "Auto," June 9, 1740, in *ibid.*, f. 946v.
52. Navarro García, *Sublevación*, 94; Huidobro, "Decreto," June 12, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 962v–967r; Cristóbal de Gurrola, "Declaración," June 13, 1740, in *ibid.*, ff. 950r–956v.
53. Vecinos de Álamos to the Viceroy, February 13, 1743, AGI, *Guadalajara*, vol. 188, cuaderno 4, ff. 1–23.
54. Huidobro to Vildósola, June 19, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 A, ff. 196v–200r; Vildósola to Huidobro, June 22, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 1036r–1037v; Vildósola to Huidobro, June 22, 1740, in *ibid.*, f. 1038r.
55. Vega to Huidobro, June 27, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 983r–989v.
56. Huidobro to Vildósola, July 7, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 C, ff. 97–104, cited in Navarro García, *Sublevación*, 103.
57. Vega to Huidobro, June 28, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 989v–990r; Huidobro, "Auto," June 28, 1740, in *ibid.*, ff. 990r–v.
58. Juan Calixto Ayamea et al. to Huidobro, June 28, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 999v–1001v.
59. Huidobro, "Junta," June 30, 1740, in *ibid.*, ff. 1009r–1010r.
60. Huidobro to Ayamea, Xicanamea, et al. July 2, 1740, in *ibid.*, ff. 1021v–1026r.
61. Huidobro, "Auto," July 2, 1740, in *ibid.*, ff. 1027v–1031v.
62. José de Ansures, "Certificación," September 28, 1740, AGI, *Guadalajara*, vol. 188, ff. 30–39; Huidobro, "Auto," July 18, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 24 B, f. 1055v; Juan Frías, "Declaración," September 3, 1740, in *ibid.*, ff. 1108v–1117r.
63. Huidobro, "Auto," July 18, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, f. 1055v; Uzárraga, "Declaración," July 19, 1740, in *ibid.*, ff. 1059v–1064r.
64. Molina to the Provincial, August 3, 1740, AGN, *Jesuitas* 1–12, exp. 323, ff. 2155r–2155v.
65. *Ibid.*, f. 2155r.
66. Juan Calixto Ayamea et al. to Huidobro, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 996v–1001v.
67. Juan Frías, "Declaración," September 3, 1740, in *ibid.*, ff. 1108v–1117r.
68. Navarro García, *Sublevación*, 113–15.
69. Viceroy Vizarrón, "Título de Capitán de la nación yaqui en la provincia de Sinaloa, en Juan Ignacio Uscamea, alias Muni, de la misma nación, por las razones que se expresan," July 16, 1740, AGN, *General de Parte*, vol. 33, exp. 36 [unpaginated folios]; Mendibil to Huidobro, September 19, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 1186r–1189r; In light of his recent experience in the Yaqui Valley, Mendibil did not think the peace would last and recommended that a presidio be set up near the Yaqui mission in order to prevent future revolts.
70. Mendibil to Huidobro, October 7, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 1190r–1192r; Basoritemea to Huidobro, October 6, 1740, in *ibid.*, ff. 1192r–1194r.

71. Navarro García, *Sublevación*, 120; Idoyaga, Uranga, Gil de Samaniego, and Ezquerro, "Pareceres," October 12, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, f. 1194r.
72. Huidobro, "Recibimiento de los cautivos," October 15, 1740, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 1218v–1221r.
73. Huidobro, "Auto," October 16, 1740, in *ibid.*, ff. 1221r–1225v.
74. Navarro García, *Sublevación*, 130–33.
75. *Ibid.*, 133–35; Juan Calixto Ayamea, "Confesión," AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244 B, ff. 1410v–1419r.
76. Navarro García, *Sublevación*, 139–43.
77. *Ibid.*, 144–45.
78. *Ibid.*, 147–49.
79. AGI, *Guadalajara*, vol. 188, cited in Navarro García, *Sublevación*, 152; Vecinos of Álamos to the Viceroy, February 13, 1743, AGI, *Guadalajara*, vol. 188, cuaderno 4, ff. 1–23, cited in Navarro García, *Sublevación*, 153.
80. Navarro García, *Sublevación*, 157–59.

CHAPTER 7. THE COLLAPSE OF THE MISSION

1. Lorenzo José García to Lucas Luís Álvarez, July 10, 1744, AGN, *Jesuitas*, leg. 01–11, exp. 15, f. 87v–88r.
2. *Ibid.*, f. 88r.
3. The "colonial pact" is a term coined by Cynthia Radding de Murrieta in *Wandering Peoples*, 12–13. That book, alongside David J. Weber's *Bárbaros*, and Radding de Murrieta's *Landscapes of Power and Identity*, are fundamental for understanding the frontiers in the Spanish-Bourbon world. Weber's *Spanish Frontier*, 227–30, provides a detailed exploration of these policies in the north Mexican context under Viceroy Bernardo de Gálvez. Gálvez consciously sought to import French ideas regarding frontier Indians to Mexico, forging alliances with native groups and selling them weapons and trade goods. This was a double-edged policy, intended both to pacify native groups and to exploit them for imperial gain, all the while making them dependent on Spanish manufactures. In a related vein, Jeremy Baskes, *Indians, Merchants, and Markets*, offers the provocative argument that Indian participation in the cochineal trade was voluntary, not coerced. Whether or not he is right about the degree of coercion involved in the notorious *repartimiento de mercancías*, few have challenged his underlying point that Bourbon economic policy was geared toward inducing Indians to participate more widely in the colonial economy; more generally, Taylor's *Magistrates of the Sacred* is the best guide to the history of religious change in eighteenth-century Mexico. Brading, *Church and State in Bourbon Mexico*, is crucial to a broader understanding of the era. Stein and Stein, *Apogee of Empire*, provides a detailed analysis of the political economy of empire and the ideological context of the Jesuit expulsion. Earlier explorations of the religious change in Bourbon Mexico include Fariss, *Crown and Clergy*; Möner, *Expulsion of the Jesuits*; and Konrad, *Jesuit Hacienda in Mexico*; recent books by two students of William Taylor's provide

- indispensable fine-grained guidance to the development of the missions in the late eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries: de la Torre Curiel, *Twilight of the Mission Frontier*, deals with Sonora from the Jesuit expulsion in 1767 to the end of the Franciscan endeavor in 1851, and McEnroe, *From Colony to Nationhood*, covers the *longue durée* in Mexico's north-northeast.
4. Arriola to Álvarez, May 23, 1749, BL, C-B 840, no. 271, 586.
 5. Francisco Ortíz, "Informes de la misión de Bahcon y Cocorin," 1745, BL, M-M 1716 v. 32, ff. 2–3.
 6. Arriola to Álvarez, May 23, 1749, BL, C-B 840, 583.
 7. *Ibid.*, 584.
 8. *Ibid.*, 586.
 9. Ortíz to García, 1749, BL, C-B 840, 630, 632, 640, 652.
 10. Ortíz to Arriola, 1749, in *ibid.*, 656.
 11. Paamea and García to Álvarez, March 20, 1747, in *ibid.*, 574.
 12. Arriola to Álvarez, May 23, 1749, in *ibid.*, 586; Ortíz to Sebiseamea, July 6, 1749, in *ibid.*, 615; Ortíz to Sebiseamea, August 12, 1749, in *ibid.*, 633–34; Ortíz to Governor of Torim, August 13, 1749, in *ibid.*, 634; Juan Salgado to Andrés Xavier García, December 3, 1747, in *ibid.*, 607; Provincial to Ortíz, May 3, 1751, in *ibid.*, 612.
 13. Mateo Ansaldo to the Provincial, AGN, *Historia*, vol. 16, ff. 405–418; Rodríguez Gallardo, *Informe sobre Sinaloa y Sonora*.
 14. Rodríguez Gallardo, *Informe*, 8–21.
 15. *Ibid.*, 21–45.
 16. *Ibid.*, 23–24.
 17. Fernando Sánchez Salvador, "Copia de las cinco representaciones hechas al Rey, por Fernando Sanches Salvador, la primera acerca de las misiones de Sinaloa, y Chinipas, la Seg.da a cerca de las Islas Marias, la tercera sobre conduccion de azogues de los Rs de Sinaloa &a Quarta y Quinta sobre poblar el Rio Colorado &a" (hereafter, "Representaciones"), March 2, 1751, BNMAF, box 33, exp. 684.
 18. Juan Lorenzo Salgado to Ignacio Calderón, March 8, 1756, AHH, *Temporalidades*, leg. 17, no. 39.
 19. *Ibid.*
 20. Rafael Rodríguez Gallardo to Viceroy Cruillas, October 14, 1761, AGN, *Provincias Internas*, vol. 69, f. 76r.
 21. *Ibid.*, ff. 77r–77v.
 22. Diego Tamarón y Romeral to Viceroy Cruillas, September 7, 1761, AGN, *Provincias Internas*, vol. 69, ff. 55–56. Tamarón y Romeral, *Demostración del Vastísimo Obispado*, 246–47.
 23. "Contra Juan Ignacio Regalado, Perfecto Elías, et al., Indios Yaquis, por la embriaguez, juego, baile, y otros excessos," February 11, 1799, AP, 1799 G-111. Hu-DeHart notes that in 1772 the mining town of Cieneguilla had seven thousand residents, half of whom were Indians, and a large part of that group Mayos and Yaquis. Viceroy Bernardo de Gálvez instructed Commander General Jacobo Ugarte y Loyola to guard the roads between the Yaqui towns and new mines of Sonora. Hu-DeHart, *Missionaries*, 100.
 24. Hu-DeHart, *Missionaries*, 90–91.

25. Brading, *Church and State*, 7, 3–21; Stein and Stein, *Apogee of Empire*, 81–118; Pradeau, *Expulsión de los jesuitas*, 20–26.
26. Brading, *Church and State*, 3–21; Taylor, *Magistrates of the Sacred*, 452–57.
27. HGS, vol. 2, 206. The officers were Bernardo de Urrea, captain of the presidio of Altar; Juan Bautista de Anza, captain of the presidio of Tubac; Juan José Bergosa, captain of the flying company based in San José de Pimas; Lorenzo Cancio, captain of the presidio of San Carlos de Buenavista; and Sebastián de Azcárraga, justicia mayor of the province of Sinaloa.
28. Cancio to Pineda, August 9, 1767, in Pradeau, *Expulsión de los jesuitas*, 67–68; Cancio to Pineda, October 3, 1767, in *ibid.*, 76.
29. Cancio to Pineda, October 1, 1767, in *Documentos para la historia de Méjico*, 4:2, 213–16.
30. Cancio to Pineda, October 3, 1767, in *ibid.*, 4:2, 220–22.
31. Cancio to Pineda, November 8, 1767, in *ibid.*, 4:2, 228–29.
32. Cancio to Francisco Galindo y Quiñones, January 28, 1768, in *ibid.*, 4:2, 249; Corbalán to the Viceroy, July 8, 1771, AGN, *Provincias Internas*, vol. 93, f. 169r.
33. *Ibid.*, ff. 169r–171r.
34. *Ibid.*, ff. 169r–174r.
35. Joaquín de Encinas and Juan Joseph de Lumbreras, “Testimonio de las Dilig.s Practicadas sobre las últimas novedades de Sonora,” August 20, 1771, AGN, *Provincias Internas*, vol. 93, ff. 251r–252v.
36. “Declaración del Denunciante,” August 20, 1771, AGN, *Provincias Internas*, vol. 93, ff. 297r–301r; “Declaración de Mateo Chinche,” August 20, 1771, in *ibid.*, ff. 301r–303v; “Declaración de Antonio Goysuay,” August 20, 1771, in *ibid.*, ff. 304r–305v; “Declaración de Lorenzo Huatemea,” August 20, 1771, in *ibid.*, f. 308r.
37. Corbalán to the captain of the presidio of Altar, August 24, 1771, AGN, *Provincias Internas*, vol. 93, f. 255r; Encinas to Lumbreras, August 26, 1771, in *ibid.*, ff. 262r–263v; Miguel de Encinas, “Carta del ministro de Cocorim,” August 28, 1771, in *ibid.*, ff. 264r–265r; Frías to Lumbreras, August 28, 1771, in *ibid.*, ff. 265v–267r.
38. Encinas to Corbalán, August 30, 1771, AGN, *Provincias Internas*, vol. 93, f. 272v.
39. Corbalán to Gurrola, August 30, 1771, in *ibid.*, ff. 274r–275r.
40. Corbalán, *Auto*, September 1, 1771, AGN, *Provincias Internas*, vol. 93, ff. 278v–279r; “Declaración de Francisco Guatemea,” September 1, 1771, in *ibid.*, ff. 279v–281v; “Declaración de Luís Sopemea,” September 1, 1771, in *ibid.*, ff. 281v–285r; “Declaración de Pablo de la Cruz,” September 1, 1771, AGN, in *ibid.*, ff. 287v–288r.
41. Pedro Corbalán, “Diligencia con el Comun de los Pueblos,” September 1, 1771, *Provincias Internas*, vol. 93, f. 289r.
42. *Ibid.*, ff. 289v–290r.
43. Scott, *Domination and the Arts of Resistance*; priests in Torim and Rahum confirmed that there were no rebel activities in their towns. Francisco Joaquín Valdés to Corbalán, September 2, 1771, AGN, *Provincias Internas*, vol. 93, ff. 292r–293v; Ignacio Fernandez Valdés to Corbalán, September 2, 1771, in *ibid.*, ff. 293v–294r.
44. Anon., June 26, 1772, Archivo Histórico del Gobierno del Estado de Sonora, vol. 62, exp. 3, f. 388–389v; Anon., August 8, 1772, AGN, *Provincias Internas*, vol. 247, f. 3v;

- Valdés to Corbalán, August 10, 1772, in *ibid.*, f. 4v; Corbalán to Gurrola, June 2, 1773, in *ibid.*, f. 4r.
45. Felipe de Jesús Álvarez to Joseph María Areñas, June 14, 1784, Archivo Histórico del Gobierno del Estado de Sonora, vol. 16, exp. 8, ff. 1r–v.
 46. Antonio de los Reyes, “Relación Clara y metódica de todas las Misiones establecidas en la Dioceci de Sonora, con expresión de las Prouincias en que se hallan su extensión, naciones de Yndios y Pueblos de visita de que se componen, gente que tiene cada Pueblo, & a. & a. . . .,” September 5, 1784, BNMAF, box 34, exp. 749, ff. 1r, 17v; “Informe del Ministro doctrinero del Río Yaqui Br. D. Francisco Joaquín Valdés al Inten. Gb. D. Henrique Grimarest, sobre el estado y circunstancias en que se hallan los Pueblos del Río. Lenguas que hablan . . .,” August 3, 1790, BNMAF, box 35, exp. 775, ff. 1v–2r.
 47. “Informe del Ministro doctrinero del Río Yaqui Br. D. Francisco Joaquín Valdés al Inten. Gb. D. Henrique Grimarest, sobre el estado y circunstancias en que se hallan los Pueblos del Río. Lenguas que hablan . . .,” August 3, 1790, BNMAF, box 35, exp. 775, ff. 1v, 5v, 8v.
 48. *Ibid.*, f. 2r.
 49. Don Jacinto Álvarez, May 18, 1804, “Informe de la provincia de Ostimuri en 1804,” BNMAF, box 36, exp. 819, f. 11v.
 50. *Ibid.*, f. 12r.
 51. *Ibid.*
 52. David J. Weber describes these dynamics: “In the Age of Reason, then, the peaceful coexistence and slow integration of independent Indians which the crown generally favored and high-ranking Spanish officials often espoused did not always prevail. In places where Spaniards coveted Indian land and had the means to take it, enlightened policies gave way to avarice, opportunism, and collective violence,” *Bárbaros*, 220; Gálvez, *Instructions*, 36, quoted in DeLay, *War*, 13.
 53. Yetman, *Ópatas*, 223–58.
 54. West, *Sonora*, 62–66; Frank, *From Settler to Citizen*, 233–34.

EPILOGUE

1. Hu-DeHart, *Yaqui Resistance and Survival*, 33.
2. On liberalism and its effects on native collective landholding, see Craib, *Cartographic Mexico*; Kourí, *Pueblo Divided*.
3. Hu-DeHart, *Yaqui Resistance and Survival*, 34.
4. Cancio to Pineda, August 9, 1767, in Pradeau, *Expulsión de los jesuitas*, 67–8; Radding de Murrieta, *Wandering Peoples*, 1769; DeLay, *War*, 30.
5. Antonio de los Reyes, September 5, 1784, “Relación Clara y metódica de todas las Misiones establecidas en la Dioceci de Sonora, con expresión de las Prouincias en que se hallan su extensión, naciones de Yndios y Pueblos de visita de que se componen, gente que tiene cada Pueblo, &a,” BNMAF, box 34, exp. 759, f. 18r; Francisco Joaquín Valdés, “Informe del Ministro doctrinero del Río Yaqui . . .,” August 3, 1790, BNMAF, box 25, exp. 775, f. 9r.

6. Hardy, *Travels*, 390.
7. Juan de la Cruz Banderas, 1826, "Proclama de Juan Banderas," Archivo Histórico del Gobierno del Estado de Sonora, box 338, leg. 1, reproduced in Hernández Silva, *Insurgencia y autonomía*, 157.
8. On independence in Sonora, see Medina Bustos, "Crísis monárquica"; Nápoli to Huidobro, July 21, 1738, AGI, *Escribanía*, vol. 244B, cuaderno 1, ff. 537v–538r.
9. For a parallel exploration of genocidal democracies, see Anderson, *Conquest of Texas*.
10. Hu-DeHart, *Yaqui Resistance and Survival*; Evans, *Bound in Twine*, 67–90.
11. Hernández, *Razas indígenas*, 89.
12. Evans, *Bound in Twine*, 67–90; Pedro Corbalán, "Diligencia con el Común de los Pueblos," AGN, *Provincias Internas*, vol. 93, f. 289v.
13. Dwyer, *Agrarian Dispute*, 136.
14. On Yaqui support of constitutionalist forces, see Padilla Ramos and Ramírez Zavala, "Los Yaquis en la revolución carrancista." On the Yaqui *ejido*, see Dwyer, *Agrarian Dispute*, 103–37.

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